Emancipative Education

Emancipative Education

Policies and Practices

Papers presented at the 45th Annual Research Seminar of ACPI
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Edited by
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Contents

Editorial vii
Chief Guest's Address xv

Part 1: Archaeology of Education: Theories and Issues 1

1. University as Symbol of Being 3
   George Panthanmackel
2. Genealogy of Self-Making Experience: Thinking Beyond the Binary of Teaching and Learning 17
   Nishant A. Irudayadason
3. *Bildung* in Kant, Hegel and Gadamer: A Cursory Look 29
   George Rajmohan
4. Plurality of Knowledge: Foucault's Perspective 53
   Kamaladevi Kunkolienker
5. Philosophy of Unlearning and Re-learning: Dewey's Progressive Learning and Models from Neurosciences 69
   Gregory Mathew Malayil
6. *Poesis* and *Praxis:* Ethics and Aesthetics in Education 83
   Ivan D'Souza

Part 2: Defragmenting Education: Perspectives and Practices 99

7. Religious Education: Scope and Challenges in India 101
   Biju Pallippadan
8. Deconstructing the Concepts "*Guru*" and "Emancipation" in the Context of Education 111
   Joy Alumkal
9. Traditional Indian Education: A Critique 121
   John Peter Vallabadoss
10. Indigenous Knowledge and Emancipation 137
    Raju Felix Crasta

11. Education: Subaltern Perspectives 151
Sebastian Alackapally
12. Education In Islam: A Critique 169
Jose Pennaparambil

Part 3: Emancipative Education for a New World 183

13. Existential and Ethical Revisioning of Science Education and Research 185
Keith D'Souza
14. Piketty's Pitfalls: Taming the Neo-Liberal Leviathan in Education 203
Jose D. Maliekal
15. Commercialisation Versus Decommercialisation of Education in the Indian Context 219
Henry Jose Kodikuthiyil
16. Teaching to Transgress: A Pedagogical Imperative 233
Victor Ferrao
17. Emancipative Education: Neurological Perspectives 245
Augustine Pamplany
18. Information-Knowledge-Wisdom: The Use of Media in Education with Special Reference to Covid-19 259
Francis Arackal Thummy

ACPI Statement 275
Contributors 277
Index 285

Editorial

The world today is on the threshold of a major transition. Until the close of twentieth century the world has witnessed several paradigmatic shifts: from unscientific to scientific outlook; from geocentric to heliocentric understanding; from mechanical world-view to relativistic world-view; from modern thought to postmodern thought; from closed-market to open-market systems; from tradition to modernity; from real-world to virtual world, and the list goes endless. The post-independent country up till the close of the millennium has witnessed several policy reformations in education system of the country.[1] The giant leap of scientific advancements and subsequent Artificial Intelligence (AI) are already changing the entire scenario in the first quarter of the 21st century itself. On the other hand, transition is bringing mixed feelings and further endangering by the changing political scenario, cultural ethos, religious loyalties, ethnic conflicts, rich-poor gap, etc. Therefore, the question that becomes central is, "What sort of society one wants to live in the near future?" The answer to this question depends on the kind of society one wants to create. The kind of society one envisages depends on one's kind of upbringing and education. Education is the key for change and growth and thus for the emancipation from that which enslaves.

The *National Education Policy-2020* expresses the significance of education in the following words, "Education is fundamental for achieving full human potential, developing an equitable and just society, and promoting national development. Providing universal access to quality education is the key to India's continued ascent, and leadership on the global stage in terms of economic growth, social justice and equality, scientific advancement, national

1 The first national policy on education came in 1968, but it remained as a 'draft policy' until 1986. The revision of the policy took place in 1992. See Marmar Mukhopadhyay and Madhu Parhar, ed., *Indian Education: Developments Since Independence* (New Delhi: Vikas Publishing House, 1999), 1-14. Recently, the Ministry of Human Resource Development, Government of India has already promulgated a new education policy in 2020 known as, "The National Educational Policy (NEP)."

integration, and cultural preservation. Universal high-quality education is the best way forward for developing and maximizing our country's rich talents and resources for the good of the individual, the society, the country, and the world."[2] The growing consumerism, fundamentalism, fascist nationalism, dictatorial approaches, totalitarian outlooks, sectarian commitments, and discriminatory attitudes over education makes one to rethink the present education system and its direction. Therefore, there is a need to deconstruct the existing system so as to realise emancipative education.

The educated person sees everything with equanimity. The *Gītā* says thus, "The enlightened person treats the humble and knowledgeable *Brāhmaṇa*, the outcastes, animals or surrounding with equanimity" (BG 5:18). Another famous Sanskrit verse says, "education begets humility, humility begets eligibility, eligibility begets wealth, wealth begets *dharma* and *dharma* begets happiness."[3] And this is the aim of education as well, a 'complete fulfilment' of the human mind, the personality, expressions and commitments as an individual, member of a family or a community for a better and ethical living. In the words of John Dewey, the purpose of education should be the cultivation of thoughtful, critically reflective, and socially engaged individuals rather than passive recipients of established knowledge.[4] Education remakes the person as 'fully human and fully divine,' world as a 'loving home,' and transvalue the entire value system. Its deeper and harmonious expression is 'growth and development,' and that should do away with poverty, oppression, ignorance, exclusion, alienation, destruction, egoism, etc.

The purpose of the book is neither to document the historicity of educational policies of the government and institutions, nor to provide new policies. Conversely, this book philosophically looks into 'education' proper: critically evaluates the education system of yesterday and today, its purpose, background and foreground for a better tomorrow. During the 45th National Annual Research Seminar held at Morning Star College, Barrackpore, West Bengal, between 14-16 October 2022, several members of the Association of Christian Philosophers of India (ACPI), under the theme, "Emancipative Education: Policies and Practices," presented their philosophical reflections, discussed, and debated. The result of the deliberation is the birth of this book.

The articles in the book are organised into three parts: the archaeology of education, defragmenting education and emancipating for a new world.

2 *National Education Policy* (Ministry of Human Resource Development, Government of India, 2020), 3.

3 *"vidyā dadāti vinayam, vinayad yāti pātratām, pātratvāt dhanam apnoti, dhanāt dharmam tataḥ sukham.*"

4 Viki Hargraves, "Dewey's Educational Philosophy," in *The Education Hub*, https://theeducationhub.org.nz/ deweys- educational-philosophy/, accessed 10 June 2023.

However, these divisions are not without overlapping the themes presented under them. The first part, "Archaeology of Education: Theories and Issues," mainly deals with education in general. That is, the papers presented are foundational in nature, analytic in flavour and theoretical in perspectives. The second part, "Defragmenting Education: Perspective and Practices," tries to analyse the education system from religious, subaltern, traditional, indigenous, etc., perspectives. The third part, "Emancipative Education for a New World," tries to understand education as a tool of emancipation from different suppressions: from commercial, political, social, neurological, virtual, etc., perspectives.

Part I: Archaeology of Education: Theories and Issues

George Panthanmackel's, "University as a Symbol of Being," the first article, acts as a launching pad for philosophising education and its end. The article is metaphysical in its nature, traces education to universality, the Being. He carefully relates Being with University. Being embraces everything or every being in itself. Therefore, Being is in beings. In a university too, many learned persons are brought together to adjust together the claims and relations of their respective subjects of investigation. They learn to respect, consult and aid each other, creating a pure and clear atmosphere of thought, though the students may pursue only a very few subjects out of the multitude. All must be committed to the one educative mission of knowledge and truth, which is emancipatory from the domination and tyrannical attitudes.

Nishant A. Irudayadason in his article, "Genealogy of Self-making Experience: Thinking beyond the Binary of Teaching and Learning," explores the multifaceted nature of learning, drawing on philosophical perspectives from Montaigne, Descartes, Plato, Kant, and Aristotle. A teacher apart from teaching must also learn from personal experiences, innate ideas, from external environment and simultaneously integrate the perceptual and affective experiences. The essay expands the concept of learning beyond the nature-culture binary, its social and cultural dimensions, the impact of learning on industrialization and alienation in capitalist societies, before calling for a deconstructive approach to education.

George Rajmohan in his article, "*Bildung* in Kant, Hegel and Gadamer: A Cursory Look," gives a comprehensive understanding to education taking the German term, *Bildung* and exploring it from Kant, Hegel and Gadamerian perspective. According to the author, *Bildung* encompasses human development in all its multidimensionality of growth—physical, mental, spiritual and cultural. It deals with the educational sciences, education itself that transforms *homo-barbarous* or *homo naturalis* into *homo-humanus*, pragmatic formation, a cultural and aesthetic cultivation. Further, he says, the education should enable the person to an *imago dei*, the image of God.

Kamaladevi Kunkolienkar gives the Foucaultean perspective on education in her paper, "Knowledge: Foucault's Perspective." Unique to its kind, she analyses various terminologies connected with education as described by Michel Foucault such as archaeology, genealogy, resistance, bio-power, will to know and truth, subject and so on in his analysis of historical events/problems faced by human beings—madness, imprisonment and punishment, sexuality—which are a result of power-relations shared in a particular discourse by particular people.

Gregory Mathew Malayil, in his article, "Philosophy of Unlearning and Re-Learning: Dewey's Progressive Learning and Models from Neurosciences," uses the American education reformer, John Dewey's methodology to understand the methodology of education. Education involves learning, unlearning and relearning. According to Malayil, though unlearning and relearning seem to be impossible in literal meaning, creative ways of addressing problems or taking new initiatives are possible by modifying existing knowledge. The paper further discusses the relevance of unlearning and relearning to education, to organizations, management strategies, etc. The paper concludes with a critical observation on the claim of NLP proponents that total unlearning is attainable.

Ivan D'Souza, in his article, "Poesis and Praxis: Ethics and Aesthetics in Education," tactfully brings together theoretical and practical dimension in the education system with the aid of Aristotelian notion of *poesis* and *praxis*. The paper examines whether these notions exist in the present education system. *Praxis* being the higher form of knowledge is linked to the concept of *phronesis*, which entails moral conduct. D'Souza also applies *praxis* to the Indian aesthetics so as to see whether the Indian aesthetics is ethical. He gives practical tips to make education a *praxis*.

Part II: Defragmenting Education: Perspectives and Practices

Biju Pallippadan, in his article, "Religious Education: Scope and Challenges in India," attempts to study the impact of religious education, culling out the chief tenets from the world religions. He argues that religious education in the West has evolved into a subject that seeks to support students to develop their religious identity, whereas in the Indian peninsula it has not yet become part of the curriculum; rather it is in its infancy.

Joy Alumkal deconstructs the concept of *guru* in relation to emancipative education, in the article, "Deconstructing the Concepts "Guru" and "Emancipation" in the Context of Education." After presenting the basic concepts, he puts forth three paradigms: the traditional paradigm, the post-modern paradigm and the meta-secular or the middle path as envisaged by Buddhism—the intuitive method. In the traditional paradigm both *guru* and emancipation have idealistic visions. But in the course of time in practice,

they fell into disrepute. In the same way, modern and post-modern that criticise the negatives of the traditional, fall into same type of negativities. This necessitates a commitment to a middle path that respect the virtues of both and remove the vices of both.

John Peter Vallabadoss, in his article, "Traditional Indian Education: A Critique," gives a beautiful critique on the Indian traditional educational system, *Gurukula* and *Vedapāṭhśāla*. After having defragmented the traditional systems, the author argues that these two structures from the Vedic period till today carry on the hegemony of the upper-class negating of inclusiveness of educational opportunities to the last and least of society. The paper further explores the deliberate and hidden agendas of powerful ideology of authority in and through these traditional educational systems and proposes counter measures in combating it.

Raju Felix Crasta elegantly expresses the plight of tribals with respect to education and emancipation in India, in the article, "Indigenous Knowledge and Emancipation." The indigenous knowledge can be termed, 'the original wisdom,' due to its primitiveness. The modern society has failed to sufficiently understand the plight of the tribals and original inhabitants. Further, the author tries to figure out the failure of modern education to sufficiently emancipate the indigenous people. According to him, the failure is from both the sides, within and without. Therefore, there is a need to understand the indigenous situation and make education a tool for emancipation.

Sebastian Alackapally, gives a subaltern perspective in the article, "Education: Subaltern Perspectives." The gift of education that has the potentiality to bring the actualization of human person, is denied to a major section of society whom it terms, 'the untouchables.' While exploring issues concerning the education of subalterns, the author looks into the efforts of prominent visionary social reformers and political leaders like Phule, Ambedkar, Periyar, Chavara, Narayana Guru, Kancha Ilaiah and others who championed the cause of educating, empowering and emancipating the Dalits for a life of dignity and freedom.

Jose Pennaparambil critiques the Islam Education in India in his article, "Education in Islam: A Critique." Islam education is unique to its kind due to the influence of the *Quran*. Those who are educated in Islamic tradition are more religious than secular. This has even paved way for indoctrination and vested interests. The author argues that the *madrasas*, the school of Islamic education, are more often critiqued for making them the centres of terrorising activities than adhering to their original purpose. The *madrasas* also need to march along with the changing times and modern techniques of education, apart from inculcating cosmopolitan outlook and respect for other cultures, religions and nationalities.

Part III: Emancipative Education for a New World

Keith D'Souza, through his innovative insights, develops a moral compass in his paper, "Existential and Ethical Revisioning of Science Education and Research." Today science has grown exponentially in all the fields and have produced marvellous results. However, there is a dearth of critical reflection over social and moral issues in all those fields. The main thrust of the paper is, therefore, to argue that there is a need for a revision of the mainstream existential or attitudinal approaches cultivated by science education, as well as the need to cultivate a wholesome ethical compass which will serve to guide scientific tutelage and exploration.

Jose Maleikal, in his paper, "Piketty's Pitfalls: Taming the Neo-Liberal Leviathan in Education," brings in the French economist, Thomas Picketty's conclusions on education and inequality of wealth. The paper highlights the contribution of Pickety to the sociology of education, before critiquing his basic predicament that 'previously accumulated wealth is always more important than income and that it is the primary factor defining our future.' In answer to the pitfalls, Maleikal puts forth three inspirational insights from social movements: 'education as a conscious-raising and grassroots agency praxis,' 'capital as power relation,' and 'democratizing capital ownership.'

Henry Jose Kodikuthiyil, in his article, "Commercialisation Versus Decommercialisation of Education in Indian Context," speaks about the kind of commercialisation that has been taking place in the education sector today. On the one hand the commercialisation has induced new policies and programmes to increase employment, outcome and income opportunities and economic development at national and international level, apart from bringing a rapid change in the educational scenario of India. On the other hand, this has deviated the purpose of education, 'the transformation.' Therefore, there is a need for 'decommercialisation,' so that the core mission of education—spiritual, humanizing and liberating activity—is achieved.

Victor Ferrao's article, "Teaching to Transgress: A Pedagogical Imperative," expresses the present experience of movement from literacy to post-literacy. The present age is of electracy. This is due to the fast-moving internet-world. This changed scenario has accelerated all and people have no time to offer a reflective as well as critical response. It has also affected the educational scene, traditional sacred beliefs, teaching and learning. Therefore, we need a new pedagogy to respond to the new development. Ferrao offers here the concept of grammatology of Lacan as the best response of pedagogy to address electracy.

Augustine Pamplany, in his article, "Emancipative Education: Neurological Perspectives," explores neurological insight into the holistic role of neural plasticity in facilitating understanding, creativity, and critical

thinking. The paper argues that an intersection between the educational neuroscience and the philosophy of emancipatory education carries the potentials for new approaches and pedagogies in promoting the transformative and liberative functions of education. The author beautifully brings in the rich tradition of Indian Philosophy, Christian world-view, and other practices to substantiate his stand.

Francis Arackal Thummy, in his paper, "Information-Knowledge-Wisdom: The Use of Media in Education with Special Reference to Covid-19," explores the significance of Media. He says that 'information-formation-transformation' are the guiding principle in education to form a wise individual. However, these modalities of imparting knowledge took a different turn during the Covid pandemic. What was considered an optional has turned out to be the basic requirement. Teachers are finally recognized as being more than sources of information and knowledge to empty vessels and are looked on as being models of strong character, patient and loving caregivers, and treasures of valuable life experiences. They are appreciated for their adaptability, especially to entirely new media communication technology, and resilience.

Final words

Jñāna, *bhakti* and *karma* are the three ways for emancipation of which Jñāna is the *meta-way.* Knowledge enlightens the path of devotion and action. The right knowledge never leads a person to doom; rather liberates from untruth, darkness and death leading to truth, light and eternity.

To conclude, I place on record my indebtedness to all those who contributed to this volume. It was an elevating experience to go through all the papers, reading and editing. Unique to its kind, each paper had something to stimulate intellectually and inspire for a better understanding. I admire each contributor for his/her dedication and hard work in composing the literature, reshaping and refining as and when needed. Special word of thanks to the Executive Committee of ACPI for having trusted in my abilities with the task of editing this work. In a special way thanks to Dr. John Peter Vallabadoss Ofm Cap., the President of ACPI for his solicitude and brotherly guidance, assistance throughout the entire process of begetting the book. Finally, I thank Christian World Imprints, New Delhi, the publishers for the touch of professionalism displayed in bringing out this book.

May the wisdom that we acquire instil in us 'Justice, Truth and Freedom.'

Raju Felix Crasta

Chief Guest's Address

Rt. Rev. Dr Vincent Aind
(Bishop of Bagdogra)

"India Needs Emancipative Education More Than Skill India"

Dear Fr. Keith D'Souza, the President of the ACPI, Rev. Fr. George Panthanmackel, the Rector of Morning Star, and all the participant Fathers, Sisters, Brothers and friends,

It was a delight to hear that the ACPI had chosen Morning Star Regional Seminary once again, after some 14 years, as the venue and host for the present Conference. Morning Star feels honoured and feels blessed to host it.

I am happy with the choice of the theme for discussion and deliberation. It's a very relevant theme for the times we are going through especially in our country. By way of keynote, I wish to put forward some of my reflections on the theme: "Emancipative Education: Policies and Practices."

There is more literacy than education today. Education is more than mere ability to read and write. A true education is or has to be emancipative. In the words of Alvin Toffler, "The illiterate of the 21st century will not be those who cannot read and write, but those who cannot learn, unlearn and relearn." Mark Twain said, "Education consists in what we have unlearned."

But 'emancipation' can be interpreted as 'liberation'—liberation within, liberation from untruth, from biases, from unreal or unrealistic approach to things. A truly learned person is a liberated person. "Only the educated are free," said Epictetus. Education is a means of emancipation.

In other words, emancipative education aims at the formation of the person and not just imparting of information. The aim is not only to enable the students to be competent, but also to make them persons of conscience, compassion and commitment. Not just the curricula and co-curricular but the school atmosphere as a whole should be such that the students passing through

the portals of the school develop habits of mind and heart which shape their character and personality. To make such an atmosphere beginning with the principal, all the teachers must have the required qualities. It is said, *values are not so much taught as they are caught or imbibed*. The positive atmosphere will work as osmosis among the students.

Two recent incidents come to my mind as good but contrasting examples of a truly emancipated person and another person sadly lacking emancipation. Both are IAS Officers; we know, that the IAS officers are supposed to be learned or at least well-qualified people. They have to crack civil services examinations which are one indication of their intelligence. In this case, both the officers happen to be ladies. One of them is Roshan Jacob from the 2004 batch and the other is Harjot Kaur from the 1999 batch. One has hit the headlines for good reasons: for being a very humane, compassionate and responsible DM. Her fearless and responsible manner of trying to tackle the tragic situation of Covid-19 first, and then her visit to a flooded township, entering into knee-deep water and yet at another time showing her human concern for a badly injured child of a poor mother who had already lost two of her children when a wall fell on them. On the other hand, the second IAS Lady officer who at the moment of the incident happened to be the Head of the Women and Child Development Corporation came to the media attention and sharp criticism for her low-classed reaction to the intervention of a 20-year-old girl participant in the UNICEF sponsored program "*Sashakt Beti: Samridh Bihar*." The reaction of the IAS was not for helping the women become emancipated. Her remarks in retort to the girl were not even deserving of an IAS; forget about her emancipation!

The latter example represents many more cases of so-called "educated people" who are far from emancipated. Another incident was of a low-caste pupil being beaten to death by his school teacher for having tried to quench his thirst from the teacher's pitcher. Our so-called "educated" society is not really emancipated from the caste-based hatred, injustices, prejudices, lies and untruth.

First and foremost, the teachers or educators themselves require emancipation—emancipation in many senses of the term. The teachers themselves have to come out of their comfort zones and venture into a new arena. The two years of Covid-19 related lockdown forced teachers to unlearn, learn anew and relearn. It was one type of emancipation for the educators themselves. It was interesting to observe the difference in level or perspective between the teacher and the student. For instance, when the old-fashioned teacher taught the alphabet and wanted the child to repeat after her "A" as in "Apple" she in fact meant an eatable apple. But the child who repeated after her thought of the "apple" company! The teachers themselves

need to realize that "You are always a student, never a master. You have to keep moving forward" (Conrad Hall).

Teachers can play a significant role in bringing about 'emancipation.' The future of the nation depends on the quality of primary education imparted. Dr S. Radhakrishnan, himself a great educationist (the first Vice President and the Second President of India, 1962-67), had expressed his desire that "teachers should be the best minds in the country." Dr A. P. J. Abdul Kalam, yet another doyen for his learning and the 11th President of India (2002-2007), also believed that there was no other profession in the world more important than that of a teacher, because a teacher can play a very important role in building the future of a nation. It's not unusual to see a kindergarten pupil challenging her mother at home that her teacher taught her differently from what the mother teaches! Her teacher knows (or should know) better than the mother! If the teachers can make the best of such simple trust and confidence the students have in them, if they make one-to-one contact with every child and pay attention to each child's uniqueness, they can make a world of difference in society. Malala Yousafzai has said, "One book, one pen, one child, and one teacher can change the world"!

The 21st century education aims at or should aim at bringing the best out of every individual, helping him/her realize his/her full potential, develop focus, making him/her self-motivated, develop his/her self-confidence and self-esteem, training him/her in the 21st century skills, develop his/her overall personality and prepare him/her for future. But the future is uncertain. We belong to the fourth industrial revolution which is constantly evolving at a breathtaking speed. According to a report of the World Economic Forum, two-thirds of our children today, will be working on jobs that do not currently exist, so what skills do they need to learn today to perform well in future? How to help them acquire those skills which will be necessary tomorrow?

Some of the positive sides of the New Education Policy 2020 indicate a roadmap towards excellence, but there are several aspects in it that are a cause of concern. The Government of India is insisting on Skill India and so little on Education India. Holistic development of the child is the need of the hour. Giving equal value to academics and skill development is imperative. The children need to learn to be adaptable and gradually exhibit an aptitude to learn new or future skills when required. "The COVID-19 pandemic has catapulted us into the digital world, and we have been forced to develop new learning-delivery systems and new pedagogies to cope with 'the new normal.'"[1] But we have also witnessed both limitations and bad consequences of this digitalization of education. Many students in our country have either

1 Ananda Amritmahal, "Higher Education Today: Challenges & Possibilities," *MAGNET* March 2021, 18.

no digital facility at all or have it only to a limited extent. The schools that conducted both online and eventually offline examinations found out to their dismay that digitalization has ruined the capacity of concentrating and learning in most children.

If there is a rising demand for professionalism or skill-oriented education, on the one hand, and there is on the other hand also need for a liberal education. The educational institutions may or may not produce 'industry-ready graduates', but what about pupils turning out as genuine and good human persons?

There is a plethora of 'knowledge', data and insights, and they are available at the click of a button in social media and mass media. They "appear to have taken over our thought processes, and issues become known, debated and discarded as passé at the speed of light."[2] There are more students of the so-called 'WhatsApp University' who adhere to the knowledge imparted through the WhatsApp as gospel truth and hardly care for logic, shreds of evidence and facts and for research-oriented learning. Some of these media are a wilful effort to divide society based on religion, castes and party allegiance. There is a concerted effort to pooh-pooh truth and justice. "In the climate of growing fundamentalism and a slow erosion of civil liberties and personal autonomy and privacy, caution and self-preservation necessitate certain choices, while being true to our beliefs demands a more radical stance. But we are not alone in this." While the overall socio-political scenario in India is becoming more and more deplorable, "Education has become the last bastion of quality, integrity, justice, compassion, and values. Even when these are crumbling everywhere else, it is expected that educational institutions should enshrine these virtues, should live by these principles."[3]

Some of the following questions are pertinent: Is the education imparted in our country emancipative? Are our universities, colleges and schools, centres for learning, unlearning and relearning? How emancipative does the New Education Policy appear? Does it augur well in the sense that it can be emancipative? I suppose this conference will throw light on some of these queries.

The timing and manner in which the NEP was passed in Parliament forced us to raise our eyebrows. Some of the statements made by the present Chairman of the UGC also do not augur well for the economically weaker section in view of higher studies. Curtailment of the budget for education on the one hand and pushing the educational institutions into the hands of the corporate or the wealthy on the other denies the possibility of emancipation for the poor section of society. Lack of professors and teachers in government-run

2 Ananda Amritmahal, "Higher Education Today," 19.

3 Ananda Amritmahal, "Higher Education Today," 19.

colleges and schools or the teaching posts remaining vacant for too long speak of the lackadaisical attitude. Instances of changing syllabi to suit religious fanaticism and fairytales to appear as historical 'facts' in the textbooks not only present a sorry situation for our education but also make education appear like a farce. Some of the incidents of communal hatred in educational institutions are counter-witnesses to the possibility of emancipation. "(T)he atmosphere prevailing in many of our schools and colleges seems to contribute to moral decadence and depravity. Educational institutions have become mere shopping centres of knowledge and information and their primary purpose, namely character formation is given a back seat or completely ignored."[4] Schools should instil in students worthwhile habits of mind and heart and should shape their character and personality.

What about our Christian (or Catholic) schools and colleges? Is the goal of our education "to prepare professionally competent, morally upright and socially conscious leaders who will not only manage their own lives and families responsibly but also change society for the better"?[5] Don't we hear or observe sometimes that some of our schools/colleges aim at only academic excellence and higher income at the expense of human and Christian values? This conference could look into this question too while asking if the education, in general, is emancipative.

I would like to conclude with some wise remarks of the Holy Father Pope Francis. Talking to the general audience at the "Global Researchers Advancing Catholic Education Project" (GRACE), a new international research project, he had said: "You cannot educate without walking together with the people you are educating. …To educate is not to say purely rhetorical things; to educate is to make what is said meet reality. …This is human education: to educate 'is this bringing forward and promoting growth, helping to grow.'"[6]

He went on to elaborate that at the centre of every educational programme, both formal and informal, should be the making of human persons in their value and dignity, fostering their distinctiveness, beauty and uniqueness, and their capacity for relationship with others and with the world around them. He also added that education should teach them to reject lifestyles that encourage the spread of throwaway culture.

I wish this august body of philosophers and educators, a very emancipating, lively and learning time in the next two days and more. May God bless you all! Thank you!

4 T. M. Joseph, "Lessons in Value Education," *Indian Currents*, 10 October 2022.

5 Joe Mannath, "Editorial," *MAGNET*, March 2021.

6 Pope Francis, "The Church's responsibility in forming and guiding new generations toward the future," *L'Osservatore Romano*, Weekly Edition in English, 22 April 2022.

Part 1

Archaeology of Education: Theories and Issues

University as Symbol of Being

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Abstract: University implies ‘one in many.’ Being also implies one in many. For, Being is that which is in some way or something. Here, we observe that there is an inseparable relation between university and Being. The exact relation is one of symbol (university) and symbolized (Being). In the classical Western Philosophy, Being does not restrict itself to any particular being or part of that being, but rather what is common to all beings, namely Being which is the ground of beings since all beings are in Being. Being is not a particular thing though it embraces everything in itself. That which is not particular is still something or in some way. Hence, Being is that which is in some way or something. Being is in beings. One is in many. The original *Rigvedic* notion of *Tad Ekam* (That One = Being = *Tad Ekam*) corresponds well with the notion of Being as ‘that which is in some way or something.’ Thus, the notion of Being, both Western and Indian, must be fundamentally ‘one in many.’ In a university too, many learned persons are brought together to adjust together the claims and relations of their respective subjects of investigation. They learn to respect, consult and aid each other, creating a pure and clear atmosphere of thought, though the students may pursue only a very few subjects out of the multitude. However, all of them are committed to the one educative mission of knowledge and truth, which is emancipatory from the domination and tyranny of one over many symptomized in fascist nationalism, dictatorial approaches, totalitarian outlooks, sectarian commitments, and discriminatory attitudes of many a regime all over the world.

Keywords: Being, Ontology, University, *Tad Ekam*, *Rgveda, Chandogya Upanishad,* One and Many.

Introduction

The word *university* is derived from the Latin *universum,* meaning "all things, everybody, all people, the whole world," "all together, all in one (many in one), whole, entire, relating to all," literally "turned into one," from *unus* "one" and *versus*. *Versus* is the past participle of *vertere,* which means "to turn, turn back, be turned." *Turning* implies another being / beings (many) to which that which turns is related. Turning is a relational term. One cannot also turn without being *in* a place, location, ground. Hence, etymologically, university implies 'one in many.'[1] Being also implies one in many. For, Being is that which is in some way or something. It is so in each being, which is in its own way. When each being is in its own way, all beings are in their own ways, which are many. Hence, Being is one in many.

In this Paper, a humble attempt is made to see the inseparable relation between university and Being. The exact relation seems to be one of symbol (university) and symbolized (Being). Therefore, university must be the symbol of Being. As we know, symbol is distinct from sign. Sign points to reality; whereas symbol not only points to reality but embodies in some way the reality of the symbolized.

1. Notion of Being

Everyone has an experience of 'something.' This experience of 'something' is an inescapable experience. One may escape from a particular experience, but one cannot escape from experiencing something. The most fundamental and radical question one can raise is this: 'Is there anything at all?' The answer can either be a negation or an affirmation. If it is a negation, it should be so: 'There is nothing.' Such an answer is self-contradictory as the answer affirms a negation which is again 'something.' Hence absolute negation is impossible. For, paradoxically every absolute negation presupposes an absolute affirmation upon which the negation rests. An affirmative experience of 'something' is not 'that which is not' but 'that which is' or 'Being.' In this way, Being is that which is in some way or something.[2] Before we arrive at a synthesis, it is of importance that we examine the development of the notion of Being from various perspectives of leading metaphysicians in the history of ontology.

1 R. Schwickerath, in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, https://www.newadvent.org, accessed 1 September 2022.

2 George Panthanmackel, *One in Many: An Investigation into the Metaphysical Vision of Karl Rahner* (Bangalore: SFS Publications, 1993), 37.

1.1. Being from Western Perspectives

For Heraclitus, Being is becoming. All things are in a state of ceaseless change. Beings seem to be permanent, because, we do not perceive the incessant movements in them. Everything is changed into its opposite and everything, therefore, is a union of opposites.[3] This view is opposed by Parmenides who interprets Being to be permanent without any change. Parmenides asks, how can a thing both be and not be? To say that it can is to say that something is and something is not. Or if Being has *become*, it must either have come from non-Being or from Being. If from non-Being, it has come from nothing, which is impossible; if from Being, then it has come from itself and is identical with itself, and thus has always been. Hence, there can be only one eternal, unchangeable Being.[4]

These diametrically opposed views of Heraclitus and Parmenides find a sort of reconciliation in Aristotle and Thomas Aquinas. For Aristotle, Being is whatever *is* in any way. Whenever Aristotle explains the meaning of *Being*, he does so by explaining the sense of the Greek verb *to be*. Being contains whatever items can be the subjects of true propositions containing the word *is*, whether or not the *is* is followed by a predicate. Thus, both *Socrates is* and *Socrates is wise* say something about Being. Every being in any category other than substance is a property or a modification of substance.[5] For this reason, Aristotle says that the study of substance is the way to understand the nature of Being. Thomas Aquinas holds that the immediate object of metaphysics is *ens qua ens* (being as being). The whole attention of Thomas appears to be on *ens*. *Esse* is the actual intrinsic principle which explains *ens*. However, *esse* for Thomas is more than a mere intrinsic principle. For *ens* always finds itself in *esse* which is the act of existing of *ens*. *Esse* is the Being of *ens* (entity). For Thomas, the Aristotelian definition of metaphysics as a science of *ens qua ens* is *ens* in terms of *esse.* Hence, Thomistic metaphysics primarily deals with *esse* and not with *ens*.[6] The *esse* is the foundation of the transcendental properties: oneness, truth, goodness and beauty. For Hegel, Being is indeterminate. That which is indeterminate is that which is not determinate. That which is not determinate is that which is not. That which is not is non-being. Hence non-being is at the

3 Frank Thilly, *A History of Philosophy* (Allahabad: Central Book Depot, 1981), 32.

4 Frank Thilly, 32-34; George Panthanmackel, *One In Many*: *An Investigation into the Metaphysical Vision of Karl Rahner* (Bangalore: SFS Publications, 1993), XXVII; See also Joseph Owens, "Being in Early Western Tradition," in *Question of Being: East-West Perspectives,* ed., Mervyn Sprung (Pennsylvania: State University Press, 1978), 18.

5 Michael J. Loux, *Metaphysics: A Contemporary Introduction* (London: Routledge, 1998), 3-4.

6 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Contra Gentiles*, I, c. 23. n. 236c; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I. Quest.3. Art. 4.

'heart' of Being. Hence there is a dialectic (thesis and antithesis) at the 'heart' or core of Being itself.[7]

Heidegger wanted to unearth being from beings, from the 'forgottenness' of being by the Western metaphysics. The Western metaphysics, since Aristotle, has 'forgotten' being on behalf of the beings, i.e., mistakenly identified the beingness of beings with being, described by Heidegger as *Seinsvergesenhe it* (forgottenness of being). He wants metaphysics to consider and disclose being through which all beings are beings. In this way, Heidegger makes the distinction between being and beings which he calls *ontological difference*.[8] *Dasein* discloses and expresses this ontological difference since it *stands out (ek-sistere)* of being and beings while being in them, i.e., in its very way of being *Dasein* understands its own being and the being of other beings including the being of other fellow-beings.[9]

According to Mar`echal, the intellect is active, fundamentally oriented towards its final goal, the absolute Being. The intellect is dynamic and active. Tending towards the infinite, it is not fully satisfied with any finite object. However, to the extent that a finite object participates in the infinite, the intellect finds in the object a partial goal for its appetite, and affirms it categorically, and makes a judgment of reality.[10] In other words, the *affirmation of Being is the apriori condition of the possibility of every object in consciousness*; and in every affirmation of the finite, the mind goes beyond the finite to the infinite, known as *intellectual dynamism*, a fundamental tendency in human.

For Lonergan, the most fundamental tendency is the pure desire to know. Being is the objective of the pure desire to know. The desire to know means the dynamic orientation manifested in question for intelligence and reflection. It moves human to seek understanding, and then it prevents one from being merely content with one's own imperfect, subjective personal experience. But when the knowledge grows, the objective becomes more and more known. In this way, the objective includes all that is known and all that remains to be known, namely, Being. Being is *what is known* by true judgement insofar as knowing is determinate. Being is also what is to be known by totality of true judgements in so far as the desire to know goes beyond actual knowledge. Hence, Being is all-inclusive: it is concrete and universal. Apart from Being, there is nothing.[11]

7 A. V. Miller (Tr.), *Hegel's Science of Logic,* ed., H. D. Lewis (Atlantic Highlands, N.J: Humanities Press International, INC., 1989), 111-114.

8 Martin Heidegger, *The Question of Being*, translated by W. Kluback and Jean T. Wilde (New York: Twayne Publishers, 1958), 33.

9 Martin Heidegger, *The Question of Being*, 34.

10 Joseph Donceel, *A Marechal Reader* (New York: Herder and Herder, 1970), 95.

11 Bernard Lonergan*, Insight* (New York: Longmans,1965), 348-350.

According to Karl Rahner, Being is grasped only as the act of existence of entity. Being is at once separate and united to a receptive subject that is distinct from it. In other words, in the pre-apprehension we grasp Being only through the concept of a specific, sensibly presented and particular entity. In the same say, every entity is apprehended in the pre-apprehension of the unlimited scope of all the possible objects of thought. This means that entity is apprehended at the moment when it finds itself with the totality of its possible objects of the world. In this knowledge of the world human pre-apprehends Being in its totality through question.[12]

For Emerich Coreth too, question is the starting point of metaphysics. When we ask question, we not only know how things are in relation to us but also how they are absolutely, in themselves–what it is in itself. In this way, the unconditioned, absolute Being puts an end to human question. The horizon of our questioning is the Unconditioned. The unconditioned is expressed in the word *IS* (Being). Here, Being is the unconditioned condition of all questioning. It is co-affirmed in the very act of questioning. Otherwise, we cannot even ask a question. In this way, question implies both identity and distinction, oneness and manyness, or rather the notion of Being as one in many.[13]

1.2. Being from Indian Perspectives

The Indian philosophical tradition approves that the question of Being assigned to a specific philosophical discipline such as ontology (General Metaphysics), is a symptomatically Western phenomenon. Yet Being (*sat*) is thematic in the *Vedic* and *Upanishadic* texts, and it remains a recurrent topic in later traditions. In one of the passages of the *Chandogya Upanishad*, Uddalaka Aruni teaches his son Svetaketu: "In the beginning, my dear, this world was just Being (*sat*), one only, without a second. To be sure, some people say: 'In the beginning this world was just non-being (*asat*), one only, without a second; from that non-being Being was produced.' But verily, my dear, whence could this be?… How from non-being could Being be produced? On the contrary, my dear, in the beginning this world was just Being, one only, without a second" (*Ch. Up.*, VI. 2, 1-2).

The text itself indicates that it is preceded by earlier discussions about Being and non-being. The theory of the origination of Being from non-being, to which the text explicitly refers, is found not only in the *Upanishads*, but also in the *Brahmanas*, and even in the *Rgveda* itself. Of course, there is no systematically developed terminology of Being in the *Upanishads*, and the

12 Karl Rahner, *Spirit in the World,* translated by W. Dych (London: Sheed & Ward, 1968), 209.

13 Emerich Coreth, *Metaphysics,* English Edition by Joseph Donceel with a Critique by Bernard Lonergan (New York: Seabury Press, 1973), 101.

applicability of *sat* to *Brahman* in its primeval unity remains often ambiguous. It is obvious that in these discussions the question of unity takes precedence over the question of Being. Brahman is Being insofar as it coincides with the world, with what there is. But there remains the aspect of transcendence, and *sat* alone falls short of the primeval unity of Brahman, as Being is both transcendent and immanent, identity and difference. Entities *are,* but Being alone *is*. Being transcends.[14]

Being As *Tad Ekam*

Here, in this article, the original *Rgedic* notion *Tad Ekam* (That One = Being = *Tad Ekam*) is preferred to all other terms as it corresponds well with the notion of Being as 'that which is in some way or something.' The hymn where the notion appears is the *Nasadiya Sukta* (*Rgveda* X. 129), which has been praised as containing 'the flower of Indian thought.' This hymn is the quintessence of Indian metaphysics. All things are traced to one principle. Opposites like being and non-being, life and death, night and day, are shown to be the self-unfolding of 'That One.' *Tad Ekam* is the ground of the universe. Because it is devoid of differences and definiteness, it is referred to as 'That One' which is in some way. It is neither a particular being nor non-being (nothing) but 'something' which is beyond them while being their core and ground, the Unconditioned Condition of all conditions. *Tad Ekam* had within it the latent power out of which the universe, including the gods, emerged. The point to be noted here is the conception of the ultimate Being as dynamic or self-unfolding, and as requiring no outside Power to guide and shape it. It is a hymn of Being. It is an invocation to the Being that transcends all the other beings of knowledge. It provides an experiential insight into the making of that Being. It does not deal with the beginning of the cosmos or with its evolution. It expresses a luminous awareness that Being is beyond being (existent = *sat* = *ens*) and non-being (non-existent = *asat* = *non-ens*). Being is beyond being and non-being while being in them as their only Ground.[15]

In the classical Western Philosophy, metaphysics is understood as the core and ground of human knowledge which underlies, penetrates, transforms and unifies all other disciplines of knowledge. It originates from the 'experience of something' or Being. That is to say, metaphysics does not restrict itself to any particular being or part of that being, but rather treats of what is *common to all beings*, namely Being which is the ground of beings since all beings are in Being. Being is not a particular thing though it embraces everything in itself. That which

14 George Panthanmackel, "Being as *Tad Ekam:* Western Scholastic and Indian Approaches to Metaphysics," in *Western Encounter with Indian Philosophy,* ed., Augustine Thottakara (Bangalore: Dharmaram Publications, 2002), 21-37.

15 George Panthanmackel, "Being as *Tad Ekam,"* 21-37.

is not particular is still *something or in some way.* Hence, *Being is that which is in some way or something*. Being is in beings. One is in many. The original *Rigvedic* notion of *Tad Ekam* (That One = Being = *Tad Ekam*) corresponds well with the notion of Being as 'that which is in some way or something.'[16] Thus, the notion of Being, both Western and Indian, must be fundamentally one in many.

2. Concept of University

A university is an institution of higher education and research which grants academic degrees at all levels (bachelor, master, and doctorate) in a variety of subjects. A university provides both tertiary and quaternary education.

2.1. Origin of University

The oldest known institutions of higher education are credited to Dynastic Egypt from the 3rd millennia BC, with Pr-Anx (houses of life),[17] containing works on law, architecture, mathematics, and medicine, and involved in the training of male and female Doctors. Pr-nq, House of Life, was a foundation of great importance for the elaboration of the various facets of Egypt's religious and magical culture. It was the teaching site for scribes with archives, library, and scriptorium. The House of Life already existed in the Old Kingdom in the 6th dynasty and lasted until the end of Pharaonic civilization.

In the Greek world, Plato's Academy (c. 387–386 BC), Aristotle's Lycaeum[18] (c. 334–386 BC) and other philosophical-mathematical schools became models for other establishments. Roman education aimed at producing the complete orator, whereas Greek education, at least under Plato

16 George Panthanmackel, "Being as *Tad Ekam*," 21-37.

17 In ancient Egyptian writings and architecture, the House of Life is an institution preserving and creating knowledge in written and pictorial form. One example survives in the city of Akhenaten at Amarna: there excavators found bricks stamped with the hieroglyphs for 'House of Life' from a building complex adjacent to the Storage Chamber of Documents of Pharaoh (for storing state correspondence). The complex was roughly equidistant from the central city royal palace and temple to the sun-god. In the ruins excavators retrieved fragments of papyrus with coloured vignettes. Cf. https://www.ucl.ac.uk, accessed 7 September 2022.

18 In 335 BCE, Athens fell under Macedonian rule and Aristotle, aged 50, returned from Asia. Upon his return, Aristotle began teaching regularly in the morning in the Lyceum and founded a school called "The Lyceum." The group of scholars who followed the Aristotelian doctrine came to be known as the Peripatetics due to Aristotle's habit of walking as he taught. Cf. https://www.britannica.com, accessed on 8 September 2022).

and Aristotle, aimed at producing the fully formed philosopher.[19] At the age of eighteen, an Athenian boy was subject to two years of military training.[20]

In India, the city of Takshasila, later the great Buddhist monastery of Nalanda (c. 427–1197 CE), attracted students and professors even from distant regions. Takshasila was not a university in the sense we understand today. Of course, it was a great educational centre, where scholarly teachers attracted a large number of students from various parts of South Asia. There was no central institution prescribing curricula. Each teacher had about twenty-five students specializing in subjects such as medicine, surgery, archery, the Vedas, grammar, astronomy, astrology, accounting, commerce, agriculture, music, dancing, painting, magic, snake-charming and elephant lore. The students entered upon their studies at the age of sixteen and continued to receive instruction for nearly 8 years.[21]

In China, the Han dynasty established chairs to teach the Five Confucean Classics, in the Grand School, Taixue (c. 3–1905 CE), to train personnel for administration, especially for imperial administration. The bureaucrats created by this system came to be known as the scholar official class. Only sons of the wealthy could be so since the tuition fees for the teacher could not be afforded by the poorer sections of the society.[22]

Undoubtedly, the oldest university in the world is the University of Bologna, founded in 1088. The universities of Italy and Southern France followed the example of Bologna. The universities of North Europe generally took Paris as their model. Education in the North Europe was in the hands of the Church, and the Church authorities claimed a large share in their government.[23]

2.2. Characteristics of University Education

2.2.1. University Education as Higher Education

Higher education is tertiary education leading to an academic degree. It is, also called post-secondary education. It is an optional final stage of formal learning that occurs after completion of secondary education.[24] Higher education

19 John E. Wise, *The History of Education: An Analytic Survey from the Age of Homer to the Present* (New York: Sheed and Ward, 1964), 35.

20 John E. Wise, *The History of Education*, 13.

21 S. R. Dongerkery, *University Education in India* (Bombay: 1967), 2-3.

22 Sreemati Chakrabarti, "Modernisation and Higher Education: The Chinese Case," in *Education, Development and Underdevelopment,* eds., Sureshchandra Shukla and Rekha Kaul (New Delhi: Sage Publications, 1998), 139.

23 William Boyd, *The History of Western Education* (London: Adam and Charles Black, 1954), 129-130.

24 Carter V. Good, *How to do Research in Education* (New Delhi: Cosmo Publications, 2006), 108-109.

is an optional final stage of formal learning that occurs after completion of secondary education. This consists of universities, colleges and polytechnics that offer formal degrees beyond secondary school education.

Higher education includes teaching, research and social service activities of universities. Within the realm of teaching, it includes both the *undergraduate* level and *graduate-level* (or postgraduate level).[25]

2.2.2. University as Place of Personal Development

Universities are seen as a place of great personal development, but have the reputation of isolation or independence. Universities fall within the purview of education, in particular higher education after the level considered necessary to function effectively as an adult citizen. As such, colleges teach more specialized mastery of particular skills, greater depth in academic knowledge. Universities provide the skilled human power necessary for modernization and in developing the personalities of the students.[26] This aspect of education is built on the foundation of earlier education, which includes not only academic knowledge but the emotional development of the person.

2.2.3. Universities as Places of Instruction in Skills that Promote General Powers of the Mind

In 1963, the report of the Robbins committee on higher education proclaimed the 'Robbins principle', that universities should be available to all who were qualified for them by ability and attainment. The report also defined four 'objectives essential to any properly balanced system'. The first objective was 'instruction in skills'; but universities must also promote the 'general powers of the mind', to produce 'not mere specialists but rather cultured (cultivated) humans' who are imaginative. For the justification for a university is that it preserves and promotes the connection between knowledge and the zest of life through imaginative consideration of learning. The university should impart information imaginatively. Knowledge is transformed through imaginative consideration. Imagination illumines facts.[27] Hence, the proper function of a university is the imaginative acquisition of knowledge.[28]

2.2.4. University as Place of Universal Knowledge

This can be traced to John Henry Newman, who gave the title, 'The Idea of a University Defined and Illustrated', to a series of lectures given at

25 Carter V. Good, *How to do Research in Education,* 109.

26 Philip G. Altbach, *The University in Transition: An Indian Case Study* (Bombay: Sindhu Publications, 1972), 4.

27 Alfred North Whitehead, *The Aims of Education and Other Essays* (London: Collier Macmillan Publishers, 1967), 93.

28 Alfred North Whitehead, *The Aims of Education and Other Essays*, 96.

Dublin in the 1850s. He thought that knowledge should be pursued 'for its own sake'. For him the search for truth was part of an educational ideal inseparable from moral and religious education. This ideal required a pastoral relationship between teacher and student. The personal gifts needed for research and teaching were quite different; research was best conducted outside universities. He also described the university as a place of 'universal knowledge,'[29] in which specialized training was subordinate to the pursuit of a broader liberal education. These ideals became the basis of a characteristic belief that education should aim at producing generalists rather than narrow specialists, and that non-vocational subjects could train the mind in ways applicable to a wide range of jobs.[30]

2.2.5. University as Place of Training for the Learned Professions

The union of teaching and research was based on the assumption that the subjects taught in universities had a corpus of theory and knowledge which needed to be kept up-to-date by current research. This model suited training for the 'learned' professions, which involves specialization and research.[31] But the logic of this was that vocational or technical subjects which did not fit the professional model were excluded from the university sphere.

2.2.6. University as Place of Autonomy and Academic Freedom

Autonomy and academic freedom mean that the academic staff of a university enjoy the right to teach or publish what they deem proper. For within the academic community each scholar is under the scrutiny of their colleagues. Many people know this and thus are willing to defend the autonomy and academic freedom.[32] The most authoritative recent statement is the Bologna principle that the university is an autonomous institution, with the distinctive mission of embodying and transmitting the culture of its society. 'Research and teaching must be morally and intellectually independent of all political authority and economic power,' teaching and research must be inseparable, and that 'freedom in research and training is the fundamental principle of university life.'

2.2.7. University as Seat of Unity in Diversity

Though the students cannot pursue every subject which is open to them, they will be the gainers by living among those and under those who represent

29 Fergal McGrath, *Newman's Idea of a University* (Vatican City: Urbaniana Publication, 1981), 114.

30 S. R. Dongerkery, *University Education in India* (Bombay: 1967), 212.

31 R. Dongerkery, 135-136.

32 Robert Homes Beck, *A Social History of Education* (Englewood Cliffs: Prentice-Hall, 1965), 40.

the whole circle. This is the advantage of a seat of universal learning. An assemblage of learned persons, zealous for their own sciences, and rivals of each other. They are brought together to adjust together the claims and relations of their respective subjects of investigation. They learn to respect, consult and aid each other, creating a pure and clear atmosphere of thought, which the student also breathes, though one may pursue only a very few subjects out of the multitude. The students in a university profit by an intellectual tradition, which is independent of particular teachers who guide them. They apprehend the great outlines of knowledge, the principles on which it rests, the scale of its parts, its lights and its shades, its great points and its little, as they otherwise cannot apprehend them. A habit of mind is formed which lasts through life, of which the attributes are freedom, equitableness, calmness, moderation, and wisdom.[33]

2.2.8. Unity in Diversity as the Nature of Being

Perhaps, it is difficult to find anywhere a thoroughgoing monism or pluralism. Most advocates of monism have thought of the One implying at least some sort of differentiation in itself. They are in tacit agreement with Radhakrishnan's view that the One is so far from being empty that it is characterized by a fullness that it surpasses comprehension. At the other extreme, is it possible to find a thoroughgoing pluralism? Here even Nietzsche, who denied that there is either beginning or end or middle, nonetheless taught a doctrine of eternal recurrence. Thus, we have to conclude that the extreme forms both of monism and of pluralism are untenable.[34] In the words of John Macquarrie, "The highest unity is that which already conceals within itself the richest diversity, while sheer diversity devoid of anything unifying is unthinkable. The one and the many do not stand in stark opposition to each other, for each implies the other."[35] But how do they imply each other? The question of their mutual implication calls for further ontological analysis. For the philosophical position of monism, of dualism, of radical pluralism, all depend upon the ontological solution offered to the problem of one and many: how can Being be *identical and diverse* at the same time? In order to answer this question, we need to take into account what finite being is before we probe into what Being is, viewed from Aristotelian-Thomistic perspectives.

33 John Henry Cardinal Newman, *The Idea of a University* (New York: Image Books, 1959), 128-129.

34 John Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," in *Meeting of Religions,* ed., Thomas A. Aykara (Bangalore: Dharmaram Publications, 1978), 173-174.

35 John Macquarrie, "The One and the Many: Complementality of Religions," 174.

2.2.9. Unlimited Being as One in Many

In reality, monism, dualism and pluralism, are extreme positions that create the illusion of solutions to *the problem of one and many* which can be briefly explained in this way: Every being belongs to Being. Everywhere Being reveals itself as an absolute. Every finite being is a whole being, a complete being; yet it is not the whole of Being. For it does not contain all reality, since there are beings outside of it. A particular being participates in Being. The particular being that participates in Being is a complete being, a subsistent whole unlike a part which is not a complete whole. The particular being, which is limited, is an imperfect being. It does not contain other particular beings; nor does it possess their perfection. Hence it does not contain all perfection. Consequently, it is imperfect. It does not mean that it is unfinished in itself. The perfection of every particular being belongs itself wholly to Being, and by that token it is to be distinguished from every other being. In this way Being possesses an absolute character. It is not opposed to anything. Consequently, it penetrates and envelops everything. Nevertheless, Being manifests some relativity, since the real is broken up into multiple unities which participate in Being. In other words, the participation of beings in Being is an undeniable fact. But how can we explain the fact that the distinct beings in Being preserve their autonomy? This is the fundamental metaphysical problem of one and many[36] that calls for fresh attempts aiming at a solution. Being as one-in-many can be the result of such an attempt: *Being is one*: being is that which is in some way. Insofar as it is in some way, it is one. *Being is many*: being is that which is in some way. Insofar as being is in some way, each being is in its own way. Insofar as each being is in its own way, all beings are in their own ways. When all beings are in their own ways, there would be a plurality of beings that are many. In this sense, being is many. *Being is one-in-many*: being is that which is in some way. Insofar as being is in some way, it is one. However, each being is in its own way. Insofar as each being is in its own way, all beings are in their own ways which are many. In other words, being which is in some way is also in its own way. Being is in beings, i.e., one is in many. Therefore, being is one-in-many. Being is a 'university' of one in many.

Conclusion

Etymologically, as we have seen, university means 'one in many.' Being also implies one in many. For, Being is that which is in some way or something. It is so in each being, which is in its own way. When each being is in its own way, all beings are in their own ways, which are many. Hence, Being is one in many. In the classical Western Philosophy, Being does not restrict itself to any particular being or part of that being, but rather what is *common to all beings*,

36 L. De Raeymaeker, *The Philosophy of Being* (New York: Herder, 1966), 29-32.

namely Being which is the ground of beings since all beings are in Being. Being is not a particular thing though it embraces everything in itself. That which is not particular is still *something or in some way.* Hence, *Being is that which is in some way or something*. Being is in beings. One is in many. The original *Rigvedic* notion of *Tad Ekam* (That One = Being = *Tad Ekam*) corresponds well with the notion of Being as 'that which is in some way or something.' Thus, the notion of Being, both Western and Indian, must be fundamentally one in many.

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An understanding of Being, as one in many, and university also, as one in many, can be of help in promoting emancipative education in university campuses, through emancipation from the domination and tyranny of one over many symptomized in fascist nationalism, dictatorial approaches, totalitarian outlooks, sectarian commitments, and discriminatory attitudes of many a regime all over the world.

2

Genealogy of Self-Making Experience
Thinking Beyond the Binary of Teaching and Learning

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Abstract: This essay explores the genealogy of self-making experience and challenges the binary framework of teaching and learning. The author delves into the multifaceted nature of learning, drawing on philosophical perspectives from Montaigne, Descartes, Plato, Kant, and Aristotle. The essay highlights the double movement inherent in learning, where a teacher transmits knowledge and a student receives it. However, it also questions the necessity of a teacher in all learning processes, considering the possibility of learning from personal experience. It examines the role of experience as a teacher, referencing Descartes' distinction between experiential and deductive knowledge. Additionally, the essay delves into Plato's theory of recollection, suggesting that learning is a process of remembering innate knowledge. Moving beyond the cognitive sphere, the essay explores learning as an adaptation to the environment and the integration of perceptual and affective experiences. It emphasizes the value attributed to knowledge and the role of motivation in learning, as demonstrated by Aristotle's discussion on virtue. The essay further expands the concept of learning beyond the nature-culture binary, highlighting its social and cultural dimensions. It also addresses the impact of learning on industrialization and alienation in capitalist societies. Finally, the essay calls for a deconstructive approach to

education, challenging the privileging of presence and advocating for a more nuanced understanding of learning.

Keywords: adaptation, cognition, deconstruction, double movement, education, experience, industrialization, innate knowledge, learning, motivation, nature-culture binary, recollection, self-making experience, teaching.

Introduction

"To philosophise is to learn to die,"[1] Montaigne, tells us. More broadly, one would be entitled to wonder whether philosophy does not relate to "learning" at all. What would it be then to learn? Is it possible to answer the question unequivocally, as it is true that the term seems to refer to a plurality of fields and that learning a lesson, learning to read or learning to love are expressions that seem to refer to all different realities?

Etymologically, "learn" originated from the Latin "*apprehendere*," which means to grasp or take. In learning, a specific form of appropriation or of taking possession is implied. However, the etymology seems to give us only a truncated aspect of what it means to learn. Indeed, learning is undoubtedly acquiring knowledge, but it is also teaching that facilitates acquiring knowledge. Learning is not a one-way movement but a double movement between a teacher and his student. Should we not, therefore, juxtapose the term "learn" with words that are close to it, such as teaching or instructing, to understand this double movement?

Nevertheless, learning seems fundamentally linked to the question of knowledge and correlatively to that of ignorance. However, if learning is seeking or striving to know, it seems essential to account for the modalities of learning if we want to discover what makes the nature of everything "learning". For this, it will be necessary to consider it as much from the heuristic point of view as from the pedagogical point of view and, therefore, to understand it in its purely cognitive dimension as well as in its social or cultural dimension.

As a first step, we will therefore endeavour to show the relationship between the act of learning and knowledge in all its forms. Having better circumscribed the "conditions of possibility" of learning, we must consider this possibility with the underlying need. From a vital need, we will then move on to a social need to finally consider the act of learning in its cultural dimension and its function of social cohesion, highlighting in particular the need for a social philosophy inherent in learning.

1 Michel de Montaigne, *The Complete Essays of Michel de Montaigne*, trans., Charles Cotton, ed., William Carew Hazlitt (Kansas: Digireads, 2017), 52.

I. The Double Movement

Whether we consider learning as gaining information about something we did not know or acquiring knowledge, it requires the presence of two subjects: one who transmits knowledge, the other who receives it. Relying on the ideas of Descartes, in his treatise on moral philosophy titled *The Passions of the Soul*,[2] we might think that activity and passivity belong to the teacher and the student, respectively. Indeed, while the teacher gives knowledge (which translates into a form of activity), the student receives it (which translates into a form of passivity). Yet the typical learning experience refers to a practice, an effort, an attention-involving activity of our mind. In this sense, we are very active in the act of learning. Thus, as Aristotle writes in his work *Metaphysics*, it is undoubtedly true that "By nature, all men long to know,"[3] but it is not sure that they all have the longing to learn because learning involves work, which can often discourage us.

The fact remains that this act seems to manifest itself in a double movement of thought: a movement of explanation that would be that of the teacher and a movement of understanding that would be that of the student. However, if this double movement seems to characterise the fact of learning, is the teacher-student binary still relevant? Indeed, I can learn to use a tool (a hammer, for example) without needing a teacher. Does this mean that my experience can play the role of my teacher, or does it mean that I am my own teacher?

The French distinguish between two words, "*apprendre*" and "*s'instruire*," thus distinguishing between learning from another person and learning from oneself. The former requires the presence of a teacher; it involves a form of exchange between two persons, while the latter does not require a teacher, and it is a voluntary personal act. This distinction does not answer the question of experience playing the role of a teacher. Can we consider experience as a teacher? In his work *Rules for the Direction of the Mind* (*Regulae Ad Directionem Ingenii*), Descartes presents a distinction between two methods of acquiring factual knowledge: experience and deduction. He acknowledges that our inferences drawn from experience are often prone to errors. On the other hand, Descartes emphasizes that the process of deduction, which involves deriving conclusions directly from other truths, is inherently reliable. Even if we overlook deduction sometimes,

2 René Descartes, *The Passions of the Soul and Other Late Philosophical Writings*, trans., Michael Moriarty (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2015).

3 Aristotle, *The Metaphysics*, trans., Hugh Lawson-Tancred (London: Penguin Classics, 1998), 4.

it remains infallible when carried out by a rational mind, no matter how minimally rational it may be (Rule II).[4]

Experience, although unable to offer the same level of certainty as the deductive method, remains a valid source of knowledge. However, it is worth noting that Descartes' explanation contains certain ambiguities as he further distinguishes two additional means of acquiring knowledge without any risk of error: deduction always, and intuition. Intuition, as Descartes describes it, is not the thoughtless assurance derived from the senses or the misleading judgment influenced by an inaccurate imagination. Instead, it is a clear and unclouded mental apprehension, so vivid and distinct that it leaves no room for doubt regarding the object of our understanding (Rule III).[5]

Experience in the usually understood sense of the term seems to disappear even though Descartes admits that senses and imagination are valuable support to knowledge. Therefore, whether intuitive or deductive (grasping a causal sequence or evidence), learning seems to be reduced in its most extensive and specific form to intellect. Now, since from principles that only intuition, it is possible to have a deduction, how can we understand the intuitive faculty itself if it derives its origin only from the soul? Perhaps, it is more satisfying to think with Plato that the phenomenon of learning is just a simple remembrance.

In *Meno*, Plato gives us an apt example of learning when he tries to make the slave discover how to double the surface of the square. The problem posed by Plato's *Meno* is that of the possibility of the search for knowledge. On the one hand, we cannot look for what we know since we know it, and on the other hand, we cannot look for what we do not know because we do not know what to look for. This question does not arise for Descartes because, for him, in every problem, there must be something unknown, which we must somehow designate, that is, refer to something known. Plato's views would not contradict Descartes on this subject and even the soul's immortality accounts for this "something that is known." Thus, he made Socrates say thus:

> Given, then, that the soul is immortal and has been incarnated many times, and has therefore seen things here on earth and things in the underworld too – everything, in fact – there's nothing that it hasn't learnt. Hence it isn't at all surprising that it should be possible for the soul to recall what, after all, it also knew before about excellence and about everything else. For since all nature is akin and the soul has learnt everything, there's nothing to stop a man recovering everything else by himself, once he has remembered – or 'learnt,' in common parlance – just one thing; all he needs is the fortitude not to give up the search. The point is that the search, the process of learning, is in fact nothing but recollection.[6]

There is, therefore, no teaching *per se* but recollection; we do not learn anything new, we only remember, that is, the genuine opinions that we carry within us, awakened by questioning, become sciences. However, as wonderful as it is, Platonic theory cannot allow us to define what it means to learn. By equating thought with a dialogue of the soul with itself, it helps us to understand how it is possible to learn, in other words, it expresses the capacity of each one to learn but does not provide the origin of the learning phenomenon.

II. Beyond the Cognitive Sphere

In his *Critique of Pure Reason* (Preface to the First Edition),[7] Kant posits experience as the foundation of all knowledge. According to him, all knowledge begins with experience so that understanding would "function emptily" and would not be able in any way to "learn" anything without sensitive intuition. For Kant, "to think is to know by concepts," but the cognitive process requires a triple synthesis that can give us objective knowledge of phenomena. To acquire knowledge, we initially need to encounter the phenomenon through intuitive perception. This involves a synthesis of grasping the phenomenon through our senses. Then, we must bring together the diverse intuitions within the framework of our imagination, which entails a synthesis of reproducing those intuitions. Finally, we integrate and unify this knowledge using the categories of understanding, resulting in a synthesis of recognizing and comprehending the concept.

However, Kant does not ask, "What can I learn?" but "What can I know?" so one may wonder if Kantian theory is a theory of learning (in the sense we commonly understand it). The fact remains that it recalls the central role that experience plays in knowledge, which makes Kant affirm in his *Critique of Pure Reason* (The Architectonic of Pure Reason) that there is no a *priori* possible learning except mathematics. "Among all rational sciences (a priori) therefore, only mathematics can be learned, never philosophy (except historically); rather, as far as reason is concerned, we can at best only learn *to philosophise*."[8]

It is on this role of experience that we must now focus, thus expanding the field of learning beyond the simple cognitive sphere. If we look at the

4 René Descartes, *Rules for the Direction of the Mind* [kindle format], trans., Tim Newcomb (Stuttgart: Newcomb Livraria Press, 2023).

5 Descartes, *Rules*.

6 Plato, *Meno and Other Dialogues Charmides, Laches, Lysis, Meno*, trans., Robin Waterfield (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005), 114.

7 Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, trans. and ed., Paul Guyer & Allen W. Wood (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 99-105.

8 Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, 694.

development of animal behaviour, for example, we see two major learning processes.

1. Some fully functional motor sequences develop innately, without prior education (e.g., birds learning to fly). In this sense, "learning" would reveal a form of innate knowledge, that is, genetic coding is possible for certain behaviours that express themselves during ontogenesis. Here, a parallel can be drawn with the Platonic theory, which (while remaining cautious and without falling into anachronism), already included this idea of a knowledge pre-existing in the individual.
2. There are behaviours where the maturation of anatomical structures is not enough to allow their correct realisation. Still, on the contrary, the individual gradually learns from a model provided by the external environment to learn would therefore be, above all, to imitate.

In the same way, many animals learn to recognise their congeners by visual or olfactory contact. Sense experience plays an essential role in what we must call learning since it gives rise to behaviour that did not exist until then.

The external environment should lead us to consider the phenomenon of learning about the world of the subject who learns. In reality, we can say that learning is adapting to one's environment. For example, if we place a rat in a labyrinth whose exit coincides with the presence of a reward (food), then we realise that very quickly, the rat will learn to relate two experiences: a perceptual experience, namely the configuration of the labyrinth, and an affective experience, the presence of food. This presupposes a memory—as suggested by Plato—and above all, a faculty of superimposing a value on an event. In other words, if the rat learns by "trial and error", it is because a cognitive process (retaining the path of the labyrinth) that supposes the processing of information comes to correspond to an affective process (it is good, because we get food, to get out of the labyrinth). To learn, therefore, is not only to acquire knowledge but also to give value to that knowledge. This is what the first Greek philosophers have constantly demonstrated.

Thus, when Aristotle discusses the question of virtue in *Nicomachean Ethics* (Book II),[9] he posits that to become virtuous, one must observe the virtuous man (*phronimos*). However, this learning of virtue is valuable and practical (*phronesis*) only because it is good to become virtuous. It is possible to learn only because there is a motivation to learn. Virtue, for Aristotle, is a disposition to which we must add a habitual practice (again, we find the idea that something is already there to which we add something through habitual

9 Aristotle, *The Nicomachean Ethics*, trans., David Ross (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), 23-37.

practice). Therefore, we see that learning is as vital as a necessity for a happy life. If the human person has an innate longing to know by nature, then this nature is undoubtedly part of a biological future but takes on a new dimension at the cultural level.

III. Beyond the Nature-Culture Binary

In Descartes, who claims to be self-taught, we have seen that the heuristic aspect precedes the strictly pedagogical part. However, if learning can indeed be the work of an individual approach, it implies a social character in an equally fundamental way.

In his book *La philosophie... biologique,* André Langaney, in a chapter entitled "Ignorer pour apprendre", shows that Pavlovian conditioning is a basic form of learning.[10] However, we cannot confuse it with cultural learning, which introduces the notions of teaching and education and, more fundamentally, the idea of transmission. Learning also means going from the natural to the cultural. By moving from a stereotyped behaviour (that of "genetic automata") to a more flexible and easily adaptable behaviour, learning allows us to be freed from the purely material constraints of the environment and, therefore, from natural conditions. The acquisition of "know-how" makes us "masters of nature," primarily through developing industrial techniques.

However, we must admit that this idea of learning contains negative consequences thus, as Marx analyses in *Das Capital*, the learning of increasingly rudimentary and precise gestures in modern industrial production leads to an alienation of the worker (assembly line work).[11] The labourer is relegated to the rank of automaton even if it is no longer genetic. In reality, this learning does not have a positive aspect of learning; it is even the negation of all learning because it annihilates all "know-how." It stifles the intellectual faculties and the Aristotelian Principle (the principle of motivation explained by Rawls in his work *A Theory of Justice*).[12] Thus, in a Capitalist society of production such as ours, we need to understand learning beyond the movement from natural to cultural. It becomes necessary to examine the nature-culture binary. If we are willing to examine the classical binaries such as nature-culture in the philosophy of education, it is possible to see that they find their roots in privileging presence. We need to move in the direction of deconstructive research in education.

10 André Langaney, "Ignorer pour apprendre, » *La philosophie biologique* (Berlin: Berlin Edition, 1999), 123.

11 Karl Marx, *Capital: A Critique of Political Economy*, Vol. 1, trans., Ben Fowkes (London: Penguin Classics, 2004).

12 John Rawls, *A Theory of Justice* (Cambridge: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2005), 427.

This primacy of the immediate presence inhabits the pedagogy of modernity: that nature of the child, which lacks full rationality, must undergo conversion towards the certainty of rational consciousness in the words of Durkheim. This is analogous to the entire presence of the human. On the contrary, for Rousseau, the entire presence of the child becomes corrupt when the child faces pressure to move from nature to culture through the opacity of social signs. However, Derrida shows that in Rousseau's *Emile*, the truth of the child is also the first manifestation of a lack that calls for substitution in the order of nature. Education rests on this finitude, which makes its task paradoxical. Pedagogy must intervene as little as possible and as late as possible, but it must intervene. The revelation of human finitude in childhood shows this paradox of a presence that can only reach its full manifestation by running the risk of alienating itself by exposing itself to what limits it, namely the signs of culture, which is the other of nature. This calls to our mind the practical model of learning of which Heidegger speaks in his *What is called Thinking?*[13] Learning involves inhering cherished doctrines as much as questioning them. Thus, the student-teacher relationship is a reciprocity of mutual learning and teaching.

In Plato's *Meno*, Socrates claims that he taught nothing to the slave Meno, but he only helped him to remember. Nevertheless, from reading Plato's *Meno*, we can infer that Socrates teaches the slave to reason, that is to apply the rules of logical sequence. Socrates makes us believe that the slave learns nothing because mathematical or logical reasoning is a priori, that is he deduces knowledge from principles without appealing to experience. Moreover, there is a certain irony on Plato's part in denying the possibility of teaching in the literal sense when Socrates' entire life is devoted to the "education" of his interlocutors and Plato himself founded an Academy. As Descartes understood, learning is above all learning a method and hence the need for a teacher. However, learning also requires action. Indeed, we learn by doing.

There are, however, things that we cannot learn: For example, we cannot learn common sense, which is a necessary foundation for all learning. The question then is not so much to acquire knowledge as to "learn to think." As Kant rightly states that we cannot learn philosophy (except historically), but we can only learn to philosophize. And as Hegel points out, to learn to think, we have to learn thoughts,[14] but for this learning to succeed, we have to give the student the desire to learn, because that is what teaching is all about.

13 Martin Heidegger, *What is Called Thinking?*, trans., J. Glenn Gray (New York: Harpers & Row, 1968).

14 Nigel Tubbs, "Hegel's Educational Theory and Practice," *British Journal of Educational Studies* 44, no. 2 (June 1996): 181-199; https://www.jstor.org/stable/3121731.

Learning, though understood in an individual logic, is also inter-individual because learning is communicating with others and weaving a social bond.

IV. Education as *Différance*

Weaving a social bond does not imply a full presence of the teacher or the student, but it refers to a process of "presencing," perhaps without completion. There is no full presence of the "Other" who alone, as Levinas would suggest in *Time and the Other*, instructs me to meet the ethical demands.[15] Nor is there a full presence of the student, which, as in the myth of the natural child,[16] is the constitutive basis of the educational activity. Indeed, *différance* is educative because it goes beyond the present and presents itself as a process of temporisation: it is the interval between past and present, between present and future that is marked by education. Education temporises first by inscribing the past in the living present, by transmitting traces of the past that has become knowledge. Education, like writing, is of testamentary origin: origin without origin, since indefinitely recommencing. To teach is not to constrain a private subjectivity; it is to tear the present from its solipsistic illusion to connect it to humanity. Education temporises – a second time – by turning the present towards the future. The dead time that rises in the present (anamnesis or reminiscence of Plato in *Meno*) makes possible a new writing, an inscription of oneself in the future. The learning subject then delves into his relationship to this future element: "to project," or to make oneself by throwing ahead of oneself. Teaching and learning are two sides of the same process of the *différance* in education, and likewise, all classical binaries become fragile.[17]

From this perspective, it is possible to understand, how education institutes a learning subject, for whom making of oneself becomes the fundamental mode of an incomplete presence. Teaching then is an act of producing signs pointing to the past given the future, but happening in the present to give rise to the desire to learn. However, this desire to learn would remain only a nostalgia for a past that has never been present if it did not communicate a power over the world that signs represent. Teaching certainly institutes the otherness of the student radically, as Levinas thinks,[18] in the play of traces, without any absolute origin: the past towards which the desire

15 Emmanuel Levinas, *Time and the Other*, trans., Richard A. Cohen (Pittsburg: Duquesne University Press, 1987).

16 Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *Emile or On Education*, trans., Allan Bloom (New York: Basic Books, 1979).

17 Jacques Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, trans., Gayatri Spivak (Baltimore: John Hopkins University, 1974).

18 Martine Berenpas, "On Facing One's Students: The Relevance of Emmanuel Levinas to Teaching in Times of Covid-19," *Journal of Philosophy of Education* 55, no. 4-5 (August-October 2021): 649-664; https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-9752.12576.

to learn tends will never be present, it will always be other than what the signs want to represent. Teaching is not a modelling or conforming to an archetype, to an absolute origin. This is why the temporisation of the future always "to-come" (*toujours à-venir*) makes the student engage with the text, who can then allow himself to bear a name. Derrida believes that the signature of the proper name is the characteristic of teaching.[19] Paul Ricœur is not far from this perspective when he thematises the question of the path of recognition, as an attestation given to a student about his ability to act, by passing from passivity to activity. To teach is to distribute signs by which the subject recognizes himself as belonging to a cultural and epistemological world, and recognizes himself as an actor in his projects. It is in this capacity that he knows himself.

The deconstructive approach makes it possible to go beyond the traditional *aporias* and free the philosophy of education from all positivist assurances.[20] Trifonas asserts that Derrida has contemplated the emergence and cessation of the philosopher, along with the subsequent thoughts and instruction of the child throughout their lifetime, which Derrida associates with the concepts of writing and memory.[21] In his work titled *Glas*, Derrida gives an unexpected response to a challenging question: What constitutes education? It involves the passing away of the parents, the development of the child's awareness, and the transcending of its consciousness into the realm of ideality.[22]

However, the purpose of deconstruction is one of praxis. The Derridean deconstruction opens the possibility of the philosophy of education as a social philosophy, engaged in practice through the interpretation of educational experience. Axel Honneth describes social philosophy as a specific part of Germanic thinking, independent of political philosophy, whose task is to define and analyse social pathologies. For Honneth, the founder of social philosophy is Rousseau because, in his *Discourse on the Arts and Science*, he makes the diagnosis of modernity in terms of social pathology, about the ethical criteria that the concepts of opacity and alienation make it possible to define.[23] It is in

19 Jacques Derrida, *On the Name*, ed., Thomas Dutoit, trans., David Wood, John P, Leavey, Jr., and Ian McLeod (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1995), 5.

20 Jacques Derrida, *Dissemination*, trans., Barbara Johnson (London: Athlone Press, 1981).

21 Peter Pericles Trifonas, "Jacques Derrida as a Philosopher of Education," *Educational Philosophy and Theory* 32, no. 3 (November 2007): 271-281; DOI:10.1111/j.1469-5812.2000.tb00451.x.

22 Jacques Derrida, *Glas*, trans., John P. Leavey, Jr. & Richard Rand (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1986), 132.

23 Axel Honneth, "The Depths of Recognition: The Legacy of Jean-Jacques Rousseau, in Avi Lifschitz (ed.), *Engaging with Rousseau Reaction and Interpretation from the Eighteenth Century to the Present* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 189-206.

this order of questioning that the philosophy of education can concretely meet the sciences of education from the critical point of view while escaping the dogmatism of a certain political thought. True sensitivity to social pathologies gives priority to educational fact, as Rousseau had shown the way. However, the analysis of the educational experience can take place only in the orientation proper to this sensitivity, which is an opening to the fragility of the other.

Conclusion

One of Derrida's primary objectives in his approach to deconstruction is to undermine and overcome the prevailing metaphysical perspectives that perceive education as lacking established universal foundations. The deconstruction method instructs us to relinquish long-standing empathetic tendencies that create divisions and categorizations among various phenomena, separating them into acceptable and unacceptable, right and wrong (truth and falsehood), central and subsidiary, wisdom and folly, and their reflections. Nevertheless, there is always a risk of falling into the trap of exclusively focusing on the latter aspect of such contrasts (i.e., getting lost in written form, subsidiary elements, plurality, abstraction, and differentiation) and neglecting the initial aspect, thereby encountering the very problem that deconstructionists aimed to avoid.

Every educational institution leaves a trace of the past and carries the potential of the future, as Derrida describes it, imbued with a sense of being "haunted." The positivist stance in education, which strives for an everlasting complete presence, rests on the belief in an indefinite perfectibility achieved through a transparent transfer of knowledge, free from any disruptions, due to the accumulation of positivist outcomes. Education, in a Derridean sense, embodies a form of justice, as it allows us to coexist with the "ghosts" of the past, in the realm of memory and heritage. By doing justice to those who preceded us, education enables us to be fairer towards others, recognizing that our presence, accompanied by the absence of those who came before us, should not diminish the presence of others. Let us, therefore, embrace the knowledge and wisdom passed down to us and learn to coexist with these spectral influences.

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3

Bildung in Kant, Hegel and Gadamer
A Cursory Look

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Abstract: The German term *Bildung* is more comprehensive than education and it means human development in all its multidimensionality of growth—physical, mental, spiritual and cultural. For Kant, education must civilize a person and make him a moral being. In this process, his autonomy should not be curtailed. He is an end in himself and at the same time he must be raised above his mere physical inclinations and natural tendencies to attain his moral perfection that makes him a good citizen for the nation. But the problem with such educational process is that this type of moral training can narrow down other aspects of education and make him an extremist pinned down to a view of morality that any alternative morality or leaning process will become an occasion to conflict.

Bildung, for Hegel, is the self-development and self-discovery of the child. It is a formation in which the child over comes his natural immediacy and attains maturity and self-realization. *Bildung* opens the child to the rational cognition of the world and in this cognition the otherness of the objective world is overcome through the conceptual understanding. *Bildung* for Hegel is a process of liberation. It is self-possession. In thought self realizes its universality. This universality for Hegel is that of the ideal that a State determines. State for Hegel is the locus of the realization of the self. Though set to the ideals of freedom and universality, Hegel's goals fall short

of true freedom and universality. Hegel's claim that the western education has achieved such a universality is mere euro-centrism.

For Gadamer, *Bildung* is *ormation*, a process of becoming. It is *Bildung zum Menschen*, a humane formation. It is rising up to humanity through culture. It is a dynamic process. *Bildung* essentially fulfills the need of man´s transcendence. But one thing that makes a clear distinction in Gadamer´s idea of *Bildung* is his understanding of history. History limits our knowledge. *Bildung* opens us towards knowledge, but not the absolute and universal knowledge as in Hegel, but leads us to our horizons; and transcendence of knowledge and self-actualization are extending and expanding of these horizons. Education for Gadamer is a hermeneutical endeavor. *Bildung,* for Gadamer is a humanistic pursuit with common-sense content. It is telling the right thing, telling truth. *Bildung* is for Gadamer learning truth. Common sense is not the only important aim of education, but also the sense that founds the community, tells Gadamer. *Bildung* is community-building. Education must build communities. Gadamer gives importance to common sense that serves community. Humanism is the hall mark of Gadamer's notion of education.

Keywords: *Bildung*, education, Kant, Hegel, Gadamer, formation, *sensus communis*, culture.

Introduction

The word *Bildung* is a German term and it means formation, cultivation, education, self-formation, development, etc. The term is often regarded as fundamentally dealing with the educational sciences, and education itself that transforms *homo-naturalis* into *homo-humanus. Bildung* is a nuanced terminology and many a times, it means more than the theory of education or the pragmatics of formation. It also means cultural and aesthetic cultivation.

There is a very strong historical and thematic development of the idea of *Bildung* in the German tradition of Philosophy. The focus of education in American tradition is that of a pragmatic orientation than its German counterpart. Although both these ideas are interconnected, traditional development of these two streams of understanding calls for a dialogue which we shall undertake sometime later.

The word *Bildung* is a rather imprecise term and culture specific and it means different things in different contexts. In some contexts, it can mean formation, education, cultivation, self-development, *cultural* integration, self-formation, self-cultivation, cultural process, etc. Richard Rorty uses the term meaning "edification" to denote Georg Gadamer's ideas in *Wahrheit und Methode.* But, none of these terms above will satisfy the nuances of the term as fully as in Gadamer's use.

Obviously, this German term, *Bildung* has a German tradition of about two hundred years or more. *Bildung* means more than mere academics or education. It means, "cultivation" of the human being into a social being, into a citizen and spiritual entity. Hellenistic term of *Bildung,* is *cultura animi*—cultivation of the soul—like that of a field which yields fruits by cultivation. Roman orator Cicero is credited to use this term originally, meaning refining of the soul.

On the other hand, the Christian notion of *Imago Dei,* God's image is recaptured in the word in *Bildung.* Human beings are God's own image and to recapture this image of man, *Bildung* is a formative process. The root of the word, *Bilden* means 'to form,' 'to create.' *Das Bild,* the picture, into which we human beings shape ourself into is the image of God. Both the Hellenistic tradition and the Christian tradition of *Bildung* see it as a process in which a person develops himself or herself as an improved and refined self, adapting to his social and physical environment. *Bildung* in modern pedagogic is self-formation and the aim is to become a better person in a society and transcend from the natural self to a higher self. In the words of Kant, "Bildung is the realization of the idea of a humanity, of a human becoming human…. It is a historical process in which a natural creature becomes a cultural creature, by which *homo barbarous* becomes *homo humanus.*"[1] For Kant, *Bildung* is the realization of the human being in his totality and multi-dimensionality.

1. Kant on *Bildung*

According to Kant, man is the only being who needs education. Education is that makes him a human being. Education includes, nurture, discipline and moral training. Animals on the other hand use their natural powers, their instincts to survive. Animals need only food and protection in its development. Man requires discipline and training to develop, he needs to be educated. Discipline is that transforms man from his animal nature into human nature. Human child needs nurturing — loving care and attention plus training. What animals need is only protection from adverse situations. Natural endowment and hidden talents of a child unfolds in the company of parents and the closest family circles. A child in the family learns to behave and to mold his animal instincts into socially acceptable behavior which makes the child socially capable in a community. Education makes a child what she/or he is.

When the education is neglected for a child, it becomes unruly and ill-behaved and often of an anti-social in nature. Each generation educates the next generation to become more refined and more human. Every generation of human beings improves and takes a step forward in humanity through

1 As cited by Pauli Siljander, Ari Kivelä and Ari Sutinen, *Theories of Bildung and Growth* (Rotterdam, Boston, Taipei: Sense Publishers, 2012), 4.

education. Mankind progresses its inner spirit gradually through education to its full human potentiality. According to Kleingeld, Kant hopes to transform the human society into an ideal moral community through education.[2]

So, for Kant, education is a process with a moral goal. It is to make the individual a human being. Education is to facilitate her/him to attain moral ideals in the society. Every human being is, for Kant an end in himself. The final goal of all education is to attain the human destiny which is none other than achieving the fullness of humanity — her/his self-realization. Ana Marta Gonzales would put this idea in the following manner: "We understand that, in saying that humanity is the goal of education, Kant is claiming that the educational process must be *guided* by the moral law, and should lead to the full flourishing of each personality."[3]

This humanity is not understood by Kant as something that exists in every human being, rather as an ideal that law-giving reason attains for the whole species. In his *Metaphysics of Morals*, Kant speaks of this law-giving reason that makes our humanity as universal.[4] This humanity is not confined to a particular class of people or political groupings, but to all of human species itself. It is universal. Hence an important aspect of education for Kant is to rise above our historical and social particularities and recognize our common humanity.[5] This ideal humanity is morally upheld by reason. Educational process must be thus guided by the moral law which is also rational.

Kant speaks of law-giving reason in his *Metaphysics of Morals.* Law-giving reason covers all human species.[6] Gonzales elaborates: Law-giving reason is universal. It is attributable to every human being, even to children. Law-giving reason as the foundation of our humanity leads to a moral culture. Education is the road to this moral culture which is the goal of all education.[7] School teaching should enable and empower the child not only to succeed in life, but also to inculcate values of self-worth, and citizenship, that he becomes valuable to fellow citizens. According to Kant, "School- teaching bestows upon each member an individual value of his own. Next by learning the lessons of discretion in the practical matters of life, he is educated as a citizen, and becomes of value to his fellow-citizens, learning both how to accommodate

2 Pauline Kleingeld, "Kant, History and the Idea of Moral Development," in *History of Philosophy Quarterly* 16, no. 1 (November 1999): 61.

3 Ana Marta Gonzales, "Kant's Philosophy of Education: Between Relational and Systematic Approaches," *Journal of Philosophy of Education* 45, no. 3 (August 2011): 436. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9752.2011.00809.x.

4 Immanuel Kant, *Metaphysics of Morals*, trans., M. Gregor (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), 451.

5 Ana M. Gonzales, "Kant's Philosophy of Education," 436.

6 Immanuel Kant, *Metaphysics of Morals,* 6:451.

7 Ana Marta Gonzales, "Kant's Philosophy of Education," 436.

himself to their society and also how to profit by it. Lastly, moral training imparts to man a value with regard to the whole human race."[8]

Kant emphasizes that the care of children at home is essential, just as the rulers' care for the state is essential. However, the care of the education of a child should be under the care of enlightened teachers and experts who manage the school as well as can ensure the universal good and the perfection to which man is destined. It is these enlightened men, the educators who can realize the rightful human destiny. In his own words: "It is only through the efforts of people of broader views, who takes an interest in the universal good, and who are capable of entertaining the idea of a better condition of things in the future, that the gradual progress of human nature towards its goal is possible."[9]

However, Kant insists that education does not and should not treat the child as a means to an end. Education in effect must consider the individual student as an end in herself/himself, and gradually develop her/him into autonomous human agents. Education primarily aims at perfecting the child into a human person from the primitive animal nature. For Kant, education is an ordered process of care, discipline, instruction and formation of the child.

In his *Critique of the Power of Judgement*, Kant observes that culture is the ultimate end of nature.[10] Culture is but nature disciplined. Lack of discipline is a greater evil than neglect of culture. Neglect of culture can be remedied even later, but not indiscipline and unruliness in behavior. A mistake in discipline can never be repaired.[11] Human nature ultimately aims at culture and culture aims at moral ends. If culture is not brought to moral ends, it can deteriorate into evil. In man there are gems of good. There is also the presence of radical evil in us which can subordinate the moral ends into the pursuit of one's own happiness. The role of discipline is to educate one's inclinations, in order to make her/him receptive to higher moral ends.[12]

According to Kant, evil is the result of nature that is not being brought under control.[13] When a man is educated, nature is perfected and forms culture. In Kant's own words: "…it is delightful to realize that through education human nature will be continually improved, and brought to such a condition as

8 Immanuel Kant, *Education,* trans., A. Churton (Michigan: University of Michigan, 1960), 9:455.

9 Immanuel Kant, *Education,* 9:449, (16-17).

10 Immanuel Kant, *Critique of the Power of Judgement,* trans., P. Guzer, and E. Mathews (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000), 5, 431-2.

11 Immanuel Kant, *Education*, 9:443 (7).

12 Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Power of Judgement,* 431-2.

13 Immanuel Kant, *Education,* 9:448.

is worthy of the nature of man. This opens out to us the prospect of a happier human race in the future."[14]

Education civilizes and enculturates a child in the social world in which he is born and brought up. He pursues through education moral and cultural perfection that is the final destiny of the human race. The *raison de´tre* of all education is for Kant the moral perfection and a happier human race.

Modern societies with the arrival of scientific education have failed to insert this most essential element of education, namely the moral aspect into our educational system in spite of the experiences of the Nazi horror or the ecological disaster of the world or the pandemic experiences. Negligent attitude to moral education is a matter of concern for a number of Kantian thinkers today such as Robert B. Louden, (2011) Allen W. Wood, Paul Formosa (2017), Jean Grenberg, G. Felicitas Munzel, (1999) Kate M. Moran, Klaus Roth, (2011) Pablo Muchnik and others.[15] Our propensity to evil in our incessant pursuit to knowledge needs to be countered by cultivating moral virtues; of love towards other human beings, of compassion and enhancement of our humanity.

"Children ought to be educated, not for the present, but for a possibly improved condition of man in the future; that is, in a manner which is adapted to the idea of humanity and the whole destiny of man…", wrote Kant.[16] As mentioned above, education of the children should be entrusted to enlightened experts rather than to Parents or even rulers. For both the parents and the rulers, their educational goals can be narrow, whereas for the experts it can be more cosmopolitan and universal.[17] In the same spirit, Kant also promotes public education to private education. In public education, which is publicly funded education, besides imparting knowledge, a universal moral culture is also imparted.[18] This is the Kantian insight.

However, such an education is not an easy task. According to him, the art of governance, and the art of education are the two difficult tasks. "Hence the greatest and most difficult problem to which man can devote himself is the problem of education. For insight depends on education, and education in its turn depends on insight."[19]

14 Immanuel Kant, 9:444.

15 Klas Roth and Paul Formosa, "Kant on Education and Evil—Perfecting Human Beings with an Innate Propensity to Radical Evil," *Educational Philosophy and Theory* 51, no. 13 (2018): 1304-1307.

16 Immanuel Kant, *Education,* 9:447.

17 Immanuel Kant, *Education*, 9:449.

18 Immanuel Kant, *Education*, 9:452.

19 Immanuel Kant, *Education*, 9:446.

Since education is looked at also as a moral enterprise, its advancement cannot be expected from mere pragmatic reason. Although, scientific reasoning can aid moral advancement, that in itself does not assure moral progress. Moral advancement of a society is a gradual process. And it takes place in slow degrees. In Kant's own words, "Education can only advance by slow degrees, and a true conception of the method of education can only arise when one generation transmits to the next its stores of experience and knowledge, each generation adding something of its own before transmitting them to the following."[20]

In nutshell, we may draw the following aspects of Kant's notion of *Bildung* as our conclusion: (1) Educational process is a moral enterprise (2) Progress in education is transmitted from one generation to the next (3) At the individual level of the child, education means achievement in self-discipline, scientific ability in living one's life, discretion and moral advancement. (4) The aim of education is the improvement of humanity as a whole in individuals as well as society. (5) The education process aims at developing human potentialities at the pragmatic and moral level and advancement in theoretical horizon. Moral reason guides human progress and the advancement of the species.

In this process, as we have already pointed out, there is no room for curtailing the autonomy of the individual who is an end in itself. Any restriction should be seen as a step forward to the autonomy of the individual. "Man's moral capacity would not be virtue, were it not produced by the strength of his resolution in conflict with powerful opposing inclinations. Virtue is the product of pure practical reason insofar as it gains ascendancy over such inclinations with consciousness of its supremacy (based on freedom)."[21] *Bildung* for Kant, is both an end and a means in the formation of a moral Society.

2. Hegel on *Bildung*

Having skimmed through the Kantian views on education, let us spend a while with Hegel that the *Bildung* notion of Gadamer becomes clearer to understand. Hegel was an acclaimed educationist and philosophy Professor. In Hegel's view, *Bildung*, means formation, development and also culture. *Bildung* is formative self-development of mind/spirit, which is a historical and social entity. *Bildung* is a self-discovery for a child, in which the child overcomes his natural immediacy, uncertainty and immaturity *(Roheit*). Child is not gathering information from the teacher, but receives an upbringing, *Erziehung*. *Bildung* is the internalizing, which is a self-directed activity in

20 Immanuel Kant, *Education*, 9:446.

21 Immanuel Kant, *Metaphysics of Morals,* trans., M. Gregor (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996): 6:477.

which the child overcomes his self-centeredness and attains universality. He learns to overcome his particularity and egoistic inclinations. Many a times, this is a frustrating experience for the child and is in conflict with his natural tendencies and Inclinations.

Bildung for Hegel is the rational cognition of the world. In understanding a given object is received by the human mind in a rational form. Rational understanding is the analytic cognition of an object. Always, the rational understanding is a conceptual understanding. Allen W. Wood of the Yale University would put it in the following manner:

> In true cognition, the otherness of the object is overcome through a struggle with it, and the mind is reconciled to the given through acquiring a rational understanding of it. What was given immediately as familiar at the start of the process is now an otherness overcome; the object is no longer present in its immediate form, but is now grasped by means of a universal concept produced by the mind, Ih therefore recognizes itself in the object.[22]

Mind's new relationship with the object of knowledge is for Hegel, spirit's actualization of freedom. Knowledge constitutes freedom and vice versa. "Only in freedom, is the will completely with itself, because it has reference to nothing but itself, so that every relationship of dependence on something other than itself is thereby eliminated."[23] *Bildung* therefore, tells Allenwood, is a process of liberation, in which the freedom of spirit is vindicated over the mere positivity of what is given in nature.[24] *Bildung* then for Hegel is a process of liberation. It is the freedom of the spirit over what is given in nature as mere positivity. This positivity is transformed into a thought. Minds relationship to nature is free and justifying through its own logic. Thing for the spirit is then thought. In thought, thing becomes actual. What is actual is spirit and spirit alone is actual.[25]

Education for Hegel then is *Gedanke der Sache behaupt*—the thought of the thing. It is the "laborious emergence from the immediacy of substantial life." It is the "acquisition of the universal principles or the thought of the thing."[26] In the words of Allen Wood, "*Bildung* is simultaneously a process of

22 Allen W. Wood, "Hegel on Education," in ed., Amelie O. Rorty, *Philosophy as Education* (London: Routledge, 1998), 4.

23 *Phenomenoligie des Geistes, Werke 3*, cited by Allen W. Wood, "Hegel on Education," *Philosophy as Education* (London: Routledge, 1998), 4.

24 Allen Wood, "Hegel on Education," 5.

25 *Phenomenolgie des Geistes*, 25.

26 *Phenomenolgie des Geistes,* 4.

self-transformation and an acquisition of the power to grasp and articulate the reason for what one believes or knows."[27] It is a liberating maturation of the subject concerned. "Acquiring a genuinely rational comprehension of things goes hand in hand with a process of liberating maturation through a struggle involving selfhood and the overcoming of self-conflict."[28] Knowing is the self-realization. It is the spirit striving to realize itself.

Hegel's first major work, the *Phenomenology of Spirit*, takes up the long process of education (*Bildung*) towards genuine Philosophy. According to him, true education moves towards philosophy. Education leads man to true science varying in specificity and explicitness. Education is the course of the human spirit that marches through historical path to realize itself. Hegel understands this as the submission of the individual consciousness to universal consciousness. Universal consciousness in fact is the individual self itself. Self-actualization for Hegel is self-cancellation of the natural-self that strives for universal-self. In his *Introduction to Phenomenology*, Hegel speaks of the two fundamental features or moments of the shape of consciousness: the first moment of it is "knowing," and the second is "truth."[29] In the words of Allen Wood, "consciousness has a conception of what it is to know reality, and also a conception of the nature of the reality that is to be known."[30] The "moment of knowledge" and the "moment of truth" must agree one another in any genuine knowledge. When consciousness is not in harmony with the given knowledge and the given truth, consciousness marches forward to reach a knowledge that does not contradict its truth. This is the dialectical process of the march of the spirit to truth. Here the spirit attains itself the fulness. Knowledge and truth coincide in the Absolute truth.

Christian culture, according to Hegel, is the alienation of the spirit as it seeks an other-worldly Kingdom, where citizenship is promised. Here on earth, Christian spirit only experiences alienation. This, for Hegel is the cancellation of the natural self, attaining its fulfillment here below. This is nothing but the alienation of the spirit.[31] Hegel engages with the world here below, where human alienation is to be overcome.

The individual spirit is united to the universal spirit and this according to Hegel completes culture. Culture for Hegel is the rising of the individual spirit to its universality. *Bildung* is aimed at reaching to this universality. This

27 Allen Wood, "Hegel on Education," 5.

28 Allen Wood, "Hegel on Education," 5.

29 *Phenomenologie des Geistes,* 82.

30 Allen Wood, "Hegel on Education," 6.

31 *Phenemenologie des Geistes*, 485-489.

means, that the individual is still submitted to the universal substance. This universal substance is for Hegel, the state.[32]

State is the ultimate point in which the individual self attains its culture by its devoted submission to the state. Self-alienation from culture occurs when state power confronts as the other and works against the individual self by sheer opposition to private wealth, etc. For Hegel, culture consists in putting one's private wealth in the service of the universal good.[33] For Hegel, modern monarchical states of his times are ordered to achieve certain universal and rational structure of state sovereignty, that they command self-cultivation which could lead to enlightenment and moral self-consciousness.[34]

This self-cultivation which is rational and universal in nature leads to its own freedom. In the words of Terry Pinkard,

> Civil society offers a new realm of freedom that is very similar to that of "Abstract Right": individual understanding themselves as free in that each is "doing what he wants" with his property within the "social space" created by the sphere of abstract rights that each individual brings with him. Within the "social space" each appears to be self-determining, for each appears to be setting his own particular ends, whatever those ends may be, and to be acting on those ends.[35]

As for Hegel, modern culture forms the modern self-actualization and its freedom. Modern culture shapes the moral subject which finds its self-actualization in subjective freedom.[36] Hegel posits civil society as the locus where *Bildung* (education of individual) takes place. It is there, where the shaping of the culture as a universal morality occurs.[37]

Hegel conceives civil society as the source of both modern market economy and consequently the regulating legal system that protects individual in this social system. It is this arrangement of civil society that paves the ground for a social home where individual freedom flourishes.[38] *Bildung* is then the formation of individuals in freedom. *Bildung* facilitates the functions in the civil society.

32 *Phenemenologie des Geistes*, 494.

33 *Phenemenologie des Geistes*, 499-503.

34 *Phenemenologie des Geistes*, 508-511.

35 Terry Pinkard, *Hegel's Phenomenology, the Sociality of Reason* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994).

36 Hegel, *Grundlinen der Philosophie des Rechts, Werke 7* (Oxford: Oxford Press), 106.

37 Hegel, *Grundlinen der Philosophie des Rechts,*182.

38 Hegel, *Grundlinen der Philosophie des Rechts*, 250-256.

Hegel does not see, how the demands of the modern societies require the curtailing of the freedom of individuals as well as their self-interests. Instead, he sees civil society as a means for the individual in realizing his/her freedom and fulfillment. State is not for him an end in itself. Every state is in the making from the present state of imperfection to more rational status. The existing states are transitional and perfecting towards more rational stages.

Gradually, the economic aspects of the state create social systems which create its own imperatives. These create interdependence of every stakeholder of the state and practical and theoretical education for the production process, etc. To be successfully integrated to such a society requires, better educational skills, intellectual capabilities, better communication and language skills. At the end what matters in this transition to modern society is education.

Hegel is quite well updated of the modern education as a slavery to the goals of the state. Corruption of the state has affected modern education. Education itself is corrupted. It has ordered itself towards market economy. Hegel hopes that the present scenario will change and that at the end the spirit and reason will overcome these corruptions and move forward from immediacy and individuality to total liberation. In his own words, "Education (*Bildung*), in its absolute determination, is therefore liberation and work toward a higher liberation; it is the absolute transition to the infinitely subjective substantiality of ethical life, which is no longer immediate and natural, but spiritual and at the same time raised to the shape of universality."[39] The nature of the spirit is liberation and universality.

Education for Hegel is not a means to an end. It is an end in itself. It is neither for mere self-satisfaction or fulfillment, or for meeting any particular ends. In his *Philosophy of Rights*, Hegel states it categorically: "Education is an immanent movement of the absolute, and it has infinite value."[40] In spite of all the corruptions and distortions, education has infinite value.

Ethical simplicity and natural immediacy of the earlier times of customary societies for Hegel is unreflectivity and illusory freedom. Unreflective traditional freedom of earlier societies is premodern and lack subjective substantiality and universality. Education is the foundation for reflective morality and happiness. Ethical life and education go hand in hand for Hegel. Education leads to an "absolute transition to the infinitely subjective substantiality of ethical life."[41] True ethical life is not any unreflective habituation. Instead, it is a rational self-harmony, achieved through *Bildung*.[42]

39 Hegel, *Grundlinen der Philosophie des Rechts*, 187, Cited by Allen Wood.

40 Hegel, *Philosophy of Rights*, 187.

41 Hegel, *Philosophy of Rights*, 187.

42 Allen Wood, "Hegel on Education," 19.

Bildung, Hegel considers has the crucial role in realizing freedom of the spirit which is the absolute end of reason. Discipline plays a substantial role in the *Bildung*. Overcoming the arbitrary will of the child and the natural dispositions and immediacy, children are guided to the adult world of the civil society. Stern self-disciplining of the child, for Hegel is the essential ingredient of the *Bildung*.[43] Thus, he opposes the modern liberal educational policy. Strict *Bildung* in education can only ensure that the child imbues the needed moral discipline as an adult that makes the transition from a family to a civil society. Child may not initially understand this. Hegel puts his ideas in the following words:

> In fact, if one waits to acquaint the human being with such things until he is fully capable of grasping ethical concepts in their entire truth, then few would ever possess this capacity, and these few hardly before the end of their life. It is precisely the lack of ethical reflection which delays the cultivation of this grasp, just as it delays the cultivation of moral feeling.[44]

Hegel's views on education which are rather strict should be seen in the light of his philosophy of the spirit. The march of reason to universality is the transition from particularity to universality. It is in universal reason, individual reason has its true liberation, freedom. Education aims at developing the individual to rise from the merely individual feelings and inclinations to universal and social imperatives. True education achieves a harmony of individual's personal life with his universal and social existence. Hegel insists that the particular and universal are not in conflict, but in harmony.

Hegel in the same train of thought considers European education as the most universalizing and hence civilizing education, and the model of *Bildung*, for the entire world. Hegel is as often, euro-centric in his educational views too, and this euro-centrism was a point of discussion in one of our earlier Seminars, we held years back in Pune. Nevertheless, we need to accept the view that Hegel's ideas on *Bildung* certainly widen our horizon on education and much could be learnt from him on this topic. However, Hegel's over confidence and for that matter, the over confidence of enlightenment rationality itself is very much criticized in our times.

The way enlightenment reason, for example trampled upon the non-European cultures, how the whole debate on of development versus underdevelopment, and the standard of progress, etc., need critical evaluation. Furthermore, we need to evaluate what is reason; is there a single path of

43 Hegel, *Philosophy of Right,* 174.

44 Hegel, *Werke: Theoriewerkausgabe* (Frankfurt: Suhrkamp,1970), 4:347. As cited by Allen W. Wood, 23.

rational progress or are there not many paths and many directions? Modernity and Hegel has stumbled upon our contemporary experiences and we need to accept Hegel in his views on education with some critical caution and after much evaluation.

3. Bildung in Hans Georg Gadamer

The way ahead of enlightenment reason in *Bildung* is also a concern of Hans-George Gadamer. According to him, the greatest idea of the eighteenth-century Europe was the concept of self-formation, education, or cultivation (*Bildung*) that replaced the perfectionism of enlightenment with the new ideal of "cultivation of the human," "*Bildung zum Menschen*", and paved the way for human sciences.[45] The project of enlightenment reason in Hegel is aimed at attaining the highest goal of human perfection and freedom, but for Gadamer it is *Bildung zum Menschen*, cultivation of the human. This 'cultivation of the human,' which Gadamer refers to in Johann Gottfried Herder is to "rise up to humanity through culture." *Bildung* (cultivation) culture is the guiding concept of the humanism for Gadamer.[46]

Bildung in Hegel is directed to cultural formation. But in Gadamer, *Bildung* "evokes the ancient mystical tradition according to which man carries in his soul the image of God after whom he is fashioned and which man must cultivate in himself." *Bildung* for Gadamer is no longer 'culture,' i.e., developing one's capacities or talents. "*Bildung* is *ormation*."[47] *Bildung* is a continuous happening, a process. It is becoming, a continuous transition, *formulierung*, from being to becoming. It is not mere development of talents and capacities of a person. It is formation which is dynamic. Gadamer will put it in this way:

> "*Formulierung* and formation – have long vied with the word *Bildung*. Since the Aristotelianism of the Renaissance the word forma has been completely separated from its technical meaning and interpreted in a purely dynamic and natural way. Yet the victory of the word Bildung over "form" does not seem to be fortuitous. For in Bildung there is Bild. The idea of "form" lacks the mysterious ambiguity of Bild, which comprehends Nachbild (image, copy) and Vorbild (model).[48]

Bildung is an end in itself. It is not any result-oriented process, but the process *itself. It is not a means to an end.*

45 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method* (London: Bloomsbury Publishing, 2019), 8.

46 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method*, 9.

47 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method*, 10.

48 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

> …the concept of Bildung transcends that of the mere cultivation of given talents from which concept it is derived. The cultivation of a talent is the development of something that is given, so that practicing and cultivating it is a mere means to an end… in Bildung what is absorbed is not like a means that has lost its function. Rather, in acquired Bildung nothing disappears, but everything is preserved.[49]

Like Hegel, Gadamer too considers *Bildung* as a genuine historical idea. According to Hegel, *Bildung* has its condition in our existence. Rational nature of man demands his transcendence. *Bildung* is essentially, this rising to the transcendence, to universality. "For the being of *Geist* (spirit) has an essential connection with the idea of *Bildung*."[50] As human beings, we become genuinely human through *Bildung*. Human rationality is of a transcending nature. *Bildung* essentially fulfills this need of the human reason.

> Man is characterized by the break with the immediate and the natural that the intellectual, rational side of his nature demands of him. "In this sphere he is not, by nature, what he should be" – and hence he needs Bildung.[51]

In *Bildung* our particularity is suspended for the universality. The formal nature of *Bildung*, is acquiring this universality. It is rising to the universality. In deductive as well as inductive thinking human mind rises above the given to the universal. This rising to universality is what *Bildung* achieves. This rising to universality is not merely confined only to theoretical *Bildung*, but to all rational activities of man. "Rising to the universal is not limited to theoretical *Bildung* and does not mean only a theoretical orientation in contrast to a practical one, but covers the essential character of human rationality as a whole."[52] And without the *Bildung* human being would be *ungebildet* ("unformed"). "It is the universal nature of human *Bildung* to constitute itself as a universal intellectual being. Whoever abandons himself to his particularity is *ungebildet.*"[53] To be educated is to be universal.

This universality is freedom from the dictates of one's natural desires, one's immediate satisfactions. Gadamer observes like Hegel in his Phenomenology of the Spirit, that true freedom is for self-consciousness in

49 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 11.

50 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

51 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

52 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

53 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

and for itself. It is the essence of work and work itself that "consciousness finds itself again, as independent consciousness… working consciousness raises itself above the immediacy of its existence to universality: or as Hegel puts it, by forming the thing, it forms itself."[54] Working consciousness is a self-transcending consciousness and distance itself "from the immediacy of desire, of personal need and private interest and the exacting demand of the universal."[55] It is the work that forms the self. In work and gaining a skill one gains the sense of self.

Like in Hegel, for Gadamer what makes oneself is one's labour. One's skill in one's profession is that which overcomes one´s alienation from the object. One's profession overcomes one´s particularity. In the words of Gadamer;

> Practical Bildung is seen in one's fulfilling one's profession wholly, in all its aspects. But this includes overcoming the element in it that is alien to the particularity which is oneself, and making it wholly one's own. Thus, to give oneself to the universality of a profession is at the same time "to know how to limit oneself – i.e., to make one's profession wholly one's concern.[56]

In practical life, it is one's labour and profession, by which one attains universality. According to Gadamer, all the more it is in theoretical *Bildung*, individual attains universality. *Bildung*, leads one beyond oneself and one´s experiences. "Theoretical *Bildung* leads beyond what man knows and experiences immediately."[57] Theoretical *Bildung* achieves universal viewpoints, by which man grasps 'without selfishness' and in greater freedom. Theoretical *Bildung* is the basic movement of the spirit towards its alien and returning to oneself, his own self-knowledge is enhanced. "To recognize one's own in the alien, to become at home in it, is the basic movement of the spirit, whose being consists only in returning to itself from what is other."[58] For Gadamer, all theoretical *Bildung*, even learning foreign languages and foreign conceptual words are *Bildung.*

What constitutes the essence of *Bildung*, is not merely the alienation, but self-actualization. It is the return back of the spirit from the alien to one's self, ones acquainted realm. Every individual is engaged in the process of *Bildung*. This to and fro movement from the acquainted to the universal and *vice-versa* does not complete itself as *Bildung*. Coming back to itself, self is enhanced

54 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 12.

55 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

56 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 12-13.

57 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 13.

58 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

and enriched. *Bildung* changes the self, and open itself to the universal, not the Absolute as Hegel imagines. It overcomes selfishness and frees him from his private desires and the objects of his desires and makes himself free. It elevates the mind from the particular to the universal.

Bildung, accepts Gadamer, frees the spirit to a universality which is historical, not absolute as in Hegel. *Bildung* is historical. Human spirit is historical and no knowledge is absolute or complete. "We must realize that the idea of perfect *Bildung* remains a necessary ideal even for the historical sciences that depart from Hegel."[59] Human consciousness is a historical consciousness and our historicity limits our knowledge.

Bildung for Gadamer is a humanistic pursuit; it is far from the scholastic ideal of knowledge that is posted as a methodological pursuit. In Gadamer, *Bildung* is a human project, and it must be pursued with a humanistic perspective, especially in human sciences. Knowledge in human sciences do not yield to methodology or systemic and mathematical path.

Gadamer takes the help of G. B. Vico, *On the Study Methods of Our Time*, and shows that how humanism, as a pedagogical system of the Jesuit education, is directed against Jansenists and even Descartes' methodology. This has re-established common sense as a humanistic ideal of *eloquentia*. '*Eloquentia*,' clarifies Gadamer is not merely "talking well", but saying "right thing" or saying truth.[60] Contrasting the notion of *eloquentia*, as mere talking well, Gadamer asserts that truth is the content of speech.

With Vico and other authors, Gadamer establishes that humanism and common sense (*sensus communis*) is equally important in *Bildung*. This in effect is a view totally contradicting the scientific and mathematical approach of modern education. Ancients developed prudence and eloquence as essential to wisdom.[61] Gadamer contrasts between a scholar and wise man – a contrast he draws from the cynics. The content of this contrast is based on the idea of *ormat* and *phronesis*. And for Gadamer, *ormat* is what the *phronesis* draws its strength from.

Now Gadamer finds that what is most important in *Bildung* is not *sensus communis* (common sense) alone, more the sense that founds the community.

> But the most important thing in education is still something else – the training in sensus communis, which is not nourished on the true but on the probable, the verisimilar. The main thing for our purposes is that here sensus communis obviously does not mean only that general faculty in all men but the sense that founds community.[62]

59 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 14.

60 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 18.

61 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 19.

Community, communal dimension of *Bildung* introduces humanism. Humanism in *Bildung* is invoked even by Socrates, tells Gadamer. And Vico considers that the modern sciences following the mathematical methods – logic, lack the wisdom of the ancients. Sciences follow a method that neglects the human necessities. Reason can only lead to abstract universality.

> What gives the human will its direction is not the abstract universality of reason, but the concrete universality represented by the community of a group, a people, a nation, or the whole human race. Hence, developing this communal sense is of decisive importance for living.[63]

Developing a sense of living communally is essential for any science. *Bildung* must essentially serve the community. Critical research and enquiry are not alone enough for education. It requires an ethical dimension. *Phronesis* (practical knowledge) involves in Aristotle ethical virtues.[64] *Phronesis*, "presupposes a direction of the will i.e., moral being."[65] *Bildung* is not seen as a theoretical process by Gadamer, but as practical and hence ethical. *Bildung* as *sensus Communis*, for Vico and others, "is a sense of what is right, and of the common good, that is found in all men… it is a sense that is acquired through living in the community and is determined by its structures and aims."[66]

Sensus Communis or common sense, should not be conceived as "practical shrewdness" or mere "general cleverness", warns Gadamer. It distinguishes between "what should, and what should not be done, what is proper and what is improper."[67] Communal sense brings in a knowledge, beyond logical or merely argumentative type of understanding. Such knowledge has no less value than the deductive type of knowledge, tells Gadamer.[68] He accepts history and tradition as valid source of knowledge of this kind. He cites Cicero and Bacon for the support of such knowledge in contrast to scientific knowledge or knowledge that is based on syllogistic conclusions.[69]

62 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

63 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 20.

64 *Nichomachean Ethics*, VI,9.1141, cited by Gadamer, *Truth and Method*, 93.

65 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method*, 20.

66 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method*, 21.

67 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

68 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* p. 22.

69 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method. Historia* is a source of truth totally different from theoretical reason. This is what Cicero meant when he called the *vita memoriae.* It exists

Gadamer is promoting the humanistic tradition of knowledge vis-à-vis rational knowledge and oppose the merely rational and methodological thinking common to a number of modern scientific search for truth. *Sensus communis* which is adhered by Vico as well as Gadamer in their research in human sciences squarely oppose the concept of method employed in natural sciences. Developing a sense of living communally is essential in science. *Bildung* ultimately must serve the community. Critical research and enquiry alone is not enough for education. It requires an ethical dimension. *Phronesis* (Practical knowledge) involves in Aristotle ethical virtues.[70] Phronesis presupposes a direction of the will, i.e., moral being.[71] *Phronesis* for Aristotle is an intellectual virtue and the capacity, *Dunamis* of a moral being. *Bildung* is not only seen as a theoretical process but also as a practical, and hence an ethical reality. For Vico, however, "sensus communis is the sense of what is right and of the common good that is to be found in all men; moreover, it is a sense that is acquired through living in the community and is determined by its structures and aims."[72]

Gadamer sees communal sense, brings in a knowledge beyond the logical and syllogistic variety of knowledge. "Community mediates its own positive knowledge."[73] He considers such knowledge has no less value than syllogistic knowledge. He considers history and tradition as valid source of knowledge. He cites Cicero and Bacon for the support of such knowledge in contrast to scientific knowledge or knowledge based on syllogistic conclusions.[74]

Earl Schaftesbury of England whom Gadamer refers in this connection promotes *sensus communis* and speak of "sense of the common weal", and the "love of the community or society" natural affection, humanity, obligingness etc.[75] For Schaftesbury, *sensus communis* is not merely "a social virtue or virtue of the heart more than of the head, but a moral and aesthetic metaphysics."[76] A humanistic and moral approach to knowledge has its background not in Greek philosophy rather in stoics, tells Gadamer. Humanist dimension of knowledge is employed in humor and wit in in typical Roman style in social intercourse.

in its own right because human passions cannot be governed by the universal prescriptions of reason. In this sphere one needs, rather, convincing examples as only history can offer them. That is why Bacon describes *historia*, which supplies these examples, as virtually another way of philosophizing.

70 *Nichomachean Ethics*, VI,9.1141, as it is referred by Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 20.

71 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 20.

72 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 21.

73 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

74 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

75 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 23.

76 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method.*

This implies certain moral and metaphysical basis, observes Gadamer. This means sympathy is an element of learning.

Realizing common sense as the goal of learning (*Bildung),* is compared to the German notion of *der gesunde Menschen Verstand* (sound understanding). According to Gadamer this sound understanding is connected to the concept of judgement- *Gesunder Menschen verstand,* is also *gemeiner Verstand, common understanding*.[77] Common understanding, tells Gadamer is without reflection. It is a sense, un reflected yet internally coherent sense.[78] This *sensus judicium* is like taste and is a moral sense. The goal of all Bildung is to achieve this *gemein Verstand*, common sense, that serves the community. I shall not dwell on this topic any longer.

All education for Gadamer is a hermeneutical task. Education opens our minds and hearts to the multiplicity of understanding of the reality surrounding us. It opens the minds to the horizons of our world and we shall dwell on the matter a bit further. Common sense that serves the community which is the essential goal of any *Bildung*, is a hermeneutical phenomenon.

Education is to open up our minds to the multiplicity of understanding in any multicultural and pluralistic world. We must recognize through our education that there is multiplicity of understanding and truths at any given time. Education is to make us open to this multiplicity of understanding, and open our minds to the horizons of others and their universes. It is here that the *Bildung*, vision of Gadamer becomes unique and contemporary.

Bildung is neither mere self-perfection or self- transcendence or moral perfection for Gadamer nor is it a movement towards the truth of the Being or a mere self-transcendence. It a humanistic pursuit that opens the mind and heart of the students to a new world of the other, that earns our attention. Gadamer's hermeneutic philosophy introduces us to a new way of learning and understanding in the multicultural context and relationships. It is an inter-disciplinary approach to knowledge rooted in the historicity of our existence.

Conclusion

Those of you who went through this essay with a critical perspective would notice a gradual change in view on education from Kant to Hegel. Kant´s view on education is that it makes man from a natural creature, *homo-barbarous to* a *homo-humanus.* Human beings are moral beings and Bildung forms man into moral creatures. Homo Sapiens are moral and reason which is the foundation of moral life is developed in education. Bildung is to make every human being into a moral person.

77 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 28.

78 Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Truth and Method,* 29.

Education civilizes and makes of every individual a moral person and a good citizen, who will contribute to the development of happier and wholesome human race. In this process of Bildung, the individual person is treated always as an end in itself and his autonomy is should not be overlooked or curtailed. Moral virtues are gained by restricting the wild and natural inclinations of the child. Education is grounded on human freedom.

We must admit that Kantian notion of education as moral training has its positive elements, but at the same time at the negative side, Bildung is narrowed down to a character formation and ethical training. Education is more than mere an ethical training. It makes the world of the child too narrow and shut the world off from him its wonder and amazement. This would deprive the child of that world of new discoveries and snub his curiosity and wonder. Mere ethical training is a partial formation of the child and not a wholistic education.

This can also turn education into a one-sided education program of religio-ethical nature and lose the universality of education itself. The danger of education that turns into a religio-ethnic extremism especially in a multicultural world like our own today can have politically dangerous consequences. One need to take note that Bildung in this case has wide reaching ramification for the entire world as the global community need to be cautious and vigilant. Particular and partial ethical norms could pose itself as universal and threaten peace and stability in the global context. Such educational practices are not unknown to our contemporary times.

Although, Kant makes sufficient caution against such happening through his ideas of the postulates, postulates in themselves will not with stand the onslaught of social pressure and majoritarian perspectives. Ethical principles could be distorted and universality of them can be claimed. Aggrieved communities and groups may posit their own ethical principles serving their own interests but that can threaten general peace and stability.

Nevertheless, at the same time, the need of ethical and moral education cannot be over emphasized in a highly secularized world of contemporary education. Value neutral education is a utopia and lead the world to uncertain consequences. Universally acceptable moral training, in a pluralistic society is a herculean task that each educationist face and its challenges need to be born in mind.

Hegel goes much ahead of Kant in his understanding of *Bildung*. *Bildung,* for him, is the self-development and self-discovery of the child. *Bildung* is formation in which the child overcomes his natural immediacy and uncertainty and attains maturity and universality. *Bildung* opens the child to the rational cognition of the world. In this cognition, the otherness of the objective world is overcome through his conceptual understanding.

For Hegel, knowledge constitutes freedom. *Bildung* is a process of liberation. It is the freedom of the spirit; it is the self-possession of the spirit. It

is thought, and in thought self attains self-realization. In *Bildung* universality of the individual spirit is realized.

But then, Hegel invents the locus of this universal existence of the individual in the state. Modern monarchical state of his times as per Hegel, may not be the perfect locus of realizing the Spirit, but such a perfect state is in the making. Due to the corruption in the state, education too could be corrupted. Market economy corrupts the state. Hegel is of the opinion that this state of affairs will be overcome by reason and move forward to the perfection of the state. Existing states are transitional and the present scenario is to be overcome by the spirit. The nature of the spirit is liberation and universality, avers Hegel. Hegel does not see the possibility of worsening the situation and the state itself can fail due to corruption. Hegel admits to the point that modern education is a drudgery-it is slavery to the goals set by the state.

Education should be an end in itself. It is the immanent movement of the absolute Spirit. Ethical life and education are the two sides of the same coin. True ethical life is a rational harmony. It is not any unreflective habituation. It is the realization of the freedom of the Spirit and true harmony in life that spirit attains in its march to universality. Such a universality of the Spirit, Hegel claims to have reached in European education. Hegel is an incorrigible Euro-centric philosopher.

Hegel's problem with regard to education realizing universality is that, it is the state that determines what this universality and self-realization means. State is the locus of the fulfilment of the Spirit. It is the state that decides the goal of education. Here Hegel's self-realizing Spirit is subjected to the state. An education, programmed and oriented to the goals set by the state and the rulers could be partial and blind and self-serving for the ruling elite and their interests.

Although, set to the ideals of freedom and universality, Hegel's goals fall short of true universality and freedom. States often become narrow entities in a globalized universe claiming universality, but serving interests of the ruling class. Hegelian notions of education need further re-evaluation and critical assessment in our times.

For Hans Georg Gadamer too, *Bildung* in the post enlightenment times is a major concern. Enlightenment reason proposed certainty, perfection, self-formation, etc., as its goal. Gadamer is not so sure of such goals. Gadamer replaces the enlightenment ideals with his *Bildung zum Menschen*—a humane education or cultivation. *Bildung zum Menschen,* for Gadamer, is to rise up to humanity through culture. (p.11) Hegel too Bildung is directed to cultural formation.

For Gadamer Bildung is *ormation,* a process, a becoming. It is dynamic. *Bildung* is an end which is historical as in Hegel. As human beings, we become genuinely human in the process of education. Bildung essentially

fulfills the need for human transcendence. Man´s transcendence is essentially abandoning the immediacy and particularity to universality. This takes place not merely in theoretical Bildung but all Bildung. "Whoever abandons himself in particularity is *ungebildet*," tells Gadamer.

The universality one achieves in *Bildung* is freedom, is liberation. In *Bildung* and his labour, man overcomes his self-alienation. *Bildung* leads one beyond himself and his experiences and lead to self-enrichment and self-expression. In *Bildung* unlike in Hegel, in Gadamer, man does not open to the Absolute, rather to himself. *Bildung* is a self-opening to historical knowledge and history.

Human spirit is historical and our history limits our knowledge. We do not open ourselves to infinite knowledge or the Absolute as claimed by Hegel. Our transcendence is a self-actualization. It is a to and fro movement from what is immediate to what is alien to him and then returning back to him, he is enriched and his horizons are expanded. This movement does not leave one to the realm of Absolute or Infinity.

Bildung for Gadamer is a humanistic pursuit. It is not a methodical effort. Primarily it is a commonsensical pursuit of truth. It is "*eloquentia.*" *Eloquentia* is not merely talking well, but "telling the right thing," i.e., telling truth. For Gadamer, in talking well truth is the content of speech. Humanism and common sense are the most important aspect of education.

Common sense is the humanistic ideal of *eloquentia.* It is not only talking well but also talking truth and talking the right thing. Truth must be the content of speech. *Bildung* is then learning truth.

Common sense, *sensus communis* is not the only important aim of education, but the sense that founds the community. Community or communal sense, a sense for living communally is essential for education. *Bildung* has an essential ethical dimension. However, it is not anything of the type of ethics that Kant suggests. *Bildung* is for Gadamer not a theoretical achievement, but a practical and hence ethical action.

The German notion of the *Gesunder Menschen Verstand* (sound human understanding) is also *gemeiner Menschen Verstand*, common human understanding. Common human understanding may lack reflection, yet it is internally coherent and serves community. Education must serve community, not as in Hegel dwells in oblivion of the Absolute abstract and unattainable.

Gadamer sees education as a hermeneutical task. It must open us to our horizons. It must open us to the multiplicity of the understanding and truths. Pluralistic societies are called for such understanding and tolerance.

Education must have a humanistic orientation. Gadamer's hermeneutics opens a new world of learning in a globalized world. Our understanding is historical and not merely self-transcendent and moral. It needs to open ourselves to the world of the other. Humanism should be the hall mark of

contemporary education. The new horizon that opens us today to the education of future generations is a challenge as well as a hitherto unforeseen potentiality assuring infinite possibilities and a promise of a new form of human existence. We are called to form a humane and inclusive world of a future humanity on which the future of human species hinges.

4

Plurality of Knowledge
Foucault's Perspective

Kamaladevi Kunkolienker

Abstract: This paper attempts to understand Michel Foucault's concept of power/knowledge, which is different from the traditional one. He employs different methods and strategies to reveal the underlying structures and linkages to understand the discourses of various periods and times. Terms like archaeology, genealogy, resistance, bio-power, will to know and truth, subject and so on which are used by Foucault in his analysis of historical events/ problems faced by human beings like madness, imprisonment and punishment, sexuality, which are a result of power-relations shared in a particular discourse by particular people are also looked into. An appraisal of Foucault's power/ knowledge concept also finds a place, by way of concluding remarks to understand his contribution to postmodern philosophy.

Keywords: Foucault, power/knowledge, discourse, archaeology, genealogy, subject, biopower, resistance.

Introduction

"Critique doesn't have to be the premise of a deduction which concludes: this then is what needs to be done. It should be an instrument for those who fight, those who resist and refuse what is…It is a challenge to what is."[1]

1 Michel Foucault, "Truth, Power and the Self: an interview with Michel Foucault," in Luther Martin, Huck Gutman and Patrick Hutton, eds., *Technologies of the Self* (Amherst:

The philosophy for Michel Foucault was a way of questioning the already established truths, which are sometimes considered as necessary truths. These truths are often involved in, or rather form the bedrock of underpinning the practices and institutions of modern society. Immanuel Kant tried to determine the a-priori boundaries of human knowledge, whereas Foucault aimed at revealing through his works on various issues—the historical contingency of ideas, those present themselves as necessary, and unsurpassable truths. He wrote book-length histories of madness, clinical medicine, the social sciences, the prison, ancient and modern sexuality.

Generally, debate over 'power' ranges across political ideologies, methodologies as discussed in various disciplines. Michel Foucault's views in his works and interviews, gives this debate over power yet another twist.

Foucault's works are mainly concerned with the relation between social structures, institutions and the individuals. For him, the notion of an individual is problematic and it is in the relationship between the individual and the institution, according to him, the power operating most clearly. In all his works, such as – *Madness and Civilization: A History of Insanity* (1967), *The History of Sexuality* (1978), *Power/ Knowledge* (1980), *The Birth of the Clinic* (1973) and *Discipline and Punish* (1977), he focused on the analysis of the effects of various institutions on the groups of people and the role that these people played in affirming or resisting these effects.

1. Power / Knowledge Twinning

Foucault in his essay on *Power* / *Knowledge* (1980) investigates into the relation between these two concepts – one political and the other epistemic. According to him, in order that something to be established as a fact or as true, the other equally valid statements have to be discredited and denied. So, rather than focusing on individual thinkers who developed certain ideas, he focused on the more abstract institutionalized processes at work, which establish something as a fact or as knowledge. He discussed his ideas or views about knowledge/power in his works—*The Order of Things* (1970) and *The Archaeology of Knowledge* (1972).

Archaeology was an essential method for Foucault because it supported a historiography that did not rest on the primacy of the consciousness of individual subjects; it allowed the historian of thought to operate at an unconscious level that displaced the primacy of the subject found in both phenomenology and in traditional historiography. However, archaeology's critical force was restricted to the comparison of the different discursive formations of different periods. Such comparisons could suggest the contingency of a given way of thinking. But mere archaeological analysis

University of Massachusetts Press, 1988), 11.

could say nothing about the causes of the transition from one way of thinking to another. So, he had to ignore perhaps the most forceful case for the contingency of entrenched contemporary positions. He introduced another term 'genealogy', to resolve this difficulty. We observe that, Foucault was influenced by Nietzsche's 'genealogy of morals.' Particularly, with its suggestion of complex, mundane, dishonorable origins in no way part of any grand scheme of progressive history. The point of a genealogical analysis is to show that a given system of thought was the result of contingent turns of history, not the outcome of rationally inevitable trends. It uncovered in its essential structures by archaeology, which therefore becomes part of Foucault's historiography.

In *Archaeology of Knowledge*, Foucault discusses the concept of discourse which is central to his thought and analysis of history of ideas. His method of the archaeology seeks to describe discourses in the conditions of their emergence and transformation rather than in their deeper, hidden meaning. In his analysis, he views ideas of a period both in their continuity and discontinuity. In each period of civilization there are layers of discourse, that is thinking about social institutions, issues and events. Archaeology of knowledge is not the history of ideas either. It does not focus on thoughts, representations, images and themes. He asserts: "Archaeology is not an interpretative discipline; it does not seek another, better hidden discourse. It refuses to be allegorical"[2] (Foucault Michel, 1969, 1972: 138-139). Archaeology defines discourses in their specificity. He is not interested in the evolution of discourse. Rather he focusses on a discourse of a particular period is different from discourse of another period, for instance, the thinking that prevailed about madness or sexuality in renaissance and later periods in history.

Next, archaeology concentrates on the types of rules which control the discourse. There may be several discourses in a period, but he is concerned about the 'types of rules' which organize and control the discourse. According to him, archaeology gives a systematic description of the discourse object. For instance, he focusses on systematic description of clinic, layer after layer in different periods in his work. He observes that history of ideas as involved in seeking to repress contradictions to show coherence in continuity in ideas. Discourses emerge on the basis of such contradictions. They function throughout the discourse as a principle of its historicity.

The archaeology of knowledge is inter-discursive: it deals with the tangle of contradictions and analogies that make up one discourse in contrast to others. The key idea in Foucault's *Archaeology of Knowledge* is to find positive knowledge about man and knowledge for the welfare of man. Thus, his approach was constructionist approach. According to him, knowledge

became a tool to subordinate the individual that is subject. So, subjectivity and knowledge are his major concerns in his early works.

Foucault's book, *Discipline and Punish*, focusses on emergence of prison system. According to him, the prison is an institution which calls for reform of the prisoner as an integral and permanent part. Jeremy Bentham's "panopticon", a design for a prison, exercised an influence on nineteenth century strict architecture. Institutional architecture was more generally up to the level of city planning. The important general idea of the book is "discipline" in the strict sense, a specific historical form of power that was taken up by the state with professional soldiering in the 17th century and spread widely across society, first via the panoptic prison, then via the division of labor in the factory and universal education. The purpose of discipline is to produce "docile bodies", the individual movements of which can be controlled and which in turn involves the psychological monitoring and control of the individual.

Bentham presented his idea of an inspection house. He presented his creation as a universal model for all buildings involved in activities that required supervisions. For example, hospital, asylums, work houses, schools, etc. His model provided an answer to the question of how a few could watch the many and this surveillance could be made more effective, so that those who were watched could always be observed and thus must live their lives knowing there was a risk they could also be seen. Thus, Foucault, through the use of Bentham's panopticon method demonstrates that it is the wielding of power which brings about the discipline in society.

According to Foucault, architecture serves in making individuals seeable, "to act on those in shelters, to provide a hold on their conduct, to carry the effects of their power right to them, to make it possible to know them, to alter them"[3] (Foucault, 1979:172). Further, he mentions that, architecture alone falls short of making visibility constant. In order to make this visibility perpetual, there is an "implementation of a hierarchical network within the group of individuals who occupy a particular architectural space. Foucault mentions that, surveillance operated in the asylum in the early nineteenth century not only through a doctor but also through supervisors who reported on patients, and servants, who feigned servitude to patients while gathering and transmitting information about them to the doctor"[4] (Foucault M., *Psychiatric Power*: Lectures at the college de France, 2006a: 4-6). This particular example of observation or surveillance demonstrates the communication of the 'gaze' from the top to the bottom, in which its 'hierarchical' feature is revealed. Foucault further reminds us that the 'gaze' may operate in a more multi-directional manner to the point of bearing on the supervisors themselves.

The above-mentioned example of examination combines the techniques of hierarchical observation and normalizing judgement in a 'normalizing

gaze' which further sustains the exercise of disciplinary power (Foucault, 1979:184). Foucault points out that this gaze is a good economical formula which "manifests the subjection of those who are perceived as objects and the objectification of those who are subjected"[5] (Ibid: 184-5). In other words, the examination binds the exercise of disciplinary power to the formation of a disciplinary knowledge.

This leads Foucault to an analysis of the specific historical dynamics of power. He introduces the concept of "biopower", which combines disciplinary power as discussed in *Discipline and Punish*, with a "biopolitics" that invests people's lives at a biological level, "making" us live according to norms, in order to regulate humanity at the level of the population.

He is critical of the notion that power is something which a group of people or an institution possess, and next, the idea that power is only concerned with constraining and oppressing people. Rather than simply looking at power from negative perspective, Foucault maintained that, even at their most constraining and oppressive measures, are in fact productive, which give rise to new forms of behaviour, rather than simply closing down or censoring certain forms of behaviour.

Foucault in his work on *History of Sexuality* (1990) clarifies about his understanding of the term 'power,' but first he mentions what according to him is excluded in terms of understanding: "[T]he word power is apt to lead to a number of misunderstandings—misunderstandings with respect to its form and its unity. By power, I do not mean "power" as a group of institutions and mechanisms that ensure the subservience of the citizens of a given state [such as characterize many liberal analyses]. By power, I do not mean, either, a mode of subjugation which, in contrast to violence, has the form of the rule [typical of psychoanalytic approaches]. Finally, I do not have in mind a general system of domination exerted by one group over another [i.e., class oppression], a system whose effects, through successive derivations, pervade the entire social body [as in many Marxist views]"[6] (Foucault M., *History of Sexuality*, 1990a:92).

Sovereignty, law and domination as three forms of power may be present in certain contexts as terminal forms, but according to Foucault, none of them are fundamental. He takes up the task of understanding power as a strategy to develop a new method, based on a richer theory that begins with basic molecules of power relations and further building more complex forms. At the outset, Foucault criticized what according to him was the most important misconception of power, i.e., 'Juridico-discursive' understanding of power.

Foucauldian view of power in his own words is stated here: "It seems to me that power must be understood in the first instance as [1] the multiplicity of force relations immanent in the sphere in which they operate and which constitute their own organisation as [2] the process which, through a ceaseless

struggles and confrontations, transforms, strengthens, or reverses them; as [3] the support which these force relations find in one another, thus forming a chain or a system, or on the contrary, the disjunctions and the contradictions which isolate them from one another; and lastly, as [4] the strategies in which they take effect, whose general design or institutional crystallization is embodied in the state apparatus, in the formulation of the law, in the various social hegemonies"[7] (ibid, 92-93).

Foucault insists on a close relationship between power and force relations, relations that are characterized by resistance and which interact by means of local tactics. He asserts that power is always accompanied by resistance. According to him, resistance is in fact a fundamental structural feature of power: "Where there is power, there is resistance, and yet, or rather consequently, this resistance is never in a position of exteriority in relation to power"[8] (ibid, 95). Resistance cannot be external to power, according to Foucault, because power is not a system of domination with an inside and outside. Power is exercised in the very interplay of force and resistance; and this interplay is observed in all social interactions. This interplay is revealed in micro interactions among people or between individuals as well as states. Even while each person shows resistance to any policy or decision, the ultimate outcome of the relation cannot be controlled by one party—as power is intentional but non-subjective.

2. Power – Knowledge: Historical Perspective

Power/knowledge in history of philosophy is recognised as two distinct but related concepts. In Plato's philosophy, for instance, he thought that philosophers, who were best able to understand the concept of justice in itself would be the best rulers and so should be entrusted with the political power, since they alone would be able to wield that power and justify. According to Aristotle, those who have the 'phronesis' (practical wisdom) are good rulers. His ideas about practical knowledge similarly influenced his views on the nature of government and the correct use of political power as a part of practical problem solving. While in the modern period, the political philosophers like Thomas Hobbes, John Locke and Jean Jacques Rousseau in their philosophies sought the foundation of human rationality for political purposes, to shape the political reality of human kind. Thus, for Plato, Aristotle, and for Hobbes, Locke and Rousseau, knowledge and power were related but still separate in principle.

According to Foucault, power and knowledge are inseparable. They were and are treated as two different concepts: power as political concept and knowledge as an epistemological concept. However, Foucault blends them together. In his book *Power/Knowledge* he describes knowledge as being a conjunction of power/knowledge. In one of his essays entitled *Prison Talk*, he

states that, "it is not possible for power to be exercised without knowledge, it is impossible for knowledge not to engender power"[9] (Foucault M., *Truth and Power*, 1980d: 52). Those who have reflected on Foucault's works, consider this as an important theoretical advance in the discussion on knowledge. Since it emphasises the way, that knowledge is not dispassionate but rather an integral part of struggles over power. However, it should be also noticed that, it also draws our attention to the way that in producing knowledge, one is also making a claim to power.

3. Power and Power - Relations

Foucault views power more like a strategy than a possession. He puts it in the following way in *Power/Knowledge*: "power must be analysed as something which circulates, or as something which only functions in the form of a chain. It is never localised here or there, never in anybody's hand, never appropriated as a commodity or piece of wealth. Power is employed and exercised through a net like organisation. And not only do individuals circulate between its threads; they are always in the position of simultaneously undergoing and exercising this power. They are not only its inert or consenting target. They are always also the elements of its articulation. In other words, individuals are the vehicles of power, not its points of application"[10] (Foucault M., *Power/Knowledge*, 1980: 98). We may note some important features of Foucault's concept of power. He conceptualised power as a net, that is a system of relations spread throughout society, rather than simply as a set of relations between the oppressed and the oppressor. And next, we should not look at individuals as simply the recipients of power, but rather as the 'place' or the medium where power is enacted and also a place where power is resisted. Therefore, his theorising of power compels us to reconceptualise not only the power itself, but also the role that individuals play in power relations. That is, further inquiring into it, whether they are simply subjected to oppression or whether they actively play a role in the form of their relations with others and with institutions. Foucault finds that it is productive of some form of behaviour that we do not notice.

Unlike Marxist theorisation, Foucault's model of power does not mean only top-down power relationships which is seen in the relationship between a monarch, such as king or queen and his or her subjects. In fact, power relationships for him includes not only top-down, they can be bottom-up, lateral, overlapping or even bidirectional relationships within a setup. In other words, he focusses on the way power relations permeate all relations within all levels of social existence and are therefore to be found operating at every site of social life—in the private spheres of the family and sexuality as much as in the public spheres of the politics, the economy and the law.

The social relationships between peers or between faculty members, are lateral power relationships, that are just as relevant to how knowledge is produced and what becomes accepted as true. These are instances of lateral power relationships that are not hierarchical. However, they have profound impact on what counts as knowledge or truth, both at the level of a particular educational institution and globally in terms of cultural contexts in which the knowledge produced is either accepted or rejected in the cultural context as a whole.

Further, it also allows an analysis which focusses on individuals as active subjects, as agents rather than as passive entities. This suggests that we all are to a certain degree caught up in the circulation of power. That is, power relations produce discourse and knowledge.

To dismantle power, we need to produce knowledge. Where there are imbalances of power relations between groups of people or between institutions/states, there will be production of knowledge. For instance, Foucault would argue that because of the institutionalised imbalance in power relations between men and women, information is produced about women and so, more books are produced on women but few about men. Another example that he gives is about heterosexuality, which remains unanalysed, while homosexuality is the subject of many studies.

Foucault appreciated the fact that the knowledge which was created and particularly by thinkers like Albert Einstein or Louis Pasteur who were able to transcend the conventional ideas of their period and were able to formulate completely new ideas and theoretical perspectives. The same is true for 'Vedic' knowledge as well. Similarly, the history of ideas within the philosophical tradition is largely characterized by the contribution of great thinkers. But Foucault was interested in producing a much more anonymous, institutionalised and rule-governed model of knowledge production.

As Ian Hunter states, "Foucault's reformulation of the concept of discourse derives from his attempts to provide histories of knowledge of what men and women have thought. Foucault's histories are not histories of ideas, opinions or influences nor are they histories of the way in which economic, political and social contexts have shaped ideas or opinions. Rather they are reconstructions of the *material conditions* of thought or 'knowledge'. They represent an attempt to produce what Foucault calls an archaeology of the material conditions of thought/knowledge, conditions which are not reducible to the idea of 'consciousness' or the idea of 'mind'"[11] (Hunter, cited in Kendall and Wickham 1999:35). Further, Foucault characterises power/knowledge as an abstract force which determines what may be known, rather than individual thinkers develop ideas and knowledge.

He asserts, "the subject who knows, the objects to be known and the modalities of knowledge must be regarded as so many effects of [the] fundamental implications of power – knowledge and their historical transformations. In short it is not the activity of the subject of knowledge that produces a corpus of knowledge, useful or resistant to power, but power-knowledge, the processes and struggles that traverse it, and of which it is made up, that determines the forms and possible domains of knowledge"[12] (Foucault M., 1991a: 27-28).

Foucault maintains that it is power/knowledge which produces facts and the individual scholars are simply the vehicles or sites where this knowledge is produced. For him the set of procedures which produce knowledge and 'keep' knowledge in circulation can be termed as 'episteme'. That is, in each historical period, there exist the set of rules and conceptual tools for thinking about what comes as factual changes. He gives an example of 'will to know' as a type of conceptual tool, which according to him characterises the 'episteme.' This 'will to know' is a voracious appetite for information, which was either accompanied by or perhaps prior to which, developed a set of procedures for categorising and measuring objects. He further assumed that, this 'will to know' or 'will to truth' are not unchanging universal truths, although sometimes we may feel so, but we should view this 'will to know' as reinforced and renewed by whole strata of practices, pedagogies, libraries, institutions, technologies and so on and so forth.

According to Foucault, truth, like knowledge is not an abstract entity, as maintained by many thinkers in the philosophical traditions. He asserts that the truth is of the world and it is produced there by virtue of multiple constraints. His view of truth is in contrast with the conventional view of truth which is conceived as a 'richness, a fecundity, a gentle and insidiously universal force'. His 'will to truth' refers to the set of exclusionary practices, whose function is to establish distinction between those statements which will be considered to be false and which will be considered true. The true statements then will be circulated throughout society and will be reproduced in books. These statements then will be commented upon, described and evaluated by others in books and articles. According to him, false statements will not be reproduced. These true statements then will become the part of 'common sense knowledge' within society. Further, he also asserts that, every society has its own 'regime of truth' which is expressed through a type of statements made by authorised people and accepted by the people as a whole.

Truth, power and knowledge are intricately connected. He feels the need to analyse the working of power in the production of knowledge. All knowledge is possible only within a network or system of power relations which allows knowledge come to be. Anything to be counted as knowledge requires a network of power structures and relations. Scientific knowledge is produced by institutions funded by the corporations or the government. The kind of knowledge that emerges depends upon the kind of power, which

remains invisible but knowledge becomes visible. It is the power relation that determines what is to be included or to be excluded from knowledge and truth.

4. Discourse

The idea of discourse is central to all his thought. It is a framework of thinking of a people about a problem.

Foucault used the term 'discourse' to refer to the "general domain of all statements, sometimes as an individualizable group of statements, and sometimes as a regulated practice that accounts for a number of statements"[13] (Foucault M., *Archaeology of Knowledge*, 1972:80). He was interested in the rules and practices that produced meaningful statements and regulated discourse in different historical periods. According to Foucault, a discourse is "a group of statements which provide a language for talking about – a way of representing the knowledge about – a particular topic at a particular historical moment…Discourse is about the production of knowledge. But… since all social practices entail *meaning,* and meanings shape and influence what we do – our conduct – all practices have a discursive aspect"[14] (Margaret Wetherell, et al., *Discourse, Theory and Practice*, 2004:72). Thus, discourse is not simply a linguistic concept but it also refers to language and practice. Thus, it overcomes the traditional distinction between what one says and what one does. Discourse constructs the topic; it defines and produces the object of our knowledge. Foucault asserted that a discourse never consists of one statement, one text, one action or one source.

A discourse according to Foucault should be seen as both, an overall term to refer to all statements, the rules whereby those statements are formed and also the processes whereby those statements are circulated, and the other statements are excluded. He uses many terms within 'theorising' that takes place in a discourse – terms like episteme, archives, discursive formation, statements – which gained importance in his philosophy.

The groupings of discursive formations and the relationships between discourses at any one time – Foucault terms the ensemble of this practices as 'episteme'. This term which is connected to production of knowledge, that is 'episteme' of a period is not "the sum of its knowledge, nor the general style of its research, but the divergence, the distances, the oppositions, the differences, the relations of its various scientific discourses: the episteme is not a sort of grand underlying reality, it is a space of dispersion, it is an open and doubtless indefinitely describable field of relationships"[15] (Foucault M., 1991a: 55). Therefore, it implies that it is not the sum total of everything which can be known within a period. Next, it is a complex set or relationships between the knowledges which are produced within a particular period and the rules by which new knowledge is generated. Foucault uses the term 'archive' to refer to the unwritten rules which lead to the production of certain types of statements

and the sum total of discursive formations circulating at any one time. He uses the term 'discursive formations' to refer to the regular associations and groupings of particular type of statements – which are associated with particular institutions or fields of power and which impacts individuals thinking. And so, a statement may be viewed as an authorised proposition. Not all statements or even those who make it are taken equally seriously – unless they have power-relations.

The reason why his analysis of statements may be called as unique is that, he tries to analyse statements, "without referring to the consciousness, obscure or explicit of speaking subjects; without referring to the facts of discourse to the will – perhaps involuntary – of their authors; without having recourse to that intention of saying what always goes beyond what is actually said; without trying to capture the fugitive unheard subtlety of a word which has no text"[16] (Foucault 1991a: 59). Foucault is interested in analysing discourse as an impersonal system which exceeds the individual.

This leads us to the problem of subject in Foucault's discourse. Edward McGushin, in his article titled "Foucault's Theory and Practice of Subjectivity", states that Foucault "defines "subjectivity" as what we make of ourselves when we do devote ourselves to taking care of ourselves"[17] (*Key Concepts*, 2012:128). Foucault was very critical of the traditional concept of subject. As per the conventional notion of 'the subject' is an individual who is fully endowed with consciousness; also, is an autonomous and stable entity. It is the 'core' of the self and the independent authentic source of action and meaning. According to this conception of the subject, when we hear ourself speak, we feel that we are identical with what has been said. And this identity of the subject with what is said gives him or her a privileged position in relation to meaning. Regardless of what others say about us, that is, other people may misunderstand us, but we understand ourselves because we are the source of meaning in the first place. However, in Foucault's discursive approach, it is the discourse and not the subjects who speak it and produces knowledge. Particular 'subjects' may produce particular texts, but they are operating within the limits of episteme, the discursive formation, the regime of truth of a particular period and culture. Foucault asserts that, a 'subject' is produced within a discourse and this 'subject' cannot be outside the discourse, and further that this 'subject' is 'subjected' to discourse. This subject may become the bearer of the kind of knowledge which discourse produces. This subject may also become the object through which power is relayed.

Stuart Hall explains the 'subject' from Foucault's discourse perspective in the following manner: "Foucault's subject seems to be produced through discourse in two different senses or places. First, the discourse itself produces 'subjects' – figures who personify the particular forms of knowledge which the discourse produces. These subjects have the attributes we would expect

as these are defined by the discourse: the madman, the hysterical woman, the homosexual, the individualized criminal, and so on. These figures are specific to specific discursive regimes and historical periods. But the discourse also produces a place for the subject (i.e., the reader or viewer, who is also 'subjected to' discourse) from which its particular knowledge and meaning most makes sense. It is not inevitable that all individuals in a particular period will become the subjects of a particular discourse in this sense, and thus the bearers of its power / knowledge. But for them – us – to do so, they – we – must locate themselves / ourselves in the position from which the discourse makes most sense, and thus becomes its 'subjects' by 'subjecting' ourselves to its meanings, power and regulation. All discourses, then, construct subject-positions, from which alone they make sense"[18] (Margaret Wetherell, et al., *Discourse, Theory and Practice*, 2004: 80).

The transformation in the later writings of Foucault was due to his revaluation of his previous positions. One of the important shifts in his later work involves a revaluation of the Enlightenment in terms of its positive contributions to a critique of the present era and his identification of his own work in line with Kant's and Nitzsche's ideas. Secondly, a major difference involves a qualified turn to a problematic of the creative subject, which was previously rejected as a humanist fiction, which is pronounced by Foucault as 'death of man'. But later he, although concerned with organization of knowledge and subjectivity, but now he emphasized on the knowledge relation which a self has with itself.

These changes occur as Foucault shifts his focus from the technologies of domination – where subjects are dominated and objectified by others through discourses and practices, to technologies of self – where individuals create their own identities through ethics and forms of self-constitution. According to Foucault the technologies of self should help an individual to transform oneself in order to attain a certain state of happiness, purity, wisdom, perfection or immortality. In this process Foucault defines the task of genealogy as attempting to create a space for freedom where there can be a constitution of ourselves as autonomous subjects (Foucault M. 1984: 43).

5. Feminist Views on Foucault

Much work has been done by feminist writers by using Foucault's concepts of discipline and sexuality. Many feminist writers have drawn upon Foucault's writings, broadly three areas of Foucault's work have been taken up by these writers: bodies/sex, authors/readers, and histories/academic disciplines. Jana Sawicki writes: "There are several reasons that Foucault's critical philosophy has been attractive to feminist social and political theorists. Among the prominent poststructuralists (Derrida, Lacan, Deleuze) Foucault stood out in so far as his writings represented interventions in specific struggles of oppressed

groups such as homosexuals, prisoners and mental patients. His analysis of forms of disciplinary power exercised outside the confines of the narrowly defined political realm of the modern liberal state overlapped with second-wave feminist insistence on the recognition of "personal politics" or the politics of everyday life. His emphasis on the regime of "sexuality" in which bodies and subjects become targets and vehicles of normalizing "biopower" converged with feminists' interests in identifying forms of social control associated with the rise of the human sciences and institutions associated with them (for example, medicine, mental health, social work and so on). Foucault shared with feminists a sense of the importance of resurrecting "subjugated knowledge," ways of thinking and doing that have been eclipsed, devalued, or rendered invisible within dominant apparatuses of power/knowledge"[19] (Jana Sawicki, 2003: 381-82).

She observes further that although Foucault was attempting to devise new tools for critique and change, to advance a view of a theory as a heuristic device. However, he does not explain to us how subjects are formed. She also mentions that, Foucault rather than explaining how it is possible to resist particular forms of subjection, he merely offers tools for doing so.

6. Appraisal of Foucault's Philosophy

Foucault's writings mark a rupture in history that introduces a radically different 'mode' of power than theorized on the juridical model. His concept of power was productive and not repressive in nature. Foucault as a critique of modernity and his development of new perspectives on society, knowledge, discourse and power made him a major source of postmodern thought. In his series of historico-philosophical works in which he attempted to develop an emancipatory and progressive line of thought from various perspectives: psychiatry, medicine, punishment and criminology, the emergence of human sciences, the formation of various disciplinary apparatuses and the constitution of the subject. He is a very complex thinker who draws from multiple sources and problematics, while aligning himself with not a single one. Critics of reason and western thought – Nietzsche and Bataille – find a privileged place in his works. Nitzsche provided an impetus to Foucault to transcend Hegelian and Marxist ideas. Influenced by Nitzsche's works, Foucault could write a 'genealogical' history of unconventional topics such as reason and madness, and the subject which located their emergence within sites of domination.

Opposition to modernist approach marks an important feature of his postmodern work. Postmodern theory in general rejects the modern equation of reason and freedom and attempts to problematize the modern forms of rationality as reductive and oppressive. While modern theories view knowledge and truth to be neutral, objective and universal, or vehicles of progress or emancipation, Foucault analyses them as integral components

of power and domination. Postmodern theory rejects unifying or totalizing modes of theory. Because these are the rationalist myths of Enlightenment which are reductionist in approach and which ignore the differential and plural nature of the social field. Opposed to this the postmodernists valorize incommensurability, difference and fragmentation as antidotes to repressive modern modes of theory and rationality. Foucault emphasizes the importance of discontinuities in discourse, particular and local criticisms. While he acknowledges that global theories such as Marxism and psychoanalysis have provided useful tools for local research, but they are reductionist and coercive in their practical implications and so need to be superseded by a plurality of forms of knowledge and microanalysis. As a result, Foucault attempted to de-totalize history and society as unified wholes governed by a center. It also gives a message that there is no limit to the ways in which the world may be interpreted.

Foucault's works also suffers from number of limitations. He acknowledges some positive aspects of Enlightenment reason, but he failed to follow the suit for institutions and technologies of modernity. His critique of modernity is one-sided in its focus on repressive forms of rationalization and fails to delineate any progressive aspects of modernity.

His archaeological works privilege discourse over institutions and practices. His genealogical works emphasize domination over resistance and self-formulation. His later works analyze the constitution of self apart from detailed consideration of social power and domination. The shift from the technologies of domination to technologies of the self is abrupt and unmediated.

While Foucault argued that power breeds resistance and on occasion has pointed out the tactics of resistance, there is no adequate description of resistance, the scope, detail and rigor with which he approaches the technologies of domination. Critics point that, Foucault's subject of power lacks agency, and hence the capacity to resist the effects of disciplinary power Foucault describes. So, some thinkers remark that a genealogy of resistance remains to be written as a full- scale study and with a historical perspective in its own right.

Foucault intends a reconstructionist approach. However, he absorbs too many things in his 'discourse' which may lead to the neglect of other factors such as material, economic, and structural factors in the operation of power/ knowledge. However, Foucault believed that his critical approach would impact – in the form of other genealogical research and of course political and social activism, that might lead to the alleviation of suffering – to making some people's more tolerable and worth living with dignity.

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Philosophy of Unlearning and Re-learning
Dewey's Progressive Learning and Models from Neurosciences

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Abstract: Unlearning and re-learning seem to be impossible in their literal meaning because what we learned cannot be deleted or re-learned. However, creative ways of addressing problems or taking new initiatives are possible by modifying existing knowledge. Unlearning relevant to education, to organizations or to management strategies is discussed. The inertia and lethargic minds of members are to be addressed in the process of unlearning. Unlearning means critical and progressive learning. As John Dewey says the purpose of learning is not rote memorization of a few facts but enabling students to think critically and contextually. Unlearning is rather easy in technology because new technologies automatically replace existing ones. Problems may be faced by a few who are in the transition period as they may be resistant to adopting changes. According to brain plasticity theories, the brain is set with what we learn and sometimes it may not be possible to reset it. Proponents of Neuro-Linguistic Programming (NLP) say that total unlearning is attainable. These different stances are subjective and empirical. The paper concludes with a critical note on the theories on learning, say various analytical stances, brain plasticity, and NLP.

Keywords: Learning, Unlearning, Re-learning, Critical Learning, Progressive Learning, Neuroscience, NLP.

Introduction

Learning is acquiring knowledge and skills, and is to be continued even after formal education. The process of learning includes certain tacit components too. How do we learn also is as important as what do we learn. As knowledge and skills are always changing, what we learn one day may be obsolete the next day. Replacing the existing with newer knowledge may not be easy, and in the process of acquiring the new, unlearning and relearning are relevant. Unlearning is a barrier for people in the transition period as far as developments in technology are concerned. A simple example is the evolution of new gadgets. People who are accustomed to the existing technology, may not be comfortable with the new technologies. Total unlearning may not be possible or not necessary when it comes to science. New knowledge, in many cases, is an enhanced version of the existing which incorporates certain new dimensions.

I would like to argue that unlearning is not possible in the sense of the direct meaning of the term. We cannot unlearn what we have already learned. Arguments against this stance are also discussed in this paper, especially those based on NLP. Unlearning conveys certain special aspects such as critical learning and progressive learning at organizational levels as well as in education.

1. Objectives

(i) Critically examine trending analytical stances on unlearning regarding educational as well as organizational levels.
(ii) Examine the viability of unlearning and re-learning with the help of findings in neurosciences.

Whether unlearning could be used to create new knowledge is an important concern of this paper. Recent critiques are reviewed to see how an alternative view on unlearning could look like focusing on processes, which deal with unlearning of already gained knowledge and previous experiences, but at the same time, are not about discarding or eliminating them.

2. Unlearning as a Process to Reduce the Influence of Previous Knowledge

It is not easy to discard or eliminate existing or previous knowledge and start from a blank slate. The knowledge structures of the past would remain within us[1]. Arguments that we are modelled by the knowledge that we have gathered and constructed and that the most inner ideas, assumptions, and perceptions of

1 C. Urquhart and W. Fernández, "Grounded Theory Method: The Researcher as Blank Slate and Other Myths," *ICIS Proceedings – Twenty Seventh International Conference on Information Systems*, (2006): 457-464.

the external world may influence our thoughts and actions are not baseless.[2] Knowledge makes us consistent and stable.[3] While highlighting cognitive unlearning and stressing its role in creating new knowledge, the question of how we can free ourselves from the past is not irrelevant. Hence, unlearning the already gained knowledge to create new forms does not mean we need to eliminate or discard knowledge. Unlearning may be the detachment from past-driven knowledge that would stem from previous experiences, assumptions, and beliefs.

Unlearning may not enhance the memory space for new knowledge. The crucial fact for the cognitive dimension of unlearning in the process of creating new knowledge is that the influence of previous knowledge will be reduced. The world can be interpreted and interacted with less determined by past experiences and previous assumptions and already set ways of thinking. Thus, in the context of the creation of new knowledge, unlearning could be defined as a process where subjects can overcome their entrenched ways of thinking and reasoning to improve their capacity to create new knowledge. Hence, cognitive unlearning is a process where subjects reduce the influence of existing knowledge to create new knowledge and patterns of thinking. The proposed definition overlaps with previous approaches claiming that unlearning generates space for gaining new knowledge.[4] However, knowledge cannot be eliminated in a binary way of thinking (i.e., either the knowledge remains or it is erased) but unlearning can be seen as a reduction of existing knowledge while creating new knowledge.

2.1. Unlearning in Practice

Following the definition of unlearning as stated in the previous section, could enhance the capacity of organizations and individuals to generate new knowledge. Unlearning is relevant in research too irrespective of the streams, say, science, humanities, or engineering. How we can realize unlearning in a practical context is an important concern. The following section deals with learning from an envisioned future as a method to illustrate how subjects can unlearn the boundaries of their current knowledge to create new forms of knowledge.

2 P. W. Dowrick, "Self-Modeling: Expanding the Theories of Learning," *Psychology in the Schools* 49, no. 1 (2012): 30-41.

3 S. A. McWilliams, "Inherent Self, Invented Self, Empty Self: Constructivism, Buddhism, and Psychotherapy," *Counseling and Values* 55, no. 1 (2010): 79–100.

4 E. Tsang and S. Zahra, "Organizational Unlearning," *Human Relations* 61, no. 10 (2008): 1435-1462.

2.1.1. Unlearning on Institutional or Organizational Levels

Learning from an envisioned future is a method that would be most relevant at organizational levels.[5] An ideal future scenario is constructed and the people concerned with the project imagine themselves in situations where everything is just perfect. This ideal context fulfills their dreams and their inner wishes and thus would achieve the goals of the organization. Answers to certain questions such as, 'What has happened in this future scenario that makes it perfect?', and 'What has ended in this scenario that makes it perfect?' are formulated. Also, the existing context and the ideal context are compared in terms of several parameters. This method is useful for a variety of organizational learning processes, such as the enhancement of vision, and developmental strategies, where members of an organization should formulate the areas they want to excel. Learning from an envisioned future consists of a minimum of two phases: (i) Participants are encouraged to overcome their experiences in the past. This is accomplished by mental time-traveling which guides them out of their current world-view. This is a phase where the members unlearn as they project themselves to a future point in time and thereby, reduce the influence of the knowledge they had. (ii) They learn after they have arrived in this ideal future where everything is possible and just perfect. They interact with the future context and experience it, and thus earn new knowledge.

Participants may feel uneasy and become anxious when they are asked to unlearn their existing worldview. Hence, it is essential to provide enabling space allowing participants to feel safe and encouraged to test and follow paths of the new knowledge.[6] Nonaka and Konno suggest the concept of *Ba* arguing that a shared space is the foundation for the creation of individual as well as collective knowledge.[7] Providing such enabling spaces and *Ba* appears particularly important for the phase of unlearning as it seems that participants are reluctant to learn something new. They must overcome an inner fear until they can let their thoughts flow freely. With the support of a facilitator, they are enabled to detach from their implicit and existing knowledge and are gradually guided into an ideal future scenario.[8]

5 A. Kaiser, F. Kragulj, T. Grisold, and R. Walser, "Learning from an Envisioned Future – An Empirical Account," *Journal of Knowledge Management* 14, no. 1 (2016).

6 M. Peschl and T. Fundneider, "Why Space Matters for Collaborative Innovation Networks: On Designing Enabling Spaces for Collaborative Knowledge Creation," *International Journal of Organ Designing Engineering* 3, no. 3/4 (2014): 358.

7 I. Nonaka and N. Konno, "The Concept of 'Ba': Building a Foundation for Knowledge Creation," *California Management Review* 40, no. 3 (1998): 40-54.

8 C. Linde, "Narrative and Social Tacit Knowledge," *Journal of Knowledge Management* 5, no. 2 (2001): 160-17.

2.1.2. Unlearning: Various Perspectives

The definition of unlearning presented in this paper and many of the current definitions, may not be in agreement. The critical observations made by Howells and Scholderer and colleagues are thoughtful and the concept of unlearning requires an interdisciplinary approach to clarify whether it can be realized.[9] The definition of unlearning as reducing the influence of previous knowledge for the sake of creating a new one is within the scope of what is possible from a psychological or cognitive scientific point of view. This is why this definition could contribute to the research on knowledge creation. At the same time, our definition provides a new perspective on other research strands in the field of organizational learning where such unlearning is an inherent but implicit part. For example, Scharmer suggests learning from the future as it emerges.[10] He says that we should overcome our current ways of thinking to see the potential that the environment yields but that we cannot recognize. This idea of unlearning implicitly suggests suspending our current thinking patterns and dwelling in a state where we attune to unknown features in the environment.[11] In the same way, the concept of mindfulness also necessitates certain features of unlearning. With a non-judging stance towards our environment, we prevent previous experiences to be projected on current situations. It provides a deep, non-conceptual approach to analysing the world.[12] This has measurable effects on cognitive performance. It has been found that mindfulness enhances creative thinking[13] and it reduces intentional blindness and improves the perception of unexpected stimuli in goal-directed tasks.[14] We reason that our concept of unlearning could guide researchers to focus on the period where we overrule our current knowledge and previous expectations to create new knowledge. Case studies reveal that we can reduce the influence of knowledge on an individual level. How unlearning on an individual level can interrelate with the organizational unlearning need to be

9 J. Howells and J. Scholderer, "Forget unlearning? How an Empirically Unwarranted Concept from Psychology was Imported to Flourish in Management and Organization Studies," *Management Learning* 47, no. 4 (2016): 443-463.

10 O. Scharmer, "Presencing: Learning from the Future as it Emerges," *Conference on Knowledge and Innovation*, (2000): 25–26.

11 M. Peschl, "Triple-Loop Learning as Foundation for Profound Change, Individual Cultivation, and Radical Innovation: Construction Processes beyond Scientific and Rational Knowledge," *Construction Foundation* 2, no. 2-3, (2007): 136-145.

12 J. Kabat-Zinn, "Mindfulness-Based Interventions in Context: Past, Present, and Future," *Clinical Psychology: Science and Practice* 10, no. 2 (2006): 144-156.

13 V. Capurso, F. Fabbro, and C. Crescentini, "Mindful Creativity: The Influence of Mindfulness Meditation on Creative Thinking," *Frontiers in Psychology* 4, (2014): 1020.

14 T. P. Schofield, J. D. Creswell, and T. F. Denson, "Brief Mindfulness Induction Reduces Inattentional Blindness," *Consciousness and Cognition* 37 (2015): 63-70.

understood.[15] Our proposed definition of unlearning states that the integration of the individual and the organizational level depends on the purpose of the overall unlearning/learning process. When the goal is to develop a new vision for an organization, the relevant changes have to happen in individuals as well as in the organization as a whole.

In the light of the above stances, I would like to argue that what we need is critical learning rather than unlearning. Critical learning includes an attitude of analysing and questioning what we learn and we never accept any stage of learning as final. As we have already seen, the viability of unlearning is questioned by a good number of researchers. They argue that knowledge cannot be discarded or eliminated, and hence, the concept is built on incorrect premises.[16] In the context of learning in educational institutions as part of an academic program, critical learning and progressive learning are more meaningful.

3. Critical Learning

Critical learning means learning with proper thinking and reflection. In critical learning, it is not expected to learn new concepts or ideas as if they are the ultimate truths. It is quite common, especially in the Indian context in general, theories irrespective of the discipline, are taught as absolute truths. But most of the theories are the interpretation of data or the superficial or empirical understanding according to the then-available knowledge or technology. What we learn now includes certain facts within the frame of available knowledge and a theory that generalizes the knowledge. If we are open to realizing that what we teach or learn today is not the final word, it would be easy to accept when new knowledge arises. It will be easy to look for new ways of learning and make ourselves ready to grasp newer insights without unnecessary resistance. But if one is conditioned with what is existing or what is taught now as the ultimate truth, the person will be in trouble and would struggle to learn something new. Nowadays, unlearning is a great concern in several fields including scientific research as well as business management. Special concerns such as organizational development, implementation of new projects, learning, innovation, crisis management, and related activities in one

15 A. E. Akgün, J. C. Byrne, G. S. Lynn, and H. Keskin, "Organizational Unlearning as Changes in Beliefs and Routines in Organizations," *Journal of Organizational Change Management* 20, no. 6 (2007): 794–812; K. L. Becker, "Individual and Organisational Unlearning: Directions for Future Research," *International Journal of Organization Theory & Behavior* 9, no. 7 (2005): 659-670.

16 Howells and Scholderer, "Forget Unlearning? How an Empirically Unwarranted Concept from Psychology was Imported to Flourish in Management and Organization Studies," 443-463.

way or another require unlearning and relearning.[17] Individuals, as well as organizations, seem compelled to discard the existing knowledge to cope with changes in the environment and to remain updated.[18]

4. Unlearning in Education: Progressive Learning

Progressive learning is a pedagogical movement that focuses on the way which the student thinks rather than on rote memorization. Knowingly or unknowingly, traditional methods of teaching make students learn facts rather than understand what is being taught. A student may be able to narrate the different parts of a cell without having a proper understanding of how a cell functions. Progressive learning uses integrated curricula to allow students to approach concepts and content from various perspectives, deepening their conceptual understanding of a subject. The major concern of progressive education is experiential learning, which means learning by doing. This makes the students learn through hands-on projects or activities. Applying what they learn to real-life contexts, helps students to grasp a subject to its deeper levels and thus to develop the skills they need in the future. Activity-oriented learning requires teamwork, critical thinking, creativity, and the ability to work independently. Thus, progressive learning enables students to reflect on their learning, follow their questions, develop investigating minds, and gain problem-solving and communication skills.

4.1. Progressive Learning: John Dewey

According to John Dewey education should be a journey of experience that helps students to create and understand new experiences.[19] Activities in school and life experiences should be connected for learning to truly be meaningful and memorable. John Dewey's contributions to education and learning have been influential internationally and accepted widely over time. According to him the purpose of education is the formation of thoughtful, critically reflective, and socially engaged individuals rather than passive recipients of established knowledge. He rejected the rote-learning method driven by a predetermined

17 A. L. Leal-Rodríguez, S. Eldridge, J. L. Roldán, A. G. Leal-Millán, and J. Ortega Gutiérrez, "Organizational Unlearning, Innovation Outcomes, and Performance: The Moderating Effect of Firm Size," *The Journal of Business Research* 68, no. 4 (2015): 803-809; E. W. K. Tsang, "Transferring Knowledge to Acquisition Joint Ventures: An Organizational Unlearning Perspective," *Management Learning* 39, no. 1 (2008): 5-20.

18 I. Buchen, "Creating the Future: Innovation and the Unlearning Organization," *Foresight* 1, no. 2 (1999): 117-123.

19 John Dewey, "Democracy and Education," in *John Dewey: The Middle Works 1899-1924,* ed., J. A. Boydston (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1980), 180-189; John Dewey, "Experience and Education," in *John Dewey: The Later Works 1925-1953,* ed., J. A. Boydston (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1988), 1-62.

curriculum which was the standard teaching method at the time and even now in many places. However, significantly, he also rejected child-centered approaches that followed children's uninformed interests and impulses uncritically. The term 'progressive education,' which he used, has since been misappropriated to describe a hands-off approach to children's learning. What Dewey proposed was not this approach. While accepting the traditional subject matter, he stood for integrating it with the strengths and interests of the learner. His concept of inquiry means a sense of need and it included intellectual work such as defining problems, testing hypotheses, and finding satisfactory solutions, as the central activity. He believed that all concepts and meanings could be opened to reinvention and improvement, and all disciplines could be expanded with new knowledge, concepts, and understandings. According to Dewey, learning and growth of individuals are consequences of interactions with the world. These interactions and related experiences lead individuals to continually develop new concepts, ideas, practices, and understandings, which would be influential in learners' life experiences and social interactions.

According to Dewey, interactions and communications which are focused on enhancing and deepening knowledge increase the potential for learning and development. Students have the opportunity to understand and work with the perspectives, ideas, and experiences of other students when they share ideas or thoughts within a group. When activities are shared the context for learning development is better. Real-life contexts and problems are appreciated by Dewey as educative experiences. If learning is just passive, students do not experience it in a meaningful, emotional, and reflective way. Consequently, they may not adapt and revise their habits or construct new habits, or even if they do so, it would be superficial. It has been observed that students learn best when their interests are engaged. Hence, it is better to develop ideas, activities, and events that stimulate students' interest and to which teaching can be geared. Teaching and lecturing must be geared toward helping students to analyse and develop an intellectual insight into a specific and meaningful situation.

Learning usually begins with a student's emotional response, which triggers further inquiry. Dewey thought that experiences say dramatic, compelling, unifying, or transforming are the moments in which students feel enlivened and absorbed. Rather than making students accept any seemingly valid explanations, education ought to give students opportunities to discover information and ideas through their effort. They are expected to apply knowledge to practical contexts by defining and solving problems and determining the validity and worth of ideas and theories. This does not preclude explicit instructions wherever appropriate.

4.2. Dewey's Approach: A Few Critical Comments

Even though there is no direct evidence that Dewey's approach improves student outcomes, his theory of students' learning aligns with current theories of education which emphasize how individuals develop cognitive functioning by participating in sociocultural practices and with empirical studies examining the positive impact of interactions with peers and adults on students' learning.[20] Quantitative research reports present a link between heightened engagement and children's learning outcomes. Strategies such as making meaningful connections to students' home lives and encouraging student ownership of their learning are found influential to increase student engagement.[21] Certain empirical studies which analysed the effectiveness of aesthetic experiences for students observed that students experienced those lessons as more meaningful, compelling, and connected than a comparison group.[22]

4.3. Progressive Learning: Educational Practices

Dewey's theory made an impact on a variety of educational practices including individualized instruction, problem-based and integrated learning, dialogic teaching, and critical inquiry. Dewey's ideas also resonate with ideas of teaching as inquiry.

(i) **Individualised Instruction**: Teachers, learn about students and their motivating interests and desires to find subject matter, events, and experiences that appeal to students and that will provoke a need to develop the knowledge, skills, and values of the planned curriculum. Students are motivated to relate learning to their lives and experiences.

(ii) **Problem-Based Learning and Integrated Learning Methodologies**: Dewey's principles of problem-based learning and project approach to learning the process begins with a practical task or problem which is complex, comprehensive, multi-layered, collaborative, and involves inquiry designed to extend students' knowledge, skills, and understandings. Problem-based learning supports students to intellectualize exactly what the problem is. It encourages controlled inquiry by helping students to develop logical hypotheses rather than depending on their habits of thinking to jump

20 A. Goncu and B. Rogoff, "Children's Categorization with Varying Adult Support," *American Educational Research Journal* 35, no. 2 (1998): 333-349.

21 Julianne Turner, "Theory-based Interventions with Middle-school Teachers to Support Student Motivation and Engagement," *Advances in Motivation and Achievement* 18 (2014): 341-378.

22 M. Girod, C. Rau and A. Schepige, "Appreciating the Beauty of Science Ideas: Teaching for Aesthetic Understanding," *Science Education* 87, no. 4 (2003): 574-87.

to conclusions. Students' engagement can be heightened when they have ownership of their learning; for example, by being engaged in curriculum planning and cooperatively building curriculum themes, or by selecting a topic to research rather than being assigned a topic.

(iii) Dialogic Teaching: Dialogic teaching emphasizes the importance of open student dialogue and meaning-making for learning and builds on Dewey's ideas about the importance of communication and social interaction. In this approach, students are encouraged to form habits of careful listening and thoughtful speaking. Attention is paid to issues of power, privilege, and access that may hinder open dialogue.

(iv) Critical Inquiry: Dewey's approach to education is obvious in curricula focused on critical thinking skills. Here students engage in critique, inquiry, and intellectual reflections and evaluate claims related to knowledge, make connections, apply their insights in different contexts, and go into deeper levels. Teachers are expected to provide opportunities for students to engage in the competitive consideration of possibilities and explore doubtful possibilities. Dewey's principles for teaching and learning suggest that teachers should cultivate an energetic openness to possibilities alongside a commitment to reflectively learning from experiences, be willing to experience ambiguity, and use problems as an opportunity to get deeper into an understanding of self, students, the subject, and the context.

5. Subjective Experience and Brain

Learning and associated experiences are related to brain anatomy and neuroscience. Whether the brain that actively controls all the processes of the brain gets affected by the processes would be of interesting concern. With the entire visual system mapped, we can see it as unlikely the brain could give rise to a unified subjective experience and therefore cannot explain how our perceptions emerge. Thus, a core issue of mind or subjective experiences cannot be explained by looking at the brain alone. The more we study neuroscience, the more we realize that the brain is referred to as plastic.[23] It means that throughout our lifetime, the brain will change and adapt as a result of experience. New pathways are constantly forming and being remade to deal with environmental changes.

Jeffrey Schwartz with his insights on neuroplasticity and the power of mental force presents the findings of his experience with patients suffering

23 M. Jeffrey Schwartz and Sharon Begley, *The Mind and the Brain: Neuroplasticity and the Power of Mental Force* (New York: Harper Perennial, 2003), 15.

from Obsessive Compulsive Disorder (OCD) and demonstrates with the help of brain scans that mental effort can rewire brain chemistry.[24] Schwartz found that certain parts of the brain displayed abnormal activity when he would have the OCD patients engage in intense mental effort in focusing through what he labelled as relabelling, re-attributing, refocusing, and revaluing. He found that patients who underwent this mental focusing therapy experienced considerable relief from OCD symptoms, especially the more they engaged. The corresponding images of brain scanning indicated a re-alignment of abnormal brain activity.[25]

John Eccles argues that physicalist models like identity theory have a difficult time explaining this, as mental events cannot generate neural events.[26] If consciousness or the mind is solely physical or a function or a property of the physical realm, then it must have a physical basis for all time. Yet the evidence indicates that this is not the case. Thus, he argues, as well as citing additional research, that we have evidence of Top-Down causation and these later studies only support this inference.

6. Neuro-Linguistic Programming and Learning Process

Neuro-Linguistic Programming (NLP)[27] sees learning as the integration of new skills into a person's faculties. Learning processes are related to conscious and unconscious processes. NLP presents a model for learning which consists of four stages as defined below.[28]

1. Unconscious incompetence: Here the person concerned doesn't have the skill or knowledge and he is not aware of even the existence of such a skill.
2. Conscious incompetence: The person starts learning and gradually becomes aware of the necessity of mastery of the skill. Lack of ability is consciously known.
3. Conscious competence: The person is proficient with the skill. But his conscious attention is necessary to perform it.
4. Unconscious competence: Now the person is proficient with a skill and is capable of using it without any thinking about it.

24 Schwartz and Begley, *The Mind and the Brain,* 15.

25 Schwartz and Begley, *The Mind and the Brain,* 23.

26 R. Karl Popper and John C. Eccles, *The Self and its Brain* (New York: Springer-Verlag, 1985), 361.

27 Neuro-Linguistic Programming (NLP) is based on the concept that the link between the mind, language, and behavioral patterns can be adapted to help build confidence, develop better communication skills, and reprogram old ways of thinking.

28 John J. Emerick Jr., *Be the Person You Want to Be* (Rose Ville, CA: Prima Publishing, 1997), 59.

The process of learning takes place through stages 1, 2, 3, and 4 in sequence. New material is learned through these stages. Unlearning is the process of going to stage 2 back from 4. When information, strategies, etc., are unconsciously integrated one must go back to stage 2, and regain conscious awareness of the process before initiating any adaptation. Relearning is the process of passing through stages 2, 3, and 4 after having unlearned.[29] The unlearning-relearning process provides added choices enabling one to integrate the skills learned to date.

7. Limitations and Further Scope

As the intrinsic complex parameters related to unlearning are presently not well understood, research has to be continued. The major concern is how we can reduce the influence of previous knowledge. Specifically, an analysis of factors that facilitate unlearning may be a concern of organizations that want to remain competitive. A great challenge for the research on unlearning lies in the unobservability of the process.[30] To test the extent to which we can reduce the influence of previous knowledge on our cognitive processes, researchers may use a variety of methods that investigate (i) the process of unlearning, i.e., what is happening on a cognitive level, and (ii) the outcome of learning processes after the influence of previous or existing knowledge had been reduced, i.e., how does this form of unlearning contribute to practice. With investigations employing different methodologies, knowledge about various types of cognitive unlearning could also be further developed. The definition followed in the paper is relevant only to the cognitive domain of unlearning.

The human behavioural domain also needs to be analysed in terms of unlearning and re-learning. Further research should investigate if or how the influence of old routines and/or habits can be reduced while new ones are being formed and/or implemented as this could be particularly relevant for unlearning in organizations.

Conclusion

Despite the controversies about whether unlearning is possible or not, from our discussions, it is clear that what we learn as part of any program or context can be changed if we are willing to do so. If we change the style of our learning the process of adapting new knowledge is easy.

Learning is not just saving certain facts to our memory but it includes a dimension of research that must always be progressive. Then we will not be

29 Emerick Jr, *Be the Person You Want to Be,* 60.

30 S. A. Zahra, S. G. Abdelgawad, and E. W. K. Tsang, "Emerging Multinationals Venturing into Developed Economies: Implications for Learning, Unlearning, and Entrepreneurial Capability," *Journal of Management. Inquiry* 20, no. 3 (2011): 323-330.

stuck up with anything and unlearning happens without any deliberate and extra effort. While learning something it is not saving truth as a file forever, but a dynamic step in the process of searching for truth. If we learn any subject with this attitude and leave sufficient margin for re-work, unlearning or integrating new knowledge would be easy.

Interpretations from neurosciences are mostly based on analysis of data and related theories are empirical. However, such theories cannot be ignored as subjective experiences, because a good number of people face such phenomena. As it is clear that the brain is affected by the experiences it controls or comes across, the brain might reach certain limiting conditions. Though the proponents of NLP argue that unlearning is possible, it would be more relevant in the case of things we learned consciously. If we are not aware of the tacit dimensions of what we already learned unlearning is not possible. Also, unlearning may not be practical with our traits of hereditary elements. Several things we learn not deliberately and we would not able to unlearn them.

6

Poesis and *Praxis*
Ethics and Aesthetics in Education

Ivan D'Souza

Abstract: This paper is a study of our education system and learning from the lens of Aristotle's notions of *poesis* and *praxis*. After clarifying the notions of *poesis* and *praxis*, the study examines whether there is *poesis* or *praxis* in our education today. *Praxis* being the higher form of knowledge is linked to the concept of *phronesis*, which entails moral conduct. The notion of *praxis* is applied to the Indian aesthetics. It tries to address the question whether Indian aesthetics is ethical. Is there *praxis* in Indian aesthetics? How to make education a *praxis*? The paper also suggests that there should be strong resonance between ethics and aesthetics.

Keywords: Aesthetics, *Dharma*, Education, Ethics, *Phronesis*, *Poesis*, *Praxis*, *Rasa*, *Techne*, Deontology.

Introduction

During the time of Aristotle there were freemen and slaves in the society. There was social inequality on the basis of race, colour, status and gender. Women were forbidden from serious intellectual work. Philosophy was the luxury of the elite class. The wise 'philosopher king' ruled society.[1] In such a context, Aristotle educated the people through his peculiar notions of *poesis*

1 Elizabeth Anne Kinsella and Allan Pitman, "Engaging Phronesis in Professional Practice and Education," in *Phronesis as Professional Knowledge: Practical Wisdom in the*

and *praxis*. The situation of Athens is repeated and reflected in our present Indian society. Religion, politics, caste, language, etc. have become basis of division and polarisation due to vested interests and fundamental ideologies. Hence, we need to revisit and reinterpret the educative ideas of Aristotle, viz., *poesis* and *praxis*. The Indian education system needs to be liberated from the hands of those who sow the poisonous seeds of enmity, bias, prejudice and wrong ideology into the minds of children and youth. Moreover, education has become a commodity in the market today. Success is measured in terms of salary, profit, possessions, mechanisation and technological facilities. There is hardly any space for thinking, reflection, ethics, values, co-operation and humanitarian values. In other words, the practical aspects of human life and nature are neglected in the present education system. This paper re-reads and applies Aristotelean notion *praxis* as a corrective to our education system. It dwells on some significant questions: How are Aristotle's notions of *poesis* and *praxis* relevant for us? Does education make us a product or it transforms us to become better humans and creates a just society and joyful community? Is there ethics in our education system? Does the education system of our day bring out our practical abilities? Does Indian aesthetics correspond to the *phronesis* of Aristotle? What is our role to make education a *praxis*?

1. Aristotelean Modes of Knowledge

According to Aristotle, there are threefold modes of knowledge: theoretical, productive and practical. They are technically known as *episteme*, *poesis* and *praxis* respectively. *Episteme* as theoretical knowledge is characterised by logical demonstrability. It is scientific, universal, invariable and context-independent knowledge.[2] It entails certain principles (*archai*) and causes (*aitiai*). *Sophia* or philosophical wisdom is the highest form of theoretical knowledge. It was considered as the 'most comprehensive and exact form of knowledge.'[3] *Episteme* is directed towards the pursuit of truth. *Poesis* and *praxis* are the practical sides of knowledge governed or animated by *techne* and *phronesis* respectively. In other words, *techne* and *phronesis* lead to *poesis* and *praxis*. *Poesis* is bringing forth through crafting or producing and *praxis* is applying a skill for action.[4]

Professions, eds., Elizabeth Anne Kinsella and Allan Pitman (Rotterdam: Sense Publishers, 2012), 3.

2 Kinsella and Pitman, "Engaging Phronesis in Professional Practice and Education," 2.

3 Joseph Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground* (Indiana: University of Notre Dame Press, 1993), 238.

4 Michael Paterson, "Discipled by Praxis: Soul and Role in Context," *Practical Theology*, 12, no.1 (2019): 7.

2. *Poesis* as Production

Aristotle understands *poesis* as making, production or fabrication. It is creating things; an activity which brings about something. It distinguishes between means and end. The materials and tools can be considered as means to bring about an end product. When a product is designed and produced the end or *telos* is achieved.[5] For example, house is built for dwelling, shoes are made for walking, etc. Aristotle explains the activity of *poesis* in the following way: "... where there are two things of which one is a means and the other an end, they have nothing in common except that the one receives what the other produces."[6] *Poesis* ceases when end is achieved through the means.

Poesis is necessarily linked to or aligned with *techne*.[7] Ordinarily, *techne* means crafts skills or productive knowledge. It was a generic term used in ancient Greece for art which included shoe-making, carpentry, music, painting, poetry, plays, literature, sculpture, architecture, etc. *Techne* is characterised as context-dependent, pragmatic, variable and craft knowledge.[8] In his work *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle defines *techne* as a "reasoned state of capacity to make." *Techne* is a "generative source (*arche*) of useful things, a habitual ability (*dunamis*) of the maker through which he can reliably produce and reproduce them."[9] *Poesis* is an activity whereas *techne* compliments it through the kind of knowledge of crafts possessed by a producer or an expert. For example, a carpenter needs a form of specialised knowledge to make a table or chair.

3. *Praxis* as Action

Praxis is an action where the factors like creativity, ethics, empowerment and enhancement are involved. It is a process of creating oneself to be something and somebody. In *praxis*, action itself is considered as an end. "*Praxis*, … has to do with the conduct of one's life and affairs primarily as a citizen of the *polis*; it is activity which may leave no separately identifiable outcome behind it and whose end, therefore, is realized in the very doing of the activity itself."[10] The neo-Aristotelian view understands *praxis* as 'right conduct.'[11]

5 Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground*, 244.

6 Oded Balaban, "Praxis and Poesis in Aristotle's Practical Philosophy," *Journal of Value Inquiry* 24, no. 3 (1990): 186.

7 Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground*, 9.

8 Kinsella & Pitman, "Engaging Phronesis in Professional Practice and Education," 2.

9 Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground*, 249.

10 Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground*, 244.

11 Stephen Kemmis, "Phronesis, Experience, and Primacy of Praxis," in *Phronesis as Professional Knowledge: Practical Wisdom in the Professions*, eds., Elizabeth Anne Kinsella and Allan Pitman (Rotterdam: Sense Publishers, 2012), 147.

Praxis is a proper way of conducting oneself by realising the excellences one has. It demands personal, experiential or practical knowledge called *phronesis*. *Phronesis* makes a person to live in accordance with the ethical norms of society. It characterizes a person to live well in a public space. *Phronesis* is manifested through *praxis*. *Praxis* is doing and *phronesis* is a disposition towards acting in a right way.

Phronesis is referred as practical wisdom or practical rationality. Aristotle defines *phronesis* as a "reasoned state of capacity to act." It is context-dependent, pragmatic, variable, and oriented toward action. It is a practical understanding or knowledge which enables one to become good. It is a deliberative knowledge having a choice between good and evil. Choosing good to live ethically is a *phronetic* act. It is a self-making project. Without cultivating *phronesis* or practical wisdom one cannot be virtuous.[12]

4. *Phronesis* Linked to Ethics

In the writings of Aristotle, we find five intellectual virtues. They are: *techne* (artistic or technical knowledge), *nous* (intelligence or intuitive reason), *episteme* (scientific knowledge), *phronesis* (practical wisdom) and *sophia* (philosophical wisdom). *Phronesis* is closely linked with ethical virtues such as justice, courage, temperance and so on.[13] Hence, knowledge which is guided by good character results in ethical action. Aristotle states, "It is not possible to be good in the strict sense without practical wisdom, nor practically wise without moral virtue."[14] In Aristotelean view, *poesis* does not take into account virtue or ethics as it is concerned with production. But *praxis* requires virtue as it deals with action.

5. *Poesis* or *Praxis* in Education?

Praxis is the higher form of knowledge as it originates in the choice of the person. It presupposes both intellectual and moral condition of the mind. Thus, ethics goes hand in hand with *phronesis*. *Phronesis* by its very definition implies excellent performance or character (*arete*). *Poesis* guided by *techne* is repetition of the form without creativity. The ethical element is absent in it or it becomes impertinent. Is not ethics involved in the very purpose of the production of an object itself, in the case of *poesis*? Ethics can be seen, for instance, in the production of a bomb or making of a video, etc. as it is made for something. This question surfaces which is reflective with Aristotle.

12 John Christopher, *Educating Character Through Virtues* (Bengaluru: ATC Publishers, 2018), 78.

13 Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground*, 275.

14 W. D. Ross, ed., *Aristotle* (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1938), 264.

It would be pertinent to note the remarks of Hannah Arendt where she makes a distinction between making and action from the political perspective of the West. She states that the social and political history of the West is seen as the story of fall from 'action' into 'making.' It can be applied to the realm of education too. Education today is making the people a kind of machines and has turned the world into a class of durable objects. She holds that 'action' makes the persons to realise and reveal themselves as distinct and unique with freedom.[15]

Education should englobe the above aspects of *poesis* and *praxis*. It would be relevant to note the analysis done by the German philosopher, Wilhelm Dilthey whereby explores a humanitarian balance between *poesis* and *praxis* in his celebrated division of sciences. He distinguishes between the natural sciences and the human sciences. The natural sciences include physics, chemistry, mathematics, etc., whereas the human sciences comprise history, law, literary criticism, economics, psychology, etc. The human sciences include both the humanities and the social sciences. If the natural sciences have great value for their exactitude and require only explanation, the human sciences, on the other hand, which look for interpretation, analysis and theorization have no final and readymade answers or solutions. The question, however, is should *praxis* be limited only to the human sciences and the positive sciences to be left out?

We need to apply and look for *praxis* in all kinds of sciences in our education. *Praxis* combines reasoning with ethics. It calls us to give shape to ourselves. It is a process of 'I am making myself' through *phronesis*. It enables us to manage any given situations with values and virtues. Hence, today's education has to be done through *praxis*.

6. Way of Zen: A Way of *Praxis*

American philosopher Martha Craven Nussbaum holds that the novels, stories and other literature educate and inspire us in practical wisdom and help us to explore human realities.[16] Hence, we take recourse to a Zen story for our reflection. Literally, Zen is a state of calmness, serenity and tranquility. In Zen, one's actions are guided by intuition. It is a way of *praxis*. The following story is a dialogue between two Zen masters—Guishan (Shan) and Daowu (Wu). It is retold by the American Zen teacher and poet Norman Fischer. It is an illustration of *phronesis*.

> Guishan asked Daowu, "Where are you coming from?"
> Daowu said, "I've come from tending the sick."

15 Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground*, 89.

16 J. Wall, "Phronesis as Poetic: Moral Creativity in Contemporary Aristotelianism," *The Review of Metaphysics* 59 (2005): 319.

> Guishan said, "How many people were sick?"
> Daowu said, "There were the sick and the not sick."
> "Isn't the one not sick you?" Guishan asked.
> Daowu said, "Being sick and not being sick have nothing to do with the True Person. Speak quickly! Speak quickly!"
> Guishan said, "Even if I could say anything, it wouldn't relate."
> Later Tiantong commented on this, saying, "Say something anyway!"[17]

'Sick' mentioned in the story suggests that there is suffering in the world. It has to be understood from the background of the first noble truth of Buddhism that all are sick by their nature. The question "Who is sick?" is an open question. According to Fischer, sick are those who think that they are not sick. Such people do not accept the truth of suffering and pain. Who are the ones not sick? They are those who know that suffering is reality of life. Such people accept the truth that world is full of suffering and pain. The story holds that the True Person simply "is." It means such a person is beyond life or death, sickness or health. Saying about one's life doesn't reveal the mystery of life. Yet saying something about the story of pain and urge to do good is crucial.[18] Wisdom is needed to make sense of this story. It is the starting point of *phronesis* which leads to greater realisations of life and deeper reflections of truth.

7. Is Indian Aesthetics a *Praxis*?

From a general point of view, aesthetics is *poesis*. It is understood as a product of *techne*. English philosopher R. G. Collingwood speaks of aesthetic as the technical theory of art in his work *The Principles of Art*. He considers art as some kind of craft.[19] It is the power to produce a preconceived result by means of consciously controlled and directed action. On the other hand, it can be qualified as *praxis*. A work of art is made or created through a process of 'imaginative expression' and creativity. Imagination is not opposed to the real. It is a usual activity through which one constitutes oneself as a conscious person.[20]

17 N. Fischer, "Phrases and spaces," *Lion's Roar*, March 1, 2008, https://www.lionsroar.com/phrases-and-spaces/ Also see, Arthur W. Frank, "Reflective Healthcare Practice: Claims, Phronesis and Dialogue," in *Phronesis as Professional Knowledge: Practical Wisdom in the Professions*, eds. Elizabeth Anne Kinsella and Allan Pitman (Rotterdam: Sense Publishers, 2012), 53-56.

18 N. Fischer, "Phrases and spaces," https://www.lionsroar.com/phrases-and-spaces/, accessed 25 January 2023.

19 R. G. Collingwood, *The Principles of Art* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1938), 9.

20 Donne, *Back to the Rough Ground*, 60.

Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard speaks of three stages of human existence, namely, aesthetic, ethical and religious. There is a movement from one stage to the other based on one's choice. These stages don't replace one another in progression though they are hierarchical in nature. Every stage is purified and taken to another level. Kierkegaard considers the aesthetic stage as the lowest stage which is limited to sensory experience. In this stage a person pursues pleasure and avoids commitment. In the ethical stage one has a sense of duty and shoulders the responsibility. The religious stage is the stage of faith in God.[21] For the Indian ethos we see a joyful combination of aesthetics, ethics and religion in a concept called '*dharma*.'

The views of Collingwood and Kierkegaard reveal that aesthetics is not different from *praxis*. *Phronesis* is not a purely rational quality. It is a blend of thought and desire. Acting well is based on a unity of thoughts and emotions.[22] When we consider Indian aesthetics in particular, ethics is already present in it and it is not disconnected from religious. From the religious sense, Indian aesthetics also gives the glimpse of the divine.

One of the prominent ancient Sanskrit texts in Indian aesthetics is *Nāṭyaśāstra*. It is ascribed to sage Bharata. He has propounded theory of *rasa* (aesthetic sense) which is applied to various artistic forms (*nāṭya*) such as drama, dance, music and literature. It entails moral and religious aspects. It is formative and axiological in nature.

> *Nāṭyaśāstra* says that *nāṭya* as an art provides:
> Religion (duty) for religious people, pleasure for pleasure seekers
> Restraints for the ill-behaved, tolerance for the well behaved
> Courage to the cowards and energy to the braves
> Knowledge for the unknowing and wisdom for the wise
> Enjoyment for the rich and solace for the worried
> Money for the needy and stability for the disturbed (*Nāṭyaśāstra* of Bharata 1.109-111).[23]

Indian aesthetician and philosopher Abhinavagupta has written *Abhinavabhāratī*, a commentary on *Nāṭyaśāstra* of Bharata. According to Abhinavagupta, the immediate aim of aesthetics is experience of *rasa,* but the ultimate goal is the promotion of *puruṣārthas* (four ends of human life. They

21 Mrinal Kanti Bhadra, *A Critical Survey of Phenomenology and Existentialism* (New Delhi: Indian Council of Philosophical Research, 1990), 173-192.

22 Samantha Broadhead and Margaret Gregson, *Practical Wisdom and Democratic Education: Phronesis, Art and Non-traditional Students* (Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2018), 60.

23 Quoted in Neerja A. Gupta, *A Student's Handbook of Indian Aesthetics*, Newcastle upon Tyne: Cambridge Scholars Publishing, 2017, 4-5.

are: *dharma* (righteousness), *artha* (material well-being), *kāma* (fulfilment of desires) and *mokṣa* (freedom from bondage).[24] According to Hindu ethics, one should follow *dharma* in whatever one does or whichever stage of life one is. *Dharma* encompasses everything. Indian aesthetics contains ethics in its essence. So, we can use the expression, 'Indian drama follows the *dharma*.'

Aesthetics concretises the thought and values that are mentioned in the sacred texts. The Indian epics, *Rāmāyaṇa* and *Mahābhārata* are great works of ethics. They enact and exemplify four ends of human life. Their depiction or presentation in various art forms evoke *rasas* in human beings leading to the highest ethics of *mokṣa,* i.e., blissful state. In this way, one can rightly assert, "*rasa brahmānanda sahodara*" (*rasa* is the sibling or twin of the transcendental bliss). In other words, aesthetic enjoyment is akin to the experience of the ultimate bliss. It is closely related to crux of Vedāntic teaching. *Upaniṣads* refer the Supreme Lord as the reservoir of all bliss. It says, "the Being is the essence. One who attains the essence becomes blissful" (*Taittirīya Upaniṣad* 2.7.1).[25] When one experiences *satyam*, *śivam*, *sundaram* (truth, goodness and beauty) through aesthetics it leads to *saccidānanda* (consciousness exists in blissful state).

8. Education as *Rasa* and *Abhinaya*

Indian aesthetics has a unique concept called *rasa* theory. The word *rasa* has two meanings: the 'aesthetic content' of literary art and 'aesthetic relish' which the reader-spectator enjoys.[26] *Rasa* harps on our likes and dislikes and propels different emotions in us. It leads to various kinds of aesthetic sentiments or moods (*rasa*). There are nine types of *rasas*. They are: erotic love (*śṛṅgāra*), humour (*hāsya*), pathos (*karuṇa*), wrath (*raudra*), heroism (*vīra*), terror (*bhayānaka*), disgust (*bībhatsa*), wonder (*adbhuta*) and tranquillity (*śānta*). The ninth *rasa* was a later addition and considered as the heart of all art experience. According to Abhinavagupta, everything begins, goes through and ends with *śānta rasa*.[27] Indian artistic forms and expressions usually have a happy ending: 'And they lived happily ever after.' Such a happiness is indicative of *śānta rasa*.

The *rasas* are based on innate emotions or abiding mental conditions known as *sthāyībhāva*. They are: pleasure of love (*rati*), laughter and

24 Dinesh C. Mathur, "Abhinavagupta and Dewey on Art and Its Relation to Morality: Comparisons and Evaluations," *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research* 42, no. 2 (1981): 224–235.

25 "*raso vai saḥ rasam hyoevāyam labdhvānandī bhavati*" (*Taittirīya Upaniṣad* 2.7.1).

26 G. K. Bhat, trans., "On Natya and Rasa," in *Indian Literary Criticism: Theory and Interpretation*, ed., G. N. Devy (Hyderabad: Orient Blackswan Private Limited, 2014), 7.

27 R. Ganesh, "Introduction to Indian Poetics," *IIT Gandhinagar* (September 10, 2022), https://www.youtube. com/watch?v=oBLnvyywwCo, accessed 25 September 2022.

cheerfulness (*hāsya*), sorrow and suffering (*śoka*), irritation and anger (*krodha*), will and strength (*utsāha*), fear and anxiety (*bhaya*), repugnance, revulsion and hatred (*jugupsā*), astonishment (*vismaya*) and knowledge of the truth or self-knowledge (*nirveda*).[28]

There are three components in the aesthetic enjoyment: *vibhāva*, *anubhāva* and *vyabhicāribhāva*.[29] *Vibhāva* means external stimulus or determinants, *anubhāva* implies consequents and *vyabhicāribhāva* stands for transitory elements. *Rasa* is the configuration or blend of all three aspects. It is not present only in actor or spectator but it is the outcome of inter-subjective and inter-personal artistic exchange. When an actor represents a character, it is universalised (*sāmanyīkaraṇa*) by the audience and it leads to *rasa*. One who experiences the aesthetic enjoyment is known as *rasika* (connoisseur or art lover or competent person). He or she should possess the qualities like open mindedness, knowledge of the arts, honesty, appreciating ability, critical outlook and so on. In other words, 'to be a *rasika* is to be a *sahṛdayi*' (of equal heart).

The qualities of *rasika* resonates with the *praxis* of Aristotle. The role of a teacher as an actor or performer is vital to evoke the psychological states of the spectator or audience. Teaching and learning are inter-subjective and inter-personal tasks. By being the persons of kindred aesthetic mood (*sahṛdaya*), the students are able to listen, participate, sympathise and respond to the aesthetics. They become *rasikas* in the process of learning. It leads to *tanmayatā* or identification of what they listen and learn.

Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* embodies the rules governing the composition of play. It is applied to drama and to other artistic forms. The *nāṭya* is based on Vedas and Śāstras (Scriptures). It represents the life of gods, sages, kings, demons, etc. *Nāṭyaśāstra* speaks about four types of *abhinaya* or histrionic representations through which the emotions of pain and pleasure are enacted. They are *āṅgika* (physical movements, gestures and expressions), *sāttvika* (emotional reaction), *vāchika* (voice and speech) and *āharya* (make-up and costume).[30]

28 Annette Wilke, "Classical Indian Aesthetics and Rasa Theory: Observations on Embodied Rhetoric Reader Response, and the Entanglement of Aesthetics and Religion in Hindu India," in *Religion and Aesthetic Experience: Drama—Sermons—Literature*, eds. Sabine Dorpmüller, Max Stille and Jan Scholz und lnes Weinrich (Heidelberg: Heidelberg University Publishing, 2018), 58-59. Also see G. K. Bhat (translator), "On Natya and Rasa," in *Indian Literary Criticism*, 3-17.

29 Bharata's *Rasa-sūtra* is: "*vibhāvānubhāva-vyabhicāri-saṁyogāt rasa niṣpattiḥ.*" See, G. T. Deshpande, *Abhinavagupta* (New Delhi: Sahitya Academy, 1989), 67.

30 "Natyashastra and Rasa," *Vidya-mitra* (February 17, 2017), https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZgpN80y4_Zs, accessed 3 October 2022

Is teaching a performance or enactment? Are there *rasa* and *abhinaya* in it? Teachers enact what others have discovered, invented or just written while teaching. Enactment in teaching also arouses the interest and curiosity of the students. It keeps the class or audience alive. Hence, teaching involves creativity, imagination, intuition, critical thinking and involvement. It combines both realistic and imagined elements.[31]

In the process of teaching both teacher and students can experience *rasa*. There can be enjoyment and detest both in teaching and learning. There can be experience of love, hate, joy, excitement, boredom, dejection, frustration, envy in the context of learning or teaching between teacher and students.[32] It can be also towards what is taught. The content of teaching and learning also arouses the feelings and emotions in the students. For example, corruption, climate change, nuclear warfare, sound and air pollution, pandemic can create *rasas* like wrath, horror or repulsion. Various events and incidents can cause different *rasas*.

The aesthetics has a transformative power. It develops our cognitive perception. Indian aesthetics is both sensual and spiritual in nature. In our education system aesthetic orientation has an enormous impact on the attitudes, behaviour and formation of the students. Aesthetics makes education a creative and dynamic reality.

Indian aesthetics focuses on achieving ends of human life according to *dharma*. *Phronesis* is generally defined as practical wisdom or knowledge of the proper ends of life.[33] Thus, there is a real congruence between *praxis* and *dharma* in terms of ethics. As long as Indian aesthetics orients us to *dharma* it becomes *praxis* oriented. They can contribute to each other by being partners in dialogue. *Praxis* of Aristotle can purify Indian ways of education through aesthetics. Aesthetics is integral to human life and it forms us to be ethical. In art making a mistake is inevitable and it always leads to a better performance. Today the students are not allowed to make mistake. Often, educational institutions, parents and teachers consider committing mistakes as failure in life. Hence, aesthetics comes as a corrective to our education.

9. Indian Ethics or Aesthetics: Deontological or Teleological?

The current political developments clearly reinforce the teleological tendencies of Indic (civilizational) philosophy, culture and religion. But do we find deontological aspects in them? Does Indian ethics or aesthetics

31 Kanchi Gopinath, "Educational Methodologies and Rasa Theory," in Conference on Hindu Aesthetics, *Indica* (July 30, 2021), https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=levxJ3myxGo, accessed 27 September 2022.

32 Gopinath, "Educational Methodologies and Rasa Theory," https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=levxJ3myxGo, accessed 27 September 2022.

33 Kinsella and Pitman, "Engaging Phronesis in Professional Practice and Education," 2.

have deontological features? That is, based on justice, mutuality and equity as governing principles, rather than merely on the notion of the teleological 'good'. Scripturally we can establish that there are deontological elements in the gamut of Indian ethics and aesthetics. There are hermeneutical or theoretical possibilities for deontology in Hindu textual resources. Hermeneutically, a Brāhmin can assume the role of a Śūdra and a Śūdra can become a Brāhmin. We can find umpteen number of examples to show that deontology is theoretically possible from the perspective of Indian axiology.

The Ṛg-Vedic hymn *Puruṣa-sūkta* speaks about four *varṇas* or castes of society (RV 10.90.12). According to Swami Chinmayananda the four castes coming from the Cosmic Person asserts the idea, "all are of equal service to the society. All are important, and each must have due respect, regard and love for the other; the entire body is one complete entity."[34] Such interpretation negates any kind of discrimination between people living in society.

Chāndogya Upaniṣad contains a story of Satyakāma and Jābāla. A young boy wanted to join the *āśram* for learning. When the sage enquired about his lineage, he said that he was born of an unknown father. As per his mother's information she was called Jābāla and the boy was known as Satyakāma. Upon hearing it, the sage admitted him to the *āśram* for he had spoken the truth. The story reveals the fact that one who speaks the truth is a brāhmin. A person's position is based on his/her behaviour and personality, rather than their family lineage or social standing. One who lives virtuous life is a brāhmin and one who lives a vicious life is a śūdra.

Bhagavad-gītā mentions the four castes as created by the Divine itself according to people's qualities and activities (BG 4.13). Some interpretations are of the view that it does not approve inequality or a hierarchical caste structure based on birth but rather it upholds the natural tendencies and abilities of different people. Everyone has a role to play in society for its welfare as a whole.

The Liṅgāyat movement, a socio-religious movement that emerged in the 12th century in Karnataka led by the philosopher and social reformer Basavaṇṇa promoted social equality, justice, inclusivity, individual dignity and spiritual freedom. Similarly, the social reformer and spiritual leader of late 19th century from Kerala, Nārāyaṇa Guru addressed the issue of the status of the Ezhava community in the caste hierarchy of Kerala society in his work *Jāti Nirṇayam*. He writes, "*Oru Jāti, Oru Matam, Oru Daivam Manuṣyanu*" which means "One Caste, One Religion, One God for all humankind." Nārāyaṇa Guru argued that the caste system had no basis in true spirituality or morality. According to him, profession does not define the inherent worth or status of

34 Quoted in Victor Borde, *The Puruṣa-sūktam* (Bloomington: LifeRich Publishing, 2021), 213.

individuals. A person should be valued based on one's character, abilities, and contributions to society.

These examples show that there are hermeneutical or theoretical possibilities for deontology. But there is a gap between the ideal and the actual. Social equality and inclusivity have been achieved to a certain extent due to the revolutions initiated by various social reformers and leaders. We cannot deny the possibilities and practicalities of religious scriptures in bringing about awareness and change in the exploiting social structures. It needs certain courage to actualize and bring out the emancipatory potential of scriptural texts. Certain vested interests hinder such possibilities to be actualized. Generally, we cannot hold any religion or tradition as an exception to such drawbacks.

10. *Praxis* in Education: Way Ahead

Plato's *Academy* and Aristotle's *Lyceum* in the ancient world in Athens promoted reflection, dialectics and debate. The *Socratic Method* questioned everything inwardly and outwardly. Greeks wanted to learn mental and physical skills. Their belief was that the education makes them morally matured persons. They wanted to be physically fit through exercises and gymnastics. The education and training were to safeguard the State and to become responsible citizens. The ultimate aim of education was to enable people to have self-knowledge. In the like manner, in the traditional Indian society, the *guru* or master imparted education to his disciples. His role was to help them to search the truth and to discover the self. According to the *Upaniṣadic* teaching, education was to realise the relationship of the Individual soul with the Ultimate Soul which constitutes the ultimate goal of human existence.

In the education system, organisation and ethos of our times, there is an over emphasis on *poesis* and a marginalisation of *praxis*. Education is been restricted to marks, grades, ranks and bookish knowledge. The educational institutions seem to be manufacturing robots and machines. Most humanitarian professions like doctors, counsellors, teachers and the rest have become monotonous and mechanical. Holistic approach is decapitated at the cost of robotic approach. It is astonishingly frightening to read on a daily basis the human follies among the super specialised techies, doctors and others. Best professionals are lost in touch with the humanity. These are caused by the factors like the neglect of creativity and value system, stereotyped teaching and academic learning, portrayal of superiority of STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics), etc. Basically, education should make us good humans. The psychometrics should help the students to identify their skills, personality and potentials. The life management skills such as dealing with

stress, taking risks, managing pressure and so forth are ostensibly missing in our syllabus.

The present world values *techne* or *poesis* than *praxis*. The invasion of technology into our minds has tampered our critical thinking and practical wisdom. It has stolen and consumed our quality time. Senior Advocate of Supreme Court, Menaka Guruswamy writes that the virtual world causes us to lose the qualities that are most special to human species—ability to reflect, to observe and to look within. She says, "we are losing the ability to live in the present moment."[35] Hence, a metamorphosis in education is the need of the hour.

It is imperative that *phronesis* should be guiding factor in our education. Education should make the students *phronimos* (person of practical wisdom). It ought to facilitate the students to deliberate about their own learning. They need to be enabled to think and act with *phronesis* with themselves and others.[36] Questioning, examining, analysing and reflecting rationally what was taken for granted is a *praxis* in education. American educator Gundula Bosch invites researchers to be thinkers and not just specialists. She opines that the students have to think critically and become creative problem-solvers that society needs.[37]

The process of education is not a passive reception and acceptance of what is taught, but there must be self-construction of ideas, thoughts, prudence and judgements. The question, 'Who is a student?' looks like a simple question. But it has to be seen from various angles. Student is not only the one who is taught by a teacher, but also teacher himself or herself is a student. The learned also is the ignorant.[38] Along with the academic knowledge or technical skills, personal qualities, practical dispositions and good character enhances the effectiveness of a teacher.[39] The goal of education is to create the best

35 Menaka Guruswamy, "Why MS Dhoni doesn't carry his phone and what we can learn from him," *The Indian Express*, October 1, 2022, https://indianexpress.com/article/opinion/columns/why-ms-dhoni-doesnt-carry-his-phone-what-we-can-learn-from-him-8183078/?fbclid=IwAR1ItJ-jlYymNtUIhelgePa_ozO4vufWWKljZKgA9bz9kxxLFryLqfPkcOU, accessed 30 October 2022.

36 Broadhead and Gregson, *Practical Wisdom and Democratic Education*, 55.

37 Gundula Bosch, "Train PhD Students to be Thinkers not just Specialists," *Nature* 554, no. 7692 (2018): 277.

38 Elizabeth Anne Kinsella & Allan Pitman, "Phronesis as Professional Knowledge: Implications for Education and Practice," in *Phronesis as Professional Knowledge: Practical Wisdom in the Professions*, eds., Elizabeth Anne Kinsella and Allan Pitman (Rotterdam: Sense Publishers, 2012), 166.

39 David Carr, "Character in Teaching," *British Journal of Educational Studies* 55, no. 4, (December 2007): 369.

minds–minds that react, think, synthesise and critique. It is to prepare people to reflect, react and read out of the box.

Praxis is becoming critical, truthful, receptive, thoughtful and inclusive. Polarization, mob mentality, religious prejudices, believing and spreading fake news and blind following of an ideology, etc. are not the marks of an educated society. *Praxis* entails acting well for and with others. It leads to friendship and inclusion. Thinking with practical wisdom should enable us to include others and develop fellow feeling towards all. Being open to newness and difference is an opportunity for creativity and innovation in our conduct. It boasts confidence in the students and they become bold enough to act upon the judgements.[40] The aim of *praxis* is to make teacher a *guru*, doctor a healer and lawyer a real advocate. The final goal of *phronesis* is *eudaimonia*. It means human flourishing, living well, welfare, happiness, felicity, etc. It is complete and integral fulfilment of life.[41]

Education should focus on both what one should know and believe (theory) and how one should act (practice). It should empower us to assume the responsibility for the world. The task of education in the words of Hannah Arendt is:

> And education, too, is where we decide whether we love our children enough not to expel them from our world and leave them to their own devices, nor to strike from their hands their chance of undertaking something new, something unforeseen by us, but to prepare them in advance for the task of renewing a common world.[42]

Conclusion

The invocation for peace in *Kaṭhopaniṣad* teaches: "May our study bring us illumination or enlightenment; May there be no enmity among us."[43] The Latin roots of the word education such as *educare*, *educere*, and *educatum* have many meanings like 'to nourish,' 'to bring out,' 'to lead forth,' 'to draw out' and so on. Hence, education must bring out the learners' innate abilities, humanity, relationship and lead to enlightenment. *Śikṣa* and *vidya* are the Indian terms generally used for education which stand for discipline and wisdom. Taking together the Western and Eastern imports, education must draw out our wisdom through reflection, thinking, dialogue, debate and the like.

40 Broadhead and Gregson, *Practical Wisdom and Democratic Education*, 17, 70 & 74.

41 Geoffrey Hinchliffe, "Work and Human Flourishing," *Educational Philosophy and Theory* 36, no. 5 (2004): 545.

42 Hannah Arendt, *Between Past and Future* (New York: The Viking Press,1961), 196.

43 "*tejasvi nāvadhītamastu mā vidviṣāvahai*" (*Kaṭha Upaniṣad*, Invocatory verse).

The Stagirite symbiosis between *poesis* and *praxis* which served as backdrop for our consideration on education today and the lacuna in the present-day curriculum should catapult in us for a better tomorrow in our learning system. Schools and universities need to have the rhythm of *dharma* and *karma*, ethics and aesthetics, *poesis* and *praxis*. As philosophers should we not spearhead this rhythm in our schools, seminaries, houses of formation, philosophical centres and universities?

Part 2

Defragmenting Education: Perspectives and Practices

7

Religious Education
Scope and Challenges in India

Biju Pallippadan, VC

Abstract: In the contemporary context, religious education in a secular society, the process such as individualization makes it harder for children to get the opportunity to learn from religion in an organized way. At school young students can learn in an orderly and beneficial way from religion. However, religious education at primary schools in Western Europe has evolved into a subject that seeks to support students to develop their religious identity. Whereas in Indian Context religious education is not part of curriculum, but now it is slowly evolving. Though religious education is imparted in religious circles it has not achieved the status of a regular subject in the education sphere. From a socio-cultural perspective, religious education intentions to support students to develop their religious identity by allowing them the opportunity to participate at religious practices. Religious traditions such as Christianity, Islam and Hinduism etc., involve religious practices such as praying, gathering, taking care of the fellow men, dealing with life and death, or the interpretation of religious stories.

Keywords: Religious Education, Judaism, Buddhism, Christianity, Sikhism, Hinduism, Disinterest, Secularism, Atheism, Political Structures and Economic Arrangements.

Introduction

According to John Dewey, "Education is the development of all those capacities in the individual which will enable him to control his environment and fulfil his responsibilities."[1] According to Heinrich Pestalozzi, "Education is natural harmonious and progressive development of man's innate powers."[2] The aim of this research is to get a clear view on the significance of studying Religious Education (RE) in one`s life by gathering all the available evidence and the influences this education has had on the way they live their lives, interconnect with the secular world and to bring to light factors that help to explain this significance.

1. Education: Different Perceptives

A child is not born with knowledge. Knowledge is acquired only after the birth of the child. Education makes it possible for a man to acquire values through the process of instruction. Education is closely connected with human life. There are many kinds or perceptives of education such as religious education, University education, etc. However, in this paper we shall see what is religious education, its scope and challenges.

1.1. Religious Education

Religious Education (RE) is a subject taught at primary and secondary levels that aims to develop an understanding of the world's religions. Religious Education can be a useful way of introducing children to the idea of community outreach. It encourages children to think about those who are less fortunate. If children are home learning due to special circumstances, such as the coronavirus outbreak, this can be a good time to ask them to think of others and devise ways to help them in times of need.[3]

1.2. Religious Education in Different Religions

Through religious education, children will learn about different religions and their traditions, practices and beliefs. Religious education also promotes children's tolerance and mutual respect in a diverse society. Religious Education can seem a daunting subject for home learning. It raises challenging questions for children to grasp, such as the meaning and purpose of life, and the concepts of right and wrong. World religions is the name of a category used in the examination of religion to talk about the 6 main religions of the world.

1 As cited by Leopoldo Perdomo, https://www.quora.com/profile/Leopoldo-Perdomo, accessed 15 Dec. 2022.

2 As cited by Leopoldo Perdomo.

3 Dorn Philip Jebb, *Religious Education* (Darton, London: Longman and Todd Ltd., 1967), 57.

They are classed on account of their world-wide distribution and presence. Around 84% of the world is affiliated to any one of these six religions. Each of these faiths represents a huge number of the population

1.3. The World Religions

There are 6 main world religions that children are commonly taught about through religious education. Religion plays an important role in a person.

1.3.1. Judaism

Judaism is one of the world's largest and the oldest monotheistic religion. Jewish people believe in one, singular and all-powerful God. They believe that they have a special agreement with God which they call a Covenant. Jewish people dedicate their lives to obeying God's laws in order to thank him for protecting and guiding them.[4]

1.3.2. Islam

Those who follow the Islamic faith are called Muslims. They are another monotheistic faith because they believe in one God. They name him Allah, the Arabic word for God. Muslim people also have five important rules that they must follow which are called The Five Pillars of Islam. The Muslim book of worship is called the Qur'an and Muslims pray in a type of building called a Mosque.

Muslims ruled India for a long time and education of masses was also their agenda. The educational process in Muslim period was accomplished at religious places, which were commonly attached to Masjid. Education was provided free and precise. Both rewards and punishments were in vogue. Teachers were treated well by the rulers of the time. They have been provided very high status. The education was imparted orally. The curriculum was Qur'anic cantered and the holy Quran was memorized by the children. This practice has preserved the book in its original form, was the very unique feature of Muslim Education. At elementary level students only memorize Quran with its proper pronunciation. Higher education was also the focus of Muslim period and at higher education level subjects like history, philosophy, grammar and law were taught. The medium of instruction was Arabic and Persian. Islam is the religion for all mankind and has relevance for both spiritual and practical life is the central philosophy of Muslim education. Overall, education was more religious in nature during Muslim period in India.[5]

4 Unknown, *Judaism Develops,* https://www.khanacademy.org/humanities/world-history/ancient-medieval/judaism/a/judaism-develops, accessed 25 September 2022.

5 Habibullah Shah, *Muslim Education in India* (Hazratbal, Srinagar: Kashmir Directorate of Distance Education, University of Kashmir).

1.3.3. Aim of Muslim Education

The chief aim of Muslim education was the propagation and spread of Islam in India. Prophet Mohammad himself taught the people the right ways of life, the right thoughts and deeds and prevention of wrong. Spread of Knowledge is necessary for all men and women according to Islamic religion and the same rays reflected during medieval education. Thus, the fundamental aim of Islamic education was to spread the light of knowledge among all the human beings. Medieval education was the foundation for the development of Islamic social morals which were based on Islamic doctrines, social traditions and political principles. Propagation of *Shariyat* was another important aim of Muslim education. *Shariyat* means a code of Islamic laws and rules of conduct to be followed by those who had belief and faith on Islamic religion and its principles. Character building was also the main focus of Muslim education.[6]

1.3.4. Buddhism

Buddhism is another world religion and has over 500 million followers around the world. Buddhists follow the teachings of Buddha, a former prince who became enlightened after giving up a life of luxury. Buddhists believe that Buddha discovered key principles known as *The Four Noble Truths*.[7] Most Buddhists dedicate their lives to finding enlightenment in order to understand these principles themselves. The main educational centers of Buddhism Were Monasteries and *Viharas*. A network of such centers of education was started during the period. The entire educational system was controlled and supervised by the monks. There was provision for both religions as well as secular types of education. Tracing back to the 5th century BC, Buddhist Education was originally taught by Lord Buddha and it is monastic and inclusive of all castes (the caste system was widely prevalent at that time in India). The central aim of the Buddhist Education system is to facilitate the all-round and holistic development of a child's personality, be it intellectual, moral, physical and mental development.

The Buddhist Education System implements a unique focus on incorporating mutual reverence and affection between teacher and student. The pupils generally accompany the teacher everywhere carrying their seats, robes, tooth stick and water. Teachers focus on imparting students with etiquettes, discipline, abstinence and simplicity. While formal education is focused on the relationship between teacher and student for a particular grade

6 V. K. Maheshwari, "*Education in India During Medieval Period," in* http:// ww.vkmaheshwari.com/ WP/?p=1786/, accessed 2 September 2023.

7 Unknown, "The Four Noble Truths," in https://www.theravada.gr/en/about-buddhism/the-four-noble-truths/, accessed 3 September 2023.

or period, informal education system emphasises a lifelong relationship between them.[8]

1.3.5. Goals of Buddhist Education System

The goal of Buddhist teaching is to bring everyone on the common platform and help achieve the highest form of human satisfaction through knowledge, meditation and self-introspection. Buddha argued that *ultimate wisdom* or '*anuttara-samyak-sambhodi*'[9] is not something that can be acquired but it is intrinsic to one's nature and a person needs to delve into the realm of self to explore it. The Buddhist education system gained popularity when it started imparting education to people from all races, across continents. It focuses on the moral, intellectual and spiritual development of a student so as to dive into the state of ultimate wisdom and equality. One of the organized and effective education systems that continue to influence society in modern times, Buddhist thought was intended to bring harmony which is essential for the progress in all forms.[10]

1.4. Hinduism

Hinduism is a set of traditions and beliefs that makes it different from other religions. It has no founder. Hindus are separated into castes, based on their Karma and Dharma. In Hinduism education is an important means to achieve the four aims of human life, namely *dharma* (virtue), *artha* (wealth), *kāma* (pleasure) and *mokṣa* (liberation). Also, it is vital to the preservation and propagation of *Dharma*, without which, declares *Vedic dharma*, we cannot regulate our society or families properly or live in peace. *Vidyā* or education is the means by which an individual can gain right knowledge, control one's desires and learn to perform obligatory duties with a sense of detachment and devotion to God. This is to overcome the impurities of egoism, attachment and delusion and achieve liberation. In Hindu tradition knowledge is a double-edged sword. In the hands of an immoral or evil person it can become a destructive force. With knowledge comes power and if it falls into the hands of an ill-equipped person who is bereft of morality and sense of responsibility, he may misuse the power and bring misery to oneself and others. The basic difference between a god and an asura (demon) is that the former uses one's knowledge for the welfare of the world and the latter for one's own selfish

8 Team Leverage Edu, "Buddhist Education System," in *Wings* (Blog), https://leverageedu.com/blog/buddhist-education-system/, accessed 3 September 2023.

9 Disha, "Development of Education during the Buddhist Period in India," in https://www.yourarticlelibrary.com/education/development-of-education-during-the-buddhist-period-in-india/44818/, accessed 5 September 2023.

10 V. K. Maheshwari, "Education in Buddhist Period in India," in http://www.vkmaheshwari.com/WP/?p=522/, accessed 21 August 2022.

and egoistic aims. Hence as a part of their education, in ancient India, students were advised to follow the path of gods and cultivate virtue under the careful and personal guidance of their teachers, so that they would remain on the path of righteousness for the rest of their lives and contribute to the welfare of society. They believe that if students were grounded in dharma, would become its upholders and take care of its survival and continuity.[11]

Hinduism is therefore not a 'belief system' based on one scripture but the ongoing participation of humanity with an evolving set of Indian 'user manuals' extended over millennia of advanced 'Experimenters' revered as sages and *rishis* (seers) 'in the field', sharing direct personal *revelation (śruti)*. More can be revealed today; hence it is *sanātana,* ever-flowing, not 'contained' as a set of tenets or belief in the divinity or message of a particular Individual. Thus, whilst there is a sense of custodianship of tested/ directly experienced wisdom and responses to the big questions recorded in ancient texts called the Vedas, people do not see the big questions as separate from the pursuit of daily life.[12]

1.5. Sikhism

Sikhism differs from Hinduism, Jainism, and Buddhism in that it believes in only one God. At the same time, the religion retains the concepts of *karma*, reincarnation, and release from the rounds of rebirth. Sikhism has a more positive attitude toward the world than the other faiths but, like them, is not a missionary faith, since it sees all other religions as leading to the same place that Sikhism does—namely to God. Sikhs live predominantly in the Punjab region of India. Their primary vocation is farming, Sikhs believe that there is one God and that he is everywhere and in everything. The term for this is *saguna* which means 'all good things.' Guru Nanak is the founder of Sikhism.[13] The aim and methodology of Sikhism is, it not only to aim at the academic syllabus but a knack at being multi-talented and this community aims at the very thing. Boys and Girls who were deprived of this facility can now make use of these facilities and indulge in extra-curricular activities as well. Sikhism aims for an all-round education and removal of class differences where all are treated as equal.[14]

11 Jayaram V., "Hinduism and Education," in *www.Hinduwebsite.com*, https://www.hinduwebsite.com/ hinduism/h_education.asp, accessed 21 October 2022.

12 Jayaram V., *Hinduism and Education.*

13 Roger R. Keller, *"Sikhism," Light and Truth: A Latter-day Saint Guide to World Religions* (Provo, UT: Religious Studies Center; Salt Lake City: Deseret Book, 2012): 90–112.

14 Sri Guru Granth Sahib Vidya Kender, "Importance and Role Education in Sikhism," in https://sggsvk.com/role-of-education-in-sikhism/, accessed 11 October 2022.

1.6. Christianity

Christianity is all about the belief of Jesus Christ's life on Earth as the Son of God who was born on 25th December in Bethlehem. Christians follow the bible and the teachings of Jesus Christ in order to live a good life. The vast majority of Christians worship in buildings called churches. Christianity is all about the belief of Jesus Christ's life on Earth as the Son of God who was born on 25th December in Bethlehem. Christians follow the Bible and the teachings of Jesus Christ in order to live a good life. The vast majority of Christians worship in buildings called churches. refraction of such arguments is rooted in the post-Enlightenment rejection of transcendentalism.[15]

2. Challenges of Religious Education

Religious Education (RE) has made positive impact in the national education system at all level but in spite of this achievement the teaching of the subject is still face with challenges in the implementation. These include inadequate funding, inadequate facilities/infrastructure, use of auxiliary teachers and student's attitude among others.

2.1. Inadequate Funding

The government is not allotting any fund for this purpose. Whereas in European countries it is part of the curriculum.

2.2. Diversity and Plurality

Diversity and plurality are the basic characteristics of one of the largest democracies in the world, namely India. It is a multicultural, multilingual, multi-ethnic and multi-religious nation. While it is a matter of pride that in spite of its plurality, India has remained one nation, it is also a matter of concern that the plurality has been the reason for many of its conflicts, outbursts of violence and atrocities against each other. Yet. India is what it is because of its diversity and plurality and, thus, it is not one context, but a context of contexts. Of the many pluralities, one plurality that stands out in India is the religio-cultural plurality, which is the prime reality and of particular interest to us since we are concerned about religious education. It is the religio-cultural plurality that distinguishes India in particular from the rest of the world. It is the most important aspect of India's identity as a nation. It may not be wrong to say that it is its uniqueness.

2.3. Scriptural Plurality

Before the Christian scriptures arrived in India the people of India had already been nurtured for centuries by their own classics and scriptures like Vedas,

15 Gabriel Moran, *Religious Education Development* (Minnesota: Winston Press, 1983), 136.

Upanishads, Puranas and so on. In fact, the Bible is a latecomer to Indian cultural traditions. The history of non-biblical scriptures in India goes back to the remote past of the people. With their vitality, they continue to influence the lives of the people even after they have been converted to Christianity.

Another important aspect of Indian reality is its issue of poverty, struggle for justice and the suffering that goes with it. What Aloysius Pieris says about Asia in general, applies to India as well. He describes the Asian reality as 'the religiousness of (Asia's) poor and the poverty of its religious.'[16] The poverty of India is not only the outcome of widespread injustice, but often aggravated by natural calamities such as floods, draughts, famines and earthquakes, some of which may have an indirect link to the injustice, corruption and greed. Ironically in India more people die from religious-ethnic and communal conflicts than from hunger, starvation and disease, even though religio-ethnic conflicts are connected with the issues of socioeconomic and political injustice. It is also worth noting here that the process and project of globalisation has its direct influence on the poverty in India. Though it appears to have enlarged the size of middle class, it also has enlarged the size of the poor. In India, religion seems to permeate everything.

2.3.1. Political Structures and Economic Arrangements

Even political structures and economic arrangements are religiously linked or motivated. There are instances where religious consideration has given birth to new nations; for example, Pakistan. A similar situation is that of Bangladesh, which for some time was East Pakistan. Even now religion plays an important role in politics. More often than not, ethnicity and religion are at the core of most of the violent conflicts in which each group tries to assert its supremacy over the other. Most of the economic crises in India and other Asian countries are easily mixed up with ethnic and religious issues. Many of India's religious problems have to do with ignorance and suspicion about those who are different and the growing religious.[17]

2.3.2. Disinterest

Though Indian Constitution guarantees the freedom of religion and education for its people, RE is facing serious threat now-a-days. It is often met with religious fanaticism and opposition. The students exhibit a kind of disinterest in religious studies. They feel it as a waste of time. There is no future hope.

16 Samson Prabhakar, "*Religious Education in India*," in Studies in World Christianity 12, no. 1 (2003): 50-58, available https://citeseerx.ist.psu.edu/viewdoc/download?doi=10.1.1.997.327&rep=rep1&type=pdf, accessed 20 September 2022.

17 Samson Prabhakar, *Religious Education in India*.

Since the secular studies guarantees job and future, the students take religious study lightly.

2.4. Secularism and Growth of Atheistic Groups

Oxford dictionary defines secularism as indifference to or rejection or exclusion of religion and religious considerations. According to the *Stanford Encyclopaedia of Philosophy*, atheism "should be construed as the proposition that God does not exist." This is the traditional and historic definition of atheism but many New Atheists want to redefine the term to mean simply "the lack of belief" in God's existence. In this sense, atheism turns into a kind of "non-theism." Dr. William Lane Craig, a Christian philosopher, points out that if someone is a "non-theist" they could fall into, at least, one of three different categories. They are, i) Agnosticism: a lack of any certainty about God's non-existence, ii) Verificationism: a view that says any talk about God is meaningless, and iii) Atheism (traditional definition): the view that God does not exist.[18]

Conclusion and Critical Evaluation

There are robust national and international philosophical debates about the aims, purpose, and scope of religious education in schools located within denominational, nondenominational, and multidenominational school systems informed by historical religious traditions, modernist and postmodernist theoretical frameworks, and multi-religious perspectives. The diversity of conception and practical realization of religious education is marked not only in debates among academics or teaching practitioners but, perhaps more significantly, also between legislators. What constitutes religious education in different polities differs quite markedly. I would like to propose the aim of religious education must be self-understanding, value for all, open-mindedness, appreciation and wonder.

Religious education needs to be a 'spiritual' process that motivates the learners to build a new ethos of mutual trust, mutual respect and mutual learning, and thereby moves towards a holistic spirituality. It needs to be a deliberate attempt on the part of the Christian community as a whole to create an environment where we look at each other with creative, constructive and critical minds with the goal of learning from each other. This kind of education would enable us to recognise and respect the 'otherness of the other' as we always try to recognise, respect and even revere the 'otherness of the Other' even our Creator. And finally, when we attempt to evolve a programme of

18 Peter Kupisz, "New Atheist Attempts to Redefine Word "Atheism"," in https://www.worldviewsummit.org/post/new-atheist-attempts-to-redefine-word-atheism?gclid=Cj0KCQjwhY-aBhCUARIsALNIC06/, accessed 24 September 2022.

Religious Education in India, we should be sensitive to all these issues. Our theory of Religious Education should be theologically sound and pedagogically viable and at the same time it should emerge out of our faith response to the reality of plurality and diversity.

8

Deconstructing the Concepts "*Guru*" and "Emancipation" in the Context of Education

Joy Alumkal

Abstract: '*Guru'* as a Sanskrit term has its baggage of meanings, from ancient time up to the contemporary times. The term 'emancipation' too has complex meanings. Traditionally these terms were used in the context of an idealistic vision of liberation. But coming to the modern and post-modern times, these terms are more used in the naturalistic and pragmatic vision contexts. From an educational point of view, in its idealistic, naturalistic and pragmatic visions, both these terms vary in their meaning. In the traditional paradigm both *guru* and emancipation have idealistic visions. But in the course of time in practice, they fell into disrepute. In the same way, modern and post-modern that criticise the negatives of the traditional, fall into same type of negativities. This necessitates a commitment to a middle path that respect the virtues of both and remove the vices of both. This paper presents all the three paradigms and the third will be exposed as the middle way that bases itself on the realm of the intuition.

Keywords: *Guru*, Deconstruction, Emancipation, Education, Intuition.

Introduction

Let me begin by exposing what I feel as the 'loadedness' that the title of our book: "Emancipative Education: Policies and Practices" contains. I shall explain it presenting three paradigms of education: 1) traditional, 2) modern

and post-modern or secular, and 3) metamodern or post-secular. In each of them the terms '*guru'* and 'emancipation' are differently understood. So, for each paradigm policies and practices will be different.

All the papers presented in this volume are fruits of philosophizing of different authors on education. The adjective 'emancipative' added to education gives us the direction of our reflection: an implicit purpose. It seems to me, answer to the question 'what education is for' is already answered: it is for emancipation. Now a pandora's box is opened! The questions could be raised are: What is emancipation? Why emancipation? From what? For what? How to get emancipation? When to achieve? Where to achieve? Whose emancipation? Who will give emancipation? All these questions are multi layered.

Take for example the answer, emancipation is for those who undergo education; another complex set of sub-questions come up. Like, who is undergoing education? Is it those who are in the institutes of the state that has the title as educational institutions? These questions further point to those who give education. Is this the same aim of those give education also? Who gives education? Is it state? Is it instruments of state in the form of schools? Many of the schools are controlled by individuals and institutions of religious, cultural, political, economic and family groups. Most of them have their philosophies of life. Depending on philosophies of life conceptions of aims, methods, discipline, teacher's role, understanding, etc., differ. Do they all have emancipation as their purpose? If the answer is *yes*, then the further question: practically what is emancipation?

Literally, emancipation refers to liberating, unchaining, untying, unyoking. The relevant question is: Will any of the institution survive if it unties, unyoke, unchain or liberate students from patriotism, nationalism, obligations to the religion, culture, group loyalty or commitment to the proposed goals of the institution? If the goals are already set, then what is the role of spontaneity, openness, discovery etc., which are also ideals connected with goals of education.

Well, we are called to tackle the issues involved with intentions of orientations. If one says, education is idealistic, spiritual, etc., then how much state and its instruments aim at it practically, is a question. For, most of the modern states, especially democratic states are humanistic and secular. By policy, these states see education as naturalistic, realistic and practical with pragmatic undertones that aim at tackling materials for living in this world. This world is looked at as real place of lot of emancipations, be it from the poverty, inequality, authoritarianism, dogmas, hierarchies, conservatisms of the tradition, etc. Many educationalists see a paradox in the functioning of the state, society, family, religion and groups: supposed to be liberating agents but practically turn to be 'tying down', 'yoking' or 'chaining' agents in a mental cage situation!

1. Deconstructing the Terms *Guru* and Emancipation

Within the above elaborated larger issues, we deconstruct the terms *guru* and emancipation. Depending on the philosophies of life, conceptions of guru will change. Thus, idealistic visions, naturalistic visions and pragmatic visions have different conceptions. In the same way within each vision, depending on space-time context of the agent who do the study and materials covered, again differences. Take for example, the varieties in the traditional meanings: If we look at the term *guru* in the context of the conceptions of monotheistic religions, they never give a place for *guru* equal to God, but within the monistic and pluralistic religious context, *guru* is equal to God. Again, as we check the history of traditional idealistic vision, we see a lot of negative weight added to the concept. Thus, deconstructing the term *guru* refers to unloading the negativities attached to it in the course of time, chiselling out burdening things from it and liberating the positives traditionally involved in the spirituality connected with this term. It is like regaining the sanctity and sacredness contained in it, especially the inner strengths that the term involves in its esoteric openings.

In order to give clarity to this presentation, I reduce all the conceptions existing about *guru* into two paradigms. I give the titles as the 'traditional paradigm' versus the 'post-modern' paradigm that comes up by criticising the negativities involved in the traditional notions by the modern and post-modern times. Towards the end after exposing the two, their strengths and weaknesses, I propose a way to overcome the extreme negatives creep into the traditional in the form of disconnecting and concealing the spiritual interior and standing out of the 'husk', which is supposed to be deconstructed and reveal the real essence which is to be preserved. For the need of what has to be preserved and what must be changed, in order to avoid extremes of the two, the possibility of a third paradigm that can come up by opening a new space in between the two extremes and title it as 'post-secular' or 'meta-modern' paradigm.

2. Traditional Paradigm to Understand *Guru*

Searching the etymology and traditional context in which this word was used and what people generally understood will reveal to us the traditional paradigm to understand *guru*. To know it further, we must look into the etymological meanings, dogmatic meanings, institutional meanings, religious meanings and the related terms, etc. As the crux of it we see the presence of an interior light, vision in *guru* that transforms one's own life and enlightens the path of

everyone who comes in contact with. This vision of the *guru* the Indians call, the '*darshana.*'[1]

2.1. Related Words to *Guru*

The Sanskrit word '*guru'* is related to the terms *darshana* (knowledge or wisdom or insight), *gurukul* (modern boarding school like place for students to stay with *guru*) and *shishyas* (the students who were sent by the parents to the teacher or *guru*). *Guru* is the head of the *gurukula*, which is like a modern boarding school for training of the students known as *shishyas* of the *guru*. In a *gurukula,* students are sent by the parents in order to live with the *guru* for a specified period of time. The aim of this staying is to get trained from the *guru* to get awareness in such a way that their '3rd eye' of knowledge be opened through '*yoga'*. This is for harmonious growth of the body, mind and heart by the inner spirit. This aims at the process of self-improvement through the integration of the 'body, mind and heart' through integration of the 'instincts reason and feeling' by the inner spirit. Further, this is to prepare a student for the socially integrated life.

2.2. Etymologies of the Word, *Guru*

The online *Etymology Dictionary* describes the term *guru* with much evolution. Most of the Indian languages use this term. Originally, it comes from the Sanskrit language. Here, '*guru'* means "one to be honoured, venerable, a teacher worthy of honour."[2] He/she is to be honoured because he/she is selfless, integrated with vision of life and wisdom for living. Traditionally, a teacher is placed on a status higher than God! There are hymns and chants that express this high status of *gurus*.

There is a famous Sanskrit *bhajan* which is widely sung at occasions of respecting teachers. This is the first verses of Shankaracharya's *Gurustotram*. The verses are: "*Guru Brahma, Guru Vishnu, Guru Devo Maheshwara. Guru Sakshath Parambrahma, Tasmai Shri Gurave Namaha.*" It can be translated like this: "Guru is the creator Brahma, Guru is the preserver Vishnu, Guru is the destroyer Siva. Guru is directly the supreme spirit – I offer my salutations to this Guru."[3]

Reason for this type of honouring of *guru* also is explained. The question is, who understands the truth about Gods? In our context, in the way

1 *Darshana* has different senses. The most important is connected with *guru* and his/her vision. *Guru* stands in relation to *shishya* or disciple or student. See, https://www.britannica.com/topic/darshan, accessed 31 May 2021.

2 https://www.etymonline.com/search?q=guru, accessed 28 May 2021.

3 https://greenmesg.org/stotras/gurudeva/guru_stotram.php, accessed 28 May 2021.

understandable to us, who will reveal God to us? Here comes *guru* as the teacher about God.

Sant Kabir asks, "If God and my *guru* come in front of me together, whom will I give my salutation first?" He himself gives answer: "Of course I first salute my *guru*, second only I will salute my God." He gives his reason also, "For it is my *guru* who revealed God to me. I saw first my *guru* in my life and then only God came in through him."[4]

The root of Sanskrit word *guru* is '*gur'*, meaning 'to raise, lift up, or to make a serious effort'. The Latin word '*gravis'* and the Greek word '*barus'* have equivalent meanings. They have the *similar* linguistic derivation. As an adjective, the word *guru* means 'heavy' or 'weighty'. It is used in the sense of "heavy with knowledge", "heavy with spiritual wisdom", "heavy with spiritual weight", and "heavy with the good qualities of scriptures and realization.

Another meaning comes from *Advayataraka Upanisad* (14-18). It describes the syllables '*gu'* as 'darkness' and '*ru'* as 'dispeller'. Thus, '*guru'* is the 'dispeller of darkness.'[5] Another meaning comes from *Guru Gita* with '*gu'* meaning 'beyond qualities' and '*ru'* meaning 'devoid of form'. And this is interpreted as "He who bestows that nature which transcends the qualities." Another Sanskrit root is '*giri'* meaning 'the one who calls.' In this context *guru* is one who always hears the divine call within oneself and is devotedly attached to the call and can make manifest it in others.

Coming to history of this word, the idealistic meanings and qualities do not stand with it in the course of time. Coming to the time of *Manusmṛti*, we see social stagnation with caste system and education as the sole right of upper caste known as Brahmin. Here the post of *guru* becomes a family business! No one else other than Brāhmin can be a *guru*! This continued even up to the times of British colonialists. The modern times, with the advent of modern education, university system of knowledge giving, teacher student relation and democratic social set up, even the sense of *guru* has changed.

Coming to the contemporary times, this word is used in a generalized sense as "mentor" since 1940 (in H. G. Wells' writings). In the sense of "expert in something" like new age *gurus*, self-help *gurus,* etc., it is first used in 1966 in Canadian English.[6]

4 http://www.mandarkaranjkar.com/kabir-doha-on-guru-and-gurus-grace/, accessed on 28 May 2021.

5 *Advaitakara Upanishad* 16, available https://www.vyasaonline.com/advayataraka-upanishad/, accessed 28 May 2021.

6 See, https://www.etymonline.com/word/guru/, accessed 28 May 2021.

2.3. Deconstructing the Term 'Emancipation' in the Context of Education

If we look at the traditional meaning of the term 'emancipation', it has an idealistic sense referring to liberation or salvation in a spiritual context. But if we go to the roots of the word emancipation, we reach at the Roman Law where praxis for liberating children and women from the hands of men were discussed. Coming to the 19th century, it is referring to political emancipation of the slaves, especially the Declaration of Emancipation by Abraham Lincoln on January 1, 1863. In this context, emancipation is the fact of liberation or process of being set free from legal or social or political restrictions.

Coming to the education field, emancipation in the context of a student-teacher relation of learning-teaching process refers to an approach or orientation to activate those regions of the brain that are accountable for social sensitivity, social responsiveness, and empathy in the process of appropriating knowledge. Usually, teaching-learning process concentrates on encouraging creation of skilled workers with creativity aimed at developing problem-solving skills. But emancipative education concentrates on developing an approach that is adequately concerned with the social and cultural upliftment of the masses in terms of values, skills, liberative potentials through technologies, not only in the individuals but also in the communities, nations and the world society as the 'global village' in which we now live. When all the members of the society have an understanding of the implications of knowledge on them, through a critical social reflection, emancipative education become practical in the communities, nations and 'global village'.

2.4. Complexities in Understanding Meanings Connected with *Guru* and Emancipation

Our search so far about the meaning of the word *guru* bring to mind a way to articulate the complex meaning in the pattern of A. K. Ramanujan, as he did in his article, "Is there an Indian Way of Thinking."[7] A question can be posed in the similar line, "Is there an Indian *Guru*"? What would be the answer? It is a question about different aspects of a vision of life; about 'looking glasses' through which we can have clarities about knower, knowing, known and how of them all. Through these answers we can have a lot of clarities. This paper is an effort to show that the word *guru* and its related words give us the 'looking glass keys' through which we can unlock the whole ways of thinking and understanding of the religions and philosophies within the cultures and

7 A. K. Ramanujan, "Is There an Indian Way of Thinking? An Informal Essay," *Contributions to Indian Sociology* 23 no. 1 (1989): 41-58, available http://profcohen.net/reli113/uploads/texts/ramanujan.pdf, accessed 20 June 2021.

traditions of India. Our larger claim is that with the same keys, we can unlock the ambiguities due to the flood of 'legitimate opinions' about issues of our times.

eg.1. **Is there a true Indian *Guru*?**

Possible answers: 'There was, but not now!' If you want to see a true Indian *guru*, you must go to some traditional *pandits*, old texts, and not to university teachers of today. The opposing group say, 'yes there are true Indian *gurus,* even today.' This tradition will not go away. Indians think like Vedas, even in the midst of modern science and philosophies of life.

eg.2. **Is there a true Indian *Guru*?**

There is no one type of Indian *guru*. There are great and little traditions. All of them have *gurus*: ancient and modern; rural and urban; classical and folk. Each language, caste and region have its special worldview. On the other hand, there are people who speak of 'unity in diversity' as far as *gurus* and their visions are concerned.

eg.3. **Is there a true Indian *Guru*?**

What we see in India is not anything special of India. Everything came to India and they looked through different glasses like Vedic, Upanishadic, Buddhist, agricultural, industrial, Marxian, etc., all those who looked through them are *gurus*. But opposite group will say, anything that came to India is 'framed' by India in its unique way. Look at the example of foreign languages. 'How an Indian speak English'! The same is true with every religion, both born in India and came to India. The Indian way inescapably 'frame' anything come to India. *Gurus* are people who are experts in doing this activity.

eg.4. **Is there a true Indian *Guru*?**

The question is like: Do the Indians have the ability to be a true *guru* at all? Do they have anything other than some show? Is there a 'philosopher *guru'* like Aristotle, Kant or Wittgenstein in India? Aren't Sankara or Ramanuja mere commentators? At the maximum, can they be accepted as mystics? The accusations go like: Indians subordinate matter to spirit, so only metaphysics, no science, not even psychology. On the other hand, one can laugh at these arguments as ignorance and prejudice against Indian heritage.

No one may stand consistently on only one side, always in all the above arguments. There are convincing arguments on all sides. The arguments go on! When we analyse the reasons for this plurality of interpretations, we see two main perspectives. The first is what we exposed as the traditional paradigm and the second the post-modern paradigm of comprehension of the term *guru*.

3. The Modern and Post-Modern Paradigm of *Guru*

With the growth of modern conceptions of education in the light of the needs of capitalism and industrial revolution on one side, and in the light of democracy and the values of liberty, equality and fraternity on the other side, a lot of traditional authoritarian believes were questioned. Growth of scientism and theories of evolution, a lot of dogmas on which faith of the monotheistic religious life bases itself too were questioned. Against the traditional authoritarian ideologies of the *gurus*, a new trend that rejected the grand theories comes up with pragmatism and relativism. We call this group as the post-modern *gurus*. Empirical approach of the post-modern trend criticises grand narratives based on dogma. For them 'traditional load' of '*guru* as perfect' and to be obeyed without questioning is a form of slavery. Instead of the traditional emphasis on esoteric rationality, modernists propose scientific rationality and coming to post-modernism, pragmaticism and relativism as the answers, which also is falling into another type of slavery.[8]

One could ask: What is the issue with both these paradigms? What is the issue with the authoritarian traditional foundations of *guru*? If we refer to the intuitive, spiritual inner light that comes to *shishya* through *guru* as grace as the tradition claims, then no problem. But the history tells us the practical unfolding of institutionalism, stagnation of the external structure and family business or profession of Brahmins. This is a decadence in the system of Guru. Instead of inner freedom and liberty, there was stagnation of the caste system. In the second paradigm it looks like they throw out with the washtub water the child whom they were bathing! One could ask: Did we lose in the modern scientific, logical, rational, mathematical secularization the inner light that illumines our interior as the traditional conception of *guru* claims?

The post-modern models of education and the role of teacher in that education conception brought down *gurus* to a level playing field of one of the products in the supermarket where there are lot of choice for the customer. Customer is child or its caretaker who seeks education, and the power of choice of the students make them masters and teachers as one who has to compete

8 Zygmund Bauman is a champion who speaks of inverted processes of reason falling into extremes as in Kantian reason of order and the opposite is consumerist market liberty of post-modern trend. In his book *Modernity and Holocaust* that came out in English in 1989 shows the scenario of modernist 'at homeness' with safety by raising an ordering of system at the expense of liberty or freedom of the individual which is built on fear of the other which is a type of slavery. In his other books, *Post Modernity and its Discontents* of 1997 and *Liquid Modernity* of 2000, presents the opposite scenario of free from the oppressive system. But the problem is, because of the replaced consumerist open market, individual once again left with no other choice than consuming, and invisibly became slave of consuming. See, the bibliography section of https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Zygmunt_Bauman/, accessed 28 May 2022.

in the supermarket for getting the attention and interest of the customer! In my understanding, this is the first delegitimizing that post-modern education brought in to the conception of *guru*! Secondly, pragmatism delegitimized the traditional goal of education as spiritual emancipation. Now our issue is, how to regain the lost honour of the conception of *guru* as one who has intuitive vision (*darshan*) about everything?

4. Building the Bridge Between Religion and Science: A Post-Secular or Meta-Modern Paradigm

Now the question is: Can we open a new space in between the two extremes of the traditional paradigm and the post-modern paradigm? In the sense of chiselling out the authoritarian, dogmatic, hierarchical and conservative burdens on the term and taking up the inner spiritual strength and open it to the modern scientific analysis? What do we mean to keep as sacred? Is it openness to insight, flow, inner experience? What John Vervake[9] speaks of as 'awakening from the meaning crisis' in which we find ourselves? Do we need to bring out a legitimizing of the term *guru* for 'saving' the purpose of education that we presented in our main heading as policies and practices for emancipative education?

How is this possible? Is the standing back and looking at the issue help? In Buddhist terms it is *vipassana* or 'inner seeing'! In the phenomenological approach it is the bracketing and the necked seeing of the pure essence of things. In the words of Ken Wilber, it is integral theory of everything as in his Four Quadrant model.[10] As spiritual practice, Buddhists speak of mindfulness practice or contemplation to see comprehensively, dynamic balance within the larger picture of our life: that involves left and right hemisphere; emotions and reason integration; primitive and modern integration; esoteric and scientific integration; prerational and rational integrate into a transrational; modernism integrated to post modernism; secularism integrated to post-

9 John Vervaeke, the Canadian Philosopher and professor of Cognitive Science at the university of Toronto, who is the proponent of "Awakening from Meaning Crisis" who did fifty lectures in YouTube about the same. See, https://www.youtube.com/@johnvervaeke/playlists; "awakening from meaning crisis."

10 Ken Wilber the American Philosopher who is a proponent of "Integral Spirituality. There are lot of writings of Ken Wilber available in YouTube and pdf form. There are very many interpretations of his vision and its criticisms too are available. See, "The Leading Edge of The Unknown in The Human Being: Ken Wilber," available *scienceandnon-duality.com*. See also, https://www.goodreads.com/author/list/22075.Ken_Wilber; http://www.paulhelfrich.com/library/Helfrich_P_The_Five_Phases_of_Wilber.pdf/, accessed 28 May 2022.

secularism etc. All of them involve a type of transcendence, an opening to new space![11]

Someone may see a new age stigma in this line of thought. The line of Ken Wilber who refuse to put his writings into scientific scrutiny as it too is dogmatic like that of institutional religion. Here his claims stand shallow like those that he rejects exclaims those clammer for scientific scrutiny. But he will escape from the criticism by presenting the possibility of parallel authorities: intuitiveness is an authority equal to traditionalism and scientific scrutiny. So, intuitiveness will suffice in his case! If we take the example of Ken Welber, he does observation of his mind and body when he meditates. From this angle he is critical of the narrow-minded paradigms of science like modern positivism, which has no way to observe the meditative experiences. In his understanding it is shallow science. In this he goes in the line of Indian *gurus*. How shall we bridge the gap between Indian *gurus* or the line of contemporary supporting of what traditional conception of *guru* stands for as we see in the presentations of Deepak Chopra[12] with the popularization of alternative medicine, mind cure and the scientism of the atheistic, secular rationalism and post-modern pragmatism?

Conclusion

After the deconstruction of two 'idols': the traditional and the post-modern paradigms of '*gurus'*, we are opening to a new landscape which bridges the two with 'pure seeing' or 'intuition' without slipping into any dogmatic camp on one side, and on the other not missing out the fruits of consciousness studies. This opens new vistas of educational horizons.

11 Here I present the insights of Yuval Noah Harari in many of his videos and articles. For his conversation with Tom Bilyeu, see, "The 2 Most Important Skills for the Rest of Your Life | Yuval Noah Harari on Impact Theory," https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=x6tMLAjPVyo&t=132s/, accessed 28 May 2022.

12 Deepak Chopra is a successful Indian American writer in alternative medicine based on Indian ancient wisdom coupled with modern science and medical practice. Most of the books and articles by Deepak Chopra are available in the Website https://www.deepakchopra.com/, accessed 28 May 2022.

9

Traditional Indian Education
A Critique

John Peter Vallabadoss, OFM Cap.

Abstract: Indian traditional educational system, *Gurukula* and *Vedapāṭhśāla*, created and sustained for centuries by Indian Vedic tradition, have been consistent with its heritage of imparting timeless wisdom of knowing the Self and/as the Divine. Serving as effective means of teaching and learning acclaimed as the noblest profession and way of life, these residential school setups are critiqued from *śāstric* period to present times: brahmanical hegemony are traced in terms of negation of inclusiveness of educational opportunities for all, of exclusive Vedic privilege for the 'twice-born', of denial of education to *Śudras*, of non-negotiable Aryan eligibility criteria, of arrogance of intellectual calibre, of assimilation of non-vedic systems, of resistance as well as appropriation to British educational reforms, of *Saṁskrita mahāvidhyālayās*, and presently of strategic proposition in the new National Education Policy. Both the systems are utilised as basic Vedic establishments as bedrock of brahmanical hegemony, for radical propagation of monolithic Vedic culture over plural fabric of Indian cultural identity. The paper explores the deliberate and hidden agendas of powerful ideology of authority in and through these traditional educational systems and proposes counter measures in combating it.

Keywords: *Gurukula*, *Vedapāṭhaśāla, Brāhmaṇical, Paramparā*, *Sanātana, Sūtra, Smṛti, Guru*.

Introduction

Indian indigenous methods of passing on the knowledge gained by one generation to the next, varied from informal learning of wisdom and trade of the family, residential religious instructions through *gurukula*, monastic establishments of organized teaching, institutionalized educational setups around the temple complex, individual training for selected students in homes of teachers, etc. With the introduction of formal educational system by the British, these traditional establishments have initially reacted and later appropriated the modern system in serving their original objectives and methods. Proposed critique of Vedic educational systems, *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaśāla,* anchors around the examination of their objective, method, practical organizational structures from the ancient epoch to the present contemporary times. Present analysis of brāhmaṇical hegemony ranges from its structural and ideological functioning, through the enquiry of categorisation of students and teachers to cleverly justified egalitarianism. The paper tends to critique it from Indian Christian perspective of access to knowledge for all, egalitarianism, inclusion and emancipation for all.

Vaidika Paramparā: An Appraisal

At the outset, appraisal for these brāhmaṇical systems is due by the fact that they have survived the onslaught of changing times, ideologies and socio-religious politics down the ages. The consistent functioning of both systems has been ensured by constant proliferation of certain 'sacredness' to the entire body of brāhmaṇical heritage, *paramparā* in terms of avowed allegiance to the Vedic tradition and its transmission through whatever means it demands. Continuity and discontinuity of characters specific to brāhmaṇical tradition holding on the *vaidika sampradāya,* holy Vedic legacy, cannot be but appreciated. Desire to be a learned and to make the offspring a learned, has been well played out by not only safeguarding the inheritance from *ṛṣimūlam,* the source of divine wisdom, but also constantly reminded of being a 'transmitter' not a 'creator' of knowledge.[1] Well-knit within the Vedic brāhmaṇical tradition, *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaṣāla* have resisted the decadence and decline of the traditional method of learning and teaching and survived throughout the changing scenario in educational field. Trysting with its own destiny from antiquity to modernity, the question of persistence and relevance in course of time have been well addressed by the brāhmaṇical

1 A traditional *vaidika śloka,* which is recited while commencing an academic session, reads like this: I bow to the tradition of teachers who impart wisdom flowing from the Divine, well received by great sages, mediated through the tradition. *sadāśiva samārambhām śaṅkarācharya madhyamām asmadācārya paryantām vande guru paramparām.*

hermeneutics of justification.[2] The kernel of Vedic tradition has been kept up with the dominance of brāhmaṇical sensibilities both with regards to socio-political-religious status quo, and to maintaining the 'purity' of the tradition.

Ancient Vedic Educational System: Benefit of Brahmins

Reaping the fruits of Western Indological studies in last three centuries, traditional academics of Vedic legacy, the learned classes of that time, the Brahmins, have benefitted much in both explaining, interpreting and glorifying Vedic antiquity. Defending the ancient educational system of *gurukula* and *vedapādashāla,* carefully considered as well integrated and holistic system of passing on the traditional wisdom, the brāhmaṇical academics highlighted the characters as ideal best suited for development of the individuals and the society at large, and as ideal for oral transmission of knowledge, preserved and conserved in-group, in Vedic case, the Brahmin class.[3] Aligned with any traditionally practiced system of knowledge, be it Ayurveda or siddha medicinal practice or in Vedic transmission, knowledge claimed to be secretive, dignified, attainable only to those who are worthy of it, exposes certain intellectual domination.

Merit as Criterion of Admission

Prerequisites or entry requirements for being admitted in these systems contains within an element of exclusion. Necessity of certain mental disposition to receive it, has an underlying insistence of 'exclusion.' On emphasising their merits, suppressing glaring defects, substantiating their views with arguments, one could quickly come to a conclusion of brāhmaṇical hegemony played out in these systemic ideologies. For instance, the homeland of Jainism and Buddhism, has been described as the land of 'peoples of impure origin,' and evidently those of that origin could never be admitted.[4]

2 One could trace historically such successful attempts from *Upaniṣadic* times through *Mīmāsaka* period and *Bhakti* movements to contemporary interpretations of Vedic science, Vedic mathematics, etc. All the efforts have been trying to justify the Vedic ritualism, conception, ideology and overall Vedic tradition, by brilliant brāhmaṇical argumentation and interpretation.

3 Although there are justified evidences of presence of other caste and class, both the teachers and students, the hegemonic aspects of the system remained largely with the Brahmins. See Sylvain Levi and others, *Pre-Aryans and Pre-Dravidians in India,* trans. P. C. Bagchi (Calcutta: University of Calcutta, 1929). Sanghamitra Dasgupta, "Brahmanical Educational Institutions in Eastern India," in *Journal of Ancient Indian History*, 14 (1983-84): 207-216.

4 Baudhāyana, *Dharmasūtra, 1.1,2,14,* in *The Sacred Books of the East* II Trans., G. Bühler, (Oxford:1896). Whereas, the heterodox systems have developed a much more open-to-public approach. "The rise and growth of a number of Buddhist monastic colleges of

Sanātana (Eternity) Claim: A Privilege

The 'a-historical' character of Vedic tradition as *sanātana dharma,* timeless-eternal-ahistorical tradition, leaves both ambiguity and privileged position for the Brahminical hegemony.[5] Existence of these structured system of *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaśāla* during pre-historical times, has not been verified archeologically or historically. Traces of these systems have been found in their own Vedic literatures, both *Śṛuti* and *Smṛti,* as internal evidence. Nevertheless, absence of external historical evidence poses a problem.

During 6th to 13th centuries, the historical records and inscriptions prove the existence of different types of Brahmanical institutions, *āśramas.* The *purāṇas* and *dharmaśāstras* proved the continuance of the *gurukula* system, under which the disciple stayed with the *guru* and was treated as one of the members of his household, looking after the cattle of the preceptor, collecting flower for the family deity and collecting wood for sacrificial pit, etc. The emergence of popular education through public teachings by great sages, the enacting of popular art forms depicting the *smṛti* literary characters, have seen as method of dissipating traditional knowledge.[6]

Development of Allied Institutions and Brahmanical Settlements

Another type of educational institution designated as the *maṭhas*[7] as educational colleges attached to the temples, continued to re-establish the predominance of Brahmanical religion.[8] Colleges sprang up in the adjuncts of the temples which became regular centres of study which appear to be

varying dimensions in the countryside attracted a large number of students. Indeed, the Buddhist systems provided for a more organised type of institutions catering to the needs of a developing society. The Brahmanical system of education, which in the pre-Gupta period centred round the *gurukula* or forest-hermitage, proved to be inadequate to cope with the growing population and increasing interest in education among the masses." Sanghamitra Dasgupta, "Brahmanical Educational Institutions in Eastern India," 207.

5 "Relative paucity of source-material makes it difficult to reconstruct a fairly systematic account of the Brahmanical system of education… No Hiuen Tsang or I-tsing has left any record throwing light on this system of education. The absence of wealth of positive data is partly compensated by the information scattered in the contemporary land-grants, and literature." Sanghamitra Dasgupta, "Brahmanical Educational Institutions in Eastern India," 208.

6 Keeping out the non-brāhmaṇical crowd through such practices, adds to the brāhmaṇical hegemony.

7 *Maṭha* is derived from the root *maṭh* which means 'to dwell,' differently described as 'dwelling places of gods' and 'dwelling places of students desirous of learning the Vedas.' Analogous to the Buddhist *vihāras, the maṭhas* appear to be of much later origin owing to their Buddhist example.

8 Sanghamitra Dasgupta, "Brahmanical Educational Institutions in Eastern India," 209; Krsna Misra's *Prabodhacandrodaya* Vol. 10, p. 841.

residential and the expenses of education were mostly borne by wealthy landlords or local rich men. An inscription[9] refers to members of the teaching staff as *upādhyāyas,* and *mahattara brāhmaṇas,* as superintendents of an institutions. Several inscriptions of land grants speak of *maṇḍapas* established by the Brāhmaṇas, and later the Śobhanesvara inscription of the 12th century refers to the construction of accommodation and residential arrangements for teachers and students, called *agrahāras*.[10] Another type of institution called *pariṣad*, signifying an 'academy of experts', with *sūtra* and *smṛti* texts explaining differently their composition, requisite qualifications of its members, kinds of duties, etc.[11]

Being Brahmin: Claims of Advantage and Privilege

Ancient Indian educational theory and practice are characterized by both the representations of Brahmanical educational scenes and figures and the total configuration of ideals, practical attitudes and conduct with theoretic orientations, accepted by society. Believing more in group-life of learned, illustrating dominant modes and forms of association, giving privileged position of both individual and group, the society with a happy compromise had placed one group as worth of the real personality of the learned, of inner culture of brahmins, recognizing the claims of the group as the necessary and inevitable intermediary formation. While castes determined crafts, the choice of the ideals and ends of life was subordinated. "Some occupations were approved for certain castes and condemned for others, as life was controlled by religion as man's supreme interest and concern, and was not left to be moulded freely by the operation of natural laws."[12] Brāhmaṇical hegemony has not been directly involved by the brāhmaṇical class of people, but infused its ideology and practiced through non- brāhmaṇical class of individuals.[13] Brāhmaṇical System has underlined emancipation of individual in life, if it is applied and served for the purpose of emancipation of all the communities, not narrowly defined for Brahmanical social group alone, both in the sense of caste privilege and class of intellectuals. The ideology of assimilation that the marginalised

9 K. K. Gupta, *Copper-Plates of Sylhet* I (Sylhet: Lipika Enterprises, 1967), 87-125.

10 Sanghamitra Dasgupta, "Brahmanical Educational Institutions in Eastern India," 212.

11 See, *Dharmaśāstrakāras* (Manu, *Sacred Books of the East*, XXV, 12, 100) describing them as best intellectuals, belonging to first three orders.

12 Radha Kumud Mookerji, Prologue, *Ancient Indian Education: Brahmanical and Buddhist* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1969), xxi.

13 See, V. Geetha and E. V. Rajadurai, *Towards a Non-Brahmanical Millennium* (Kolkota: Samya, 1998); Kancha Illaiah, *Post-Hindu India* (Sage India: 2009).

with knowledge and skills merge with the dominant group's strategy of being 'educated' as being on top privileged position.[14]

Brahmanical hegemony continues, when the educated refuse to cultivate a capacity and willingness to work with hands and be closely related to productivity, and to strengthen social integration and help to create a more just and egalitarian social order.

Filial Relation with *Guru*

Living with the teacher as a member of his family and the student treated as his son, the *gurukula* system is a natural formation, not artificially constituted, as a hermitage. The constant and intimate association between teacher and taught is vital to imbibe the inward method of the teacher, the secrets of his efficiency, and the spirit of his life and work. Ensuring individual attention and treatment, personal touch, the living relationship, enables the pupil belonging to the teacher of a tradition, and not to an institution or the abstraction called the school. Devotion of teacher as a parent, not merely an education which quickens intellectual development but which leaves slight impress upon life and character. "If education is without its telling influence on the springs of conduct the progress of the country is retarded."[15]

Individual intimate relationship between the teacher and the pupil is inaugurated by *upanayana,*[16] by which the teacher, 'holding the pupil within him as in a womb, impregnates him with his spirit, and delivers him in a new birth. The pupil is then known as a *dvija,* 'born afresh,' in a new existence, 'twice-born' (*Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa,* XI, 5,4). *Brahmacarya*, mode of life, enables student as 'newly born' to be initiated to a system of educative practices. With the ceremony of *agnihotra,* duties to tend teacher's house and cattle, as training in self-help, the dignity of labour, of menial service for his teacher and the student-brotherhood, Vedic education was not exclusively theoretical and academic but was related to a craft as a part of liberal education as manual and vocational training. Educative value of *Brahmacārī's* daily round of begging,[17] in a spirit of humility and renunciation. Our critique on such practice of being a 'twice-born' undergoing an investiture ceremony, and physical labour to humble oneself.

14 Usha Zacharias, "To Race with the Able? Soft Skills and the Psychologisation of Marginality," in *Beyond Inclusion: The Practice of Equal Access in Indian Higher Education,* ed., Satish Deshpande and Usha Zacharias (New Delhi: Routledge, 2013), 325.

15 William Meston, *Indian Educational Policy: Its Principles and Problems* (Madras: Christian Literature Society, 1936), 420.

16 Reference to *Brahmacārī* and *Upanayana* ceremony is found in *Ṛgveda*, X.109.5 and III.8.4-5.

17 *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* xi.3.3.5.

Alienation arises between the individuals educated in system and the masses of the people[18] common experience that these system of education created two distinct social groups: 1) the educated persons, who refuse to work with their hands and who live a parasitic life, and 2) the masses, who work with their hands and produce wealth but are deprived of all opportunities of formal education.[19] Can these systems ensure avoiding this dichotomy between work and education and train all individuals to be educated, productive workers?

Personal Emancipation of Individuals: Objective of Vedic Education

The entire system was planned on the principle that it should offer the best scope for the development of the individual as its centre and chief concern. "In the same way, the process of adjustment to the group-life is not left to chance, to the raw impulses of the individual, or to the changing patterns of mores and fashions. The ideals of the group, its scheme of values, and the realities that the group-tradition conceived as supreme, must be clearly reflected in the mind of the individual. The end can only be achieved through a course of training that reshapes the psychic and bodily life of man."[20] Method of learning according to capacity: the evolved methods by which such knowledge could be acquired, conserved and transmitted to posterity, from *Ṛṣi* to his family of the *guru,* and each such family was functioning like a Vedic school admitting pupils for instruction in the literature or texts in its possession. Unlike the modern school teaching pupils by 'classes.' "Individual rather than class teaching was the rule, and each pupil was free to develop at his own speed according to his own intellectual power."[21] In fact, Vedic education is a process of control of mind, to drive it down to its deeper layers, to subterranean depths and reveals one's original personality.

The individual was educated not so much for his own sake as for the sake of society and individualism came to have very little scope for development.[22] Learning to serve society would no way sever the ties with the larger society, brāhmaṇical education tends to serve individuals and serve society in the pure malicious intent of being on the top of society, in the pretext of serving with intelligence. Critically speaking, age-long continuity shows the vitality of

18 J. P. Naik, *An Assessment of Educational Reform in India and Lessons for the Future* (Paris: UNESCO, 1980), 2.

19 J. P. Naik, *An Assessment of Educational Reform in India*, 2.

20 Radha Kumud Mookerji, Prologue, *Ancient Indian Education: Brahmanical and Buddhist* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1969), xxi.

21 F. E. Keay, *Ancient Indian Education: An Inquiry into its Origin, Development, and Ideals* (London: Oxford University Press, 1918), 166.

22 Santosh Kumar Das, *The Educational System of the Ancient Hindus* (Calcutta: Self Published, 1930).

the system; but as the ideals of the past guide its existence and growth, the methods of learning and teaching become stereotyped.

Serving Misguided Patriotism

Educational and national development are intimately inter-related. Education not merely focussing on individual but also the social group of all belongings in a nation. The pre-independence period where indigenous educational institutions set up by Tagore, like Sriniketan, Shantiniketan and Vishwabharati, had a distinctive feature of their own. Gujarat Vidyapeeth, Tilak Maharashtra Vidyapeeth, and Kashi Vidyapeeth, maintained through public contributions and sacrifices of dedicated Indian educators, trained a large number of individuals who provided leadership in the struggle for freedom.[23] In claiming to decolonize education, through new policies of education, brāhmaṇical intelligentia in joining hands with seekers of political power, have created yet again a thickly populated service sector as 'enabled' and 'competent' in securing a place in higher-end job markets. The knowledge society that does not begin with the decolonisation of knowledge may only create new knowledge colonies.[24] Brahmanical training is not merely for a livelihood but for a life style itself. How far these new policies of education in India both pre-Independence and post-Independence have created these sensibilities? The Brahmin class have become victims of their own making; in the sense of *swadeshi* system of education created for preparing the other castes for job-markets, have now become well-placed job positions, either in India or abroad, taking once again a higher status of jobs in the society.

Presently, being used as propaganda tool of radical forces, these Vedic educational systems serve their own interest. Aiming at inculcating a spirit of patriotism and a sense of proper pride in shared cultural heritage, these systems should instil an urge to build a nation of its dreams of relentless war against the evils of poverty, inequality, ignorance and ill-health, immoral and anti-social activities.

Vedic Education: Its Religious Orientation

Claiming the Vedas the most ancient source of Indian thought, and attaching the eternal principle of its origin as the seeds and sources of entire course of brāhmaṇical thought, has demonstrated Vedic intellectual or ritual-religious monuments.[25] Priestly schools had been formed as the centre of the Aryan

23 J. P. Naik, An Assessment of Educational Reform in India, 3.

24 Usha Zacharias, "To Race with the Able? Soft Skills and the Psychologisation of Marginality," in Beyond Inclusion: The Practice of Equal Access in Indian Higher Education, ed., Satish Deshpande and Usha Zacharias (New Delhi: Routledge, 2013), 325.

25 Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education: Brahmanical and Buddhist*, 17.

civilization. From the very start, Vedic education came under the influence of religious ideas. Learning in Vedic tradition had been prized and pursued not for its own sake but for the sake of religion, and was sought as the means of self-realization to the highest end of life, *mokṣa,* liberation. And education was understood as being ultimately the outcome of theory of knowledge and a particular angle of Vedic vision, a sense of perspective in which the material and the moral, the physical and the spiritual, the perishable and permanent values of life are clearly defined and strictly differentiated. Devoting oneself to the fundamental truths of life, the ideal self was believed to be discovered through contemplation, *svarūpānubhūti,* and through intellection, *manana. Dharma* and *Brahma* as subject matter of Veda, are known only through the Veda and not through any other source.[26] "He who does not know the Veda cannot comprehend *Brahma.*"[27] Those admitted as resident pupils live with the teacher under prescribed disciplines or vows as *vratācārīs.*

Education is seen as an aid in the self-fulfilment, not the acquisition of mere objective knowledge. It is more concerned with the subject than the object, the inner than the outer world. "The pursuit of objective knowledge is thus not the chief concern of this Education."[28] The individual must achieve his emancipation, his escape from bondage, *saṁsāra,* the vicious circle of birth and death. Indifference to objective knowledge and the perception about cerebral mechanism or the brain aimed only to the outer physical sensible universe, creative cultivation of mind where as to transform the entire psychic organism, as the objective content of knowledge.

The young brāhmaṇa was being prepared as a priest and teacher in present life, as well the need of preparing oneself for the life after death was included.[29] Preparing the individuals for practical duties of life, the tendency is to despise the ordinary life, brāhmaṇical philosophy, sets forth an ideal of life which despised, or regarded as unreal, this fleeting world of time, practical life as something on a lower plane.[30] "The spirit of other-worldliness which thus gained a hold upon the brāhmaṇical schools made them more out of touch with the ordinary life of the world and helped to make them unfit to mould the Indian peoples in the paths of progress and general culture."[31] Despising the earthly life is itself a strategic claim of positioning oneself for hierarchical and higher status among those who considered the life lived here and now as higher and superior to anything unexperienced, imagined and never verifiable

26 "*dharmabrahmaṇī Vedaikavedye."* Jaimini, *Pūruva-Mīmāṁsā Sutra.*

27 *"nāvedavinmanute taṁ bṛihantam*." *Taittriya Brahmana*, III.12.9.

28 Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education,* xxiii.

29 F. E. Keay, *Ancient Indian Education*, 171.

30 F. E. Keay, *Ancient Indian Education*, 171.

31 F. E. Keay, *Ancient Indian Education*, 172.

in its empirical plane. Following the idealistic and absolutistic thought pattern brāhmaṇical system dares to label all that is concrete and empirical as inferior, non-permanent and illusory.

The inevitable association of religion with education is evident. Indian mind finds it hard to think of education dissociated from distinctive values taught by their religions. The close association of education and religion has a historical support and is woven into the texture of the national life.[32] When the old religious and cultural loyalties are being set aside, reverence is passing and the attitude of indifference and irreverence of those educated, to sacrifices made by parents and educators is largely ascribed to the secular character of the education imparted. So, it is a return to that form of education which finds its support in religion.[33] The difficulty of religious neutrality lies in between the desire of religious education with values embedded in culture and tradition, and the secular neutral values of humanity, in all educational matters in a country with diverse creeds. Imparting sound secular instruction is feared as developing a population with dry intellectual capacity.[34] Religious neutrality in not supporting any religious groups, is often confused with secularity. Education as tool of propaganda of a religious ideology or social thinking, served well by *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaśāla*. Recognition of *vedapāṭhaśāla* in line with formal schools and creation of Sanskrit universities, bringing them into main stream of national educational policies and opposing all other seminaries and *Madrasas* of other religions will have unwanted recuperation in a country of plural religious traditions.

Preserving Ritualistic Tradition

The Vedic *mantras* are regarded as the words employed by Ṛṣis in praise of the gods for fulfilment of desires, *artha. Mantras* convey a mystical meaning and produce unseen results, for which their mere recitation is rigidly followed according to the prescribed order of their words. The *mantras* must be properly pronounced and their meanings also must be properly mastered with the aid of the *Vedāṅgas*.[35] On commenting on the conservation of its texts one finds that some mechanical linguistic devices by which the sacred text handed down from time immemorial could be conserved in their pristine purity and original

32 William Meston, *Indian Educational Policy: Its Principles and Problems* (Madras: Christian Literature Society, 1936), 419.

33 William Meston, *Indian Educational Policy: Its Principles and Problems*, 420.

34 William Meston, *Indian Educational Policy: Its Principles and Problems*, 422.

35 Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education: Brahmanical and Buddhist*, 3. Strict adherence of recitation is by "*pāṭha-kramaniyama,* is sufficient, *mantrāṇām adṛishṭārthamucchāraṇa-mātram; ucchāraṇāt adṛṣṭārthāḥ"* And the sense of a sentence, *vākyārtha,* can be deduced from the relations of its constituent parts. "*kriyā-kāraka-sambandhena pratīyamāno vākyārtho loka Vedayoraviśiṣṭaḥ*." Jaimini, I.2.40

forms and ensured against the interpolations of later ages. "The traditional orthodox respect for the sacred word was already responsible for the high standard of verbal authenticity. The inherited and established tradition and literary practice further improved and confirmed by a rigid adherence to the words of the old seers and even to their most minute irregularities of accent or alternate forms."[36] The invocation of *mantras* is not only an act of religious observance but as transmission of orality.

Oral Tradition and Transmission: A Strategy

The method of teaching was purely oral with some principles, due to the absence of a script in those days.[37] With allusion to pupils reciting the syllables dictated by the teacher who carefully saw that not a single accent, *svara,* was wrongly pronounced. The text of the Veda is to be learnt by the method of learning it from the lips of the teacher and not from a manuscript.[38] "No doubt, the tradition of Vedic learning was to impart it to the ear as a secret doctrine to be contemplated and realized and not to make it a visible object available to all, irrespective of their fitness."[39]

The strategical strength of brāhmaṇical hegemony has been the system of oral tradition in *gurupāramparya* or *sampradāya* as 'the uninterrupted ideal succession of pupils and teachers, by which knowledge is conserved and transmitted.'[40] *Śabda,* the word is Brahma; that the spoken word is god, has by itself its own potency and value—apart from its sense, and its intrinsic attributes, its rhythm, and vibrations—should be captured. The high aim of Vedic education has been explained as the achievement of the supreme, saving knowledge. The oral education defines *śravaṇa* as listening to the instruction of the teacher and knowing from him the primary truth that the Self is to be differentiated from the non-Self, appearing in various forms.[41] Hearing of texts and words uttered by the teacher is to be followed by the process of *manana*, deliberation, reflection on the topic taught, but it results only in an intellectual apprehension of its meaning, in the stage of *nididhyāsana* by which realization of truth can be attained.

36 Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education: Brahmanical and Buddhist*, 20.

37 Santosh Kumar Das, *The Educational System of the Ancient Hindus* (Calcutta: Self Published,1930), 130.

38 "*adhyanavidhiśca llikhitapāṭhādivyāvṛitya adhyayanaasaṁskṛitatvaṁ svādhyāyasya gamayati.*" Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education,* 27.

39 Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education*, 27.

40 "*sampradāyonāma sishyopādhyāyasaṁbandhasya avichchhedena śāstraprāptiḥ."* Udyotakara, *Nyāya-Vārttika.*

41 Śaṅkara, *Viveka-Chūḍāmaṇi,*

Setting up such a system of oral education through above mentioned three stages, serves the purpose of dependence on the Vedic education. As the quote from the Upaniṣad goes the uselessness of bookish knowledge, "The seeker after the highest knowledge should not seek after the knowledge of the books, for that is mere weariness of the tongue."[42] Further, the teacher himself is the living and walking library. Even up to the time of Kumārila (8th century CE), it was considered sacrilege to reduce the Veda to writing, for learning was not reading but realization, and knowledge was to be in the blood as an organic part of one's self.[43]

Seclusion of Place and Persons: Specialized Space and Class

The idea of *gurukula* institutions in a remote place betrays an inbuilt hegemonic strategy, besides its academic ambience for better learning, an idea of the working of the school as whole, physical surroundings away from centres of population, opportunities for contact with nature and for solitude. "The individual becomes in this way wholly dependent upon the social group; sense of dependence within. Isolation having its own effects on one's inner development, isolation from objects, material and social, helps in the elimination of the disharmonies of inner life, *citta-śuddhi* giving scope for reflection, for self-possession, for the integration of different life processes, and a complete awareness of one's individuality or self-hood.[44] "Though the Brāhmanic education was no doubt also carried on in towns, especially in later times, the forest sanctuary has always been the Indian ideal."[45]

Brāhmaṇa as an educated, has a nuance of not merely a class or a caste, but a class-apart group of intellectuals with a hegemony expressed and exercised throughout Indian history influencing all spheres of life. "The brāhmaṇas were the real intellectual leaders controlling education"[46] with supremacy established and exercised over the rest of the people.

Glorifying the Veda as knowledge absolute is a means of achieving spiritual ends. Veda as the end which cannot be known by the evidence of direct perception, inference, and the like, can be known through the Veda,

42 *Bṛhadāraṇyaka*, IV, 4, 21.

43 Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education*, xxxi.

44 Even in contemporary times, Tagore expressed his opinion that the forest is the fountain-head of all its civilization. In these forests there was enough of open space, of aloofness; still this aloofness did not produce inertia, rather it rendered it all the brighter. As quoted in Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education*, xxxv.

45 F. E. Keay, *Ancient Indian Education: An Inquiry into its Origin, Development, and Ideals* (London: Oxford University Press, 1918), 181.

46 Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education*, 155.

and therefore, this determines the character of the Veda.[47] Knowledge was looked upon as the primary qualification for the recognition of a person as *brāhmaṇa* later Brāhminhood came to depend upon birth, Vedic learning was compulsory duty of all brāhmaṇas. "The *śṛuti* and *smṛti* are the two eyes of the brāhmaṇas created by God."[48] The methods of education naturally varied with the capacities of pupils. Rig X.71.7 points out the equality of knowledge (*samānaṁ khyānaṁ jñānaṁ yeśām),* but betrays inequality in respect of their power of mind or the wisdom attained by the mind.[49] In the *sūtra* period, with freedom of thought and study, specialization in different schools of thought emerged. Education in the philosophical *sūtra* literature, in the systems of philosophy as the systems of discipline, emphasis of skill of debate have set apart these intellectuals as class-apart. Vedic education is to be studied as an integral part of Vedic thought and life. Adequate appreciation of the system of Vedic education, its ideals and institutions – as part of defence of tradition in terms of cultural heritage, being lost in Westernised modernization of Modern India in the making. As nationalist right-wing idealisation of such monolithic tradition of Vedic, raises question.

Standing alone as intellectual and receiving honour as possessor of knowledge, could never be a license to dominate. Claiming that 'knowing is liberating' as of Vedantic tradition, the brāhmaṇical intelligentia have placed power of Self-knowledge as God-knowledge, as above all other ways of learning.

Brāhmanic Elitism

"The brāhmaṇas who neither study nor teach the Vedas, become of the conduct of *śūdras*. Without studying the Ṛgveda, one does not become a brāhmaṇas. Manu states, "A twice-born person who not having studied the Veda, spends his labour on another subject, soon fails, even while living, to the condition of a *śūdra* and his descendants after him."[50]

While unlearned brāhmaṇas are deprived of status, offering and respect, the learned have been noted for their intelligence, bravery, high birth.[51] "The society not only honoured its learned but also granted them special privileges."

47 *alaukikaṁ puruṣārthopāyaṁ vetti aneneti;* and *pratyakṣeṇānumityā vā yastūpāyo na vudhyate; etaṁ vidanti vedena tasmād vedasya vedatā.*

48 *Harit Saṃhitā*, I.25; I.344.

49 "*asamāḥ manojabeshu, manasāṁ prajaveshu.*" Yāska, *Nirukta*, I.9. See, Radha Kumud Mookerji, *Ancient Indian Education*, 25.

50 Santosh Kumar Das, *The Educational System of the Ancient Hindus,* 436.

51 Kautilya, *Arthaśāstra, trans., R. Śyāmaśāstri, 252.* Śukrāchārya describes learned men as ornaments in palaces. See, *Sukranītisāra,* IV.7.638-45.

Elitist character of educational power and knowledge is concentrated in the hands of a small elite who always keep a united front against the masses of people who are marginalized. "We created this elite structure of our society… all power was vested in the three upper castes (or social groups): the Brahmins monopolized the power of knowledge, the Kshatriyas monopolized political power, and the Vaishyas monopolized the money power. These three castes were described as twice-born, their second birth being their initiation into the study of the sacred texts to which they alone were entitled. This designation, therefore, shows what united these castes together, as well as what separated them from the vast masses of people, the Shudras, who lived as slaves or workers without any human dignity."[52] Such elitist model keeps the masses of people suppressed and marginalized, is perpetuated as it suited well, even in time of British to use this group as intermediaries and interpreters stabilizing their rule.

Exclusive categorization of belonging to elite caste by birth and refusing vertical social mobility even with education as merit, has basically hegemony by learned people, the intelligentisia, the modern Brahmins. The elitist character with its hierarchical organization based on some real or imagined advantage, refuses an equalization in horizontal relationship. The hierarchical tradition is inimical to the values of social justice.[53]

To combat this elitist trends, new philosophy of 'faith in the common man, believing in his dignity, basic wisdom, inherent capacity to manage oneself.' Organizing society on basic principles of individual dignity and autonomy, not on growth of extreme professionalism.

Concluding Remarks

A critical appraisal of *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaśāla* would consider many positive aspects of the Vedic-Vedantic-Brahmanical legacy for centuries, dating from oral transmission to present day. Thanks to such strenuous efforts of *guru-prampara,* Vedic values have been alive till contemporary times. Continuity and discontinuity enable a tradition to be revitalised every epoch. What we have focussed in the present analysis of Brahmanical hegemony illustrates the strategic ideology and practice of the Vedic-Vedantic tradition down the ages, through notions of *sanātana, guruparampara, upanayana,* study of Vedic literature, individual emancipation, power of knowledge, justification for exclusion of non-brāhmaṇical aspects, focalising the otherworldly and superior knowledge of self and God as the ultimate end of human, purity and eligibility criteria. Vedic education through *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaśāla* comprised the transmission of the sacred texts by the teacher to his pupil by

52 J. P. Naik, *An Assessment of Educational Reform in India*, 61.

53 J. P. Naik, *An Assessment of Educational Reform in India*, 62.

means of regulated recitation and prescribed pronunciation which the pupil had to listen to as *śruti* and commit to memory. The education is primarily a matter of hearing and memorising by repetition. Memorising and repetition without mistake, followed by explanation and reflection, enabled the capacity to be a successful student.

The Vedic education specifically mentions about need of teacher, rules of studentship, process of admission, period, duties, inner discipline, pursuit of highest knowledge, duties of teacher, insistence of morality. Education of non-Aryans and depressed classes, of women, and secular learning have been compromised largely, even though there are justification with certain evidences. *Ātma vidya* as the supreme denies the empirical knowledge and wisdom of the masses exclusion begins here. Continuously insisting on manual labour and local culture as inferior, uncivilized do not have emancipatory elements in Vedic education through *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaśāla,* even though those students admitted in them do certain duties of manual labour.

Various facets of Vedic education have highlighted the factual ideological exclusion of non-brāhmaṇic candidates, although forced justifications are mooted out citing exceptions of inclusion. The brāhmaṇical hegemony has been widely demonstrated against continuing reservation policies after four decades of post Independent India. Merit and equality of opportunities are largely open debatable with Brahmanical intellectual blocks for emancipation of all: for, at the basis, Vedic education is not for All, but for 'few' dignified and meritorious. Rare is the possibility of Inclusive and emancipative education within Brahmanical set up of *gurukula* and *vedapāṭhaśāla.*

Our view as an 'outsider' of Brahmanical, 'Vedic' and 'Hindu' tradition could have some blind spots. However, as an insider of Indian Christian tradition, one holds the critique of brāhmaṇical hegemony with regard to education of both individual and society. Such analysis could even have liberating potential for the Vedic traditional system from its own clutches of power, entangled in its own powerful ideology of authority. India holds human and Christian values of equality and egalitarianism. As Indian Christians we recall the history of scholastic institutions of medieval Europe and setting up of educational institutions in mission lands as apostolic activities could be related. Unlike the Vedic one could argue for better egalitarianism and openness in Indian Christian educational mission. Yet facts of propagation of religious values have a pinch of salt. Monopolising a particular tradition as representative of all in diversified India, betrays a continued hegemony evident.

Much-needed 'educational revolution' does not contain in reinventing the ancient system and pursuing uncritically its ideals alone. Transformation, qualitative improvement and expansion of traditional basis of education of

indigenous values, need a bigger perspective than a narrow application of monopolising Brāhmaṇical tradition. New approach will elevate the elite by freeing them from the dehumanizing role of an oppressor in which they have trapped themselves. The critical efforts in counteracting would even hope to liberate the brāhmaṇical tradition.

10

Indigenous Knowledge and Emancipation

Raju Felix Crasta

Abstract: Education is not the monopoly of one set of people, rather it is a basic right of every individual. It emerges from one's interaction with other as a 'local' knowledge. This knowledge is transmitted by 'dis-locating' it from one individual to the other and from one place to the other to bring emancipation. The Indigenous knowledge can be known as an 'original wisdom' due to its primitiveness, may sound 'uncultured' to the 'cultured' ears. This paper tries to figure out the failure of modern education to sufficiently emancipate the indigenous people. The failure is from both the sides, within and without. Therefore, there is a need to understand the indigenous situation and make education a tool for emancipation.

Keywords: Education, wisdom, knowledge, emancipation, tribals, indigenous people, Chotanagpur.

Introduction

Knowledge is a dynamic process for development which starts with the birth of human being. By acquiring knowledge, one begins the process of emancipation of one's own self and that of the other. Though the Indian Constitution has vividly spelled the Fundamental Right to Education, it is far from the reality actualized among the indigenous people. While the elites can afford the best education possible, the people in the margin struggle for a morsel of bread, leave alone the dream of having basic literacy.

This paper is an attempt to show how the indigenous people begin to understand education and the knowledge production, thus carry forward their cultural legacy to the next generation. In the modern terminology it is the formal and informal education system. The knowledge thus acquired leads a person to live in par with the other in society which in other words termed development and emancipation.

The paper is divided into four parts. The first part deals with the knowledge production and education. The second part gives us the plight of formal education system among the indigenous people of the country, in particular, the Chotanagpur[1] people. While the third part enlists the causes of lack of emancipation, the final part gives a solution through education.

1. Knowledge Production and Education

There are two ways something can be understood: explicitly or by semantics, and implicitly or by symbolic. While explicit knowledge is a consciously available information by the use of language and its semantics, the implicit knowledge refers to a thing which is unconsciously available in terms of intuition, not expressed directly and lack verbal expression. To clarify, there is a routine life in each one of us, the way we live and interact with our neighbourhood. Several of our belief systems are never questioned and have become part of our life style. However, there is a wisdom behind the way one lives which is expressed implicitly and not narrated explicitly. Our procedures become automatic and in their operation one cannot find details as how something is done. Upon introspection one finds meaning in its performance.

How do we understand a fact then? Knowledge cannot be produced like any other object as in a machine. It happens in one's conscious or unconscious interactions with an environment. It needs a media. One cannot simply claim that knowledge is produced either through languages or by symbolics. It is by an integrated effort knowledge is produced. Integrated effort here refers to a collective effort of implicit and explicit memetics. Therefore, the knowledge production has its roots in the hermeneutics, the way one tries to understand and express by various means and forms.

As every culture has its own way of knowing, the indigenous people, otherwise known as the 'primitive people' have an integrated approach to knowledge production. Theirs is not the sophisticated or the 'cultured' way as in the scientific world the knowledge is produced. The advanced cultures use

1 The Chotanagpur plateau refers to Jharkhand, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Orissa, and the western part of West Bengal where tribals are inhabiting. Ecologically, it is rich in flora and fauna with several sanctuaries; uranium, coal, bauxite, copper, iron, and other valuable natural minerals. For this reason, the multinational companies see the plateau as the place of investment at the cost of the life of the majority indigenous people living here.

the scientific or rational way of understanding and reasoning and produce the finest way of knowledge and transmit it to the next generation and bring out advancement in society.

Conversely, the knowledge of indigenous people is 'local', comes from their struggle for existence. As a result, the knowledge is transmitted by 'dis-locating' it from one place to another, from one situation to the other. This knowledge is transmitted orally, through imitation and demonstration. However, by putting in writing it misses out its sensitivity. Further, the indigenous knowledge is the consequence of the practical engagement in everyday life, subjected to trial and error and finally conceptualized making it universal truth. Thus, it is empirical in nature. Repetition is an essential characteristic of this knowledge. It is repeated in various cultural elements, rituals and customs. Though the basics remain static, the peripherals will keep on changing.[2]

Though this knowledge can be considered 'original wisdom' due to its primitiveness, the advanced scientific temperament will brand it 'uncultured.' Thus, according to them, they need an emancipation to be in par with the advanced society. The advanced culture would call it education or the formal education system.

However, it is not that the indigenous people lacked this technology. They have their own way of educating or passing on the knowledge from one generation to another. The children are essentially educated by their parents, as the saying goes, "as the father, so the son." Alongside, the parents and children learn from their peers. Conversely, the parents can also learn from the children. Thus, there is no competition among the indigenous people for the supremacy of knowledge unlike that of advanced cultures.

Some of the ways of educating the future generation is by means of songs and dances, prayers and rituals, stories and myths. Feast days and gatherings are the occasions to educate the NextGen. Though in the eyes of advanced people, the indigenous people are 'illiterate,' in reality they are all "Learned without being literate"[3] in the sense that they knew their traditions, folklores and the collective wisdom. Another noteworthy aspect is'dormitory systems' known with different names among different groups of people. Though this system is getting extinct, is alive in some tribes of Chotanagpur and North East tribes. There used to be separate houses for young boys and girls for this purpose, guarded by an elder of the society. This person passed the knowledge

2 S. G. J. N. Senanayake, "Indigenous Knowledge as a Key to Sustainable Development" *The Journal of Agricultural Sciences* 2, no. 1 (2006): 87-93. Here, 87-88. DOI: 10.4038/jas.v2i1.8117.

3 Vijay Kamath, *Tribal Education in India: Empowering Perspectives, Shifting Paradigms* (Ranchi: Joshi Printers and Binders, 1998), 9.

of the elders to these people, taught dances and songs, cultivation and other wisdom facets. In the modern terminologies, these are the formal schools of these groups.[4] Sad to say, that these practices are losing its significance in these days.

2. Formal Education System Among the Indigenous People

The Education system, *per se*, goes back to its civilization. The oldest known education systems in India are Takshashila (600-500 BC), Nalanda (425 -1205 AD), Vikramashila (800-1203 AD), Vallabhi Vidyapeeth (600-1200 AD), Nagarjuna Vidyapeeth (600 AD), and Jagaddala Vihara (1084-1207 AD).[5] The formal or non-formal education taught by these universities was on Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, astronomy or Mathematics. And the beneficiary students were also from these sections of people. The aboriginals, tribals and socially backward people were kept away from education for reasons undefined, and were/are not part of this elite culture. The modern education system was introduced by British colonial rule under various presidencies. Bengal and Madras Presidency were known for their activities. Under these presidencies, Calcutta and Madras became the hub of modern education with several universities, colleges and schools. With this, English education took momentum in the country. However, the colonial mentality limited the literacy to elite people in the urban regions only.

Though Ranchi and Chaibasa areas, thickly populated by the tribals of Chotanagpur, were administratively well connected to Bengal already in 1765, Modern English Education arrived in these regions only in 1839 and 1841 respectively.[6] However, even after years of their existence, the tribals of this plateau remained illiterate and backward in education. While other districts of Bengal sent their best students for higher education to Bengal University, the district collector of Chotanagpur regretted to send the children, saying "the boys cannot be induced to present themselves as candidates at the Calcutta University Entrance Examination."[7] This summarizes the colonial mind that the tribals are not capable enough to cope with the modern education, leave alone the education proper that they can compete with others.

The constitution of India, especially, the Article 45 guarantees free and compulsory education to all the citizens till 14 years of age. It states,

4 Agapit Tirkey, "Cultural Identities and Education," *Sevartham* 26 (2001): 35.

5 SNS, "List of Ancient Indian Universities," *The Statesman*, Delhi, May 25, 2022. Accessed from https://www.thestatesman.com/education/list-ancient-indian-universities-1503075194.html, accessed 16 August 2022.

6 Joseph Bara, "Seeds of mistrust: tribal and colonial perspectives on education in Chhotanagpur, 1834–c.1850," *History of Education* 34, no. 6 (November, 2005): 617.

7 Joseph Bara, 618. Also see, General Report on Public Instruction in the Lower Provinces of the Bengal Presidency, 1862–63, page 77.

"The State shall endeavour to provide, within a period of ten years from the commencement of this Constitution, for free and compulsory education for all children until they complete the age of fourteen years." Further, it adds the "provision for early childhood, care and education to children below the age of six years." The 86th amendment of the constitution in 2002 further adds though it is yet to be brought into force, "The State shall endeavour to provide early childhood care and education for all children until they complete the age of six years."

It is true that in the post independent country there has been a rapid growth in educational institutions both in formal and non-formal way, from elementary up to higher learning. There has been several government policies in the past and still new ones are on the way like the National Educational Policy 2020 (NEP)[8] regarding this. But the reality is, the remote areas of the tribal belt are still in dark. The concept of 'free education' even after 75 years of independence has remained a utopia to most of the tribals, Dalits and backward people.

In the verge of bringing the peripheral people to the centre, the government opened several basic schools, *anganwadis*, upper and higher learning schools alongside giving 'free incentives' in the form of free education, mid-day meals, free books, free cycles, uniforms, scholarships, and more such things. While the policy benefited a big percentage of people, it remained a failure for a considerable per cent of people and that in particular the tribals and Dalits. In the attempt to overcome the failure, it opened residential schools, hostels, increased the number of teachers and other facilities and installed several scholarship programmes. Alongside the government's endeavor for education, there are equally and a greater number of efforts from non-governmental organizations, various religions, multinational companies, and even by individuals. Some of the top institutions are non-governmental with or without aids and at times without government recognition.

Having all these enabling things, the country's education structure has failed to emancipate sufficiently the last, the least and the lost people of society. The Parliamentary Committee in 2015 lamented in the statutory board that despite government effort to promote education among the STs, their literacy rates as compared to the national average has remained low. The literacy rate as per Census 2011 is 73 percent but for STs is 59 percent only. Ditto is the female literacy rate. The committee says that the overall literacy gap amongst the various groups and STs has come down from 19.77 percent in 1961 to

8 For more details on NEP see the Ministry of Human Resource Department of Government of India. The policy is available, https://www.education.gov.in/sites/upload_files/mhrd/files/NEP_Final_English_0.pdf, accessed 26 November 2022.

14.03 percent in 2011. A positive note here is that in most of the North Eastern states like Meghalaya, Mizoram and Nagaland, STs are at par with the general population. But in rest of the tribal dominated areas, the literacy gap is as high as 18 to 26 per cent.[9]

To give another data, the 1951 census records 5.6% of the total population of the country as tribal, while 2011 census it is 8.6% of the total population of India. When 11.3 % of STs live in rural areas, 2.8% live in urban areas. During 2001-2011, the decadal growth rate of the population of India was 17.64%. During this period the decadal growth rate of the scheduled tribes was 23.7%. The decadal growth rate of the scheduled tribes in rural areas was less (21.3%) whereas it was more (49.7%) in urban areas.[10]

These alarming facts raise some basic questions. What are the causes for miserable education among the indigenous people? To put it differently, why have the indigenous remained at the backyards while their co-citizens are already in the path of emancipation? What causes these people to migrate to the urban areas for education if the government has sufficient policies to address the issue?

3. Causes of Lack of Emancipation

3.1. Indigenous as Closed and Isolated Communities

Though there is a sizeable number amongst the indigenous people, the demographical distribution points out the fact of its restricted existence in special and temporal ranges in society. Among hundreds of tribes, there are sub-clans and groups distributed in different places with distinct social, political, moral, religious, linguistic, culture, philosophy and worldview. Characteristically, their language is unwritten and tradition is oral. This makes the formal education tougher and blocks to bring them to mainstream.

The indigenous communitarian bond is very strong. They live in isolated pockets in society, with compactness and self-sufficiency lacking the modern facilities. This is due to the close and at times unilateral, connections that exist between tribal institutions or principles of social organization. This goes along with seven criterion that can be enlisted about tribe: functional dependence with the community, economic backwardness, geographic isolation from others, speaking common dialect with or without variations, a political unit under a common tribal chieftain, averse to change and having

9 Hidden, "Literacy rates of Scheduled Tribes far below national average, says parliamentary panel," *Firstpost* March 15, 2015, available in https://www.firstpost.com/india/literacy-rates-scheduled-tribes-far-national-average-says-parliamentary-panel-2154745.html, accessed 17 August 2022.

10 For details, see https://www.jagranjosh.com/general-knowledge/schedule-tribes-in-india-1448689214-1, accessed 17 August 2022.

its own customary laws.[11] Correspondingly, they have unity and coherence in their value systems and their norms making them as supremely ethnocentric. These things make society a 'closed system' than an 'open system.' When a community looks at the other community with suspicion, not open to accept modern way of life, it remains stagnant. Psychologically it is true of any individual. This principle can very much be applied to the indigenous community. The community which are open to change are pacing with the rest of the mainstream communities as in the case of North-Eastern tribals.

The modern education and literacy is understood 'being able to read and write' (Art. 46) in the language that society recognizes. This is usually the official national languages the country recognizes. The Eighth Schedule of the Constitution of India, as of 1 December 2007, lists 22 languages as Scheduled Languages of the country in which only Santali language of the tribes of Chotanagpur gets a place (8th Schedule, Article 344 (1) and 351). The script (*Ol Chiki*) of Santali is created in 1925, first published in 1939[12] and introduced in universities by UGC in 2013.[13] If this is the status of the biggest languages and tribes of Chotanagpur, then one can imagine the plight of other lesser spoken tribes of the country. This gives us an additional insight that not much is sufficiently done for the indigenous people: their development, language, culture and other aspects of emancipation.

3.2. Demoralized Psyche due to Constant Struggle for Existence

The indigenous people, ideally to be called the *Adivasi* (the original settlers) have their historical roots in the Indian subcontinent way back during the Indus Valley Civilization (2500-2100 BC). S. C. Roy, the notable anthropologist opines that the original settlers, the Munda tribe had continuous bloody warfare waged in the land of five rivers (the Sindhu River bank) against the invading Aryan intruders.[14] Unable to withstand the supreme warfare techniques of Aryans, the adviasis moved toward eastern part of the country and settled in Chotanagpur.[15] The settlement, however, was not a smooth one. Kings and dynasties have made use of them to unsettle their enemies by forcing the inter-tribe war. The Kautilya's *Arthashastra* supports this view, that "the hill tribes may be recruited so that they may destroy other wild tribes engaged in the

11 Stephen Fuchs, The Aboriginal Tribes of India (New Delhi: Inter-India Publications, 1992), 11.

12 P. C. Hembram, *Santali, a Natural Language* (New Delhi: U. Hembram, 2002), 165.

13 "Syllabus for UGC NET Santali, Dec 2013." Accessed from https://www.ugcnetonline.in/Subject_ Code_95.pdf, accessed 17 August 2022.

14 S. C. Roy, "Mundas and Their Country (Calcutta: The City Book Soceity, 1912), 26-27.

15 For further details, see M. L. Tirkey, "Historical Roots of the Tribals and Their Struggle for Survival," in Vincent Aind, ed., *Enigma of Indian Tribal Life and Culture: Philosophical Investigation* ACPI Series-10 (Bangalore: ATC, 2009): 23-46.

enemies."[16] In the last two millenniums there has been several wars for the tribal survival. This means to say for the tribals transition from primitive way of life to advanced way of life is not easy.

Viktor Frankl in his book *Man's Search for Meaning*[17] speaks of mental state of a person who undergoes continuous suffering. When subjected to continuous suffering the person gets accustomed to apathy, moral deformity, bitterness, disillusionment, and at times their reaction to issues of life is *depersonalization*. In the past they struggled for survival, food, and accommodation. And now they are facing problems of economy, land, middle men and many other political gimmicks. The resulting self from such life is only a 'wounded psyche.' Therefore, one can find them low in self-esteem, self-dignity, fear and other psychologically related issues. This sums up a probable reason for the disinterestedness in the modern way of life.

3.3. Cultural Limitations and Taboo of Social Exclusion by Majority Culture

Post-independent India carried along with it the burden of the heritage of social inequality and variation in the economic distribution. This resulted society with the philosophy of separation even unto education. Education which was understood to be the right of elite group remained so even after establishing several schools. Thanks to several Christian education mission and minority institution that showed a ray of hope to the people in the margins. It is noted way back in 1970s in a survey that states where Christianity has made its impact as in the North Eastern and South Indian states, the indigenous education is relatively higher. It is true that these places have relatively lesser indigenous and non-indigenous disparity than in other states.[18] The survey also indicates that the states where the rate of non-indigenous education is higher, the indigenous education is also higher.

Education is a window to the modern world. It is the means of empowerment. Alongside, its acceptability is caused by the condition of society. Education among the indigenous is not the same as in the case of other people of society. There are several aspects involved in it: their acceptability, stage of social evolution, ecological settings, their economy, geographical setting, demography, exposure to external environment, languages and technology.

16 Vasudha Dhagamwar, "A Search for the Tribal Identity: An Odyssey," ed., B. K. Roy and V. G. Verghese, *Aspiring to Be* (Delhi: Konark Publishers, 1998): 223.

17 Viktor E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (London: Beacon Press, 1959).

18 Moonis Raza, Aijazuddin Ahijiad and Sheel Chand Nuna, *Tribal Literacy in India: The Regional Dimension* (New Delhi: National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration, no date), 14. See, http://www.niepa.ac.in/download/Publications/Occasional%20Paper%20No.%2009Tribal%20Literacy%20in%20India-The%20Regional%20Dimension_NIEPA.pdf/, accessed 17 August 2022.

Most of the indigenous people in the country are facing these troubles. If these external factors affect very much for the emancipation, equally are the internal culprits. The behavioural pattern, mental attitude and openness of certain tribes towards any new ways of learning stop their intellectual pursuit. Add to it, the constraints of the tribal elites within the group and largely that of the village head's attitude to newness closes the education altogether. This is the reason among leading tribes of Chotanagpur Hos and Munda have least percentage of education while Santhals have better and Oraons have greater percentage of learned people.

3.4. Low Assimilating Power

Comparing to other groups of people, the indigenous people have lower level of assimilating power. Intellectual pursuit is not the preference of these people by their very nature unlike that of other. Moreover, the formal education or the analytical culture entered their sphere is just a century and half years ago. Moreover, breaking the conventional method from the open and free movement to a strict scheduled academic life is an uphill task. These are the reasons, not able to cope with the demands of the academic life.

3.5. Poor Contact Points with Outsiders

Another noteworthy issue that affects one's intellectual acumen is the contact point with outsiders. The contact point here refers to the people who guide them, instruct them, use them or follow their movements. Chotanagpur indigenous people term these people as '*dikus*' (the outsiders). However, their indoctrination is such that one will feel that they are part of their cultural heritage.

Ever since independence indigenous people are used as a tool of political gain by several mainstream political parties. Due to this, Hindutva and safronization have become part of their culture. Ekalavya Residential Schools as against traditional Hindu *Gurukula* system of education are mushrooming in every village and urban areas. The implicit meaning running in this institutional system is to make the indigenous as part of Hindu fold which is nothing but destroying their heritage. The language and content of the education in these institutions are in line with the Hindutva ideology. These types of separate *Adivasi Avasiya Schools* (Tribal Residential Schools)[19] meant for indigenous people is demeaning the very concept of education as they create a sense of rift between indigenous and non-indigenous people. Often, the children belonging to non-indigenous or the elite group seldom feel confident to get admission

19 In recent years, the government has started several tribal residential schools meant for tribals only. Some of them are, Ekalavya schools, Ashram Schools, etc. As on 2020, there are 566 Ekalavya Schools in India and by the end of 2022 the aim is to have 750 such schools among the tribal dominated areas.

in these schools. Further, it adds up to the inferior complexity among them. Already they are vulnerable and have a low self-esteem.

The Christian missionary education had a very good purpose when it is introduced around 150 years ago in this area. As the days passed on, several indigenous people benefited from this and came out from their years of suffering. In 1950s the Church in Chotanagpur had only few schools and training institutes, but in 1998 the Church runs 23 Colleges, 209 High Schools, 719 middle and primary schools and 45 training institutes.[20] The number is increasing every year. This is to be lauded that what was run by missionaries in the initial years, presently several indigenous people are running several school, colleges and institutions to cater the education of their own people. On a sad note, on the contrary, it seems that several Church run institutions have lost their original goal in the recent years. In the name of education, several institutions are marketing knowledge which is not a good sign of growth. While such practices are to be discouraged, new ways of approaching the vulnerable need to be looked into.

3.6. Unsophisticated Skills that Stops One to Pace with the Modern Development

Primary means of survival of the indigenous people is agriculture, livestock and forest produce. Comparing to the advanced agricultural practices of people, these people follow a traditional means of production. Their tools used, mode of cultivation, seeds used, manure and labour are all primitive. It is true that this kind of agriculture has low productivity, but high in quality and nourishment. This keeps them strong physically and mentally. However, if modern means are used, with the same amount or even with less energy more can be produced.

Often the financial assistance stops them to use technology. When available, their lethargy in using advanced mode does not propel them to go ahead. Saving for the future is a distant dream and often their philosophy seems 'live today and tomorrow will take care by itself.' Alcohol is one of the common enemies of their development. What is earned is spent on it and when it is over completely, begin to earn afresh. Thus, the lack of futuristic goal and skills limits them to remain within their own cozy environment.

3.7. Loopholes in the Judiciary System of the Country

Does the constitution sufficiently define the meaning of 'literacy'? "Literacy is the ability to read and write with understanding in any language."[21] Such

20 *The Catholic Directory of India 1998* (New Delhi: CBCI Centre). Also see, Linus Kujur "Social Transformation of Chotanagpur Through Education," *Sevartham* 35 (2010): 60-61.

21 *Census of India*, 1971, Series 1, Part I I-A (i) General Population Tables (Delhi, 1975), 20.

a nebulous understanding leaves open much scope for inclusion of groups at disparate levels of knowledge of reading and writing within the category of 'literates.' This has some repercussions. If a person is able to recognize alphabet in one's language (surely, he/she will be able to understand what it means) will be considered literate and for the official record such person is considered educated. What about the competency of pacing with others or cultivation of skills required for higher goals?

Education should not be understood as merely making people literate, by passing through various classes of schools and colleges and eventually to earn a decent job. Such is the present education system and even the NEP is aiming at. For the indigenous people to be empowered, there is a need for a drastic change, they need an empowering education. The empowerment should be aimed at understanding their situation, energizing them to be constantly proactive, with a strong sense of personal identity. The methodology also should be designed accordingly.

3.8. Land and Economy as the Limits for Acquiring Knowledge

For the indigenous people, land is directly connected to their intellectual pursuit. One can observe four kinds of people among them, viz., i. people with surplus fertile land, ii. People with just sufficient land, iii. People with very little land, and iv. People with no land at all. The first group are well off and are able to expose their children to the modern education system. These are the people one can find in par with mainstream culture. The second group though have sufficient land and people to earn, need someone's guidance and external encouragement for intellectual pursuit. Third group who are totally dependent on the seasonal income from their agriculture and livestock need their children to take care of the other siblings and at times to help the adults for income generating activities for their survival. They cannot afford to send their children to formal schools. They need support both for the family and education. The last and final group simply unable to think of education due to their abject condition. Often, the government policies of education and help just reaches the first two groups only.

4. Education as a Tool for Emancipation

Often in our education system we find a patronizing attitude.[22] It is an attitude where the elders feel that the children are weak in studies and they need the protection and help. Here, the teachers decide how much to give, what to give and how to give. Implicitly, the system makes the students dependence and perform minimum. There is no further curiosity or independence generated here. Already at the back of the psyche of the system, there is a universal belief

22 Vijay Kamath, *Tribal Education in India*, 86.

that the indigenous people are weak in academics. This adds up the lethargy from both students and teachers, and hence, fresh knowledge is not produced. This attitude is fine in the beginning, but not throughout one's formation period. To bring them to the forefront there is a need to create a trust of their capacity to own and manage their learnings and accomplishment so that they develop a strong self-esteem and confidence.

Another attitude of people towards indigenous people is rescuing attitude.[23] Here the assumption is that the indigenous people are in trouble and therefore one needs to rescue them. Once an initial help is rendered, there is neither a follow-up nor a genuine interest in educating them. This weakness of the system fails to create a real vision and motivation in knowledge production. The defunct institutions, single teacher schools and haphazard facilities provided in the villages speak volumes about this condition. Alongside, the teachers also follow the same note, become lethargic and find no interest in guiding them. This leads to finding excuses initially with the understanding of the problems and conditions of the people and soon assume that 'they are not able to learn.' Thus, the teachers put their minimum efforts in teaching and the only interest seems job security and its income.

Third attitude which delimits the intellectual capacity is the attitude of abandoning the children. Teachers complain of being tired of explaining to dull students and find that it is waste of time in investing time and energy. They begin to blame children and brand them as lazy, not hardworking, unmotivated, etc. So, they divert their attention to other places and people where they find presumably non-indigenous people who are quick and smart. The education supposed to be the tool of emancipation is abandoned altogether to the personal satisfaction of the instructor.

Another attitude that stops the indigenous people from learning is the motivation teachers carry with them. On the one hand such instructors have low socialization and professional skills. Such are the schools where there is highest drop outs. It also happens at times that instructors or the people responsible for education, despise the children or develop a dislike towards indigenous people. Some even find them as tool for exploitation doing all sorts of menial work and unskilled jobs. The basic idea is, 'if they are educated and skilled will pose a threat for our future.'

Conclusion

When one moves from these above negative attitudes to more positive attitudes, education becomes a happy experience. It is only through education the indigenous emancipation is possible. The positive and healthy attitude is that of companionship and respect for welfare of the indigenous people.

23 Vijay Kamath, *Tribal Education in India,* 88.

What is needed therefore is the respect for their uniqueness, willingness and motivation to lift the people to bring to the mainstream, and appreciation and guidance to reach the destiny. If the teacher is visualized as equal to divine, then it has to be actualized in one's vision and mission.

Having these things in mind, there is a need for a proper infrastructure. And it is the duty of the people concerned to provide. And that is the constitutional right of the lesser privileged people as well. To enumerate a few,

- Addressing the basics: understanding the root cause of backwardness and addressing it with suitable measures.
- Strengthening the non-formal education system: dissemination of information through non-formal education system.
- Identifying and promoting right contact people and with people-oriented programmes.
- Active developmental process
- preparing policies according to the people and culture: treating policies of indigenous welfare not as synonymous with policies of other people. Often the government policies are shaped according to the whims and fancies of the bureaucracy.
- providing world class facilities and institutions, this itself is a motivating factor for many.
- Instilling faith in the emancipation and thus become part of the mainstream.

Let's be hopeful that in the coming years the doors of emancipation be open to the vulnerable and the beneficiaries march with dignity and right.

11

Education
Subaltern Perspectives

Sebastian Alackapally

Abstract: In India the precious gift of education that brings the actualization of the person was denied to millions of its Dalits for centuries through casteist prejudices and exclusiveness. The contemporary India witnesses the reclaiming of the Dalits for their rights in all spheres of life including the right to education. Education has the potential to change the face of India with its humanising dynamics – where equality and human dignity will thrive and freedom will blossom. An attempt is made to look into the efforts of prominent visionary social reformers and political leaders like Phule, Ambedkar, Periyar, St. Chavara, Narayana Guru, Kancha Ilaiah and others who championed the cause of educating, empowering and emancipating the Dalits for a life of dignity and freedom.

Mahatma Phule and his wife Savithribhai pioneered education of lower castes, especially the women in order to eradicate social inequalities and to affirm the right to dignity and freedom in the whole of Maharashtra. Ambedkar saw education as a human right, and as an instrument of empowerment and liberation for all Dalits. Ambedkar moved with the teaming millions of Dalits, stood by them, struggled for them and educated them to bring about freedom and dignified human life. Periyar advocated education to all, to the poor and deprived. He proposed education as the future way out from the dark tunnels of Brahmanism, casteism, poverty and all forms of oppressions. His unique way of the self-respect movement urged the Dalit classes to assert and affirm

their dignity and freedom through education which has brought a real shine to the face of Tamil Nadu. St. Kuriakose Elias Chavara initiated the daring steps to educate the people by laying the foundations of a Sanskrit school in 1846 two years before Mahatma Phule started the first school for the Dalits in 1848. Chavara was the first Indian to admit the untouchables to Sanskrit education which was forbidden for them. Chavara's vision of inclusive education has triggered rapid socio-cultural changes in Kerala making it number one in literacy in the whole of India. Narayana Guru initiated a social revolution in Kerala by providing an effective leadership to the lower strata of society, particularly the Ezhava community and enlightened them about the need to educate themselves in order to liberate them from the system that had marginalized them. Kancha Ilaiah, the Dalit rights activist advocates the Dalits to undo the moorings in spiritual fascism of the Brahmin orthodoxy which refuses equality and freedom to Dalit Bhaujans. According to Ilaiah, education especially English education is vital in the struggles of Dalits against inequality and oppression. In his opinion education should decasteise society as a whole and there is urgent need for desaffronisation of education.

Keywords: Education, Dalit, Phule, Ambedkar, Chavara, Kancha Ilaiah, caste, dignity, freedom, oppression, transformation, freedom, justice

Introduction

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) in its Article 26(2) upholds that "Education shall be directed to the full development of the human personality and to the strengthening of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. It shall promote understanding, tolerance and friendship among all nations, racial or religious groups..."[1]

In India the precious gift of education that brings the actualization of the person was denied to millions of its Dalits[2] formerly known as the 'untouchables.' The history of Dalits is a history of deprivation. They are deprived of their land, culture, language, dignity, freedom and the right to have education. Why Dalits are deprived and their thought did not occupy the main stream of education in India? A search towards the problem takes us to the great cultural debate- the class-caste struggle between Brahminic upper class minority and the exploited low-caste Dalit majority. The upper castes through casteist prejudices and exclusiveness tactfully manged to deny the socio-economic, religio-political rights, dignity and freedom of the Dalits for centuries.

1 Draft Committee, "Universal Declaration of Human Rights," https://www.un.org/en/universal-declaration-human-rights/, accessed 20 April 2022.

2 Dalit, meaning "broken/scattered" in Sanskrit and Hindi, is a term used for the members of the lowest social groups who have been subjected to untouchability in India.

The contemporary India witnesses the reclaiming of the Dalits for their rights in all spheres of life including the right to have education. Despite the continuing simmering of the Dalits and their anti-caste struggles and challenges, even today the face of India continues to be Brahmanic and Sanskiritized to a great extent. It is education which has the potential to change the face of India with its humanising dynamics – where equality and human dignity will thrive and freedom will blossom. An attempt is made to look into the efforts of Mahatma Phule, Ambedkar, Periyar, St. Chavara, Narayana Guru and contemporary Dalit thinker Kancha Ilaiah who championed the cause of educating, empowering and emancipating the Dalits. The discussions will focus the attention on how these revolutionary leaders could empower the Dalits to channelize education for a life of dignity and freedom. These discussions are set in the background of the Indian reality of the educational struggles of the Dalits and concluded with an analysis of educational challenges, change and progress of the Dalit life in India from a subaltern perspective.

Dalit Education: The Indian Realities

Education in India during the Vedic period was reserved to the Brahmin upper castes. The lower caste Dalits were prevented under severe penalties from accessing the Vedic knowledge. Hence the doors of empowerment through education were closed to the Dalits and they were not entitled to gain neither intellectual nor material resources due to their low caste status.

Macauley's 'Minute on Indian Education' (1835), the British Policy on education in India upheld the supremacy of English and concentrated on the education of the elite. This in effect resulted in the denial of education of the lower castes Dalits and the consequent increase in inequalities. The social backwardness of Dalits arising out of the practice of untouchability further accelerated their economic backwardness. The British had accepted the discriminative social hierarchy with all its status quo. "The British not only followed the policy of neutrality and non-interference as regards the disabilities of the untouchables but also, in some cases, violated the principle of equality and justice by giving undue weightage to the socio-religious customs of Hindus which enforced untouchability."[3]

Discrimination against Dalits in all spheres of life, especially in the field of education is a widespread problem in caste-ridden India. The forms of structural discrimination, alienation, and abuse that Dalit children face in schools are so stigmatising that they are often forced to drop out of school. One of the main issues is the discriminatory practices by the teachers. In 2006,

3 A. C. Pradhan, *The Emergence of Depressed Classes* (Bhubaneswar, Bookland International, 1988), 8.

the Special Rapporteur on the right to education noted that "teachers have been known to declare that Dalit pupils cannot learn unless they are beaten."[4]

Discriminatory practices against Dalit children exercised by teachers may include corporal punishment, denial of access to school water supplies, segregation in class rooms, and forcing Dalit children to perform manual scavenging on and around school premises.[5] According to Prof. Kancha Ilaiah even the class teacher's attitude depended on one's own caste background. 'The teacher often condemned the Dalit students as backward/incapable or reactionary. Such lop-sided/biased education is conditioning the minds and attitudes of Dalit students, and causing continued embarrassment, even humiliation as second-class citizens, leads them to drop-out at various levels of their studies.'[6] Dalit children also face discriminatory attitudes from fellow students and the community who perceive education for Dalits as a waste. There is a perception among some higher caste people that the Dalits are generally incapable of being educated. For them the uneducated would serve as better mute vote bank.

Intolerance, prejudice and harassment towards Dalits students continue even at higher levels of education including the IITs[7] where discrimination is practiced by upper-caste students, teachers, and administrations. In the opinion of Velaskar unequal schooling of Dalits have created and strengthened new inequalities.[8] The denial of basic minimum facilities to the Dalits while actively promoting the interest of the dominant sections prove the severity of this fact. The curriculum adopted by the upper-class projects knowledge, values, norms, linguistic styles, world views, as being intrinsically superior and valuable as compared to the culture of the Dalits. The fact that India still has 38 million plus illiterate Dalit children between 6-13 years of age, unable to attend schools as per the 2011 census presents the sad face of Dalit education in our country.

4 HRW, 2007. The Special Rapporteur on the right to education is one of the thematic special procedures overseen by the United Nations Human Rights Council. It promotes the right to education both as an independent human right and as an essential means of realizing other human rights.

5 IDSN and Navsarjan briefing note, 2010. http://idsn.org/wp- content/uploads/user_folder/pdf/New_files/Key_Issues/Education/DALIT_EDUCATION_IDSNbriefingpaper.pdf, accessed 20 March 2020.

6 Kancha Ilaiah, *Why I am not a Hindu* (Calcutta: Samya, 1996), 12.

7 Rukmini S., "India's Unequal University System," *Mint* 09 September 2019. https://www.livemint.com/news/india/still-too-few-dalits-in-indian-colleges-1568013598781.html, accessed 20 March 2020.

8 Velaskar Padma, "Unequal Schooling as a factor in the Reproduction of Social Inequality in India," *Sociological Bulletin* 39 (1990): 182.

We shall explore the efforts of Phule, Ambedkar, Periyar, St. Chavara, Narayana Guru and Kancha Ilaiah in educating the Dalits and in empowering them for a life of dignity and freedom.

Mahatma Phule and Dalit Education

It was during the turn of the nineteenth century that Jyotirao Phule (1827-1890) began to address the issue of social problems such as caste and gender discriminations. In fact, he tried to deconstruct the caste and gender discriminations as he dreamed of a free, egalitarian Indian society. Phule and his wife Savitri Phule (1840-1897) made every effort to transform the society starting with education of girl children concentrating on the betterment of the status of women in Maharashtra.

Mahatma Phule, a social reformer from Maharashtra and a victim of untouchability himself could properly realize the importance of education for a dignified and liberative life. He realized that lower castes and women were at a disadvantage in Indian society, and that education of these sections was vital to their emancipation. Throughout his famous book *Gulamgiri* (Zenith of Slavery), Phule asserted how lack of access to education was the reason for subjugation of Dalits. He stated categorically that, "For want of education intellect deteriorated. For want of intellect morality decayed. For want of progress wealth vanished. For want of wealth the Shudras perished. All these sorrows sprang from illiteracy."[9]

Mahatma Phule was a symbol of the revolution of social equality. He considered equality as a force that could make for social, economic and national change all over India. In his view social inequalities can only be eradicated through education of the lower castes especially the women. Pioneering women's education in India with the help of his wife Savithribhai, Phule established the first girl's school in August 1848. Due to religious orthodoxy and practice of caste system no teacher came forward to teach the girls of the lower castes. Savitribai herself took the challenge of teaching. The British government declared her to be the best teacher in 1852 and she received further praise from the government in 1853 for her work in the field of education.

In 1853, Savitribai and Jyotirao established an Education Society that opened more schools for girls and women from the lower castes, in surrounding villages. Sympathising with the plight of widows, Savitribai opened a shelter for them in 1854. After years of continuous reform, she paved the way to build a large shelter in 1864 for destitute women cast aside by their families. She educated them all and through Phule's pioneering institution, Satyashodhak

9 Cited in R. K. Kshirsagar, *Dalit Movement in India and its Leaders* (New Delhi: M.D. Publications, 1994), 44.

Samaj (1873), continued her fight for equality of all. In 1873, Savitribai started the practice of Satyashodhak Marriage, where couples took an oath of education and equality.[10]

Both Jyotirao and Savitribai carried out their struggle for gender equality and fight against caste system through education. Despite strong opposition and hurdles Phule couple were firm on educating the lower castes and women. Mahatma Phule knew that knowledge transforms the people and the spread of female education will help change the society. He believed that emancipation of the depressed and suppressed castes was possible only through education and social reforms. His schools for Dalit girls were the humble beginning of a bigger social movement and a symbol of social transformation. In his own life time, he became a legend and pioneer of Dalit liberation from dehumanization, tyranny and oppression.[11] Savitribai Phule was a trailblazer in providing education for girls and a beacon light of women's rights in India.

Ambedkar and Dalit Education

The Dalit movement under the leadership of Bhim Rao Ambedkar (1891-1956) began to consciously oppose the Hindu socio-religious values and hierarchies. He spent his whole life fighting against social discrimination against Dalits. Ambedkar was increasingly disturbed by the segregation and degradation of the Dalits which prompted him to advocate their social freedom and political rights through the publication of a weekly *Mooknayak* (Leader of the Silent) giving them a clarion call for emancipation from oppression in all forms. He criticized the perceived reluctance of the Indian political community to fight discrimination in the name of caste. Ambedkar also organized the *Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha* (Association of the Welfare of the Outcaste) to promote education and socio-economic uplifting of the Dalits along with launching active movements against all forms of caste discrimination.

It was perhaps in the field of education that the Dalits met with the stiffest resistance and opposition from the upper castes. Ambedkar saw education as a human right, and a fundamental civic right. He advocated the education of children and youth saying, "Education is something which ought to be brought within the reach of every one… higher education should be made as cheap to the lower classes as it can possibly be made."[12] Ambedkar knew well that the more the education, the more the chances for progress and the easier the opportunities for his people. In his view the primary education should cater

10 Google Arts & Culture, "Savitribai Phule," https://artsandculture.google.com/exhibit/savitribai-phule-zubaan/UwKCW6eHcTWSLg?hl=en, accessed 4 April 2020.

11 Vitthal Ramji Shinde (1873-1944) was yet another important social and religious reformer in Maharashtra who worked relentlessly for the upliftment of Dalits and to promote their education.

12 Cited in B. Das and J. Massey (Eds.), *Dalit Solidarity* (Delhi, ISPCK,1995), 99.

to the minimum essential need of educating the masses. He said that the Government should spend enough money so that 'every child who enters a primary school reaches the fourth standard.' In his debates on the Bombay University Act Amendment Bills as well as on the Bombay Primary Education Act Amendments Bills Ambedkar convincingly establishes how primary and higher education is important for the Dalits. He states further that the Dalits have realized that without education their existence is not safe.[13]

Ambedkar knew only primary education was not enough for the upliftment of the down trodden masses, so he encouraged them to take higher education. For Ambedkar, the surest way for salvation of the oppressed and 'untouchables' lies in higher education, higher employment and better ways of earning a living. Ambedkar held the view that education should be an instrument of social change. With this end in view, he founded the People's Education Society in 1945, which started high-schools, night high schools, hostels, colleges and other institutions with a view to promoting higher education among the Dalits. In his view education makes the Dalits aware of their humiliation and enslavement and ultimately it emerges as an instrument of empowerment and liberation. He also stressed the need of character formation of his people through education.

Ambedkar believed that establishing educational and economic benefits would not only raise the living standards of the Dalits but would also enhance the self-respect of the people. To promote the spread of an educative culture among the Dalits he opened libraries, social centers, classes and study circles. He criticized that Government was making a very slow progress in the matter of education. He appealed to the Government to make higher education cheap and thus to give favoured treatment to the Dalits. Ambedkar argued, "If all these communities are to be brought to the level of equality, then the only remedy is to adopt the principle of inequality and to give favoured treatment to those who are below the level."[14] As the chief architect of the Constitution of India he envisaged in it the policies and provisions for the educational and overall upliftment of the Dalits.

Ambedkar believed that education would enhance the self-respect of Dalit people. Ambedkar was also a believer in women empowerment. He fought for equal human rights for both men and women. He seemed to have believed that if women were educated the entire family will be educated. He was convinced that no real progress could be made in education, if education was entrusted to the teachers coming from the Brahmin community. Ambedkar observed: "Those who drummed into the ears of the backward class students

13 Ambedkar, *Writings and Speeches* Vol. 2 (Bombay: Education Department, Government of Maharashtra, 1982), 45-71.

14 Dhananjay Keer, *Dr. Ambedkar Life and Mission* (Bombay: Popular Prakashan, 1954), 80.

that they were born to do odd jobs like their forefathers, that they belonged to lower categories, and that education was a thing meant for a particular class, should not be entrusted with this noble, national, human, enlightening work."[15]

Ambedkar fought a battle for socio-economic and religio-political justice on behalf of the teaming millions of Dalits who found in him a liberator – their messiah. He moved with them, stood by them, struggled for them and educated them to bring about freedom and dignified human life. He initiated the Dalits to make every effort to transcend from all that was decaying and dead in tradition and march together towards new horizons of dignity and freedom. His final words of advice is a clarion call for all Dalits and the key to success for empowered life: "My final word for advice to you is "educate, agitate and organize, have faith in yourselves and never lose hope."[16]

Periyar and Dalit Education

Erode Venkatappa Ramasamy (1879-1973), commonly known as Periyar, also referred to as Thanthai Periyar, was an Indian social activist and politician who started the Self-Respect Movement (*suya mariyadi*) and Dravidar Kazhagam political party. He is known as the 'Father of the Dravidian Movement.' As a Congress member he realized that the Brahmins had many more government jobs than the non-Brahmins and that higher education was their prerogative. He wanted the Congress to pass a resolution demanding communal representation in education and in employment. Though he failed in his demand, finally he got the government of Madras to pass a law on communal representation in education and employment.[17]

Periyar advocated education to all, to the poor and deprived. He analyzed it to be the future way out from the dark tunnels of Brahmanism, casteism, poverty and all forms of oppressions. For him, 'education is the liberating force that qualifies a human being to live a good life in the world, …with self-respect and self-knowledge…'. Education is necessary to the people to develop themselves, to behave cultured, to acquire adequate knowledge in the fields of politics, economics, industrial education, etc. It is education that is responsible for one's development and status.

Periyar considers the present education system as a mere practice for food and survival. He regrets that the education does not produce any educated, rather it produces only labourers. In his view education is useful only for the literates to betray the illiterates. According to him the aim of

15 Dhananjay Keer, *Dr. Ambedkar Life and Mission*, 80-81.

16 Ambedkar, *Writings and Speeches,* Vol. 17, part-III (Bombay: Education Department, Government of Maharashtra, 2003), 276.

17 Gopalakrishnan M. D., *Periyar: Father of the Tamil Race* (Madras: Emerald Publications, 1991), 45-49.

education should be eradicating the caste system in its entirety. It should be to develop knowledge and to eradicate our degradedness, foolishness and superstitious beliefs, and it should not be for earning money. Education should keep a human being close to science, general knowledge, self-respect and discipline. Education is to maximize knowledge and minimize disgracefulness in order to make all equal.[18]

In 1952, Madras Presidency's Congress government led by Rajagopalachari introduced a new education policy in Tamil Nadu based on family vocation which was dubbed as *Kula Kalvi Thittam* (Hereditary Education Policy). As per this policy, schools will work in the morning and students can help their fathers in their work in the afternoon. Periyar felt that this scheme was a clever device against Dalits and Other Backward Classes. Periyar demanded its withdrawal and launched protests against the Hereditary Education Policy which he felt was caste-based and was aimed at maintaining caste hegemony. After becoming the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, Kumarasami Kamaraj scrapped Rajaji's caste-based education policy in 1954, initiating a lasting impact on the state's education policy.

The Successive governments in Tamil Nadu have since then followed the principle of 'universal education' or 'education for all.' Inspired by the ideal of Periyar that poor people should have free education, Kamaraj allowed all children to have free education up to standard ten. Through Periyar's spirit of social service, Kamaraj introduced the free mid-day meal scheme for school children and later granted free books and free clothes to school children. When Muthuvel Karunanidhi (Kalaignar) was the Chief Minister in 1969, he extended free education up to the pre-university class. As a result of Periyar's devoted service for the cause of the under privileged, scheduled caste men and women could achieve higher education and occupy high positions in government jobs in Tamil Nadu. Hence, the imprint of Periyar's struggles is to be found in the social, political, economic and cultural spheres of the Tamil Nadu even today. His challenge to Brahmanism paved the way for an alternative, democratic culture. It was the unique self-respect movement which was a great force for social reform, assertion and affirmation of human dignity and freedom through education.

ST. Chavara and Dalit Education

St. Kuriakose Elias Chavara (1805-1871) was an Indian Catholic priest, the founder of the first indigenous religious congregation for men in India named Carmelites of Mary Immaculate (CMI) and a revolutionary social

18 Arul Thirumurugan, "Periyar: A Pragmatic Educationist," available https://www.researchgate.net/publication/216529634_Periar_A_Pragmatic_Educationist, accessed 23 April 2022.

reformer in Kerala. He was an educationist par excellence. Until his time, the Church in Malabar had not achieved much in the field of education. He established a Seminary in 1833 hardly two years after the establishment of the first Monastery at Mannanam for the priestly education. Reading the signs of times St. Chavara initiated the daring steps to educate the people by laying the foundations of a Sanskrit school at Mannanam in 1846 two years before Mahatma Phule started the first school for the Dalits in 1848. The status that Sanskrit had among the upper castes of the then society as the language of the elite may have influenced Chavara in adopting Sanskrit as the medium for the first school. What makes this school unique is that Chavara opened its portals to all children irrespective of caste and creed in a caste ridden society.

Chavara was the first Indian who not only dared to admit the untouchables to schools but also provided them with Sanskrit education which was forbidden to the lower castes, thereby challenging social bans based on caste, as early as the former part of the 19th century.[19] His realization that social inclusion happens only if the education of the society is assured, was displayed in his subsequent actions. In 1864, he opened a Malayalam school at the neighbouring village, Arpookara, for converts from the Pulaya caste. Chavara introduced the midday meal system in his schools for poor students.[20] These creative initiatives taken by Chavara indicate his vision and action in education and empowerment of the lower castes against all odds. Chavara turned his attention also in enhancing the dignity of women in the society through education.[21]

Chavara knew by then that the protestant missionaries had already started and experimented with the running of English Schools and perhaps he also wanted to spread English education. But the Western Missionaries who ruled over the Syrian Christians then were skeptical about the English as it might be a channel for the spread of Protestant ideology. In addition to the fear of Protestant ideology, the missionaries were not keen on promoting education among the native Christians.[22] This, in fact, narrowed down the scope of educational opportunities for the native Christians.[23] However, under the inspiration from St. Chavara, members of the CMI Congregation

19 Kokkatt Wilson, *Vazhthappetta Chavarayachante Dalit Darsanam* (Kottayam: Centre for Dalit Spirituality, 1998), 8.

20 The Government of India has launched the Midday Meal Scheme in 1995 with a purpose to better the nutritional standing of school-age children nationwide.

21 Navya Maria, *Empowered Womanhood* (Bangalore: Dharmaram Publications, 2014).

22 Payngot Charles, *Kerala Sabha Pathonpatham Noottandil* (Kottayam: OIRSI, 1997), 14.

23 Gibi Jose, *Catholic Church and Higher Education in Kerala: A Socio-Historical Study* (Bangalore: ATC Publishers, 2022), 98.

started private English classes in 1874.[24] The first Catholic English School was started in 1885, at Mannanam. The English school at Mannanam and all the other schools along with the boarding houses following the legacy of St. Chavara admitted all, irrespective of caste, colour or religion.

Despite all hurdles the educational revolution initiated by Chavara in starting the first school at Mannanam and the consequent establishment of schools adjacent to parish churches and the English schools have caused rapid socio-cultural changes in the Kerala society. It is largely because of the prophetic and farsighted vision of Chavara's inclusive education which triggered such a great socio-cultural change in Kerala paving its path to the level of a high literacy State in India.

Chavara dedicated himself wholly to God and worked always for the socio-cultural and educational uplift of his people. History is witness that in and through his charismatic initiatives Chavara played a major role in educating and uplifting people especially of the lower ranks in Malabar. He is one of the first Indian Christian leaders who was bold enough to effectively use education as a tool of social inclusion—a legacy cherished, carried out and continued by the CMIs to this day in salutations to their founder St. Chavara. His life is an inspiring and edifying saga for all those involved in the pursuit of educational revolution and social uplifting mission.

Narayana Guru and Dalit Education

Narayana Guru (1856-1928) was a great socio-religious reformer and messiah of the Ezhava community in Kerala who championed the cause of the downtrodden against all forms of discrimination and injustices. A strong proponent of Advaita Philosophy, he stood for universal brotherhood and popularized the concept of *one caste, one religion and one God*. He preached social equality, equal opportunity for all, elimination of caste-ridden society, education for all, social and economic progress for all, as 'there is no difference between higher and lower castes and all are equal in the eyes of God.'[25]

Narayana Guru initiated a social revolution in Kerala by providing an effective leadership to the lower strata of society and enlightened them about the need to educate themselves in order to liberate them from the system that had marginalized them. During his lifetime, his activities made great impact

24 For further insights on Chavara's vision of education, see, Rosetta, "Chavara: A Champion of Education," *Herald of the East* 11, no. 2 (2015): 285-298; Kripa Maria and Kennedy Andrew Thomas, "An Integral Educational Vision: Chavara and the Present Educational Scenario," *Herald of the East* 11 no. 2 (2015): 273-284.

25 Mangalore University, "Brahmashri Narayana Guru," *Brhmashri Narayana Guru Adhyayana Peetha,* retrieved https://mangaloreuniversity.ac.in/brahmashri-narayana-guru, accessed 8 April 2022.

not only in Kerala but also outside the state including the coastal districts of Karnataka and other parts.

The *SNDP Yogam*[26] following the footsteps of the Guru has rendered dedicated service for the educational progress of the Ezhava community. The leaders of the *SNDP Yogam* were aware of the importance of education for the social progress of the community. They looked upon education as the best means to liberate the Ezhavas from their age-old inferior status. They realized education as the best tool to liberate them from superstitions and as a means for economic independence and a weapon to fight social injustice. Education enables the people to integrate the opposing values of spiritual and temporal, traditional and contemporary.

Narayana Guru and SNDP choose education as the instrument to embolden the community and to eradicate social evils. Guru wanted the upliftment of the Ezhava Dalits who were ignorant of their own potentialities due to lack of education. He believed that only through education the uneducated and unskilled people could get the correct perspective about good life and the resultant realization of the 'oneness of humanity.'[27]

Kancha Ilaiah and Dalit Education

Hyderabad-based Kancha Ilaiah is a Dalit rights activist, a prolific writer and a political scientist. In his famous work, *Why I am not a Hindu: A Sudra Critique of Hindutva Philosophy, Culture and Political Economy*, Ilaiah elaborates how the caste system was created by the Brahmins and used as a tool to oppress the Dalits. In his work, *Buffalo Nationalism: A Critique of Spiritual Fascism*, he strongly advocates the Dalits to undo the moorings in spiritual fascism of the Brahmin orthodoxy which refuses equality and freedom to Dalit majority. He commends the positive values of the buffalo as a productive beast that epitomizes the qualities of the Dalits whom he calls Dalit-Bhaujans.

As regards education Ilaiah observes that the old-time prejudices against Dalit education not only continue to exist today, but have also acquired new dimensions and aggressive proportions. In his view, "The post-colonial Brahminical India is more hypocritical than the medieval and ancient Sanskritic Brahminical India. At that time Brahminical forces were open and transparent about their superiority. They never accepted the notion of equality.

26 *The Sri Narayana Dharma Paripalana Yogam* (SNDP) was founded in 1903 with the guidance of Narayana Guru. It is a charitable society working for the spiritual and educational uplift of the backward Ezhava community.

27 Ayyankali (1863-1941), a contemporary of Narayana Guru was a great leader who challenged the casteist practices of the upper caste and elevating the social wellbeing of the Pulaya community and improving their access to education.

But the post-colonial Brahminism propagates that it stands for equality of opportunities and lives in its Brahminical English world."[28]

According to Ilaiah, education is vital in the Dalit's struggle against inequality and oppression. In his opinion education should decasteise society as a whole and there is urgent need for desaffronisation of education. The process of saffronisation was deep as Murli Manohar Joshi had pushed the Hindutva ideology to all levels of the education system. Ilaiah observes that the school textbooks brought out by the NCERT during the BJP regime make the Vedic Brahmanism central to future life ignoring any attempt to treat the caste as a negative system.[29]

What makes Ilaiah stand out from other Dalit leaders and politicians is that he emphasises the importance of English education for the Dalits. Ilaiah spoke on English education to *Gulf News* in an exclusive interview thus: "English education is a liberator because it does not carry caste and cultural baggage. It is also embedded with global knowledge and scientific spirit. Brahmins, who constitute the main historical ruling intellectual class of India, adopted double standards by using Sanskrit as their spiritual language and English as their power and market language. The Dalits, however, lost out in every sphere because of the forceful denial of education."[30] Ilaiah's role in the onward march of the Dalits is significant along with the youthful proponents of Dalit thinking like the educational activist – Anand Teltumbde, the Bhim Army founder – Chandrasekhar Azad, youthful Gujarati MLA – Jignesh Mevani, and others.

Dalit Education in India Today

In India, Dalits have suffered from all forms of discriminations, exploitations, caste-class prejudices and deprivations especially in the field of education. Their development and upliftment have been a serious concern of the Government of India since independence. To promote equal opportunities in education along with the provisions and safeguards made for Dalits and Tribals, various Committees and Commissions were constituted. Based on the recommendations of these committees and commissions, a National Policy of Education was formulated in 1986 and a Programme of Action was developed in 1992, both at the National and State levels.[31]

28 Kancha Ilaiah, "Bogus Merit Theory," *Decan Herald,* 1 May 2006, 10.

29 Kancha Ilaiah, "Desaffronising Education," in *Countercurrents.org* 23 July 2004, https://www.counter currents.org/dalit-ilaih230704.htm accessed 4 April 2022.

30 Nilima Pathak, "Kancha Ilaiah Bats for English Schools for Dalits," in *Gulf News* 31 March 2013, https://gulfnews.com/world/asia/india/kancha-ilaiah-bats-for-english-schools-for-dalits-1.1165058, accessed 4 April 2022.

31 NCERT, "Policies, Programmes and Schemes for Educational Development of Children from Scheduled Castes," http://www.ncert.nic.in/departments/nie/degsn/pdf_files/

The National Curriculum Framework (NCF, 2005) affirms the fact that "…we need to reaffirm our commitment to the concept of equality, within the landscape of cultural and socio-economic diversity from which children enter into the portals of the school."[32] According to the *National Education Commission* (*Kothari Commission* 1964-1966), "One of the important social objectives of education is to equalize opportunities enabling the backward or under-privileged classes and individuals to use education as a level for the improvement of their condition."[33] The five year plans developed by the country also has several provisions and schemes to facilitate and promote education of scheduled castes. Article 46 of the Constitution of India commits the State to promote educational and economic interests of Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Weaker Sections. The National Policy on Education (1986) was egalitarian and inclusionist in its approach. It laid special emphasis on the removal of disparities and to equalize educational opportunities by attending the specific needs of those who have been denied equality so far. The revised Policy Formulation and Program of Action (POA, 1992) recommended schemes and programs for educational development of Scheduled Castes including other disadvantaged sections of the country. Different schemes have been developed from time to time to endorse the Human Rights and constitutional provisions to resolve the educational problems of children from Scheduled Castes communities and their welfare.[34]

In spite of all these policies, programmes, schemes, recommendations of commissions and committees the educational progress of Dalits remain awfully inadequate even to this day. Millions of marginalized Dalits are not provided the basic equality of education. The specific efforts by central, state governments and voluntary organizations for improving conditions of education so far did not succeed to end the inequalities in educational opportunities. In fact, the numerous schemes for the educational development, seems to be lacking sufficient political and bureaucratic will to implement them.

degsnmodule6.pdf, accessed 5 April 2022.

32 NCERT, "National Curriculum Framework 2005," http://www.ncert.nic.in/rightside/links/pdf/framework/english/nf2005.pdf, accessed 5 April 2022.

33 *Kothari Commission*, https://byjus.com/free-ias-prep/kothari-commission/, accessed 5 April 2022.

34 NCERT, "Policies, Programmes and Schemes for Educational Development of Children from Scheduled Castes." http://www.ncert.nic.in/departments/nie/degsn/pdf_files/degsnmodule6.pdf, accessed 5 April 2022.

Conclusion

Mrs. Indira Gandhi once said, "Education is a liberating force, and in our age, it is also a democratizing force, cutting across the barriers of caste and class, smothering our inequalities imposed by birth and other circumstances."[35] In independent India the main objective of education is to assure the upliftment and liberation of Dalits who have remained isolated from the ambit of education for centuries. Education should empower the Dalits as a liberating force, as a democratizing force beyond the boundaries of caste-class discrimination. We have had great examples of men and women who have dedicated their lives to achieving this aim, especially in raising the educational standards of the Dalits. Phule, Ambedkar, Chavara, Narayana Guru and others have championed the cause of the Dalits, stood with them and raised their voices for the voiceless Dalits. These spiritual visionaries could motivate and empower the Dalits to channel education for a life of dignity and freedom. Their tireless efforts have brought tremendous changes in the quality of life for a large section of Dalits.

In addition to the visionary leaders who empowered the Dalits, the individual leaders like Vitthal Ramji Shinde in Maharashtra; Sasipada Bandopadhyaya, Harichand Thakur and Guruchand Thakur in Bengal; Ayothidasar, Rattaimalai Srinivasan, Appadurai, Ayyakkannu and Boosami in Tamil Nadu; Ayyankali, Chattambi Swamikal, Father Kunjachen Thevarparampil in Kerala, and others to mention a few, were charismatic leaders who contributed significantly for the all-round development and upliftment of the Dalit communities in their own regions. There are also several Dalit Liberation Movements[36] which continue to spread education in actualizing the dignity and freedom dreams of the Dalits.

Despite all claims of growth and achievements, the Dalits have a long way to travel to realize an egalitarian India for all. Even though Article 17 of the Indian Constitution forbids the practice of untouchability in any form, untouchability is still practised in subtle forms, especially in rural areas. The Dalit children are reported to be still feeling discriminated against by other children. The core principles of human rights, equality and non-discrimination, are being violated, and dignity and freedom are often denied. It is seen that children with poor socio-economic backgrounds from all communities, especially the Dalit community, are employed as working children. According to the 2011 National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPR), there are 82.2 lakh child labourers,

35 Indira Gandhi, "Quotes," https://www.goodreads.com/quotes/889467-education-is-a-liberating-force-and-in-our-age-it/, accessed 29 April 2022.

36 For more information on Dalit Movements and Dalit leaders, see: R. K. Kshirsagar, *Dalit Movement in India and Its Leaders* (New Delhi: M.D. Publications, 1994).

in India. As Nobel laureate Kailash Satyarthi (founder of the *Bachpan Bachao Andolan*) observes: "Education is the best empowering device but some 50 million children work even now as labourers according to Civil Society estimates."[37]

It is to be acknowledged that after independence, there was a considerable rise in the educational standard of the Dalits. Nevertheless, it has been found that the growth of the educational standard among Dalits is not uniform, and educational facilities among backward castes are being distributed unevenly. In almost all the states in India, certain prominent castes among the Dalits dominate the educational facilities meant for the whole Dalit community.

The correlation between quality education and emancipation is well established globally. Undoubtedly, education must be the priority earmarked for the development, dignity and freedom of Indian Dalits as well. The recommendations of the International Dalit Solidarity Network (IDSN) demand Governments adopt special measures to ensure the enjoyment of human rights, including education and fundamental freedom of the Dalits. IDSN points out the need to have effective measures on the part of the Governments to reduce drop-out rates and increase enrolment rates in schooling among Dalit children while taking concrete steps to eradicate caste-based discrimination at all levels. Further, all children should be trained to accept and respect the dignity and freedom of each other. [38] It is true that the Dalits' right to equal participation and non-discrimination in education and all spheres of life could be ensured if Governments implement such action-oriented recommendations, which is the need of the hour.

Education is the cornerstone of progress and upliftment of men and women. It lays the foundations of a dignified and emancipated life. It leads to increased awareness and social consciousness of the people and provides for more responsible leadership of the nation. Education is a precious privilege for enabling members of Dalit communities to benefit from the policy of positive discrimination. It can play a significant role in minimizing and eliminating all forms of class-caste barriers of discrimination. Equality of access to quality education and opportunity will lead to self-actualization of the person and the transformation of society. Despite individual and organizational efforts and the lofty ideals of the country's Constitution, the dominant forces in society and

37 Kailash Satyarthi, "Education is the best empowering device," *Mathrubhumi* 06 November 2015, https://englisharchives.mathrubhumi.com/education/news/news-updates/english-news-1.653098, accessed 12 October 2022.

38 The recommendations were formulated by IDSN in connection with the first session of the UN Forum on Minority Issues in 2009. See, http://idsn.org/news-resources/idsn-news/read/browse/2/article/dalits-access-to-education-debated-at-the-unforum-on-minorities/128/, accessed 20 April 2020.

the ruling powers of India seem to ensure that education may not spread easily. They fear and are sure education can make the subservient Dalits assertive and demand their rights. With the simmering of education and the resulting sense of dignity, the Dalits will no longer remain mere mute vote banks. Education in the name of Dalits but with an eye on making economic benefits by various untrustworthy agencies also can no longer serve the upliftment of the Dalits.

Today more than ever, we need genuine leaders who can enliven the process of empowering the emancipation of Dalit lives. We need more charismatic leaders for our times to unite all those left behind under a collective consciousness to strive together to achieve dignity and freedom, which results from genuine education. The Dalits must be empowered to assert their rights so that the dignity and freedom of the Dalits through education do not remain a mere pipe dream.

12

Education In Islam
A Critique

Jose Pennaparambil

Abstract: Islamic education is uniquely different from other types of educational theory and practice because of the all-encompassing influence of the Quran. Due to this, the children who undergo Islamic education are more religious than secular and the extremist Islamic leaders indoctrinate these children and use them for their vested interests. There are extremist Islamic *madrasas* in Indian sub-continent which are posing a perennial threat to peace and tranquility of the entire world. Hence, each government should make sure that the madrasas are primarily education centers and not the training centers terrorism. Children are to be taught religious and moral values of all religions and modern subjects, using modern e-literature and other modern techniques of education. It may help them to have a cosmopolitan outlook and they learn to respect other religions, cultures, nationalities and will be equipped to live like world citizens. Hence, reforms are to be made in the matter of madrasa curriculum, female education, together with the attitudinal change of the Islamic educators.

Keywords: *Ilm* - knowledge, *Kuttab* - serious Quranic study, *Madrasa* - Islamic school, *Tafsir* - Quranic interpretation, *Shariah* - Islamic law, *Hadith* - recorded sayings and deeds of Prophet Muhammad, *Mantiq* – logic, *ulema*-teacher, *shaykh* - teacher or leader, *Madhhab* - legal schools. *Ijthihad* – independent legal judgment. Islamic curriculum, female education, e-literature, cosmopolitan outlook, world citizen.

Introduction

Education is so fundamental for the development of any culture, religion or civilization. Each religion has contributed its share in imparting high level of education to its faithful in various realms for the development of the world. Islam has always placed a high premium on education. Knowledge (*'ilm*) occupies a significant position within Islam. Islamic education is uniquely different from other types of educational theory and practice largely because of the all-encompassing influence of the Quran. Subsequently, informal religious instruction took place in sites such as in mosques, palaces and homes of learned people, culminating in organized schools and universities. However, because of the overemphasis on Quran this education system adversely affected the overall personality development of the student as compared to the Western standard of education as well as the secularist mind of the modern world. Hence, in this study we are trying to critically evaluate the Islamic system of education and propose some solutions.

1. History of Islamic Education

Islamic education through the teaching and learning of the Quran can be traced back to Prophet Mohammad's time. The Quran serves as a comprehensive blueprint for both the individual and society and as the primary source of knowledge. Arab society of Mohammad's time had enjoyed a rich oral tradition, but the Quran was needed to be organically interacted by means of reading and reciting its words. Thus, education in Islam unequivocally derived its origins from a symbiotic relationship with religious instruction.

During the golden age of the Islamic empire (usually defined as a period between the tenth and thirteenth centuries), Islamic scholarship flourished with an impressive openness to the rational sciences, art, and even literature. It was during this period that the Islamic world made most of its contributions to the scientific and artistic world. Ironically, Islamic scholars preserved much of the knowledge of the Greeks that had been prohibited by the Christian world. Other outstanding contributions were made in areas of chemistry, botany, physics, mineralogy, mathematics, and astronomy as many Muslim thinkers regarded scientific truths as the tools for accessing religious truth. However, the statistics and data shows that, in this modern era, Islamic countries are lagging far behind in most of the fields of modern way education than the developed or developing countries because of the extremist and fundamental attitude that crept into the mindset of the Islamic teachers and scholars.

2. Levels of Islamic Education

Islamic education has to be divided into three levels: elementary, secondary, and higher education. Students have to spend four years in each level, assuming

they could end-of-year examination in compulsory subject areas like Arabic, mathematics and religious sciences. Electives would be offered in applied subjects, such as composition, preaching and court system. Instructors would be given bonuses if they could teach electives like geography and hygiene.[1]

There are two venues of primary education: the *kuttab* and the *madrasa.* The *kuttab* serves the functions of a primary school by providing instruction in the formal Arabic literacy, via memorization of the Quran, and mapping of the memorized verses to the printed page. Promising students then advance to the *madrasa* to study more complex subjects, like grammar, and subsequently progress to the study of theology, law or theoretical sciences. The primary school instructions are fairly widespread with small *kuttabs* in rural mosques and urban neighbourhoods.[2]

2.1. The *Kuttab*

The *kuttab* (serious teaching on the Quran by Islamic scholars) served a vital social function as the only vehicle for formal public instruction for primary-age children and continued so until Western models of education were introduced in the modern period. Even at present, it has exhibited remarkable durability and continues to be an important means of religious instruction in many Islamic countries. The curriculum of the *kuttab* was primarily directed to young male children, beginning as early as age four, and was centered on the Quranic studies and on the religious obligations such as ritual ablutions, fast, and prayer. The focus during the early history of Islam on the education of youth reflected the belief that raising children with correct principles was a holy obligation for parents and society.

2.2. The *Madrasa*

In the Arabic language, the word '*madrasa*' simply means the *school* as in the English language whether that is private, public or parochial school, as well as for any primary or secondary school whether Muslim, non-Muslim, or secular. *Madrasa* literally means "a place where learning/studying is done." Unlike the understanding of the word *school* in British English, the word *madrasa* is like the term *school* in American English, in that it can refer to a university-level or a post-graduate school as well.

Madrasas did not exist in the early beginnings of Islam. Their formation can probably be traced to the early Islamic custom of meeting in mosques to discuss religious issues. At this early stage, people seeking religious knowledge tended to gather around certain more knowledgeable Muslims.

1 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education* (London: Bloomsbury, 2015), 25.

2 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education*, 17.

These informal teachers later became known as *shaykhs*; and these *shaykhs* began to hold regular religious education sessions called *majalis* (sessions).

Unlike the *kuttabs,* the *madrasas* admit both boys and girls. A typical Islamic school usually offers two courses of study: a *hifz* course – memorisation of the Quran (the person who commits the entire Quran to memory is called a *hafiz*), and an *'alim* course – leading the candidate to become an accepted scholar in the community. A regular curriculum includes courses in Arabic, *Tafsir* (Quranic interpretation), *Shariah* (Islamic law), *Hadith* (recorded sayings and deeds of Prophet Muhammad), *Mantiq* (logic), and the Muslim history. The certificate of an *'alim* for example, requires approximately twelve years of study. A good number of the *huffaz* (plural of hafiz) are the product of the *madrasas*.

Depending on the educational demands, some *madrasas* also offer additional advanced courses in Arabic literature, English, other foreign languages, science and world history. Ottoman madrasas along with religious teachings also taught styles of writing, grammar, syntax, poetry, composition, natural sciences, political sciences, and etiquette.

Established in 859, Jami'at al-Qarawiyyin (located in Al-Qarawiyyin Mosque) in the city of Fas, Morocco, is considered the oldest *madrasas* in the Muslim world.

The *madrasa* education comprises the primary education, the secondary education and the higher education. The higher education implies college education in which students study law, medicine and the higher education like doctoral studies.

2.2.1. The Primary Education

In the medieval Islamic world, an elementary school was known as a *maktab* which dates back to the 10th century CE. Like the *madrasas* (which referred to the higher education), a *maktab* was often attached to a mosque. Children are to be sent to a *maktab* school from the age of 6 and taught primary education until they reach the age of 14. During this time, they should be taught the Quran, Islamic metaphysics, language, literature, Islamic ethics, and manual skills.

2.2.2. The Secondary Education

The secondary education stage of *maktab* schooling is a period of specialization when pupils begin to acquire manual skills, regardless of their social status. Children after the age of 14 should be allowed to choose and specialize in subjects they have an interest in, whether it was reading, manual skills, literature, preaching, medicine, geometry, trade and commerce, craftsmanship, or any other subject or profession they would be interested in pursuing for a future career.

2.2.3. The Higher Education

The formative period of the *madrasa* used to refer to a higher education institution. Philosophy and the secular sciences were often excluded from its curriculum, which initially only included the 'religious sciences.' The curriculum slowly began to diversify, with many later *madrasas* teaching both the religious and the 'secular sciences,' like logic, mathematics and philosophy. Some *madrasas* further extended their curriculum to history, politics, ethics, music, metaphysics, medicine, astronomy and chemistry. The curriculum of a *madrasa* was usually set by its founder, but generally taught both the religious sciences and the physical sciences. *Madrasas* were established throughout the Islamic world, the most famous being the 10th century Al-Azhar University and the 11th century Nizamiyya, as well as 75 *madrasas* in Cairo, 51 in Damascus and up to 44 in Aleppo between 1155 and 1260 CE.

2.2.3.1. College: The origins of the college lie in the medieval Islamic world. While "*madrasa*" can now refer to any type of school, the term "*madrasa*" was originally used to refer more specifically to a medieval Islamic college, mainly teaching Islamic law and theology, usually affiliated with a mosque, and funded by an early charitable trust known as *Waqaf*.

2.2.3.2. Law School: Madrasas were largely centred on the study of *fiqh* (Islamic jurisprudence). In the medieval Islamic legal education system had its origins in the 9th century after the formation of the *Madhhabs,* the legal schools.

2.2.3.3. Medical School: Though Islamic medicine was most often taught at the *Bimaristan* - teaching hospitals, there were also several *madrasa* medical schools dedicated to the teaching of medicine. For example, of the 155 *madrasa* colleges in Damascus in the 15th century, three were medical schools.

2.2.3.4. Universities: The commonly accepted view is that the Islamic Mosque school was an institution distinct from the medieval university and that the university with all its facets, including granting of the academic degrees such as bachelor, master and doctorate, was a proper medieval European development unrelated to contemporaneous Islamic learning.

3. Female Education

Women were known to be actively involved in the transmission of Islamic Knowledge in Damascus in the early periods of Islam, but the trend gradually declined from the ninth to eleventh centuries, and subsequently revived between the twelfth and fifteenth centuries, after which it largely disappeared.[3]

3 Mohamamd Akram, Nadwi, *Al–Muhaddithat: The Western Scholars in Islam* (Oxford, Interfaith Publications, 2007), 2.

Since the 1970s, this tradition has seen a revival and growing number of girls and women of all ages are joining the mosque-based or home-based study circles to gain knowledge of Islamic texts. In the Indian subcontinent there is no recorded evidence of women ever being actively engaged in studying Islamic texts in the earlier period of Islam.

The ancient Arab women were having no right to inheritance, considered them as property, and men could inherit women and all that they owned. The Quran says that, they are not equal to men. Allah made men superior to women (Sura 4:34) and in the court, the evidence of two women were considered equal to the witness of one man (Sura 2:282). In the case of inheritance too, women are not considered equal to men (Sura 4:176). However, women played an important role in the foundations of many Islamic educational institutions, such as Fatima al-Fihri's founding of the University of Al Karaouine in 859. This continued through to the Ayyubid dynasty in the 12th and 13th centuries, when 160 Mosques and *madrasas* were established in Damascus, 26 of which were funded by women through the Waqf (charitable trust) system. Half of all the royal patrons for these institutions were also women.

But, when both men and women of other religious communities reached in all heights of achievements in the modern world, women in the most of the Islamic countries are lagging behind in all respects, especially in the field of education. This is clear from the words of the famous feminist Islamic writer, Amina Wadud: "Women are not deemed as important as men in most Muslim majority countries; Muslim women do not enjoy equal status to men."[4] This is because, the male dominated Muslim community kept the women folk in the cage of gender discrimination on the basis of the Quran and Hadiths (Sura 4:34, 2:282, 4:176)). They don't have the freedom to study as they wish or to dress as they like or to move around as they please. They all are restricted one way or the other.

The treatment of women in Islamic countries is consistently shocking to the modern world. Women were completely excluded from the foundational discourse that established in the paradigmatic basis for what is meant to be a Muslim, and they are often regulated to the role of subject without agency.[5] In the extremist Islamic countries like Afghanistan under Taliban, women have no right to be educated. Only recently women got the right to vote in Iran and right to have driving licence in Saudi Arabia. Only after 1970s the movements aimed at giving Muslim women access to the serious study of Islamic texts, have emerged across the world.

4 Amina Wadud, *Quran and Women* (New York, Oxford University Press, 1999), ix.

5 Amina Wadud, *Quran and Women*, xi.

4. Critique on Islamic Education

4.1. Critique on the *Kuttab*

In the *kuttab*, the girls are not admitted and the conditions in which young students learned could be quite harsh. Corporal punishment was often used to correct laziness or imprecision. Memorization of the Quran was central to the curriculum of the *kuttab,* but little or no attempt was made to analyze and discuss the meaning of the text. Once the students had memorized the greater part of the Quran, they could advance to the higher stages of education, with increased complexity of instruction. The Western analysts of the *kuttab* system usually criticize two areas of its pedagogy: the limited range of subjects taught and the exclusive reliance on memorization. A common frustration of modern educators in the Islamic world is that while their students can memorize copious volumes of notes and textbook pages, they often lack competence in critical analysis and independent thinking.

4.2. Critique on the *Madrasa*

From rather elite beginning in the medieval period, the *madrasa* system in colonial India became institutionalized as a system of education for the poor Muslims. But the *madrasas* have become the greatest obstruction in the path of the progress of the Muslim community. While the community provides all the resources, the grip of the self-serving *maulavis* and *ulemas* over the system, serves only their own interests. The *madrasas* or the religious schools have begun to flourish in the post-independence period, say 1960s, when the Western education was emphasised. The present-day *madrasas* have changed a lot in their aim of education as well with regard to their function. They have lost their pristine purity in all realms. It seems to have changed the purpose from the centres of education to the centres of terrorist training camps. For example, according to the sources, the police had received a tip-off after which the raid was carried out at the Darul Quran Hamidia Madrasa on Kandhla road in Sherkot area in Utter Pradesh on 11 July 2019. Circle Officer (CO) Kripa Shankar Kannaujia said that three country-made pistols, a 32-bore pistol and bullets in large numbers were recovered from the *madrasa*. The weapons and the ammunition had been stored in medicine boxes.[6] After the revocation of the Article 370 from Jammu and Kashmir State of India, several *madrasas* were been raided by the intelligence agencies.

The typical *madrasas* reflect the political agenda of Hamas in Palestine and the Taliban in Afghanistan: Islam as a vehicle for all-encompassing change, Islam as a challenge not only to corrupt local elite but to the whole world order. These *madrasas* laid foundations for the populist and militant

6 https://www.indiatoday.in/india/story/uttar-pradesh-arms-found-in-madrassa-during-raid-6-arrested-1566498-2019-07-11, accessed 25 September 2022.

Islamic leadership that emerged in the 1990s. Mostly from lower middle-class backgrounds, speaking the local language, traditionally dressed, and significantly growing beards, the students of religious schools were the Taliban warriors who went on to conquer Afghanistan.[7]

The *madrasas* remained peaceful for more than hundred years. It is only in the 1980s that several intelligence agencies started using them as a brooding ground for producing militants to combat soviet armies in Afghanistan.[8] All most all the major extremist organizations such as Taliban movement in Pakistan and Afghanistan, Lashkar e jhangvi and Jaish e Mohamamd also affiliate themselves with Deobandi school of thought.[9]

As a generally isolated institution, *madrasa* drew very little research attention before 9/11. The first serious works on these institutions emerged around the 1990s.[10] The situation changed drastically after 9/11 terrorist attacks. The *madrasas* were directly targeted for inculcating an extremist mindset among Muslims. Their connection with the global war on terror sparked an increase in *madrasas*. However, even after more than a decade, very little is known about these institutions. *Madrasas* try to avoid any interaction with the state, and thus avoid registration.[11] Hence, the exact numbers of the registered *madrasas* are unknown. The *madrasas* in India and Pakistan, at present, pose a perennial threat to peace and tranquility of the world. Hence, they are to be studied.

4.2.1. *Madrasas* in India

In India, there are around 30,000 operating *madrasas*. The majority of these schools follow the *Hanafi* School (one among the four Sunni sects of legal schools in Islam) of thought. The religious establishment forms part of the mainly two large divisions within the country, namely the Deobandis, who dominate in numbers (of whom the Darul Uloom Deoband constitutes one of the biggest *madrasas* in the world) and the Barelvis, who also make up a sizeable portion (Sufi orientated). Some notable establishments include: Jamia Ashrafia, Mubarakpur which is one the largest learning centres for the Barelvis. Darul Uloom Deoband which is the largest, and is considered by many to be the most renowned *madrasas* in Asia, is located at Saharanpur district of Uttar Pradesh.

7 Umesh Bhatt, *Religious Fundamentalism and Human Rights* (Delhi, Vista International Publishing House, 2005), 86.

8 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education*, 105.

9 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education*, 106.

10 Malik J. *Colonization of Islam: Dissolution of Traditional Institutions in Pakistan* (Lahore: Vanguard Books, 1996), 78.

11 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education,* 99.

4.2.2. *Madrasas* in Pakistan

It has been proved that the *madrasas* in Pakistan have not only been busy with indoctrinating the young and credulous in Asia but also elsewhere in taking up jihad against the West. In 1997, it is estimated that there are 6,357 *madrasas* are in Pakistan and there were at least 165 registered madrasas with 2,000 students each in Karachi alone. Of these at least 30 fall radical category. The number of unregistered *madrasas* is almost double the official figures. More or less, the similar situation is in Lahore, Baluchistan, North West Frontier Province and other parts of Pakistan. In 2002, the then Minister of Religious Affairs, Mohammad Ahmed Ghazi estimated that there were about 10,000 *madrasas*. Press estimates on the number of *madrasas* range from 5,000 to 50,000. Despite the difficulty in obtaining accurate information on the *madrasas*, many scholars labored tirelessly to advance our understanding of these institutions. Today, the *madrasas* are not as mysterious as they were few decades ago. One of the more well-researched aspects is the political economy of the *madrasas*.[12]

According to Tariq Rahman, parents enroll their children in the *madrasas* because they cannot afford to finance their education in government schools.[13] Most of the literature on *madrasas* concur that its students tend towards terrorism, when they cannot find jobs after graduation. According to Malik, "The fact is, that limited market and job opportunities for the *ulema* (teacher) have led to a growing radicalization, as the increasing number of sectarians or communal outbreaks exemplify.[14]

According to statistics collected by Tariq Rahman, 40 percent of the Urdu medium schools and 26 percent of English medium school students support open war to reclaim Kashmir, as compared with 60 percent of *madrasa* students. Similarly, 33 per cent of Urdu medium schools and 22 per cent English medium school students support jihadi groups to reclaim Kashmir, as compared with 53 per cent of the *madrasa* students.[15] Another study by the US Commission on International Religious Freedom found that only about 60 cent of the teachers and a similar percentage of the students in public schools consider non-Muslims to be Pakistani citizens. Nearly all the teachers and most of the students also believe jihad to be obligatory and necessarily violent.[16] These statistics show that extremist mindset cannot be eradicated

12 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education,* 100.

13 Tariq Rahman, *Denizens of Alien Worlds: A Study of Education, Inequality and Polarization in Pakistan* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004), 91.

14 Malik, *Madrasas in South Asia, Teaching Terror?* (London: Routledge, 2008), 8.

15 Tariq Rahman, *Denizens of Alien Worlds*, 82.

16 Hussain Salim & Naveed, *Collecting the Dots: Education and Discrimination in Pakistan*, (Washington DC: US Commission on International Religious Freedom, 2011), 106.

merely by adding secular subjects to the curriculum. Furthermore, some of the studies have shown that extremism with modern education have proven more dangerous than the traditionally educated ones.[17]

These *madrasas* have attracted a large number of students from all over the world, because of the fabulous offer put forward by the terrorist leaders, especially countries like Britain, Malaysia, Indonesia and Bangladesh. Apart from teaching Islamic tenets, these schools tutored the young and the impressionable students a sectarian jihadi outlook, besides giving them military training. Today, Pakistan's huge network of Islamic seminaries (*Madrasas*), in every region of the country, churns out hundreds of thousands of fanatics year after year which is a perennial threat to peace and stability of the whole world. These *madrasas* publish jihadi literature, advocating sectarian hatred and violence in the name of the religion and spawn the future army of extremists.[18]

4.2.3. Critique on Female Education

A comprehensive just social order not only emphasises fair treatment of women, but also includes women as agents, responsible for contributing to all matters of relevance to human society. Amina Wadud proposes a female centered or female-inclusive reading of the Quran might finally lend itself to more than just syntactical, legal articulations, and historical renditions and help to wave a symbiotic relationship between the Quran and the reader.[19] She proposes that on the Quran, every usage of the masculine plural form is intended to include males and females, equally, unless it includes specific indications for its exclusive application to males.[20]

On the basis of the Quran women are inferior and unequal to men. But according to Amina, this superiority is for the men to be more human and to consider the women as equal partner in all aspects of life as an equal individual and co-creature as envisaged by Allah. It is a call to be more responsible since women are the mothers and caretakers of the children who mainly form the character of the children. She says, "Whatever differences existing between males and females could not indicate an inherent value, or else free will would be meaningless." Because, "There is no distinction between the male

17 Bergen and Pandey, "The Madrasa Myth," *The New York Times* 14 June 2005, retrieved from http://www.nytimes.com/2005/06/14/opinion/14bergen.html, accessed 29 September 2022.

18 Sharma, *The Global Jihad Current Patterns and Future Trends*, 91.

19 Sharma, *The Global Jihad Current Patterns and Future Trends*, xiv.

20 Sharma, *The Global Jihad Current Patterns and Future Trends*, 4.

and female with regard to individual capacity. With regard to their potential relationship with Allah, they are the same."[21]

In this context what is needed is, in the social, political and moral arena, a reciprocal relationship must be made between particular historical or cultural practices during the time of the Quranic revelation as reflections of the underlying principles and the diverse reflections of those principles in other historical and cultural contexts.[22]

5. Solutions

Islamic education system has changed and diverted a lot in its objectives and purposes from the earlier periods of Islam. There are very many factors behind it. However, the main problem is the literal interpretation of the Islam's holy book, the Quran. Hence, a solution for the rereading of the Islamic system of education is inevitable.

1. One of the solutions for Muslim educators is to teach contextual interpretation of the Quran: how to read an individual verse within the context of surrounding verse, how to use biographies such as that of Ibn Ishaq (The biographer of Prophet Mohammad) to provide historical context, how to critically evaluate hadith and their soundness, and how to judge the dicta of historical jurists within their particular culture and political markets. Essential to this teaching is how the interpretations of scripture change overtime in different contexts. The quest for truth and the scholarly struggle for discernment are essential to the spirit of Islamic education.[23]
2. Reformers suggested three areas of change. 1) Adding science, mathematics and hygiene to the curriculum of Arabic language and *fiqh* (Islamic jurisprudence), 2) Replacing *taqlid* (following precedent) with a curriculum based on *ijthihad*[24] (independent legal judgment), and 3) Replacing the *halqa* system in which the student sat with the *shaykh* and discussed his interpretations of the text until the *shaykh* was satisfied, the students was competent the text for others, with European style text books and examination.[25] In the same manner Abduh proposes that, religious education had to teach *ijthihad* through critical examination of primary sources of the religion, and it had to include mathematics, the sciences and

21 Sharma, *The Global Jihad Current Patterns and Future Trends*, 34.

22 Amina Wadud, *Quran and Women*, xiii.

23 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education,* 31.

24 *Ijthihad* had arisen in early Islamic history as a means to deal with the novel legal questions, the answers to which could not be found in the Quran or hadith.

25 Charlene Tan, *Reforms in Islamic Education*. p. 18.

comparative history as a vehicle for a well-rounded understanding of the implications of juristic judgments.[26]

3. Further, reforms should never be geared towards the purpose of securing a job or earning wealth, but rather towards the purpose of understanding religion better, and for the benefit of society.
4. The will to reform is essential. The international community perceives an urgent need for reform of *madrasas* all over the world.
5. Equal emphasis has to be given for the betterment of female education and women should get equal right as that of men to interpret and preach the Quran. The *madrasa* education should be reformed and male domination in religious and social realms are to be avoided.
6. Understanding *madrasas* is the prerequisites for reforms. Before undertaking any reform project, an extensive study about the history of *madrasas*, their background purpose and more importantly their social role and sources of support in community, is necessary. Reformers must be aware of the diversity of *madrasas*, because they are autonomous and are different from each other (*Madhabs* or legal schools). Besides, their ideologies and preferences also vary widely.
7. Reforms should concentrate more on the inclusion of social sciences rather than the natural sciences.
8. Reforms should not be forced. Attempts to forcibly impose change would, and did, produce backlash from the community. In countries which already struggling to stem the tide of the ever-growing threat of terrorism, it would unwise to further alienate hundreds of thousands of *madrasa* students.
9. Financial incentives should not be considered as primary tool for reforms.
10. Collective events (seminars, workshops, study tours, etc.) between students of schools and *madrasas* should be organized to promote better understanding between youth studying in traditional and modern schools.
11. The reformers created a binary opposition between scientific subjects and religious subjects, arguing that the former had been neglected and this has led to the decline of Islamic societies relative to the West. The conservatives clarified that theoretical sciences had always been taught at madrasas, which had been universities in true sense – the locus of higher education in all subjects. Therefore, there was a historical precedent for a religious education conducted with awareness of contemporary science and mathematics.
12. One of the critical elements of Islamic education in premodern period was the person-to-person transmission of knowledge within *halqa.* It involved the student in the chain of transmission, acknowledging the human role in preservation of knowledge and conventional interpretation. It does

26 Abduh M. *al-Amal al-Kamilia lil-Imam Abduh* Vol. 3, 2nd edition, (Beirut 1980), 127-79.

not coerce students to learn, as does the threat of examination, but rather enticed them through dialogue.[27]

13. There must be a sense of ownership and empowerment by the Muslim educators as change agents. At the same time there is a need for the *madrasas* to obtain strong and ongoing support from their stakeholders, including the state, parents, teachers, students and the general Muslim community for reforms to be effective and sustainable. Such an outcome is of course not easily attained, and requires a long process of communication, negotiation, contestation and compromise.[28]
14. Cosmopolitan outlook: Now-a-days, Muslims become a migrant community and living in a multicultural and multi-religious context. In other words, they are in a world where citizens enjoy multiple identities, and communities accept some of the general values of the state while preserving their own identity. Each person in any country may have to learn to become a cosmopolitan citizen who is capable of mediating between rootedness, national traditions and alternative forms of identity. According to *Qualification and Curriculum Authority* in Britain there are three strands. They are, i) social and moral responsibility whereby children learn from the very beginning self-confidence, and socially and morally responsible behavior inside and outside the school, both towards those in authority and towards each other. ii) Community involvement through which pupils learn about and become helpfully involved in the life and concerns of their communities, including learning through community involvement and service to the community. iii) Political literacy through which pupils learn how to make themselves effective in public life through knowledge, skills and values.[29]
15. According to Maryam Serajiantehrani an Islamic writer in Iran, the Islamic education should be modified with the taste of the modern children, i.e., the electronic literature or *e-literature,* books and magazine to attract children aged between 7-11.[30] The digital multimedia world of the World Wide Web (www) and CD–ROM technology is enhancing and expanding the story of the worlds of literary narratives accessed primarily through the reading of books, as well as generating exiting new

27 Charlene Tan. *Reforms in Islamic Education,* 29.

28 Charlene Tan. *Reforms in Islamic Education,* 178.

29 Qualification and Curriculum Authority, *Education for Citizenship and Teaching Democracy in Schools*. Final report of the Advisory Group on Citizenship (London: The Crick Report, 1998).

30 Maryam Serajiantehrani, "Children's Literature: Effective Means of Islamic Education in Iran," in *Reforms in Islamic Education*, ed., Charlene Tan (London: Bloomsbury, 2014), 232.

forms of digital narrative such as hyperfiction and electronic narratives.[31] Besides, E-literature includes blogs which are quite popular, and can be considered a part of children's literature.

Conclusion

Islamic education is uniquely different from other types of educational theory and practice largely because of the all-encompassing influence of the Quran. From the elementary level to the higher level, we experience this fact. Because of the overemphasis on Quran and the prophetic tradition (*Hadith*) the children who undergo Islamic education may tend to be more religious than secular and as a result the extremist Islamic leaders can easily indoctrinate these children and use them for their vested interests. The extremist Islamic madrasas in the Indian sub-continent are the best examples. Children are to be taught religious values as well as moral values and they are to be taught secular subjects, physical sciences, and other modern technical subjects together with the religious subjects and these should be by using modern e-literature and other modern techniques of education. It may help to have a cosmopolitan outlook and they learn to respect other religions, cultures, nationalities and will be equipped to live like a world citizen. It is inevitable for Islam which is migrating to the secularist European and Western countries. Strict measures are to be taken for the revise of the Islamic curriculum. Reforms are needed in very many fields as mentioned in the solutions. The prime one is the attitudinal change of the teachers or Islamic educators. Above all Islam should accept and admire other religions and cultures as they are and teach the students the Islamic principles in such a way for a tranquil and peaceful life on this beautiful earth where all can co-exist in a brotherly manner. Extremism and religious fundamentalism will always lead to anarchy and instability.

31 Unsworth L., *E-Literature for Children: Enhancing Digital Literary Learning* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2006).

Part 3

Emancipative Education for a New World

13

Existential and Ethical Revisioning of Science Education and Research

Keith D'Souza

Abstract: The fields of science and technology have grown exponentially ever since the Enlightenment in Western society. This development has impacted the globe in general as well as India in particular. Indians have taken to science like fish to water, and the world over witnesses a huge demand for Indian IT and FinTech service providers at various levels, as well as the rise of several Indian-origin CEOs of leading STEM-based MNCs. India has produced world-class institutions like the Indian Institute of Science and the various Indian Institutes of Technology. The alumni of these institutions have found homes across the globe.

However, a major lacuna in Indian as well as global science education and research is the apparent lacuna of critical reflection over social and moral issues. This reflection is very easily and often sidelined by mainstream science—as it is largely understood to fall outside the scope of scientific reflection and exploration. As a result, such reflection is quite often outsourced to other academic disciplines, and at the civic level, to civic regimes responsible for public policy and practice the world over.

The main intent of this paper is to argue towards the need for a revision of the mainstream existential or attitudinal approaches often cultivated within science education, as well as the need to fashion a wholesome ethical compass which will serve to guide scientific tutelage and exploration.

Keywords: Existential, Ethical, Revisioning, Science Education, Scientific Research, Ignatian Pedagogical Paradigm, Design Thinking, Experiential Learning

Introduction

The human community has grown in leaps and bounds with regard to scientific education and research projects all across the globe—especially with regard to the natural sciences. Humanity has benefited immensely from the contribution of the scientific community in terms of gaining a firmer grasp over how we understand the natural world and how we may tap its resources to make human life more comfortable, efficient and predictable.

Among most of the fields of knowledge, perhaps there is no other field which may compare with the natural sciences, in which contemporary knowledge keeps on developing and superseding prior knowledge and accepted conclusions. If students refer to past knowledge gained in specific fields of the natural sciences, it is mostly out of a sense of historical curiosity. This is unlike most other fields of knowledge—including that of the social sciences—in which many past theories and discoveries continue to enjoy a meaningful and relevant status within the accepted corpus or canon of knowledge in specific subjects.

However, the very nature and scope of scientific inquiry and investigation as professionally understood and practiced may not by itself allow for extra-scientific factors to affect scientific inquiry. While this may seem to allow science to retain its autonomy as an intellectual and institutional discipline, the main pitfall is a tendency towards "silo thinking", autonomous from social and environmental considerations, among others. This insular approach has led to a hydra-headed crisis—philosophically and conceptually recognized by thinkers like Husserl and Heidegger many decades ago, and closer home, by thinkers and activists like Gandhi. This crisis has now spilled over into the tangible and ordinary world of human experience, with climate change and digital addiction being only two of the many serious collateral damages brought about by a spirit of rampant but not sufficiently prescient scientific innovation.

One way to address this crisis is to tackle it at its very roots, that is, by addressing the manner in which scientific education is undertaken in various educational institutions across the globe. The main thrust of this paper is to highlight the need for a radical shift in the cultivation of existential dispositions associated with scientific learning, as well as to argue for the need for developing an ethical compass in scientific education and research.

1. The Need for an Existential Reorientation Within Scientific Rationality

The Constitution of India states that "it shall be the duty of every citizen of India . . . to develop the scientific temper, humanism and the spirit of inquiry and reform."[1] Cultivating a wholesome scientific mentality or disposition—a "scientific temper"—is important as a prerequisite for steady progress in inquiry, experimentation and technological and industry application. However, the moot question is whether this goes along with the cultivation of "humanism" and "the spirit of reform." Are those engaged more intensely with the sciences also equipped with the existential and cognitive skills to see how scientific developments may be best corelated with social developments?

More fundamentally, while the development of a scientific temper is salutary and even necessary, the collateral development of rigid, insular and overconfident existential dispositions—especially by those more intensely engaged with scientific teaching or research—is not. If not tempered, these somewhat insalubrious attitudinal elements may gradually dominate consciousness and conversation—not only pertaining to scientific discussion, but even overflowing into other areas of human and social life. The conflict between science and religion is one example of how a world dominated by scientific and rational discourse could easily dismiss the contributions of religion as an appropriate social and cultural force.

However, there are many more areas and ways in which scientifically-oriented existential attitudes transgress holistic human development. One is the tendency to cultivate rigid and inflexible cognitive positions. One of the reasons why this may arise is because of the nature of scientific reasoning, which is often argumentatively linear and conceptually binary—reasoning stemming from a preponderance of neurologically left-brained activity. Left-brained thinking is typically rational, in contrast to lateral thinking, which uses far more of imagination and association of ideas.

A more serious collateral concern about linear, left-brain thinking is the tendency to view reality in reductionist terms and categories, often succumbing to the temptation to convert or reduce qualitative phenomena into quantitative analysis and assessment. Another serious limitation of left-brained reductionist thinking is the tendency to process reality in a binary or "either this or that" or "black and white" form of perception and argumentation which brooks no grey or compromise position.

Such thinking—reductionist, quantitative, binary—may be useful at the mechanical level, in which technical certitude is desired and expected. Accuracy, precision and perfection—or in the words of Descartes, "clear and

1 *The Constitution of India*, National Law University, Delhi (Delhi: Eastern Book Co, 2012), IVA, "Fundamental Duties," 51A. (h).

distinct ideas"—may perhaps be necessary in the world of applied sciences and technology when safety and health may otherwise be compromised.

However, both in the field of the pure and applied sciences, lateral and inclusive thinking is precisely the form of thinking that leads to new discoveries and inventions. The movement from a deductive to an inductive manner of inquiry was precisely the form of thinking which guaranteed the liberation of thought from the shackles of tradition. This proved beneficial not only to the world of science—which exploded exponentially in terms of new knowledge and various applications—but to the larger social world, which ushered in positive humanistic features since the time of the Renaissance and the Enlightenment in the Western society.

The greater the measurability or predictability of a science, the greater the tendency towards idealistic projections. This is especially true of the physical and chemical sciences, as opposed to the biological. The mathematical and physical sciences deal with inanimate objects—either conceptual or real—as a major part of their study. Those engaging in the biological or life sciences are comparatively more grounded in the vagaries of realism—as living bodies of all species tend to grow in quite unique ways, based on their heredity and living conditions. However, even these often tend to undervalue uniqueness as opposed to generalities and universal tendencies, which is the normal trajectory of any science, if it has to hold on to its universal import.

A graphic manner in which to illustrate this existential difference between those tutored in the sciences and those tutored in the arts and humanities is that it is only after many years of study seeped in any one scientific discipline does one normally develop the courage to contend with accepted theories and practices. Whereas mere beginners in the humanities and even the social sciences feel emboldened to question accepted theories and practices in their fields of study—as it is far easier to defend rival or alternative theories in these fields.

Yet another existential attitude associated with the sciences is the overt or subtle sense of superiority over those who engage in the humanities, for at least two significant reasons. Firstly, the claims of science are governed by a relatively universal and sturdy justificatory discourse, as compared to the arts and humanities. Secondly, scientists and technocrats are perceived as being engaged in tangibly productive and significantly contributive professions and projects.

Some of these existential or attitudinal dispositions often adopted by those engaged in science education are worrisome enough. However, even more troubling is the lack of sufficient ethical reflection consciously adopted in the process of scientific education. While Sam Harris seems to feel that "The scientific community is predominantly secular and liberal,"[2] this may largely be true from a Western perspective, in which there have been several science versus religion skirmishes over the past half-millennium. In India, however, the opposite may well be true, especially as Indians largely subscribe to a two-tier approach to truth: science deals with empirical truths, while religion is concerned about supernatural truths. In such a scenario, ethical reflection is often outsourced to others, with possibly unhealthy consequences. One possible consequence is the uncritical reinforcement of traditional values and behavioural patterns, as those who have no time or interest or opportunity for critical and ethical reflection may favour traditional and even conservative ways of cultural thinking and behaviour. Similarly, though at the other end of the ethical spectrum, some may want to live a life unfettered of social constraints, for want of adequate reflection (though the latter does not seem to find much favour in India, except perhaps by libertarian youth).

2. Ethical Education as an Integral Part of Science Learning and Research

Why is there a need for a conscious and systematic insertion of value education in general and ethical education in particular in science education and research? Berkowitz and Simmons provide a rudimentary answer to this question:

> In the 21st Century, science education must serve as a foundation for the education of *an informed citizenry* who participate in the freedoms and power of a modern, democratic, technological society. With the rapid development of scientific knowledge and the advent of new technologies, all members of society must have an understanding of the *implications of that knowledge* upon individuals, communities, and the "global village" in which we now live.[3]

A significant component of an "informed citizenry" are those who have been tutored in educational institutions. It is important for these and for the public in general to become aware of the "implications" associated with the "rapid development of scientific knowledge and the advent of new technologies." If educational institutions do not systematically ensure reflection over these issues, then what they will produce are merely "skilled

2 Sam Harris, *The Moral Landscape: How Science Can Determine Human Values* (New York: Free Press, 2010), 5.

3 Berkowitz and Simmons, "Integrating Science Education and Character Education," in Dana Zeidler, ed., *The Role of Moral Reasoning on Socioscientific Issues and Discourses in Science Education* (Dordrecht: Kluwer Academic Publishers, 2003), 117. Italics added.

workers" without the ability to engage in critical social reflection—especially reflection connected with their productive outcomes. This would be a classic example of Marxian "alienation"—the workers being materially alienated not only from what they produce, but even worse, socially alienated from the consequences of what they produce.

Is science value neutral? Beyond the banal issue of the distinctiveness between the "is"—the apparent realm of the sciences—and the "ought"—the realm of values and ethics—this question has been laboriously pondered over in academic circles for some decades now. However, in more recent times it has gained even more prominence, as we have become more aware and critical of the collateral damage done by rampant scientific and especially technological "development" or "progress."

Arguing for the value-ladenness of science, John Dupre asserts that, "If scientific results concerning IQ and race, free markets and growth, or environmental emissions and planetary weather make value assumptions, treating them as entirely neutral is misleading at best."[4] Dupre goes on to argue that,

> if most or all of physics is value free, it is not because physics is science but because most of physics simply doesn't matter to us. Whether electrons have a positive or a negative charge and whether there is a black hole in the middle of our galaxy are questions of absolutely no immediate importance to us. The only human interests they touch (and these they may indeed touch deeply) are cognitive ones, and so the only values that they implicate are cognitive values.[5]

While Dupre may seem to exaggerate a bit—as there may indeed be proximate applications for positively or negatively charged electrons—the example he provides implicitly introduces a subtle distinction between epistemic and social validity and value. Even at the epistemic or cognitive level, there are many conflicting theories in the philosophy of science which may confer differing values as to how theories are produced and data is processed. In terms of a social validation and evaluation of what science and technology has to offer, there is even more of a range of views regarding the value of scientific projects. Dupre puts this point across strongly but plainly: "Physics assists us in building particular kinds of power stations, and particular kinds of power stations are more or less safe, efficient, ugly, and so on. Anyone

4 John Dupre, "Fact and Value," in Harold Kincaid, John Dupre and Alison Wylie, eds., *Value-Free Science?: Ideals and Illusions* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007), 4.

5 John Dupre, "Fact and Value," 32.

who supposes there is a value-free theory of nuclear power station building, let alone hydrogen bomb construction, is, it seems to me, a fool or a liar."[6]

If an easy separation between scientific inquiry and experimentation on the one hand and social consequences on the other have been easy in the past, it has become increasingly more difficult to sustain this separation today. Huge Lacey asks a disciplinary-related fundamental question related to the value-neutrality of the sciences:

> Do the practices of scientific inquiry express the values of impartiality, neutrality, and autonomy? . . . Not all theories actually accepted in the scientific community accord with impartiality; most actually accepted theories (contrary to the aspiration of neutrality) serve to further the manifestation of some value complexes (those containing the modern values of control) much more than that of others; and the claim of autonomy must contend with the numerous compromises into which the scientific community enters with the values of those institutions which provide for its material and social conditions.[7]

However, Lacey himself contends that a case may and should be made to retain the ideals of impartiality and neutrality in scientific inquiry—with some caveats. Having said this, he realistically admits that, "only fragments of autonomy can be sustained."[8]

Given the fact of the value-laden nature of scientific investigation and experimentation, it is imperative that those engaged in science study and research are trained to develop wholesome existential dispositions in general, and develop a healthy and appropriate ethical compass in particular, keeping in mind the social applicability of science and technology. While there is no doubt that there is a need to develop this existential-moral compass for those engaged in science education and research, there is a similar need for those engaged in the social sciences and the humanities in general. However, in comparison to the physical and life sciences, the arts, humanities and the social sciences by default engage in a significant amount of critical thinking with regard to various issues which fall under the ambit of their study and research.

3. Existential and Ethical Aspects of Science Education and Research

Huge Lacey argues that, "elite universities embody to a high degree the value of intellectual cultivation and distinctiveness, but not that of solidarity

6 John Dupre, "Fact and Value," 32.

7 Huge Lacey, *Is Science Value Free?: Values and Scientific Understanding* (London: Routledge, 1999), 249.

8 Huge Lacey, *Is Science Value Free?*, 219.

with the poor; and capitalist economic institutions embody to a high degree various egoist values, but not sharing."[9] While India has gained tremendous reputation over the past few decades in terms of creating world-class institutions in the fields of technology and information communication, it is not clear whether these institutions have originally or even gradually been oriented towards creating technological and communication systems that contribute towards the alleviation of poverty and hardship for the masses. It is not surprising that these institutions have facilitated a massive exodus of skilled workers to materially more developed nations, depleting the local industry of highly skilled labour in the sophisticated scientific fields in which they have specialized.

There is a need for a concerted effort across the nation and the globe to train future science and technology thinkers and workers to keep the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) of the UN as a necessary benchmark for productivity and success.[10] In keeping with these SDGs and beyond, but also looking beyond them, what may be some major aspects of existential and ethical import which need to be inculcated in scientific study and research? The following list of focal options is not exhaustive, but is a good basic template of desirable outcomes, keeping in mind this field of expertise and production:

3.1. Serving Human and Social Needs

Any programme of study or research needs to be consciously identified as contributing towards some social need or the other. Positively speaking, the outcome of any scientific project needs to be specified as benefiting society in some specific manner. Negatively speaking, the identifiable collateral damage which results from any scientific pursuit needs to be identified and minimized.

3.2. Aiming for Inclusive and Accessible Outcomes

Scientific reflection and especially technological production need to be oriented towards the creation of accessible as well as affordable projects and products. A good example of a product which has become both accessible and affordable is the smart phone. Within the span of a few years, it has become increasingly possible for common people to have relatively easy and affordable access to phones which have multiple functions, featuring as computer, watch, camera, calculator, diary, map and navigation tool all rolled into one. Internet connectivity, however, is another product that similarly needs to become as accessible and cheap.

9 Huge Lacey, *Is Science Value Free?*, 26.

10 See "The 17 Goals," in https://sdgs.un.org/goal, accessed 5 January 2023.

3.3. Caring for the Natural Environment

Today more than ever than the past, the culpability of science and technology—stemming from the arrogance and surety of modernity—has been recognized, in terms of adding to substantial environmental stress. The rampant abuse of natural and unrenewable resources as a result of economic and political expediency has severely compromised the integrity of science as a progressive discipline. Wise and integral growth in science has consequently become stunted, not for a want of adequate expertise or creativity, but on account of factors such as sluggishness to improvise and improve, monopolies which limit inventiveness, the buying and freezing of patents, industry cartels, etc. – and at the bottom of this all, sheer greed, coupled with a narrow vision that does not consider the wellbeing of present and future generations and the health of the planet and all of its inhabitants.

3.4. Recognizing Diversity and Plurality Within Disciplines

There may be multiple ways to understand and respond to problems, even in a specialized field of study. Just because things have been done in a particular manner or pattern to resolve natural or social problems, there is no need to assume that there are no other ways to do the same. Diversity and plurality are important elements if one is to employ an inclusive spirit of study and research. This would enhance the ability of collateral and innovative thinking.

3.5. Engaging in Cross-disciplinary Learning

While inclusion, diversity and plurality are important values in intradisciplinary programmes, what would enhance the quality of any academic programme is learning and doing across disciplines—not just across disciplines within a particular faculty or school, but disciplines across different faculties and schools. This is especially important if one is to reframe existential and ethical perspectives—thinking outside the departmental box is imperative to gain a larger and more critical view of ground realities.

3.6. Adopting a Critical and Creative Approach

Critical and creative thinking are important, especially in terms of a revisioning of accepted theories and practices. Science has brought about multiple and major paradigm shifts precisely because of these benchmark ingredients of critical thinking and innovative thinking. Such thinking is especially relevant and necessary if scientific and technological outcomes need to be oriented towards fulfilling social needs.

3.7. Embracing Humility

Human beings know only a little about the cosmos and even about the human situation. The Covid-19 situation bears ample testimony to the frailty of the

human condition—and the severe limitations of science in dealing with such crises. The more we learn, the more we become astonished about the vast scope of the subject matter even within specialized areas of study. This makes revision of preciously held theories possible. Humility also serves to moderate and minimize the hubris that science has enjoyed over the past few centuries.

3.8. Cultivating Aesthetic and Mystical Appreciation

The study of the cosmos—both in terms of discovery as well as inventiveness—is one of the most aesthetically appealing of human projects. Unfortunately, like other fields of study, this aesthetic dimension has been largely snuffed out or buried, because of numerous institutional and economic concerns—and the inability of good teachers to communicate this dimension of study to their students. Sensitizing students and researchers to develop an aesthetic sensibility would enhance the happiness quotient, and hopefully even the social quotient. Creating conditions for science students to view the universe via the lens of mystery rather than that of mastery is important, if one is to develop healthy existential and ethical perspectives benefiting persons, communities and the environment.

4. Reorienting Existential-Ethical Concerns Within Science Education and Research

The list of existential and ethical concerns expressed above seem very lofty and perhaps even daunting, in terms of accomplishment. The challenge is to operationalize institutional and administrative processes in science learning and research, so that we may meet these goals. What educational strategies could be employed meaningfully and reasonably, in order to meet these outcomes?

The larger context of education has to do with serving personal development and the common good. To bring this about, wise public policy and the benevolent interest of major stakeholders like the government, business corporations, NGOs, educational institutions, etc., are necessary. If these stakeholders do not invest in holistic science education, it is very difficult to take this project forward, for lack of civic support and funding. The much smaller—but very important—operational canvas is that of domestic value education. Most of the value education of human beings takes place at home—albeit more in practice than in theory. Existential attitudes and moral reflections are cultivated in a non-formal manner in the domestic sphere, with many such values and convictions inculcated for life.

The mediatory canvas of education—between massive stakeholders on the one hand and the family on the other—are educational institutions: primary, secondary, tertiary, higher and professional. It is this sphere of concerted and institutionalized science education that needs to take the project of holistic

science education seriously. How may we put this project into action: in school, college and professional education? What model or structure of educational formation could best be employed towards this end? There are indeed several such models available, but we will consider just three, from the point of view of reorienting and reframing existential and ethical concerns and perspectives.

4.1. The Ignatian Pedagogical Paradigm (IPP)

The "Ignatian Pedagogical Paradigm" (IPP) is rooted in the spirituality developed by St. Ignatius of Loyola, the founder of the Jesuits. Towards the end of the 16th century, the Jesuits outlined a "*Ratio Studiorum*" or template for holistic educational formation, which proved to be the benchmark for educational institutions administered by the Jesuits the world over.[11] The IPP is in continuity with the pedagogical wisdom and dynamism of the *Ratio Studiorum*, but moves away from the classical mould of thinking which inspired the latter, and embraces a much more contemporary perspective of integral education.

> Ignatian pedagogy begins with **context** . . . shaped and driven by the individuality and complexity of the learners, taking into account their background, skills, goals, and anything else that might be relevant. The next step is **experience** . . . [engaging in] the material in a way that fully involves them. This means both cognitive and emotional involvement; personal investment; societal engagement; and behavioral investment. In this paradigm, the process of learning is as important as the content of learning, or perhaps even more so . . . [The next step involves **reflection** at various levels]: cognitive and emotional (what is this and how do I feel about it?); personal (what does this mean to me?); societal (what does this mean to the world?); and behavioral (what does this tell me about what I should do?) . . . Introspection is meant to lead to **action** . . . it is hoped that real education will lead the student to take actions, large and small, to make the world a better place for all, and particularly those most in need. [The last step in the process is **evaluation**].[12]

The step of reflection is especially significant, as it involves a collective, concerted and intense engagement with the subject matter, and with others in the classroom setting. In terms of process, it is important to "Build opportunities for reflection into the course, whether through student journals, mid-semester

11 See "The Jesuit Ratio Studiorum," in https://www.primematters.com/foundations/catholic-intellectual-tradition/jesuit-ratio-studiorum, accessed 17 November 2022.

12 See "Ignatian Pedagogy," https://cndls.georgetown.edu/ignatian-pedagogy/, accessed 15 July 2022.

course evaluations, reflective papers, group discussions and debriefs, or any other method that asks them to think about what they've learned and what it means to them."[13] Such reflection is important in the formation of convictions regarding the subject matter and how the subject and its applications have a direct or indirect impact on social conditions. In terms of outcomes, we need to similarly ask: "What kind of guidance will be best for getting students to reflect on not just what they have learned, but what that content means to them, how it changes their view of themselves and the world, and how it calls them to action on what they have learned?"[14]

4.2. Design-based Learning

"Design-based learning" has its foundations in "design thinking." While summarizing an article providing an overview of design thinking, Jeanne Liedtka has this to say: "Recognizing organizations as collections of human beings who are *motivated by varying perspectives and emotions*, design thinking emphasizes *engagement, dialogue, and learning*. By involving customers and other stakeholders in the definition of the problem and the development of solutions, design thinking garners *a broad commitment to change*."[15]

Jeanne Liedtka also provides a table explaining the benefits of a design-thinking way of doing things:[16]

Problem	**Design Thinking**	**Improved Outcome**
Innovators are trapped in their own expertise and experience.	Design thinking provides immersion in the user's experience, shifting an innovator's mindset toward…	…a better understanding of *those being designed for.*
Innovators are overwhelmed by the volume and messiness of qualitative data.	Design thinking makes sense of data by organizing it into themes and patterns, pointing the innovator toward…	…new insights and possibilities.
Innovators are divided by differences in team members' perspectives.	Design thinking builds alignment as insights are translated into design criteria, moving an innovation team toward…	…convergence around what really matters to users.
Innovators are confronted by too many disparate but familiar ideas.	Design thinking encourages *the emergence of fresh ideas* through a focused inquiry, shifting team members toward…	…a limited but diverse set of potential new solutions.
Innovators are *constrained by existing biases* about what does or doesn't work.	Design thinking fosters articulation of the *conditions necessary to each idea's success* and transitions a team toward…	…clarity on make-or-break assumptions that enables the design of meaningful experiments.
Innovators are *lacking a shared understanding of new ideas* and often unable to get good feedback from users.	Design thinking offers pre-experiences to users through very rough prototypes that help innovators get…	…accurate feedback at low cost and an understanding of potential solutions' true value.
Innovators are *afraid of change and ambiguity* surrounding the new future.	Design thinking delivers *learning in action* as experiments engage staff and users, helping them build…	…a shared commitment and confidence in the new product or strategy.

In the Prelude to the seminal volume titled, *The Design Way*, authors Harold Nelson and Erik Stolterman assert that, "We believe that the culture of inquiry and action that infuses design thinking is an essential part of the variety of human traditions of being in the world—of "human being.""[17] In the first chapter of the book titled, "The First Tradition," they go on to add:

> Design is a *tertium quid*—a third way—distinct from the arts and sciences. In support of this argument we make a case for the reconstitution of *sophia*—the integration of *thought* and *action* through design … Design is the ability to imagine that-which-does-not-yet-exist, to make it appear in concrete form as a new, purposeful addition to the real world. Design is the *first tradition* among the many traditions of inquiry an action developed over time, including art, religion, science, and technology. We design

13 "Ignatian Pedagogy."

14 See "What is Ignatian Pedagogy?," in https://www.luc.edu/fcip/ignatianpedagogy/whatisignatianpedagogy/, accessed 20 July 2022.

15 See Jeanne Liedtka, "Why Design Thinking Works," *Harvard Business Review* (September-October 2018), https://hbr.org/2018/09/why-design-thinking-works, accessed 17 March 2022. Italics added.

16 Jeanne Liedtka, "Why Design Thinking Works." Italics added in all three columns.

17 Harold Nelson and Erik Stolterman, *The Design Way: Intentional Change in an Unpredictable World*, 2nd ed. (Boston: MIT Press, 2012), 2.

> our cosmologies, our homes, our businesses, and our lives, as well as our material artifacts.[18]

The IPP and Design Thinking and Learning processes share a lot in common. More than that, both of them share important ingredients of the educational process: empathy, *cura personalis* or accompaniment towards the holistic growth of the person and a strong sense of an underlying desire to make learning applicable in some way or the other. Even more, what is similar to both the IPP and design learning is the consideration of learning as something fundamentally oriented towards service, and in the case of the IPP, service towards the more vulnerable:

> Both design thinking and Ignatian pedagogy are fundamentally human-centered approaches. Each has at its core the value of empathy, or the quest to understand another. The aim of Jesuit education is that a focus on the full growth of the person will lead to action. Jesuits embrace a tradition of practical spirituality which intersects with design thinking's bias toward action and solving real world problems. This focus on the practical connects with another central mission of both enterprises: service.[19]

It is not difficult to find similarities between IPP and design thinking processes, as graphically depicted in this comparative layout:[20]



4.3. Experiential Learning Strategies

In a Socratic fashion, these strategies begin with life-experience and derive content from such experience. This may also be termed a "constructivist

18 Harold Nelson and Erik Stolterman, *The Design Way*, 11-12. Original italics.

19 See "Ignatian Pedagogy," https://cndls.georgetown.edu/ignatian-pedagogy/, accessed 15 July 2022.

20 "Ignatian Pedagogy."

approach" in pedagogy. A good example of such a constructivist approach is that formulated by David Kolb.

> Kolb's Learning Cycle is based on Jean Piaget's focus on the fact that learners create knowledge through interactions with the environment … Kolb's learning process cycle begins with a **concrete experience** … the key to learning is involvement … [The second step is **reflective observation**]: to ask questions and discuss the experience with others. [the third step is **abstract conceptualization**]: to make sense of these event … to classify concepts and form conclusions on the events that occurred … This involves interpreting the experience and making comparisons to their current understanding on the concept. [The last step is **active experimentation**]: the testing stage … applying their conclusions to new experiences … to make predictions, analyze tasks and make plans for the acquired knowledge in the future. By allowing learners to put their knowledge into practice and showing how it is relevant to their lives, you are ensuring that the information is retained in the future.[21]

According to Kendra Cherry, "Kolb described two different ways of *grasping* experience: Abstract Conceptualization [and] Concrete Experience, [and] … two ways of *transforming* experience: Active Experimentation [and] Reflective Observation."[22] Cherry provides an example of different learning styles: "Let's imagine that you are going to learn how to drive a car: One person may choose to begin learning via reflection by observing other people as they drive. Another might prefer to start more abstractly, by reading and analyzing a driving instruction book. Yet, a different person could decide to just jump right in and get behind the seat of a car to practice driving on a test course."[23]

This theory too—like the IPP and design-based learning—is cyclic in nature. One may enter into the learning process at any step or stage. However, the cycle needs to be complete, if learning has to take place. Roger Fry worked with Kolb to further refine this theory, in order to consider both the complexity of the learning process as well as the unique preferences and talents of individuals—some who may be better at some stages rather

21 See Serhat Kurt, "Kolb's Experiential Learning Theory & Learning Styles," https://educationaltechnology.net/kolbs-experiential-learning-theory-learning-styles/, accessed 12 May 2022.

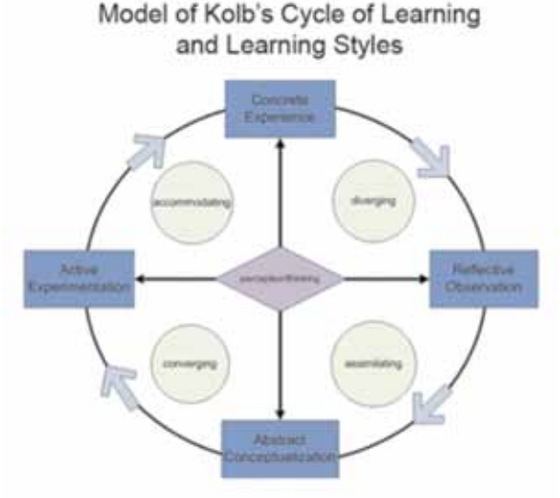
22 Kendra Cherry, "The Experiential Learning Theory of David Kolb," https://www.verywellmind.com/experiential-learning-2795154, accessed 20 May 2022.

23 Kendra Cherry, "The Experiential Learning Theory of David Kolb."

than others. Accordingly, they identified four different learning styles: diverging, assimilating, converging and accommodating—each of which is a combination of the four components which Kolb had outlined.

> **Diverging** is associated with concrete experience and reflective observation. These people tend to have a strong imagination and the ability to see from different perspectives. **Assimilating** is associated with reflective observation and abstract conceptualization. Assimilators are more skilled with inductive reasoning, theoretical models, and abstract concepts. **Converging** is associated with abstract conceptualization and active experimentation. They are strong in areas of practical application and hypo deductive reasoning. **Accommodating** is associated with active experimentation and concrete experience. Strengths in this area include intuitive problem solving and high performance in task completion and responding to immediate circumstances.[24]

Below is a graph of the experiential model proposed by David Kolb and Roger Fry:[25]



24 See "About Experiential Learning," http://nonprofit.davenport.edu/explearning/about.html, accessed 5 June 2022.

25 "About Experiential Learning."

Venkata Bayineni provides a simple comparative table indicating the major differences between conventional learning and experiential learning:[26]

Conventional Learning	Experimental Learning
Training focused	Learning focused
Predefined learning	Customised learning
Very theoretical	Very hands-on
Fixed in its framework	Open ended and flexible
For organizational needs	For one's personal growth
Involves the transfer of knowledge	Knowledge is usually developed

Bayineni asserts that, "Children need realistic learning experiences that are authentically set in real-life environments that are built to intentionally imitate how the world currently operates outside the classroom boundaries. With science focusing more on innovation, it comes as no surprise that its pedagogy is also evolving."[27]

4.4. Training of Trainers

Whatever model may be applied to bring about a greater sensitization or development of existential and ethical compasses, perhaps the most significant role in the process is that of the catalyst, mentor or teacher. There is a dire need for good teacher training programs, in order to change the way teaching takes place across the globe. The success of any educational programme depends to a major extent on the mediation of a good teacher, especially in situations which are less financially resourceful.

Conclusion

Science and technology have grown exponentially over the last few centuries, and especially over the last few decades—as compared to the entire length of human history. In order to make this growth more holistic and safer for humans and their natural environment, it is imperative that those engaged in science education and research cultivate wholesome existential dispositions. More so, it is important that novices, interns and experts in this field of science develop and adopt personal, institutional, and social guidelines which are justifiably normative in nature. This would not only make the discipline of science more integral as a learning system, but it would also ensure less damage to society and the environment in the short and long run.

26 Venkata Krishna Bayineni, "What is Experiential Learning of Science?," in https://www.prayoga.org.in/post/what-is-experiential-learning-of-science, accessed 27 May 2022.

27 Venkata Krishna Bayineni, "What is Experiential Learning of Science?"

Developing a wholesome existential-ethical compass is an ongoing process, and may understandably differ from context to context and age to age. However, the time has come when science education and research need to consciously integrate elements of existential and ethical reflection and application. The wellbeing of humanity and the globe depends on this.

14

Piketty's Pitfalls
Taming the Neo-Liberal Leviathan in Education

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Abstract: The paper is entitled, "Piketty's Pitfalls: Taming the Neo-Liberal Leviathan in Education." It stands under the hermeneutical key of Political Economy of Knowledge Production, inspired by the thematic of "Emancipative Education: Policies and Practices." It intends capturing in broad contours, the nuances of the debate, revolving around, the French economist, Piketty's conclusions regarding education and inequality of wealth, as put forth in his widely publicised book, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century* (2014). The architectonic of the paper is crafted along the following lines. In the first part of the work, key insights of Piketty, on education, in relation to Capital, and the growing inequality of wealth, which are considered as positive by the critics are gathered. In the second section of the Paper, some of the pitfalls of Piketty, as regards education, either by way of being in need of being complemented, in spite of their positive content or being deficient in the sense of their being aids to the marketization of education, in the context of Neo-Liberalism, are brough into relief. The conclusion attempts to contextualize this debate, grounding itself in the grassroots.

Keywords: Piketty, Capital, inequality, education, social mobility, social reproduction, political economy, human capital, social capital, inequality of wealth, social movements, forces of convergence, forces of social transformation, Pedagogy of the Oppressed.

Introduction

"Piketty's Pitfalls: Taming the Neo-Liberal Leviathan in Education" intends capturing in broad contours, the nuances of the debate, revolving around Piketty's conclusions regarding education and inequality of wealth, as put forth in his widely publicised book, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*.[1] In the first part of the work, key insights of Piketty on education, in relation to Capital and growing inequality of wealth, which are considered as positive by the critics are gathered. In the second section of the Paper, some of the pitfalls of Piketty, as regards education, either by way of being in need of being complemented, in spite of their positive content or being deficient in the sense of their being aids to the marketization of education, in the context of Neo-Liberalism, are brough into relief. The conclusion attempts to contextualize this debate, grounding itself in the grassroots, especially the Indian situation.

1. Piketty's Contributions to the Sociology of Education

"The entrepreneur inevitably tends to become a rentier, more and more dominant over those who own nothing but their labour. Once constituted, capital reproduces itself faster than output increases. The past devours the future."[2]

In this statement from *Capital in the Twenty-first Century*, Piketty summarizes the central thesis of his book, that previously accumulated wealth is always more important than income and that it is the primary factor defining our future. This predicament is particularly troubling for educators, who are preparing the youth for the future world. If past levels of inequality are destined to grow, regardless of how hard students work in school, why bother studying? Piketty's thesis succeeds in simultaneously disheartening an entire generation of students while also ripping away from teachers the most powerful reasoning that they have to convince students to study: it is an investment in a more equal future.[3]

1.1. First Contribution

Piketty refutes the myth that inequality will naturally decrease with industrialization and economic growth. He further argues that the returns on accumulated wealth are destined to increase at a much higher rate than

1 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2014).

2 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, 571.

3 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study? Piketty, Social Movements, and Future Directions for Education," *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 37, no. 6 (2016): 861-872, here 861. See, http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/01425692.2016.1165084, DOI: 10.1080/01425692.2016.1165084, accessed 04 September 2022.

economic growth, leading to an ever-expanding gap between the rich and the poor.[4]

Piketty's economic arguments have direct relevance for the sociology of education. First, his work represents a frontal assault on the idea of meritocracy in schools, therefore contributing to theories of social mobility in education. Second, Piketty dismisses traditional arguments about human capital and economic growth, also offering support to critical studies of neo-liberalism and market-based educational reforms. Third, Piketty also provides evidence for a need to return to the political-economy tradition in education—which emphasizes the political reasons for inequality—an approach that has been strong in neo-Marxist theories of social reproduction and critical educational studies.[5]

His argument basically implies that students' work ethic has little to do with the overall distribution of wealth. Piketty discusses two types of societies that currently exist: a 'hyperpatrimonial' society (society of rentiers) and a 'hypermeritocratic' society (based on income). In the former, education, meritocracy, or even relative social mobility is completely irrelevant for addressing inequality, since the source of this inequality is inheritance. This is an important finding for sociologists of education, especially in Europe where these 'hyperpatrimonial' societies are most prevalent, illustrative of the real limits of education's contribution to social equality. However, Piketty's arguments about hypermeritocratic societies are more interesting topics for the field of social mobility. Piketty argues that even in a hypermeritocratic society—largely created by the United States in the past decades—differences in educational attainment, merit, talent, and skill cannot explain inequality.

Piketty claims that inequality is as irrational today as in previous centuries, but now it is justified through belief in meritocracy. This, of course, is what sociologists of education have been providing evidence for about decades, but Piketty's economic comparisons with the past provide greater support for these ideas. Second, Piketty makes a convincing case that the prominence of meritocracy in our ideological imagination is harmful, as it blames the poor for problems they have not caused. Sociologists of education have referred to this as 'deficit' thinking, in which poor communities are blamed for their lack of educational and economic success.[6]

4 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 862.

5 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 862.

6 Phillip Brown, "Education, Opportunity and the Prospects for Social Mobility," *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 34, no. 5-06 (2013): 678–700, here 678; also see *The Evolution of Deficit Thinking: Educational Thought and Practice*, ed., Richard R. Valencia (London: Routledge Falmer, 1997).

1.2. Second Contribution: Human Capital Theory in Retreat

A second contribution Piketty makes to the field of education is his discrediting of human capital theory. In the middle of the twentieth century, beliefs about the purpose of education began to shift as economists entered the educational debate and the idea of 'Human Capital' gained global importance. This notion of 'human wealth' became widely known as 'human capital,' offering a framework for analysing educational investment in terms of rates of return and economic productivity. 'The fundamental principle underpinning Human Capital Theory is the belief that peoples' learning capacities are of comparable value to other resources involved in the production of goods and services.'[7] Piketty directly attacks this assumption, and human capital's relationship to wealth and inequality. He writes:

> In the decades after World War II, people began to think that the triumph of human capital over capital in the traditional sense (land, buildings, and financial capital) was a natural and irreversible process… The evolution of technology has certainly increased the need for human skills and competence. But it has also increased the need for buildings, homes, offices, equipment of all kinds, patents, and so on, so that in the end the total value of all these forms of nonhuman capital… has increased almost as rapidly as total income from labour.[8]

The importance of capital in wealthy countries today is only slightly smaller than it was at the beginning of the nineteenth century. Therefore, investing in 'human capital' cannot reduce inequality if the distribution of non-human capital is not also addressed. Nonetheless, by the end of the 1970s, global institutions such as the World Bank had embraced the concept of human capital, using it to justify educational expansion as a key investment for poverty relief. Human Capital Theory became solidified as a form of capital that facilitates personal success on the job market and adds to a nation's economic prosperity.[9] Piketty, however, directly critiques economists at the World Bank for using what he refers to as 'arbitrary' numbers to calculate rates of return.

He argues that the World Bank's conclusion of human capital being the leading form of capital in the twenty-first century is mathematically incorrect. Similarly, to the previous point on meritocracy, Piketty's critique

7 Fredrick Muyia Nafukho, Nancy R. Hairston, and Kit Brooks, "Human Capital Theory: Implications for Human Resource Development," *Human Resource Development International* 7, no. 4 (2004): 545–551, here 545-546.

8 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, 234.

9 Karen Mundy, "Retrospect and Prospect: Education in a Reforming World Bank," *International Journal of Educational Development* 22 (2002): 483–508.

of human capital theory has also been a common theme among sociologists of education and other educational scholars, over the past decade. In the field of comparative and international education, several articles and books have been published questioning not only the theory of human capital, but the entire agenda of the World Bank in the educational sphere.[10] Bonal argues that Human Capital Theory was embraced by nation-states during the Keynesian economic era, as a form of legitimacy:

> The ideology of equality of educational opportunity appeared adequate to legitimate meritocracy and social justice. The state carried the burden of being responsible for, at least rhetorically, neutralizing the effects of class, gender or ethnic differences on educational performance, mainly because it was the only way to justify a 'fair' but unequal social structure as a result of educational performance distribution.[11]

However, as indicated already, the relationship between an investment in human capital and relative social mobility has proved fleeting. Furthermore, as other scholars argue, the idea of human capital reduces the purpose of education to preparation for the job market, 'rather than in any moral, social or ethical contributions to the "public good."'[12]

1.3. Third Contribution: Reigniting the Political Economy Tradition

A third lesson that education scholars should take from Piketty is a need to return to political economic analysis in education. This political economy approach is associated with neo-Marxist educational traditions, which takes an analysis of capitalism and its relationship to schooling as central.[13] Bourdieu integrated culture into these 'social reproduction' theories, analysing how culture has become the mediating link between ruling-class interests and everyday life. Schools, through their appearance as impartial and neutral, are able to sort students based on the cultural capital they have (or do not have)

10 Steven Klees, Joel Samoff, and Nelly P. Stromquist (eds.), *The World Bank and Education: Critiques and Alternatives* (Rotterdam: Sense Publishers, 2012).

11 Xavier Bonal, "The Neoliberal Educational Agenda and the Legitimation Crisis: Old and New State Strategies." *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 24, no. 2 (2003): 159–175, here 162.

12 Glenda McGregor, "Education for (Whose) Success? Schooling in an Age of Neo-Liberalism," *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 30, no. 3 (2009): 345–358, here 351.

13 Jean Anyon, *Ghetto Schooling: A Political Economy of Urban Educational Reform* (New York: Teachers College Press, 1997); Samuel Bowles and Herbert Gintis, "The Problem with Human Capital Theory – A Marxian Critique," *American Economic Review* 65, no. 2 (1976): 74–82.

upon entering school.[14] Over the time, this political economy approach has become more generally known as 'critical educational studies,' which assumes that education is a 'political act' and that scholars must situate education 'in the unequal relations of power in the larger society.'[15] Scholars in this tradition have analysed how ideology, housing, language, race, and conservative political alliances, among other forces, contribute to education's role in social reproduction.[16]

Piketty adds to this literature, illustrating how inequality is not only reproduced but also exasperated due to previously accumulated wealth. Piketty draws on politics, history, philosophy, and even literature to make his arguments. His belief in integrating the social sciences is clearly stated in an interview, when he is asked what 'intellectual tradition' he is part of. He responds: 'A tradition which is outside of economics and more in historical research, i.e., a long tradition in social and economic history … I view myself more as a social scientist than as an economist.'[17] The history of inequality is shaped by the way economic, social, and political actors view what is just and what is not, as well as by the relative power of those actors and the collective choices that result. It is the joint product of all relevant actors combined.[18]

Overall, Piketty's book offers three major lessons about the merits of a political economy approach: economics alone cannot solve the social issues facing our society; politics, culture, and social forces such as racism and classism affect every aspect of our society; and public debate is necessary to construct the society we want to live in. These lessons are extremely important for educators.

Inequality is also one of the central problems facing education, as finding expression in the extreme economic inequality between rich and poor public schools, public and private schools, charter and public schools, rural and urban schools, and Global South and Global North schools. The policy debate surrounding education, however, is not focused on inequality. Rather, there is an assumption that we can improve education by simply drawing on best practices and developing technocratic solutions for our schools. Economics in education, in particular, has focused on scarcity, rationality, optimization, and 'how individuals, organizations, and societies

14 Pierre Bourdieu and Jean-Claude Passeron, *Reproduction in Education, Society and Culture* (London: Sage Publications Inc, 1990).

15 Michael W. Apple, "Putting 'Critical' Bank into Education Research," *Educational Researcher* 39, no. 2 (2010): 152–155, here 152.

16 Michael W Apple, *Ideology and Curriculum* (New York: Routledge Falmer, 2004).

17 Thomas Piketty, "Interview: Thomas Piketty Responds to Criticisms from the Left - Interview by Antoine Dolcerocca and Gokhan Terzioglu," http://potemkinreview.com/pikettyinterview/-2014, accessed 25 October 2022.

18 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, 20.

employ time, money, and effort.'[19] This has led to an emphasis on statistical models that assess the efficiency in the allocation of educational services and factors influencing outcome-based assessments. Piketty's argument about the economy—Nothing is certain: inequality can move in either direction[20]—is equally apt for education inequities.

2. Beyond Piketty and Social Reproduction: Inspirations from Social Movements

Despite the important contributions, Piketty's analysis of inequality and wealth often falls into the same pitfalls, as economic determinism disregarding the role of education in addressing inequality and therefore offering little hope for educators attempting to counter inequality in schools. In the following section, three arguments are offered about why it is necessary to go beyond Piketty, drawing inspiration from the experiences of social movements for a deeper debate about educational purpose in a highly unequal society, and propose alternative narratives to Piketty's economic proposals, with implications for education. These alternative narratives at three levels also serve as a counter narrative to the Neo-Liberal totalizing narrative on education.

2.1. A Freirean Turn: Education as a Conscious-Raising and Grassroots Agency Praxis

The first alternative concerns how we should address economic inequality, and what role, if any, education has in constructing a more egalitarian society.

'Piketty educational dilemma': no matter how much we invest in more equitable school systems, our investment will not directly address income inequality, is similar to what Brown has termed 'Sociology's inconvenient truth' that social mobility in the twentieth century was due to occupational re-structuring, not 'a narrowing of inequalities in life-chances.'[21] These pessimistic views seem to reinforce social reproduction theories in education. As an alternative, we have to take our lead from social movements, and begin conceptualizing education as a consciousness-raising process that teaches people about these inequalities, so that they can develop creative solutions to address these issues. This re-envisioning of educational purpose has its roots in

19 Dominic J. Brewer, Guilbert C. Hentschke, Eric R. Eide, Ally Kuzin, and Nayfack, "The Role of Economics in Education Policy Research," in *Handbook of Research in Education Finance and Policy*, eds., H. Ladd and E. Fiske (New York: Routledge, 2008), 23–41, here 25.

20 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, 376.

21 Phillip Brown, "Education, Opportunity and the Prospects for Social Mobility," *British Journal of Sociology of Education 34*, no. 5-06 (2013): 678–700.

the ideas of Brazilian educator Paulo Freire, and the theories he first developed in his book *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*.[22]

The most critical component of Freire's philosophy: education is for social action and intervening in the world. In other words, all education is a relationship between reflection and action, what Freire calls praxis. Freire's educational ideas offer a different theoretical starting point for analysing schools' ability to address inequality. The 'Piketty educational dilemma' only holds if the purpose of education is to prepare students to adapt to the world as it is currently economically and politically organized. If, on the other hand, we conceptualize educational purpose as analysing these economic and political realities and developing collective solutions to intervene, the dilemma is overcome. A Freirean educational vision would involve teaching students about the roots of inequality and the fact that schools are not currently serving their meritocratic purpose, while also helping these students propose solutions to these unjust circumstances.[23]

As Apple writes, "We need to see the world through the eyes of the dispossessed and act against the ideological and institutional processes and forms that reproduce oppressive conditions."[24] In practice, teachers and educators are already implementing many of these counter-hegemonic practices in public schools[25] and non-formal contexts.[26] These practices go against the dominant idea of education as 'preparation for productive work' or 'job skills.' A Freirean perspective suggests that researches should continue highlighting these experiences. A Freirean educational approach also has the potential to contribute to Piketty's own policy goals. For example, Piketty poses the question: 'Can we imagine political institutions that might regulate today's global patrimonial capitalism justly as well as efficiently?' Piketty's answer is a global tax on wealth. However, if the implementation of a global tax on wealth was ever to be accepted, it would be necessary to implement a massive grassroots educational campaign about the importance of progressive taxation as a solution to inequality. Of course, a real Freirean

22 Paulo Freire, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (New York: Continuum International Publishing, 2002).

23 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 867.

24 Michael W. Apple, "Putting 'Critical' Bank into Education Research," *Educational Researcher* 39, no. 2 (2010): 152–155, here 152.

25 Michael W. Apple and James Beane, *Democratic Schools: Lessons in Powerful Education* (Portsmouth, NH: Heinemann, 2007); Glenda McGregor, "Education for (Whose) Success? Schooling in an Age of Neo-Liberalism," *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 30, no. 3 (2009): 345–358.

26 Liam Kane, *Popular Education and Social Change in Latin America* (London: Latin America Bureau, 2001).

grassroots educational campaign could also take a different direction, helping youth develop other creative solutions to extreme inequality.[27]

The Brazilian Landless Workers Movement (MST) has been involved in these types of educational campaigns for over three decades.[28] The MST is an agrarian reform movement, involving hundreds of thousands of landless peasants who occupy large unproductive land estates, to pressure the government to redistribute this land to landless families.[29] Over time, MST leaders began to realize that the public schools in their new rural communities were diametrically opposed to the movement's larger social goals, as teachers taught youth that the purpose of studying was to acquire a job in the city. The MST began to intervene in the school system, implementing alternative pedagogies that would encourage students to live and work in the countryside, participate in struggles for land redistribution, and become peasant-intellectuals in their local communities. This positioning of education as consciousness-raising and intervention overcomes the 'Piketty educational dilemma,' because students contest the unequal distribution of previously accumulated wealth.

2.2. A Marxian Turn: From 'Capital' as Wealth to Capital as Power Relation

Another area in which Piketty's argument is limited is in his definition of capital as wealth, and his lack of focus on production and power. Throughout his book, Piketty uses 'capital' interchangeably with 'wealth' in order to represent all forms of accumulation – from money to housing, bonds, factories, land, and even slaves. However, this definition of capital is not what Karl Marx was discussing in his book *Capital*.

A Marxist understanding of capital is relational, specifically referring to the relationship that developed between the owners of the means of production and workers who are forced to sell their labour power to survive. Marx makes a clear distinction between 'money,' 'commodities,' and 'capitalism.' While money was traditionally a means for exchanging commodities, commodities have become the means for making money. This is capitalism, the shift from capital-money-capital (C-M-C) to money-capital-money (M-C-M); or in other words, the fundamental transformation in society's relationship to money and commodities, wherein the aim is

27 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 367.

28 Rebecca Tarlau, "Coproducing Rural Public Schools in Brazil: Contestation, Clientelism, and the Landless Workers' Movement." *Politics & Society* 41, no. 3 (2013): 395–424.

29 Angus Wright and Wendy Wolford, *To Inherit the Earth: The Landless Movement and the Struggle for a New Brazil* (Oakland, CA: Food First Books, 2003).

now the 'unceasing movement of profit-making.'[30] Since the commodity is always equal to its social value (the amount of labour needed to produce it), profit is only possible by paying workers less than the labour time needed to produce the commodity. For Marx, this creates the fundamental contradiction of capitalism: the tendency for the bourgeois to undermine their only source of profit, by incorporating labour-saving machinery into the production process.[31]

While Piketty is analysing dynamics of wealth that are true throughout history—even before industrial capitalism emerged—Marx is focused on how the production process fundamentally transformed in the current capitalist era. Marx's focus allows us to analyse the implications of unequal capital ownership and the fact that bosses have the ability to exploit, control, discriminate, and hold power over people's lives. It also allows us to analyse how these power relations are racialized and gendered.[32]

For Piketty, the critical issue is not the point of production but the outcomes in total wealth distribution, and the fact that those who receive income from capital receive a greater proportion of the economic gains. This focus on income and wealth leads Piketty to suggest a global tax on wealth as the solution to inequality. However, even an 80% global tax on wealth would leave the process of production that currently exists solidly in place.[33]

In other words, inequality is more than an abstract number; it is why poor people are at the mercy of their employers, it is the system through which African Americans are blamed for poverty, it is how women's work is made invisible, and it is the reason that immigrants are both forced to take on 'unwanted jobs' and accused of stealing these jobs. Even if profits from wealth were taxed, are we willing to accept that these power relations remain as they are?[34]

Piketty clearly falls on one side of this debate, arguing that 'the progressive tax thus represents an ideal compromise between social justice and individual freedom.'[35] Piketty's focus on wealth distribution allows him to ignore any discussion about the production process itself. It is important to recognize that theories of social mobility often fall into this same paradigm, ignoring the production process. However, recently some sociologists of education have critiqued this perspective, arguing that 'social justice cannot be reduced to measuring the relative life-chances of people from different

30 Karl Marx, *Capital*: volume 1, trans., Ben Fowkes (London: Penguin, 1976), 254.

31 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 868-869.

32 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 869.

33 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 869.

34 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 869.

35 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, 505.

class backgrounds entering professional or managerial positions. There is much more to 'fairness' than social mobility.'[36]

Social movement theory can build on these critiques, helping us think about how to construct schools that are explicitly linked to more equitable production processes.

2.3. Beyond Global Tax: Democratizing Capital Ownership and Local Sovereign Economies

The final strand of our alternative narrative concerns Piketty's proposal for a global tax on wealth, which is his solution to inequality in the twenty-first century. Two other viable solutions to interrupting social reproduction, which do not involve growth or redistribution, may be proposed: democratizing capital ownership and investing in local economies. The first solution, democratizing capital ownership, could occur through collective property rights. As Piketty himself admits, 'The capital/income ratio for the country as a whole tells us nothing about inequalities within the country.'[37]

If capital was collectively or equally owned, then the capital/income ratio would be irrelevant, since workers would share in all of the returns on capital. Thus, Piketty's second law of capitalism does not need to be overcome to address inequality; capital ownership could simply become more democratic. In the Global South, there have been attempts to experiment with alternative forms of collective decision-making and capital ownership for decades. For example, for over two decades the city of Porto Alegre, Brazil, has given over a large portion of its budget (the city's wealth) to citizens, who determine the allocation of the budget each year based on local community discussions and neighbourhood meetings.[38] This example is important, because it illustrates the importance of education in not only promoting 'democracy,' but also participatory governance.

A second alternative to a global tax on wealth is investing in local and sovereign economies. This would essentially reduce total economic production and slow growth, which is perhaps the antithesis to Piketty's position, as he argues that 'Decreased growth – especially demographic growth – is thus responsible for capital's comeback.'[39]

36 Phillip Brown, Diane Reay, and Carol Vincent. 2013. "Education and Social Mobility," *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 34, no. 5-06 (2013): 637–643, here 639.

37 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, 51.

38 Gianpaolo Baiocchi, *Militants and Citizens: The Politics of Participatory Democracy in Porto Alegre* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2005).

39 Thomas Piketty, *Capital in the Twenty-First Century*, Piketty, 166.

3. Conclusions: Piketty's Relevance for Taming the Neo-Liberal Leviathan in Education

Given both Piketty's contributions and limitations, what is the overall value of his recent economic treatise for educational scholarship? Many left-leaning scholars reject his arguments for their utopian propositions, their lack of focus on production, their lack of engagement in discussions of race, class[40] and gender,[41] and their overall adherence to neoclassical economics. While I agree with these critiques, I have illustrated three concrete ways in which Piketty's economic treatise contributes to debates in the sociology of education: his critique of meritocracy confirms many of the findings in the field of social mobility; his rejection of Human Capital Theories complements sociological critiques of education's assumed economic purpose; and his focus on political solutions to inequality rejects technocratic traditions in education and supports an interdisciplinary, political economy approach.[42]

Debates around empire and imperialism within the field of international development and education seek to explore the complex ways in which global inequalities between north and south are systematically reproduced through the powerful practices and activities of key education and development actors – from the World Bank and beyond.[43]

Although Piketty continually states throughout his book that he is not a Marxist, overall, his ideas support theories of social reproduction and the lack of social mobility through education. We have suggested the limits to the economic determinism in Piketty's arguments, and illustrated the need to draw on the experiences of social movements to think about education's transformative potential. First, the need to move beyond a utilitarian vision of education as a 'force of convergence,' and instead to draw on

40 See in this context, Roger Dale, "The Under-Recognition of the Significance of Social Class Conceptions of Education in Piketty's *Capital*," *British Journal of Sociology of Education*, 37, no. 6 (2016): 836-847, DOI: 10.1080/01425692.2016.1165088, https://doi.org/10.1080/01425692.2016.1165088, accessed 04/09/2022.

41 For a Feminist Critique of Picketty's *Capital*, Kathryn Moeller, "A Critical Feminist and Race Critique of Thomas Piketty's Capital in the Twenty-first Century," *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 37, no. 6 (2016): 810-822, DOI: 10.1080/01425692.2016.1165085, https://doi.org/10.1080/01425692.2016.1165085/, accessed 04/09?2022, where the article argues that Piketty's proposed solution would leave corporate strategies for accumulating wealth untouched, and would do little to transform the entrenched inequalities experienced by poor, racialized girls and women.

42 See in this context, Mario Novelli, Capital, Inequality and Education in Conflict Affected Contexts, *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 37, no. 6 (2016): 848-860, DOI: 10.1080/01425692.2016.1165087 https://doi.org/10.1080/01425692.2016.1165087/, accessed 04/09/2022.

43 Mario Novelli, "Capital, Inequality and Education in Conflict Affected Contexts," 885.

the educational theories of Paulo Freire to recast education as a force for 'social transformation.' It also has been discussed how Piketty's arguments take agency away from grassroots movements, and alternatively, the need to emphasize agency, especially teacher and student agency in schools. We have also critiqued the short-sighted focus on economic redistribution throughout Piketty's book, and have emphasized why his analysis makes power relations at the point of production invisible. Two alternative solutions to a global tax on wealth: more democratic capital ownership and investment in local, sovereign economies. Throughout these arguments, it has been illustrated how transforming education has been critical for the social movements and grassroots communities that have fought for these types of economic alternatives.[44]

To conclude, the fame Piketty has earned is an important sign that people are interested in and willing to talk about inequality in the twenty-first century. Although Piketty's arguments mostly serve to reinforce many of the well-established findings in the field of sociology of education, his ability to bring these critiques to the mainstream economic world is important. This is similar to a Gramscian political strategy, which draws on people's 'common sense' – what Gramsci refers to as the ambiguous and contradictory folklore of the people – to draw out people's 'good sense.'[45] In this case, that good sense is an acknowledgement of the negative effects of extreme inequality for our society. Educators and scholars should use this moment to renew discussions about inequality within, between, and around their schools. We should also go beyond Piketty's arguments, and talk about the community organizing that will be necessary to transform extreme inequality, and the role schools have in that process. Although Piketty's predictions are pessimistic, the past will only devour the future if we stop trying to transform our schools and communities.[46]

It is clear that Piketty is able to name the problem of the age—the concentration of capital amongst a small elite—and challenge the assumptions of the neoclassical economists with evidence. Piketty and colleagues' analysis of education—as part of the solution and not part of the problem—fails to engage with the role that education currently plays in furthering, rather than ameliorating, these inequalities.[47]

44 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 871.

45 Antonio Gramsci, the *Prison Notebooks*, (eds) and trans. Quintin Hoare and Geoffrey Nowell Smith (New York, International Publishers, 1971.

46 Rebecca Tarlau, "If the Past Devours the Future, Why Study?," 871.

47 Susan Lee Robertson, "Piketty, Capital and Education: a Solution to, or Problem in, Rising Social Inequalities?," *British Journal of Sociology of Education* 37, no. 6 (2016): 823-835, here 833. DOI: 10.1080/01425692.2016.1165086, https://doi.org/10.1080/01425692.201, accessed 4 September 2022.

Firstly, we look at strategies and other interventions where a tax rather than debt state 'manages' the race between competing social groups for education as a positional good through forms of redistribution. This, in turn means challenging human capital accounts of education, and those powerful interests who propagate these views; the unprecedented power that neoclassical economists of education have in shaping education policy, along with the growing power of key international organisations in advancing human capital arguments and projects. It also means challenging the ideological project that has normalised ideas like 'choice', 'talent' and 'resilience'. These tropes have obscured the class-based nature of capital's project. As Streeck so potently points out, "capital is treated as a factor in production, and not as a class … capital is a player and not a play thing."[48]

A second alternative is that we develop new kinds of research tools that enable us to see beyond the limits of national data-sets to bring into view the ways in which global labour markets are developing and what this means for the organisation of national-located labour. To be sure this will demand the collection of data on flows of capital, the locatedness of workers and the ways in which global space is used by capital to gain a competitive advantage.

Finally, education must be extracted from the vortex that is rapidly sucking it up into the new culture of capitalism. For education to be recovered as a human right, and the basis of a new social contract, it must be viewed as a societal good funded by the state. This means the reform of societies and their regulatory mechanisms, including progressive forms of taxation, that in turn contribute to the collective wealth and health of any society. This is, in itself, a job of education, writ in its widest of senses – so that societal arrangements are built and judged fit for purpose, not because they benefit a tiny greedy elite but because they take in, and care for, those who are most vulnerable.[49]

Education is at its best when it creates those spaces, opportunities, and encounters where a next generation are helped to ask the kinds of questions and engage in the kinds of politics that will make a positive difference to their lives and the lives around them. An education system committed to social justice and not market justice would have a radical effect on politics. Only then might education become part of the solution and not the problem.[50]

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48 W. Streeck, *Buying Time: The Delayed Crisis of Democratic Capitalism* (London and New York: Verso, 2014), 18 -19.

49 Susan Lee Robertson, "Piketty, Capital and Education," 830-834.

50 Susan Lee Robertson, "Piketty, Capital and Education," 834.

15

Commercialisation Versus Decommercialisation of Education in the Indian Context

Henry Jose Kodikuthiyil, MSFS

Abstract: The term education has been defined as the process of developing and training the powers and capabilities of humans. In the context of an increasingly complex, global and competitive world, commercialisation has become an important strategic priority for many countries, governments and different education institutions. India, even after 75 years of its independence, is far away from the goal of universal as well as the proper way of literacy. Commercialisation of education in India introduced new policies and programs to increase employment and achieve economic development at national and international level. It has brought about a rapid change in the educational scenario of India. Commercialisation also encourages the individual and society to establish schools, colleges and private universities to meet the growing demand for education. As a result, private educational institutions are growing day by day throughout the country. Education, by its very nature is a transformative process, namely changing human persons, and through them, society and its structures. This activity of transformation is a spiritual, humanizing and liberating activity and constitutes the core mission of education. The world of knowledge that is emerging, 'quality education' serves as the gateway to the socio-cultural and economic development of the country. It is desirable that all educational institutions as

well as educationalists make a pledge that imparting knowledge is a mission rather than a profession.

Keywords: education, commercialisation, decommercialisation, consumerism, school, college, university, *gurukula*, National Education Policy.

Introduction

We live in a world of commercialisation and consumerism wherein everything has a price tag. Today more than ever the commercialisation of education has been a trend all over the world. Since the last three decades or so, due to the educational reforms in the country, India has become the breeding ground of this trend. One can notice mushrooming of private schools, colleges and universities. Higher educational institutions as well as professional colleges are set up in view of profit maximization. As a result, there has been a paradigm shift in the traditional concept of education. India has a rich tradition of imparting knowledge in order to illumine the human mind. The present paper makes an investigation into the positive and negative impact of commercialisation of education in India.

1. The Meaning and Purpose of Education

The word 'education' is derived from the Latin word *educare*, which means 'to bring up'. There is yet another Latin word namely, *educere* which means to bring forth. Education, therefore, means both to bring forth as well as bring up. It was Marcus Terentius Varro, a Latin writer who said: "*Educit obstetrix, educat nutrix, instituit paedagogus, docet magister*," that is, "the midwife brings forth, the nurse brings up, the tutor trains, and the master teaches."[1] According to V. R. Taneja, to educate means "to lead forth" or "to extract out" the best in humans. Thus, the word education means to draw out all that is best in a person including the development of one's habits, attitudes and skills which help a person to lead a full and meaningful life.[2]

The Sanskrit word that stands for education is '*vidya'*. *Ya* means that which and *vid* means light. So, that which gives light is *vidya*. The saying goes, '*Sā vidya yā vimukti,*' that is *vidya*, which liberates one from ignorance. *Vidya* is that process which makes us aware of the bondage we are in, and the suffering we live through and the darkness within. Upanishad exhorts us *'uttiṣṭata jāgrata, prāpya varānnibodhita'* (Kaṭhopaniṣad 1.3.24), arise, awake, approach the wise and learned. Thus, one can say that true education is illumination as revealed in the word '*vidya.*'[3]

1 Gisbert Pascual, *Fundamentals of Sociology* (Bombay: Orient Longmas, 1967), 210.

2 V. R. Taneja, *Educational Thought and Practice*, Sixth edition (New Delhi: Sterling Publishers, 1983), 3-4.

3 Madhu Kapani, *Education in Human Values* (New Delhi: Sterling Publishers, 2000), 44.

Vidya is of two types. The first one is worldly education, which teaches skills and various disciplines and imparts knowledge and information useful for earning one's livelihood and attaining and maintaining some standard of living. The second type is moral and spiritual education, which imparts equanimity, tolerance, self-control, gratitude, devotion to God and dedication to the realization of the reality. Thus, true education is that which can show the transcendental truth, which can give meaning of creation and life on earth.[4]

Regarding the definition of education, there seems to be no consensus among the authors. The term can be understood in a literal as well as philosophical sense. In the literal sense we can define education as "a discipline that is concerned mainly with methods of teaching and learning in schools or school like environments as opposed to various informal means of socialization."[5] However for Mahatma Gandhi, "education is an all-round drawing out of the best in the child and man – body, mind and Spirit."[6] Rabindranath Tagore understands it as "all-round growth and development of the individual in harmony with the universal, the supreme person who has in himself the various levels of consciousness and experiences corresponding to man's physical self, life, mind and soul."[7] John Dewey's vision of education is the affirmed in the following words:

> I believe that all education proceeds by the participation of the individual in the social consciousness of the race. This process begins unconsciously almost at birth, and is continually shaping the individual's powers, saturating his consciousness, forming his habits, training his ideas, and arousing his feelings and emotions. Through this unconscious education the individual gradually comes to share in the intellectual and moral resources which humanity has succeeded in getting together. He becomes an inheritor of the funded capital of civilization. The most formal and technical education in the world cannot safely depart from this general process. It can only organize it; or differentiate it in some particular direction.[8]

New Catholic Encyclopedia defines education "as the aggregate of all those experiences that enlighten the mind, increase knowledge, foster insight, develop abilities and attitudes and strengthen the will. It also focuses to attain

4 Madhu Kapani, *Education in Human Values*, 45.

5 Robert P. Gwinn, *The New Encyclopedia Britannica* vol. 4, (Chicago, 1991), 372.

6 As Quoted in Madhu Kapani, *Education in Human Values*, 22.

7 Madhu Kapani, *Education in Human Values*, 22.

8 As quoted in Philip W. Jackson, *What is Education?* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012), 73.

social competence and optimum personal development."[9] In the vision of Betrand Russel education should generate intellectual, spiritual, moral, ethical and social values in the heart of the person. As he states, "It [education] must foster and promote the precious wealth of moral strength and spiritual victory. Mere mastery of books does not entitle a man to be known as 'educated.' Without the mastery of the inner instrument of emotion no man can be deemed to be educated."[10]

Following Tagore's vision of education, Susmita Mitra writes, "The ultimate purpose of education, according to Tagore, is not to teach us how to make a living but how to live, i.e., 'learning throughout life'; based on the four pillars of learning—learning to know, learning to do, learning to be, and learning to live together."[11] According to the National Education Policy 2020, "Education is fundamental for achieving full human potential, developing an equitable and just society, and promoting national development."[12]

From the above definitions we come to the conclusion that education implies an integral formation of the human person involving an all-round personal growth and maturity which enables him to play his role in the community, society, nation and the world at large.

Now, let us consider the purpose of education. "Helping to develop virtue and build character have been central aims of education since the time of Plato and Aristotle. After years of neglect, universities everywhere have rediscovered the need to prepare their students to grapple with the moral dilemmas they will face in their personal and professional lives."[13]

According to Jiddu Krishnamurti, the purpose of education is to have 'Self-knowledge.' He writes:

> Education should not encourage the individual to conform to society or to be negatively harmonious with it, but help him to discover the true values which come with unbiased investigation and self-awareness. when there is no self-knowledge, self-expression becomes self-assertion, with all its aggressive and ambitious conflicts. Education should awaken the capacity to be self-aware and not merely indulge in gratifying self-expression.[14]

9 William J. McDonald (ed.), *New Catholic Encyclopedia* vol. 5 (Washington: Catholic University of America, 1981), 111.

10 Bertrand Russel, *Education and Social Order* (Boston: London Unwin Paperbacks, 1977), 9.

11 Susmita Mitra, "Tagore's Vision of Education and Its Relevance Today," in Muchkund Dubey and Susmita Mitra (eds.), *Vision of Education in India* (Routledge, 2020), 33. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003124306.

12 National Education Policy 2020, 3. https://www.education.gov.in/sites/uploadfiles/mhrd/files/NEP_Final_E nglish_0.pdf.

13 Derek Bok, *Universities in the Marketplace: The Commercialization of Higher Education* (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 2003), 109.

Elsewhere, Krishnamurti brings out this idea in more persuasive manner. He states:

> Self-knowledge alone can bring tranquility and happiness to man, for self-knowledge is the beginning of intelligence and integration. Intelligence is not mere superficial adjustment; it is not the cultivation of the mind, the acquisition of knowledge. Intelligence is the capacity to understand the ways of life, it is the perception of right values.[15]

Thus, for Krishnamurti the purpose of education is "not to produce mere scholars, technicians, and job hunters, but integrated men and women who are free of fear: for only between such human beings can there be enduring peace."[16]

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights states that "all human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights," and that "education shall be directed to the full development of the human personality and to the strengthening of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. Many of the deepest problems in current systems of education result from losing sight of this basic principle."[17]

Education should enable one to have a critical thinking. Speaking on the importance of critical thinking in education Malcolm D. Evans gives two reasons. The first one is personal and individual, the other societal. Following Whitehead's position, he says "individual human beings as having a three-fold urge: (i) to live, (ii) to live well, (iii) to live better... As individuals, who indeed have this urge, do not live isolated lives but live in community."[18] Further he says: "To construct and maintain civilization built on the first notion requires that persons possess not only the skills to live well personally but also the ability to cope, manage, and direct events in a rapidly changing society."[19] Formerly, society has been based on nationhood, civic participation, community, and a sense of the common good. However, today

14 J. Krishnamurti, *Education and the Significance of Life* (Madras: Krishnamurti Foundation in India, 1994), 15.

15 J. Krishnamurti, *Education and the Significance of Life*, 64.

16 J. Krishnamurti, *Education and the Significance of Life*, 15.

17 https://www.edutopia.org/article/what-education/ accessed on 5 July 2023.

18 Malcolm D. Evans, "Reason: A Gift to be Nurtured," in George Allan and Malcolm D. Evans (eds.), *A Different Three Rs for Education: Reason, Relationality, Rhythm* (Amsterdam, VIBS, 2006), 161.

19 Malcolm D. Evans, "Reason: A Gift to be Nurtured," 161.

there is a frame of reference of economic materialism, market capitalism, military power, and individualism has arisen bringing with it fateful changes at both a personal and a societal level. The skills, attitudes, and behaviours needed by students, communities, and the nation are confronted with issues of war, peace, security, terrorism, environment, governance, and family.[20]

The National Education Policy 2020 underlines the purpose of education thus: "The aim of education in ancient India was not just the acquisition of knowledge as preparation for life in this world, or life beyond schooling, but for the complete realization and liberation of the self."[21] It also reminds us of the rich heritage of the ancient Indian education system in the following words.

> World-class institutions of ancient India such as Takshashila, Nalanda, Vikramshila, Vallabhi, set the highest standards of multidisciplinary teaching and research and hosted scholars and students from across backgrounds and countries. The Indian education system produced great scholars such as Charaka, Susruta, Aryabhata, Varahamihira, Bhaskaracharya, Brahmagupta, Chanakya, Chakrapani Datta, Madhva, Panini, Patanjali, Nagarjuna, Gautama, Pingala, Sankardev, Maitreyi, Gargi and Thiruvalluvar, among numerous others, who made seminal contributions to world knowledge in diverse fields such as mathematics, astronomy, metallurgy, medical science and surgery, civil engineering, architecture, shipbuilding and navigation, yoga, fine arts, chess, and more. Indian culture and philosophy have had a strong influence on the world. These rich legacies to world heritage must not only be nurtured and preserved for posterity but also researched, enhanced, and put to new uses through our education system.[22]

2. Commercialisation of Education

Commercialisation of Education is defined as a process of private ownership and management of educational institutions whereby investments are made with the motive of earning profits.[23] It is a process by which a service is introduced into the general market. It is also a tendency which gives emphasis

20 Malcolm D. Evans, "Reason: A Gift to be Nurtured," 161.

21 National Education Policy 2020, 4.

22 National Education Policy 2020, 4.

23 Christiana N. Nwadiokwu, "Commercialization of Educational System in a Dwindling Economy: Positive and Negative Impact," *Journal of Resourcefulness and Distinction*, 16, no.1 (November, 2018): 113.

to make education profitable as well as business oriented.[24] According to Subhadeep Dutta, "During the last two decades, universities world-wide have come under increasing pressure to adapt to rapidly changing social, technological, economic and political forces emanating from the immediate, as well as from the broader postindustrial external environment."[25]

It is also said that the "corporate models of education in which students are viewed as 'customers' are not appropriate…Universities are absolutely essential in contemporary society as centers of free inquiry, free expression, open discovery and dissent. Any attempt to force education into a corporatist mold devalues faculty, lowers academic standards, and harms both students and the institution itself."[26]

There are various reasons for the commercialisation of education in India. In the words of Anusha Misra, "The basic reason for the commercialization of education is measured by the amount of money invested in education. India faces a high level of competition in the education sector on a global level. Thus, schools have adopted the strategy of increasing fees to gain popularity."[27] Another reason she observes is that there is a steep rise in the number of private educational institutions with the increase in population. The large number of students in the secondary education is drastically increasing every year which leads to a good opportunity for educational institutions to make more profit.[28]

3. Commercialisation of Education: Positive Impact[29]

3.1. Employment Availability

Most of the private educational institutions in India offer job-oriented courses that attract many students to join for the professional courses. The General Agreement on Trade in Services (GATS) provide students with the possibilities to do their studies in foreign educational institutions.[30] Thus, the

24 Christiana N. Nwadiokwu, "Commercialization of Educational System," 113.

25 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India: A Close Outlook to Teachers' and Students' Perspective," *International Journal of Research* 5 (2018): 782.

26 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India," 783-784.

27 Anusha Misra, "Commercialization of Education in India," https://blog.ipleaders.in/commercialization-education-india/ accessed on 8 July 2023.

28 Anusha Misra, "Commercialization of education in India," https://blog.ipleaders.in/commercialization-education-india/.

29 For this section I am indebted to Anusha Misra, "Commercialization of education in India," https://blog.ipleaders.in/commercialization-education-india.

30 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India," p. 784. See also Christiana N. Nwadiokwu, "Commercialization of Educational System," 113. In the recent issue of *India Today* magazine carried a cover story on the exodus of Indian students going to international educational institutions. See Shelly Anand, "The New Exodus: Record

commercialisation of education can tackle the problem of unemployment in the country to a great extent.

3.2. Economic Progress

Due to the commercialisation of education the literacy rate has gone high and consequently there is a marked economic development. Added to that commercialisation also improves the gross domestic product of the country. A number of products are exported to the foreign countries. Hence, the commercialisation of education contributes to the economic development of a country.[31]

3.3. Ability to Overcome Global Challenges

The commercialisation of education helps students to face global challenges such as modernization, industrialization, privatization, globalization, information and communication technology, the emergence of international knowledge networks, etc.[32] In this context, it is a fact that the education system has transformed its structures and curriculum to meet the new global challenges.[33] Harry Anthony Patrinos observes, that "the market in education can lead to important improvements in school quality by encouraging innovation and promoting efficiency."[34]

3.4. Personality Development

"Education is the process of developing the person's underlying ability and its personality."[35] The commercialisation of education fosters the personality development of students. In the school syllabus, subject like moral science, soft skills, physical health, facing interviews and competitive examinations, social skills, etc. are included. This would be helpful for students in their entire life.

numbers of Indian students are heading to International Universities," *India Today* (July 17, 2023): 34-45. According to Aroon Purie, "Flexible curriculums, tremendous research opportunities, worldclass faculty and facilities… a wealth of reasons is fueling the new exodus of Indian students to foreign shores." Quoting Dinesh Singh, the former vice chancellor of Delhi University and the current chancellor of KR Mangalam University in Gurugram "The universities and education abroad let students express themselves, be critical, offer useful and practical knowledge." *India Today* (July 17, 2023): 7.

31 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India," 784, Christiana N. Nwadiokwu, "Commercialization of Educational System," 114.

32 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India," 784-85.

33 Christiana N. Nwadiokwu, "Commercialization of Educational System," 114.

34 Harry Anthony Patrinos, "Market Forces in Education," *European Journal of Education* 35 (March 2000): 76.

35 Hemlata, K. L. Sharma, "Commercialization of Education," *International Journal of Recent Technology and Engineering* (IJRTE) 8 (May 2019): 1266.

3.5. Development of Society

The commercialisation of education leads to social development. For the development of a country, social development is very necessary. In educational institutions, students are conferred with skills that inevitably lead to their social development. Through education, students develop social skills. Thus, the commercialisation of education helps in social development and provides education based on the needs of society.

3.6. Improvement in the Quality of Education

The commercialisation of education gives emphasis on quality education. The concept of quality education is broader term which indicates the quality of the learner, quality of the learning environment, quality of content, quality of process and quality of outcomes. The commercialisation of education makes every effort to provide quality education to the students and also offer more demanding courses in the modern society. Generally, all parents want that their children take the quality education which help them in their future life as well as in the development of society. A person who gets good education will become a more dependable worker, better citizen and strong consumer. The private educational institutions provide good learning environment, good infrastructure facility, good teachers etc.

3.7. Development of Professional Efficiency of Teachers and Students

The commercialisation of education helps to give attention to the development of professional efficiency of teachers. Private institutions have highly qualified teachers who are allowed to develop their professional efficiency through seminars, workshops, study circles, conferences, etc. The commercialisation of education also emphasises very much on the professional as well as vocational development of the students. The advertisement made by the school and colleges such as coaching, diploma degree, vocational training, various professional and skill development courses, etc., help the student to get a background about these courses, and provide opportunities to develop their academic career.

4. Commercialisation of Education: Negative Impact

Today, more than ever, "the world economy is experiencing an unprecedented change. New developments in science and technology, competition, media revolution and internationalisation are revolutionising the education sector. We are witnessing paradigm shift in higher education, from 'national' to 'global education,' from 'state controlled' to an 'open market economy,' from 'general education' to an 'educational system driven by market forces. These changes in the form of market forces make new demands and pose fresh

challenges to our established education systems and practices. The impact of market forces on the development of India's higher education system has risen substantially since the country began opening up its economy in 1991. Indian higher education is confronted by a dilemma. Many individuals argue that the application of market forces to higher education is inappropriate because higher education is a "public good". While there are others who say that university education is a "non-merit good", not necessary for everybody, and that it is best left to the market forces."[36] "The impact of market forces on the development of India's higher education system has risen substantially since the country began opening up its economy in 1991."[37]

According to Derek Bok,

> Commercialization can undermine collegiality and trust within academic communities by creating divisions and tensions that did not previously exist. Professors who work hard at their traditional academic tasks will resent the extra income earned by colleagues who start a new business or spend a lot of time consulting. Humanists will feel devalued. Conflicts will arise between faculty and administration over the proper division of patent royalties or the management of a business founded by a professor but partly funded by the university. Graduate students may accuse their supervisor of taking their ideas to benefit a company in which the professor has an interest. Scientists may bridle at the secrecy imposed by a colleague in their department who is funded by a corporation.[38]

The following are some of the disadvantages of commercialisation of education:

4.1. Profit Maximization

Today we find that there is a corporate culture in education. As Syed Tanveer Ahmed rightly observes, "Almost 99% of all preschools opened during the last five years are purely commercial ventures. Many educationists have described them as 'education shops.'"[39] It is observed that 'education' is no more imparting knowledge or making a child learn rather it has transformed into a business and more or less every institute charges a vast amount in return

36 Randeep Kaur, "Higher Education and Market Forces in India," *International Journal of Business Management* 2 (2015): 1471.

37 Randeep Kaur, "Higher education and Market Forces in India," 1471.

38 Derek Bok, *Universities in the Marketplace,* 113.

39 https://indiatomorrow.net/2022/09/27/the-commercialization-of-education-and-its-ill-effects-on-indian-society, accessed 12 June 2023.

of the amenities they give. Thus, the commercialisation of education focuses only on the profit-making ability of the education sector. It transforms the education sector into a business. One can notice that many big brands are entering the vast market of education. In the preschool sector, big corporate houses have launched their brands. Very soon, the market will be flooded with private schools. Corporate houses are entering the education market as it is considered the second biggest in market size after the health sector. Therefore, if any government or society looks at education as a commodity or a market, then that society will not progress.[40] According to Stephen J. Ball,

> The education market is no longer simply a matter of choice and competition between educational institutions. The education market is a diffuse, expanding, and sophisticated system of goods, services, experiences and routes – publicly and privately provided. For many parents, educational opportunities are sought for their children through a made-up mix of state and/or private institutions, and paid-for add-ons, like educational toys, parental tasks, tutoring, commercial activities and sources of information and advice (School and Higher Education Guides). Parenting is increasingly serious, demanding and professionalized – and parenting is now widely taught.[41]

In the words of Derek Bok,

> Commercialization has also taken a toll on the quality of education. Many institutions, seeking to profit from their correspondence schools and extension divisions, have followed academic policies of a kind they would never allow in their regular degree programs. They have granted little or no financial aid, while keeping faculty compensation well below the normal scale for the rest of the university. As a result, access to these programs has suffered, along with the quality of instruction.[42]

Finally, it is observed that "profit-seeking can threaten the university's obligation to give the best possible teaching to its students."[43]

40 Syed Tanveer Ahmed, "The Commercialization of Education and its Ill Effects on Indian Society," in *India Tomorrow* (September 27, 2022), https://indiatomorrow.net/2022/09/27/the-commercialization-of-education-and-its-ill-effects-on-indian-society, accessed 12 June 2023.

41 Stephen J. Ball, "Education For Sale! The Commodification of Everything?" www.researchgate.net/publication/267683502, accessed 12 June 2023.

42 Derek Bok, *Universities in the Marketplace,* 202.

43 Derek Bok, *Universities in the Marketplace,* 179.

4.2. More Emphasis on Academic Activities

The commercialisation of education leads to more emphasis on academic/ intellectual activities rather than focus on the all-round development of students. They are forced to focus solely on scoring more marks. The extra-curricular and co-curricular activities are given due importance.

4.3. Inequality and Discrimination

The commercialisation of education fails to keep up with the rule of equality. The phenomenon of commercialisation is deepening and strengthening the class and caste system. It also results in the ghettoization of students. This is particularly visible in the minority community. It is risky in the long run as ghettoization will inhibit and create hurdles to making an equitable and just society.[44] The increasing fee structure in the schools prevent the poor and weaker section of society to acquire quality education.[45]

4.4. High Expenditure

The impact of the commercialisation of education makes education very expensive. In many private institutions, the fees are very high making it very inaccessible. They have several types of fees – admission fees, monthly fees, development fees, semester fees, etc. It becomes impossible to poor people to send their children to this type of institution. Further, the institutions demand a lot of donations during the admission time. From the commercialisation point of view, students are looked as the consumer, education as the thing or commodity and the educational institutions as the shop or the consumer outlet.[46] Hemlata and K.L. Sharma confirm this aspect followingly,

> Getting good education has become a dream for the common and middle-class family. The point of view is that without money is not possible and non-education is impossible, quality education has become a joke in a crowd of money. As a result, good education can be attained with someone who has wealth. It is not possible for ordinary and middle-class families to get good education. About 70% of India's people come from the middle class. In such a situation, if education cannot be attained, then perhaps the foundation of Indian economy can be weakened.[47]

44 Syed Tanveer Ahmed, "The Commercialization of Education."

45 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India," 786.

46 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India," 787.

47 Hemlata, K. L. Sharma, "Commercialization of Education," 1266.

4.5. Materialistic Outlook

The commercialisation of education has resulted in students developing a materialistic and consumeristic outlook. Students only think of themselves and not for the development of their region, society and the nation. They want to spend on luxurious life. The commercialisation of education also makes students self-centred. Thus, students tend to develop a selfish attitude rather than focusing on the development of the country. Students become more insensitive to their duties and not becoming dedicated and committed citizens of the nation.[48]

5. Towards a Decommercialisation of Education

5.1. Education as a Mission Rather than a Profession

Ancient understanding of education was under the notion of *guru-śiṣya* learning through experience and expertise. There was profound devotion and reverence in the learning process. However, today education is understood or rather misunderstood as a profession rather than mission. Profession leads one to do something to earn some material or financial gain.[49] Therefore, we can compare it as "*duty for duty's sake*" which refers to an undedicated and unwilling to do hard work in teaching–learning process. Whereas, mission becomes a complete, dedicated and committed service. All India Catholic Education policy aims at recreating human lives, communities and wider society. It earnestly urges the educational institutions to work unitedly to build up a better future for our country.[50]

Education, by its very nature is a transformative process, namely changing human persons, and through them, society and its structures. This activity of transformation is a spiritual, humanizing and liberating activity and constitutes the core mission of education. In the knowledge society that is emerging, 'quality education' serves as the gateway to the socio-culture and economic development of the country. Thus, education enables one to become responsible and accountable person.

5.2. Education as a Powerful Means of Social Transformation

Nelson Mandela once said, "Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world." Over the centuries, leaders, thinkers and

48 Subhadeep Dutta, "Commercialization of Education System in India," 787.

49 Here I do not undermine the need to be professionals or having professionalism. By all means all teachers who impart knowledge should conduct themselves with responsibility, integrity, accountability, and excellence. They should be more productive and have the willingness to learn new things every day.

50 See *All India Catholic Education Policy 2007.*

revolutionaries around the globe have believed in the power of education to catalyse social change.

Decommercialisation aims at achieving the following:

- An education of quality and relevance to all, and in particular, to the marginalized section of society is the need of the hour. An education that frees persons from social conditioning (such as caste, class, gender and other culture-linked prejudices) and prevents them from living as persons in bondage.
- An education that leads the young into the sacred space of every person, making them aware of the inalienable human rights of every individual and group. A value-based education helps to foster pluralism, cultural and religious diversity, individual and collective freedom and respect for an appreciation of differences even in the face of a globalized world that aggressively pushes towards economic and cultural uniformity.
- An education that humanizes and contextualizes, by assisting the students to raise essential questions concerning the meaning of life and their role in society, enabling them to become conscious of their responsibility to contribute to evolving a borderless society and to promote the common good.
- An education that enables the youth to understand the implication of economic policies and structure, political decisions and the media that plays a critical role in shaping people's life especially those of the poor, marginalized and less fortunate ones in society.

Conclusion

Commercialisation adversely affects the education sector, society, and the economic development of India. However, without commercialisation, education can't occur. Schooling is to draw out the potential in a student furnishing them with the most suitable physical and social climate to assist them with understanding their fullest potential. Then again, education is an industry and its commercialisation or privatisation is growing day by day in India. Eventually, we can say that for these individuals schooling has today become a choice to bring in cash rather than giving quality education to all people irrespective of caste, creed, gender and region. All educational institutions and educationalists should pledge that imparting knowledge is a mission rather than a profession.

16

Teaching to Transgress
A Pedagogical Imperative

Victor Ferrao

Abstract: We are living at a time when our experience of time has changed. This is because we have moved from literacy to a post-literacy world. During the oral stage, our experience of time was cyclic and our past was privileged. During the literacy stage time was linear and future was paramount. Today time has broadened and we are multi-tasking and are submerged into an endless now. This change has occurred because a fast-paced world of internet. This changed scenario has accelerated us and we have no time to offer a reflective as well as critical response. It has also affected our educational scene. We have entered what is called electracy. This study attempts to manifest the imperative that this changed condition has for our educational scenario It posits that we have the challenge to teach to transgress so as to enable our students to resists several of the allurements and attunements of electracy.

Keywords: Electracy, grammatology, pedagogy, discourse, digitization, logic of opposition, logic of juxtaposition.

Introduction

Ivan Illich's, *Deschooling Society*,[1] Paulo Friere's *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*,[2] Bell Hooks, *Teaching to Transgress*[3] have enabled us to problematize the teaching and learning practices of our education system. These critical writings have challenged us to view how practices that are employed in our educational system are often dehumanising, silencing and domesticating practices. Hooks takes us to a terrain that imagines education as the liberatory practice of freedom. While we critically examine our teaching/learning practices,[4] we have the obligation to factor in the context of education which is rapidly changing with the growing digitization and phigitalization[5] of the internet of things. Gregory Ulmer indicates that we have moved from the world of literacy to the world of electracy.[6] Electracy is to digital media and matches what alphabets were to literacy. Alphabetic writing is an apparatus (partly technological partly institutional) that was the matrix that embedded literacy. Hence, in this study, we critically examine our changed condition, especially the growing digitalization of our society. Our Education has the challenge to bridge the digital divide. This will require us to transgress or contest our teaching and learning practices that we have employed so far. The changing context of education, as well as our society under digitalization, cannot be simply addressed through media studies but nevertheless have to be addressed to understand the transformations that it has introduced in our ways of being in the world. We do have the imperative to reimagine new practices that are required for the world of electracy. Electracy is impacting our lives profoundly. We have to be attentive to the broader cultural, institutional, pedagogical and ideological implications inherent in the transition from the culture of print literacy to a culture saturated with digitalization and electronic media. Roland Barthes taught us about the transgressive power of punctum that punctuate the photograph and lead us to interrogate it.[7] Electracy needs this transgressive logic of punctum to assist us to respond to the worlds of electracy. This paper tries to examine how education can empower us to participate in as well as contest the worlds of electracy.

1 Ivan Illich, *Deschooling Society* (Harmondsworth UK: Penguin, 1973).

2 Paulo Frierre, *Peddagogy of the Opressed* (New York: Continuum, 2005).

3 Bell Hooks, *Teaching to Trangress: Education as a Pracitce of Freedom* (New York: Routledge, 1994).

4 Disciplinary practices.

5 Victor Ferrao, *Being Human in a World of Artificial Intelligence: Quest for Fusions of Sangam* (New Delhi: Written Words, 2020), 34-35.

6 Jeff Rice and Marcel O'Gorman (eds.), *New Media/New Methods: The Academic Turn from Literacy to Electracy* (Indiana: Parlor Press, 2008), 6.

7 Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida* (New York: Hill and Wang, 1981), 25-26.

The Imperative of Electracy

We have moved from orality to literacy and now from literacy to electracy. Literacy emerged out of orality on the wings of alphabetic writing with its operating metaphysics that took us from the world of Religion and Mythology to the world of science. Ulmer points out that the nineteenth-century vanguard artist of the bohemian cabaret scene in Paris is the electrate 'Presocratics' who created Dadaism as a logic of software (Ulmer, electracy , 2018). If the identity of the individual self and democracy was invented by literacy, we find that these are commoditized by the social media supported by electracy. Electracy does not replace the institutions of orality and literacy but supplements and displaces them with a new order in every dimension. Ulmer succinctly states, "The "Plato" of electracy is Walt Disney–Theme Park is our School, Mickey Mouse our Socrates, Animation our Dialogue, Caricature our Categories–augmenting visceral experience."[8]

With the rise of electracy, we can see the change in the experience of time. We are trapped in the present moment today. Orality was cyclic and literacy was a linear experience of time. It seems that in a high-speed world of electracy, we are accelerated and have no time for critical thinking or even persuasion through the exchange of ideas and arguments. We as individuals as well as communities are subjected to a bias that intuitive Malcolm Gladwell calls 'blink.'[9] 'Blink' appears to take us into the realm of prudence or phronesis. We can say that there is a shift in the episteme of our knowledge and being in the world. Hence, Ulmer invites us to move to grammatology as a pedagogy to understand the changing context of our life and being in the world and discern its impacts education.

Grammatology introduces new knowledge practices that occur on the internet and the world of digital media. Thus, we have the challenge to unthink the exteriority of writing to speech and speech to thought. We have to overcome the positivist, instrumentalist and technicists view of grammatology. This means we have to overcome or deconstruct the logocentrism of writing/grammatology. Logocentrism of grammatology is connected to the phonetization of writing. Writing when freed from its phonetic cage[10] will open us to non-phonetic writings. This will enable us to apply grammatology to our digital world. Everything in the digital world remains digitized. We can see it as silent writing. Think of musical notes. They remain in what we call silent writing until we sing or play them with a musical instrument. Now the writings on the web are also silent writings. It can become oral, visual, phonetic, and

8 Roland Barthes, *Camera Lucida,* 25-26.

9 Malcolm Gladwell, *Blink: the Power of Thinking Without Thinking* (NY: Little, Brown and Co., 2005).

10 Phonetic-alphabets.

ideo-graphic when we open the web. This means the silent writings on the web are not subjected to the linearity of alphabetic writings. They are more horizontal and rhizomatic. Therefore, it is not so much logic of succession but opens itself to the logic of juxtaposition that controls them.

The logic of juxtaposition opens the logocentric closures. The logic of linearity is a logic of succession and is itself a logic of opposition. We oppose one thing with the other. It is dialectical. This takes us to what we may say is the science of grammatics. It enables us to read different forms of writing/grapheme. Applied grammatology cannot be simply opposed to science. Grammatology inscribes and delimits Science. Science itself is a form of writing/grapheme. Within the linear thinking of literacy, we can see how what we consider something as knowledge passes from prescience to science and becomes invested and accepted as truth. Hence, we have the challenge not just to divest the phonetic strains but to strip the picto-and even the ideo-centric strains of knowledge and truth. This means we have to squeeze all logo-centric strains that stain our knowledge and truth.

We have to pass our knowledge through a black hole that will squeeze out the semiotic, logical, temporally positivistic (attached to linearity), essentialist (logocentric) strains or traces that stain our knowledge and truth. This is happening in the world of electracy. We have already become electrate just as we were literate under literacy.[11] This does not simply mean literacy is dead and gone. It only means electracy has displaced it. When we accept the impact of the changing conditions of electracy, we will accept that we have to change our pedagogies of teaching and learning in our educational system. Old pedagogies will no longer assist us to address the new condition that has already affected our life and being in the world. This is why we have the challenge to transgress the old model of teaching and learning. We have to become more and more critical and transgressive to be responsive to the logic of juxtaposition in the world of electracy. This is required because of the sheer acceleration of life that we face today as well as the intimidation that we experience with the changing experience of time. The linearity of our experience of time has given way to horizontalization of time and we are trapped in a broadening of time that keeps us submerged into a now. The broadening of time is chaosmotic.[12] It can bring us to a new horizon. But we can also lose our ways of being human in the world on the wings of the possibilities of multitasking that it offers us. Hence, the new imperative of the educators is what I call teaching to transgress. It will enable us to respond

11 Gregory L. Ulmer, "Electracy: The Internet as the Fifth Estate," *Journal of Pedagogic Development* 8, no. 3 (November 2018): 13-16.

12 F. G. Bians, *Chaosmosis: an Ethico-Aesthetic Paradigm* (Indiana: University Press, 1995).

to information overload as well as the logic of juxtaposition that is invading our lives both as individuals as well as a community.

Facing the Death of the Book[13]

Pessimism and the aesthetics of silence have died in society with the advent of electracy. With the arrival of electracy, our culture is showing signs of shifting from a paradigm based on language (literacy) to one based on silent writing. We have already moved towards non-phonetic writings (other writings). The resurgence of the graphic element on the web has led to the decline of the domination of the spoken word (phonocentrism). Everything on the internet whether pictographic or ideographic inscription is silent writing. These developments are significantly far away from the order of the voice. This means literacy has received a death blow with the development of electracy. Maybe drawing on the analogy of music, we can say that everything is becoming a system of notations waiting to be deciphered or played into the cacophony of meanings. Better still maybe, we may say that everything has become an App that opens us to the dance of meaning and non-meaning and thus instigates us to act. The fact that we can find pacing and trace that are graphic elements, we are still not fully free from logocentrism. All the same, logocentrism is loosened, deconstructed and displaced by grammatology.

What is more important besides being a mode of signification (meaning and non-meaning), it is a source of instigation often leading to mindless action (think of mob lynching on the basis of WhatsApp). Electracy raises the question of energetics as it seems to apply non-cognitive force and keeps us drown into the aesthetics of the spectacular. The spectacular is non-discursive and stays beyond reason attached to the world of senses. The reason is deconstructed/castrated and displaced. Hence, we may name it transreason. It instigates us into action or inaction. This manifests that we are shifting to a new ontology that is outside the founding concepts-words of ontology. It is closer to the Heideggerian being of being. We may at best describe it as the dance of being. This indicates that the Book is dead. The web has already done its funeral. What we have is simply the dance of trace. The dance of trace slips in several ways in the web and generates unforeseen meaning that takes control over us. This is why we have the huge challenge to let our education system which is already inundated by the dance of trace enable us to resist or transgress the allurements of the dance of trace. Maybe we need to develop psychoanalysis of graphology (trace-ology) taking inspiration from Melanie Klein's essay

13 Gregory L. Ulmer, *Applied Grammatology: Post(e)-Pedagogy from Jacques Derrida to Joseph Beuys* (Baltimore, London: John Hopkins University Press, 1985).

'The role of the school in the libidinal development of a child.'[14] This rings in the challenge to empower us to discern how the other writing (silent writing) operates as knowledge without being theoretical.

We are already deschooled by the dance of trace (other writings). With the end of linear writings (post-literacy), we have not reached a closure of all writings but have opened ourselves to all other forms of writing. The web has opened us to the forms of writing that largely appeal to our aesthetic sense. This means writing now has opened and not closed itself only to phonetic writing like literacy. Writing has indefinitely no end. Moreover, we are now into the dance of trace that controls or shapes our libidinal investments. This is why our school cannot merely be one that enhances our cognitive abilities but one that enables us to resist, circumvent and transgress rather than circum to the allurements and attunements of the dance of trace in the web. Our education system has to come to terms with our break with the investiture of the Book. This is urgent because the word that was the matrix of literacy is now displaced by image which is ruled by associative logic (the logic of juxtaposition). If literacy mainly influenced our mind, electracy influences our body. Here what is at stake is not just the meaning of the image but the power of the image. Maybe we have some kind of unconcealment of the dynamism of the image in the dance of the trace. To get into the constellated dance of trace, we have to view grammatology as a pedagogy. Grammatology as a pedagogy will manifest to us how we inscribe signification without saying or using words. It opens the world of other writings.

Grammatology as a Pedagogy

The non-phonetic moment in writing challenges the metaphysic of the proper (self-possession). It is chiefly concerned with speaking pictures. We are still into logocentrism as we are into philophemes of sight and voices. This realization is in indeed important because what we call Big Data Analytics desemiotizes, squeezes, and hollows out speaking pictures and converts them as figures of numbers which are then resemiotized producing intimate knowledge of each of us who have our presence in the social network sites.[15] This is why education has to equip us to resist and teach us to transgress the invasion of big data analytics into the intimacy of our life. This means grammatology as a pedagogy opens us to these speaking pictures (new alphabets) and numeric figures of information (big data analytics) and thus

14 Melanie Klein, "The Role of the School in the Libidal Develoment of a child," *International Journal of Pschoanalysis* 5 (January 1924): 312-331.

15 Victor Ferrao, *Being Human in a World of Artificial Intelligence: Quest for Fusions of Sangam* (New Delhi: Written Words, 2020).

enable us to decipher other forms of writings that dominates the world of electracy.

This attention to the dephonetization, depictographication and figurative or number graphification is important to understand how information Data Analytics is used to allure and enslave us. In this, grammatology as a pedagogy deconstructs phonetic writings, picto-ideogahic writings, picto-graphic as well as number-graphic writings. This squeezes out of all shades of logocentric traces from our writings. This means we deconstruct both semiotic and asemantic forms of writing and we are launched from the hermeneutic, semiotic forms of writing to dramatic modes of writings. We have to critically examine the critical dramatic or the performance aspect of the non-phonetic writings in the web. The dramatic writings examine the performative aspects of non-phonetic and non-discursive shades of meanings.

With the sphere of dramatic modes of writing, we have the challenge to think fetish. It works as substitute or displacement on which we invest emotive energy and think that it is directed to the real. Fetishizing is not merely a pictogram, it is an emotive form of writing. In this context, we have to consider, what Melanie Kline calls partial object. An infant for instance relates to the feeding breast of the mother by substituting the nipple for her mother. We invest on these partial objects and they too emanate pleasure to us. This is a form of writing and being written. Jacques Lacan posits the role of object petit a as the source of desire. These are forms of writings that produce a return of the gaze. Somehow, they bring about a sense of void/sense of loss and trigger a psycho–dynamism of recovery. These loss-recovery dynamisms are other forms of non-phonetic writings.

We can find several complex ecologies in the internet. They have power over us and often control and organize our ways of being human in the world. They open to us the world of possibilities. They produce in us an imperative to seek fulfillment of our desire. In this context, we can also think of forms of identifications or ego-extensions that are also other forms of writing and being written. These are producing autographies. We are written as we write. All forms of our writings carry our signature. We can call these forms of writings as ecologies of writings because they are complex ways of writing and be written about. This may indicate that there is an eco-logic at work in this kind of complex non-phonetic writings. They can produce de-motivating (signify oneself as insignificant) as well as highly motivating response in us. Grammatology as a pedagogy therefore can open us to the way these ecologies of non-phonetic writings work and produce us.

Electracy being a world of post-literacy requires grammatology as a pedagogy to understand and respond to non-phonetic writings. We need logic of juxtaposition in order to understand and decode the world of electracy. But to respond we need a rebellious logic or transgressive logic that will enable us

to resist the lures of the world of electracy. This does not mean that everything the internet nurtures is bad. What we need is critical approach that will enable us to embrace what is good and right and reject that which is harming our ways of being in the world. Therefore, teaching to transgress means not reproduction of the status quo of the old. It is transgressing the old and working to bring about emancipative transformation and innovation.

If we employ grammatology as a pedagogy, we can bring about innovation and transformation. It will deconstruct the scene of teaching in our educational institutions which has largely become a monologue. The teacher thinks that he/she is the master of knowledge which he can only repeat rather than produce. This means teacher operates from extrinsic location from the scene of education. This eccentricity to scene of education becomes the legitimacy of the magisterial authority of the teacher. Against this traditional topology of education, grammatology proposes to turn the teaching scene into a learning space rather than a teaching space. This means it blurs the boundaries between teachers and students. Thus, grammatology challenges us to de-semiotize or destructuralize the reigning scene of teaching and challenges us to build learning communities and not passive, silenced, consumerist and domesticated communities.

Therefore, what we need is Heideggerian mode of Alethia (revelation) and rather than the reigning Platonic and Aristotelian edaeuquatio (correspondence) to take a hold of the teaching scene. The mode of Alethia gives us a heuristic sense of discovery and is therefore not to be seen as one that which is slowly revealing what we may call a thing in itself. We therefore have the challenge to embrace this new grammatology of the classroom. The challenge therefore boils down to both the teacher and students to produce (autograph) themselves. This rethinking of the scene of teaching/education is actually a rethinking of what Derrida calls spacing. In fact, grammatology as a pedagogy takes us to a shift in the operation of education as a domain of representation (repetition) to the education as a domain of production/ invention. Here the concern is not so much in the production of truth as representation of some fixed essence (logocentrism) but the production of effects. This is an exercise of heterology that avoids the closure at a singularized point or destination. Such a production of truth or knowledge does not closes put stays into what we may call dynamic openness.

The Four Discourses of Lacan

Psychoanalysis is important in the application of grammatology as a pedagogy. Applied Grammatology does not wish to eliminate speech, representation, truth as correspondence and even Science from academic discourse. What it aims at is to put them in their place. It means that it attempts to show that they are not the binary opposite of each other speech

and writing. This raises the question: how are we to talk, lecture or mount a discourse in a grammatical classroom? Lacan did not use grammatology directly but he used a non-magisterial style as a necessary corollary to teach psychoanalysis as a university course. One way of entering the pedagogic significance of the work of Lacan is to investigate the phenomenon of transference and countertransference comparatively, by juxtaposing the patient-analyst relations with student-teacher relations.

This approach is in contrast to Bergson and Piaget's tradition that thinks the student grows in abstraction when the teachers know how to keep himself/ herself out. Lacan on the other hand teaches that student is already an intertwined subject. The four discourses of Lacan become our guiding map or DNA of public space that we constitute and inhabit as human subjects and struggle with each other in that space. The first discourse is the discourse of mastery, where students are often trapped in what is called writer's block. It denies the existence of the other in the apotheosis of the self. It is basically despotic.[16] The second discourse is the discourse of the university where a faceless bureaucracy facilitates the transmission of information. This discourse is basically regulative and disciplinary.[17] The third discourse is the discourse of the hysteric where an individualized student carries out a border-jumping performance of a critic. It, therefore, is a discourse of an obsessive questioner.[18] The fourth discourse is called the discourse of the analyst in which the student discovers the possibilities of connection, potentially ad infinitum.[19] It is a discourse of an ethical listener. This is a reversal of the discourse of the master just like the hysteric discourse was the reversal of the discourse of the university. This discourse brings about the balancing of the self and the other.

We may be able to see the play of all discourse at different levels of orality, literacy and electracy. We may try to identify the dominance of one in each of them. Under the condition of orality, it seems that the dominant discourse is one of the masters. This is why we can only repeat what the master says. The master signifier or the transcendental signified opens as well as restricts the play of the chain of signifiers on the paradigmatic (metaphor) and syntagmatic (metonymy) axis. This play is fully controlled by the master signifier. When it comes to literacy, we may notice that it is the discourse of the university that regulates it. This is why the transcendental signified is disciplinary and accordingly sets the play of the chain of signifiers on the paradigmatic axis and syntagmatic axis. Here one has to follow the line/ discipline to be counted.

16 Slavoj Zizek, "*Jacques Lancan's Four Disourses*," *www.lacan.com* 1997-2006, https://www.lacan.com/ziz four.htm, accessed 30 March 2023.

17 Slavoj Zizek, *Jacques Lancan's Four Disourses*.

18 Slavoj Zizek, *Jacques Lancan's Four Disourses*.

19 Slavoj Zizek, *Jacques Lancan's Four Disourses*.

In the context of electracy, one may find that the discourse of the hysteric sets the play of the chain of signs on the paradigmatic and syntagmatic axis as a performance of interrogation. This play breaks with the master's discourse as well as the discourse of the university and opens a transgressive boundary crossing chain of signifiers.

The question is what does this chain of signifiers do to the subject's desire? in the case of orality, the subject's desire is to become the image and likeness of the master. Under the condition of literacy, the subject's desire is to follow the code laid down by the university and become expert ordered by the laws and institutions of the university. In the case of electracy, the subject desire is thrown open to the dynamic networks of the internet and hence the subject become a hysteric. We have to note that Lacan teaches that desire cannot be fulfilled as a result the drive to become a master, or the expert recognized by the university, even to play the hysteric is always delayed and differed. Therefore, the Challenge is to transgress the discourse of the master, the discourse of the university and that of the hysteric and embrace the discourse of the analyst. But we have to remember that none of these discourses exists in their pure forms. They intermingle and cannot be fully boxed into the role of Master or Hysteric. This means we often switch from masterly, disciplinary or hysteric practices of teaching and learning. This does not mean that these four discourses merge so as to lose their characteristics. But we can of course tell when someone talks like a master, or start talking on behalf of the university or when the discourse of hysteria stops and the voice of reason begins to shine.

In the fast-changing world of electracy, the teacher can no longer play the role of the master and be the sole producer of knowledge. Students have excess to knowledge on the tips of their fingers and cannot be expected to reproduce the voice of their master. Electracy has castrated the discourse of the master. In the discourse of the university, Knowledge and disciplinary competence takes the place of the master. This means the student is disciplined to work in a competent manner. The ecology of electracy dismantles the ecology of the university as well as of the master. The discourse of the university has become a special case in the world of internet-driven electracy. We may agree that electracy is a hysteric world. It hysterises us. It is crazy, utopian and even suicidal. It violates all textual codes of production of knowledge. It breaks the boundaries of discursive limits. It is a world of excess and surplus. We need the sanity of the analyst to sail through the worlds of electracy. Listening is the mainstay of the discourse of the analyst. Listening, therefore, become the pedagogic tool. This is active and opens listening without having the need to prejudge or pre-empt the desires of the students. It is this listening that makes heterogeneous voices comfortable. We have to add a tinge of third discourse that will interrogate the multi-voices that we listen thus transgressively produce

our life and being and create conditions that will enable students to produce their life and being in the world.

Conclusion

The growing electracy has put the last nail on the coffin of a Book. This has displaced literacy. Even the school and the university has come inhabit the world of the internet. We have now have moved from the logic of opposition to the logic of juxtaposition. Hence, we embrace grammatology as a way of understanding and responding to the new world of electracy. This world of electracy takes us in to the third discourse of Lacan. It is challenging us and interrogating our long held firm sacred beliefs about teaching and learning. We need a new pedagogy to respond to this development. We are proposing the fourth discourse combined with the third discourse of Lacan as the best response of pedagogy to address the new world of electracy.

17

Emancipative Education
Neurological Perspectives

Augustine Pamplany, CST

Abstract: The general principles of emancipative education such as, transformation, value orientation, social embeddedness, networking, etc., are significantly informed and complemented by the recent findings from neuroscience. The complementarity of the analytical as well as the synthetic mindset as founded in the left and right hemispheres of the brain challenges the traditional view of the compartmentalized or specialist understanding of what genius is. At the root of the quest for academic interdisciplinarity today is a neurological insight into the holistic role of neural plasticity in facilitating understanding, creativity, and critical thinking. The computer simulation studies of Einstein's brain underscore the integration of knowledge with imagination, and conversely, of nature with nurture. This view is very much substantiated by the traditional Indian philosophical perspectives on education such as the primacy of intuition, proximity between the teacher and the student, the salvific value of knowledge, etc., which are rediscovered by the philosophy of Holistic Education in contemporary times. The Christian appropriation of these fresh cognitive directions will take us to the experiential compulsions of Jesus founded on his God experience and committing him to the emancipation of the socially oppressed. The role of Insight and Functional Specialties in the knowing and discovering process as described by Bernard Lonergan is an anticipation of the implications of cognitive neuroscience for education. In general, this paper argues that an intersection between the

educational neuroscience and the philosophy of emancipatory education carries the potentials for new approaches and pedagogies in promoting the transformative and liberative functions of education.

Keywords: Emancipative Education, Neuroscience, Neural Plasticity, Sociality, Lonergan, Einstein, Holistic Education, Indian View of Education, Abba experience.

1. Introduction

The human brain containing 100 billion neurons is the most complex thing we know of and the super 'machine' ever evolved. Neuroscientific discoveries are already matters of contentious debate among scientists, philosophers, theologians, ethicists and policy makers. The astonishing findings of the different branches of neuroscience have claimed to have mapped even the subjective secrets of human beings. Neuroscience today revisits the traditional debates on the link between mind and the body, the existence of the soul, etc. Neuroscientists also explore the neurological underpinnings of cognitive development. A scientific and philosophical voyage into the territories of neuroscience is very promising for drawing some useful tips for determining the future trajectories of research in emancipative education.

This essay is a hermeneutical exploration of the implications of the cognitive neuroscience for emancipative education. The first part of this paper explores the neurological complementarity of the rational and imaginative forms of knowledge. The second part of the paper argues that the recent neurological understanding of the neural structures involved in sociality, empathy, terrorism, violence, etc., do convey important suggestions for emancipative education. The third and fourth sections of this essay make a brief appropriation of the insights from cognitive neuroscience from the Indian and the Christian perspectives respectively.

2. The Neuroscience of Creativity – Implications for Emancipative Education

Unlike the old understanding of the specialist functioning of the brain through different hemispheres, the present neurology affirms the integral and complementary roles of both hemispheres in most motor, psychological, cognitive, affective and intellectual operations of the humans. Our brain, generally put, is organised into two symmetrical hemispheres, viz., the left and the right. Each of these hemispheres control the functions of the opposite sides of the body. That is to say, right hemisphere controls the functions of the motor organs on the left side of the body and vice versa. Normally, the sense data from the right side of the body is collected in the left hemisphere of the body. Though there are special functional correlates and associations located

in each hemisphere, say for instance, the left hemisphere is mostly the seat of analytical and linguistic operations, there is no scientific evidence implying that any cognitive skill is specific to any one side do the brain.[1]

As per the understanding of neuroscience, what constitutes a genius is not the size of the brain, but the number of connections in the brain. Physiologically, elephants have bigger brain than the humans. However, proportionate to the body size, humans have the largest brain. What makes human brain unique is the number of active connections in the brain. Genius, in terms of neuroscience, is a combined product of both nurture and nature. That is to say, the more the brain is utilized, a greater number of connections are produced in brain and the larger number of connections are what makes a genius. Naively put, the ability of the brain to reorient the connections according to use or non-use is termed as neural plasticity. The old metaphor of brain being conceived as a skeleton which cannot be stretched out has now given way to the new metaphor of skeleton which malleable.

The left hemisphere of the brain is more focused on analytical, mathematical, computational, linguistic and linear kind of mental functions. Whereas the right hemisphere is said to be associated more with the poetic, musical, literary, religious, mystical, imaginative and philosophical kind of operations. It might appear from this division that left hemisphere dominated people will be excelling as scientists and technicians, whereas the right hemispheric person may be more competent as literarists, artists or philosophers. However, this sort of division is only considered as an old-fashioned myth in neuroscience. It is realized today that even in the processing of the single function of vision, about thirty regions of brain spread across the left and right hemispheres are involved.

The case example of Einstein might well establish this point. Going by the conventional understanding, it might appear that Einstein must have had a much-advanced left hemisphere. However, studies of Einstein's brain shows that originally his brain was not anything exceptional. As a child he had poor memory for words and he even failed in the entrance examination to the Zurich Polytechnic Institute. It was the sustained concentration on a single task that caused the generation of more glial cells in Einstein's brain, which may have been responsible for his exceptional genius. The ratio of the glial cells to neurons in certain areas of Einstein's brain suggested an excessive metabolic need and it had to use more energy. Recent studies suggest that had superior thinking capacities as well as conceptual skills.[2]

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1 U. Goswami, "Neuroscience and Education: From Research to Practice," *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 7, no. 2 (2006): 406–411.

2 C. Abraham, *Possessing Genius: The Bizarre Odyssey of Einstein's Brain* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 2002).

Einstein had an equally developed left and right hemisphere. Thus, Einstein was as good a philosopher and mystic, and a mathematician and physicist. His autobiography is rightly titled as *Einstein – The Philosopher Scientist*.[3] His saying on imagination particularly counts in this context: "Imagination is more important than knowledge. For knowledge is limited to all we know and understand, while imagination embraces the entire world, and all there ever will be to know and understand."[4] In his interview with G. S. Viereck for the Saturday Evening Post in 1929, Einstein famously had said that if he were not a physicist, he would have been a musician.[5]

In the words of educational thinker and theoretician, William Huitt, "a new vision for educating children and youth, both formally and informally, is required if they are to become successful adults in the twenty-first century."[6] As for Tate, scholar in educational methods, the use of imagination holds the key to education and with imagination one is capable of going beyond the conventional.[7] Creativity is therefore more a matter of imagination. This was further testified by the fact the very discovery of the old quantum hypothesis which was merely matter of imaginative leap by Max Planck. The remark of Shiny Toms matters here: "Copernicus broke off the grips of the Aristotelian geocentric worldview with his observation of the strange orbital path of the planet Mars that he could land on the radical and creative idea of heliocentrism. Thus, a very useful and powerful starting point towards developing creativity and critical thinking is to cultivate the habit of rigorous observation which will set them on the path of creative imagination."[8]

The trend of holistic education as advocated by many educationists today count much in this context. The emphasis on observation and imagination as a tool for creativity is founded on the neurological finding on the role of

3 Albert Einstein, *Einstein – The Philosopher Scientist*, tr. Paul Arthur Schilpp (Open Court, 1970).

4 Albert Einstein in *Cosmic Religion: With Other Opinions and Aphorisms* (1931).

5 G. S. Viereck, "What Life means to Einstein," *The Saturday Evening Post,* October 26, 1929, pp. 17, 110, http://www.saturdayeveningpost.com/wp-content/uploads/satevepost/what_life_means_to_ einstein.pdf, accessed 9 October 2022.

6 William Huitt, William Huitt, "A Holistic View of Education and Schooling: Guiding Students to Develop Capacities, Acquire Virtues, and Provide Service," http://www.21stcenturyskills.org/documents/MILE_Guide_091101.pdf, accessed 9 October 2022.

7 N. Tate, "What do Children in the 21st Century Really Need to Learn?" Presentation at the International Primary Curriculum Conference, International School of Geneva, 4 October 2008, available at http://www.edpsycinteractive.org/papers/holistic-view-of-schooling-rev.pdf, accessed 8 October 2022.

8 Shiny Toms, "Holistic Education as a Paradigm for Creativity and Problem Solving," in *Creativity and Problem Solving Through Education,* eds. Alex George, Bindhu Jose, Bindu Thomas and Jincy Johny (New Delhi: Media House, 2021).

observation of nature. Lincoln's letter to the principal of his son's school reads: "Teach him, if you can, the wonder of a book...but also give him quiet time to ponder the eternal mystery of birds in the sky bees in the sun, and flowers on a green hillside."[9]

As for emancipative education, this would mean activating and involving those regions of the brain that are accountable for social sensitivity, social responsiveness, and empathy in the process of appropriating knowledge. Creativity is not to be understood as mere problem-solving skills, but developing an approach that is adequately concerned with the social and cultural upliftment of the masses in terms of values, skills, liberative potentials through technologies.

This view of the social embeddedness of creativity is well captured by the recommendations of Programme for the International Students Assessments (PISA). PISA recommends problem solving to be incorporated in the curriculum. It expects the learners to be successful problem solvers.[10] According to PISA, problem solving is "an individual's capacity to engage in cognitive processing to understand and resolve problem situations where a method of solution is not immediately obvious. It includes the willingness to engage with such situations in order to achieve one's potential as a constructive and reflective citizen."[11] Applying the PISA definition of creativity and problem solving to education will necessitate a serious interaction with one's context and circumstances.

3. Neurobiology of Sociality and Empathy – Implications for Emancipative Education

The recent insights from neuroscience seem to suggest that humans as a species are genetically and innately programmed to commit themselves to the welfare of the others. The Darwinian emphasis on the principle of the survival of the fittest or Dawkin's version of the selfish genes[12] have been pushed to the sidelines, or to the least challenged, by the recent researches in neuroscience.

Lesion studies have shown that the sociality of the humans can be impaired by the particular regions of brains. This is shown by the studies on the brain of the humans and the primates. Monkeys with damage to the amygdala and the anterior temporal lobe exhibited difficulty in reacting to the signals

9 Jack Ray, "Lessons from Abraham Lincoln's Letter to his Son's Headmaster," https://medium.com/@dinhnguyen0504/abraham-lincolns-letter-to-his-son-s-headmaster-2f287fd33bfa, accessed 9 October 2022.

10 http://citeseerx.ist.psu.edu/viewdoc/download?doi=10.1.1.117.8503&rep=rep1&type=pdf, accessed 6 October 2022.

11 https://www.oecd.org/pisa/pisaproducts/Draft%20PISA%202015%20Collaborative%20Problem%2 0Solving%20Framework%20.pdf, accessed 9 October 2022.

12 Richard Dawkins, *The Selfish Gene* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1976).

from other monkeys.[13] The implication is that greater complexity of the brain leads to greater sociality of the organism. Researches with primates showed that individual amygdalial neurons are responsive while presented with stimuli that are socially relevant. In another study, social feelings were reported by amygdala patients prepared for surgery when regions of their amygdala were stimulated.[14]

3.1. Emotional Intelligence

It is good to recollect in this context that the notion of emotional intelligence that has gained momentum in the educational neuroscience can carry some neurocognitive implications for emancipative education as well.[15] Emotional intelligence, is claimed to be facilitating effectiveness in every aspect of life. There are claims, though contentious, that emotional intelligence is superior to cognitive intelligence.[16] Studies have found that emotional intelligence is associated with academic performance.[17] Prefrontal cortex of the brain is largely responsible for processing social emotions like empathy, compassion, envy, etc. Accordingly, damage to this area can generate social insensitivity. This can influence the way a person processes responses to social approval or rejection.[18] This finding endorses the view of Vygotsky who emphasised the cultural and social influences on cognitive learning.[19] This calls for the intersection of neuroscience with the social reconstructivist theories of education.

The antisocial behaviours of children are also studied in neuroscience today. For example, the callous-unemotional traits among children revealed

13 Ralph Adolphs, "What does the Amygdala Contribute to Social Cognition?" *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences* 1191, no. 1 (2010): 42–61.

14 Cory Inman, Bijanki, R. Kelly, David I. Bass, Robert E. Gross, Stephan Hamann &, Jon T. Willie, "Human Amygdala Stimulation Effects on Emotion Physiology and Emotional Experience," *Neuropsychologia* 145:106722 (August 2020).

15 P. Salovey, D. J. Sluyter, *Emotional Development and Emotional Intelligence: Educational Implications* (Basic Books, 1997).

16 D. Goleman, *Emotional Intelligence* (New York, Bantam Books, 1995).

17 K. V. Petrides, N. Frederickson and A. Furnham, "The Role of Trait Emotional Intelligence in Academic Performance and Deviant Behavior at School," *Personality and Individual Differences* 36, no. 2 (2004): 277-293; D. Ansari and Karmiloff-Smith, "Atypical Trajectories of Number Development: A Neuroconstructivist Perspective," *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 6, no. 12 (2002): 511–516.

18 S. W. Anderson, et al., "Impairment of Social and Moral Behavior Related to Early Damage in Human Prefrontal Cortex," *Foundations of Social Neuroscience* (2002): 333–343.

19 M. H. Immordino-Yang and A. Damasio, "We Feel, Therefore We Learn: The Relevance of Affective and Social Neuroscience to Education," *Mind, Brain, and Education* 1, no. 1 (2007): 3-10.

reduced activation of amygdala to fearful objects, faces or circumstances.[20] It shows that the neural correlates of antisocial behaviour are present in the early stages of development. Researches on social cognition among adolescents suggested that emotional processing during adolescence undergo major functional changes.[21]

Imaging studies have shown greater activity in the amygdalae for participants who viewed pictures of black people as opposed to white people's faces. It points to the unconscious grounds of racial attitudes.[22] As seen earlier, prefrontal cortex is responsible for processing and regulating impulsive behaviors. PET scan reports found poor functioning of the prefrontal cortex of the committed murderers. It leads to poor weighing of uncertain risks or assessing the social and moral consequences of an action. Childhood abuses or neglects can lead to the damage or poor development of these areas. Such children may turn out to be culpable offenders.[23] PET scan studies showed prefrontal activity is less and subcortical brain functioning is more in predatory murderers.[24]

Neurological dysfunctions or abnormal functioning of brain regions are found to be responsible, to some extent for aggression, violence and terrorism. A dysfunction of the frontal cortex, dysfunctional or undeveloped amygdala, lack of adequate wirings linking amygdala and the frontal cortex are said to be some of the neurological factors leading to extreme antisocial behaviour like terrorism.[25]

3.2. Sexual Orientation

The sexual orientations of persons are found to be significantly influenced by the neural connections in the brain. The connection patters in the brain between

20 A. P., Jones, et al., "Amygdala Hypoactivity to Fearful Faces in Boys with Conduct Problems and Callous-unemotional Traits," *American Journal of Psychiatry* 166, no. 1 (2009): 95.

21 S. J. Blakemore, "The Social Brain in Adolescence," *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 9, no. 4 (2008): 267-277.

22 E. A. Phelps K. J. O'Connor, W. A. Cunningham, et al., "Performance on Indirect Measures of Race Evaluation Predicts Amygdala Activity," *Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience* 12 (2000): 1–10; A. Etkin, K. C. Klemenhagen, J. T. Dudman, et al., "Individual Differences in Trait Anxiety Predict the Response of the Basolateral Amygdala to Unconsciously Processed Fearful Faces," *Neuron* 44 (2004): 1043–1055.

23 A. Raine, *The Psychopathology of Crime: Criminal Behavior as a Clinical Disorder* (San Diego, CA: Academic Press, 1993).

24 M. J. Farah, "Neuroethics: The Practical and the Philosophical," *Trends Cognitive Science* 9 (2005): 34–40.

25 A. Raine; E. A. Phelps, et al., J. S. Morris, C. D. Frith, D. I. Perrett, & D. Rowland, "A Differential Neural Response in the Human Amygdala to Fearful and Happy Facial Expressions," *Nature* 383, 6603 (1996): 812–815.

amygdala and the cerebral cortex are decisive in defining the homosexual, lesbian or heterosexual behaviours. It is found that there are female-like connection patterns in the brains of homosexual men where connections are more widespread from the left amygdala to the right cerebral cortex. Similarly, connections are more widespread from the right amygdala to the left cerebral cortex for lesbians which is the normal pattern for the male.[26] Neuroimaging data has shown that there are neural correlates for sexual aggression.[27]

3.3. Mirror Neurons

An exploration of the emancipative potentials of education from the cognitive point of view will invite a serious consideration of the mirror neurons. Mirror neurons are a particular set of neurons located in the prefrontal cortex, Wernicke's area and the parietal lobe. Researches by Gaccamo Rizzolatti and his team first identified the mirror neurons in monkeys. They found that group of neurons in the ventral premotor area fire as they grab certain objects and the same neurons fire when these monkeys watch other monkeys do the same activity. Though monkeys do not have the regions for speech in the brain, neuroscientists are of the view that these regions in monkeys are homologous to the regions associated with speech in the human brain. It suggests the role of mirror neurons in correctly judging the feelings and intentions of others. Emergence of mirror neuron must have been a later development in the evolutionary process.

A unique of feature of this set of neurons is that they are activated not only when one performs a particular action, but also when one watches others performing the same action. For example, mirror neurons in the brain of a child fires when he/she watches another child on the bed in pain when the nurse injects him/her. The name, mirror neurons, reflects their capacity to mirror the actions. Persons with active mirror neurons will be more empathetic and altruistic. For, mirror neurons normally define the degree of empathy and compassion in a person. Such persons will be least prone to violence or terrorism.[28] Sociality is very much associated with mirror neurons. Understanding the biological roots of human sociality and empathy may accelerate the potentials of emancipative education in future.

These studies have been cited here to show how the personality of humans have been shaped by their neural correlates even from the early days of their development. Cognitive development and the conversely

26 V. S. Ramachandran, *Tell Tale Brain - A Neuroscientist's Quest for What Makes Us Human* (W.W. Norton & Company, 2012).

27 B. A. Arnow, J. Desmond, L. F. Huang, et al., "Brain Activation and Sexual Arousal in Healthy Heterosexual Males," *Brain* 125 (2002): 1014–1023.

28 Ramachandran (2012).

the liberative or emancipative impact of education are influenced by the neural makeup of a person. Emancipative education with its focus on social embeddedness, promotion of social justice, personal meaning, other-orientation, and empathetic outlooks, therefore, have to rely heavily on the foundational implications of the findings from cognitive neuroscience. Developments in neuroscience can add new cognitive strings to the future researches in emancipative education.

By nature, humans are not prone to be selfish, but to be altruistic. It is a matter of social and environmental conditioning that people tend to be self-centered in their value systems. Unfortunately, most mirror neuron are bound within the brain and are not adequately informing the brain regions responsible for sociality and responsiveness. The importance of mirror neurons for emancipative education is that it calls for holistic approaches to education from the early stages onwards. If only constant activation of these set of neurons are promoted through regular existential exposures, they could be functional. Bookish and class room approaches will not help develop an empathetic brain in a child with sufficient functioning of the mirror neurons.

3.4. Cognitive Neuroscience and Current Trends in Education

The implications of the neurology of empathy and sociality for education are very consistent with the models of education proposed by philosophers of education, such as, John Dewey, Maria Montessori, Charlett Mason, Paulo Freire, and many others. The current dominant approaches in the philosophy education such as educational progressivism, Essentialism, Social Reconstructionism, contemplative education, etc., presuppose the cognitive grounds of learning as informed by the neuroscience. Progressivism rejects traditional schooling that focuses on memorization and learning in a strictly organized classroom and considers education to be the science of relations. Critical pedagogy or social constructivism advocate the advancement of the consciousness of freedom by eliminating the authoritarian tendencies in education and promote the ability to take constructive action. Heidggerian existentialist approach also advocates testing and interrogating the ontological assumptions and presuppositions which implicitly guide research in each domain of knowledge. Social reconstructivists attack the banking concept of education, recommend teacher student reciprocity, participatory development and emancipation through participation.

Contemplative education is a recent approach promoted by Parker Palmer, Zigle which hold the students contemplating over pedagogical texts. On an evaluative note it could be seen that much of the experiments and practices in the recent trends are founded on the anthropological principle that the early phase of education is the most decisive phase of learning. The recent

transition from the personal to the technological is also critically viewed by the philosophers of education.

In this context it may be recollected that although the contemplative approach and social reconstructivist theories of education may appear to be close to the suggestions from neuroscience, almost all recent trends in education share some kind of cognitive and neurological platforms with the brain sciences. Say, for instance, Nel Noddings's feminist approach and care approach in education is a restoration of the holistic traits in education and it assumes the integral functioning of the left and right hemispheres of the brain.

Emancipative education must be intersected with the present movement of holistic education. Holistic education views education as an integral process addressing the social, spiritual, and environmental aspects of human life in addition to the academic. Emancipative knowledge cannot be produced without integrating the social and the spiritual. The ambience of holistic education as envisaged by thinkers like Forbes, Krishnamurthy, Lee, Koetzch, etc., are quite compatible with the perspectives provided by the cognitive neuroscience today. Multidisciplinarity is intrinsic to the holistic education and conversely to emancipative education. "Creative Problem Solving is a methodology based on a multidisciplinary approach dealing with the role of creativity, innovation and problem solving in various situations of daily life."[29] Emancipative education can be facilitated only by cultivating the mental dispositions of serenity, calmness and inner peace.

4. Cognitive Neuroscience and Intuitive Learning – Indian Perspectives

A neurologically informed analysis of emancipative education will find analogical similarities with the Indian traditional values and models of education. As for the Indian tradition, the process of liberative knowing as envisaged in *Bhagavat Gīta* shares some common grounds with the neurological insights. In as much as neuroscience underscores the integration of the rational and the intuitive or the analytical and the synthetic, the Indian mind-set is keen not to get stuck up with the sense data in passing judgements. The data collected by the senses are coordinated by the *manas* and *manas*, instead of making its own judgement, has to pass it on to the *cit*. *Cit* also should not make its own judgement. Rather, it should receive the light from *Purusa* in making the judgement. Only the *cit* illuminated by the spiritual principle of *Purusa* is capable of making authentic judgement. Such sort of a judgement will be radically reformative and emancipative. Thus, enlightenment is considered to be one of the most powerful sources of

29 https://www.researchgate.net/publication/332945659_creative_problem_solving_methodology_gui de, DOI:10.13140/RG.2.2.35949.64484, accessed 9 October 2022.

revolution and reformation in the Indian tradition. The integral vision of Gita about the three *yogas* of *bhakti*, *karma* and *jnana* have at their depth a vision of personal, social and cosmic emancipation. Analogically speaking, what the model of liberative knowledge as envisaged by the ancient seers may be said to have been rediscovered and restored by the recent developments in cognitive neuroscience.

The intimate bond between the master and the student is an immaculate element of the Indian tradition of education. Enlightenment is facilitated by the training under a *guru*. Even if the parents were to forsake the child, the master will not forsake the child. Master is compared to a mother with baby in the womb. To teach Rama mathematics, the master needs to learn Rama first and then mathematics! It is said that in the Indian tradition, a child who has completed the training under the master is a spiritual miracle who is visited by gods. This mode of personal education founded on the bond between the master and the disciple is much close to the recent emphasis on the care and the feminist approaches in the social reconstructivist theory of education advocated by John Holt and Nel Nodding.

5. A Christian Appropriation of Cognitive Educational Emancipation

In the above discussion we argued that recent trend of the complementarity of the analytical and the synthetic, the rational and the mystical is essential for integral knowledge and conversely for creativity. It has also been our contention that such a trait is easily identifiable in the ancient Indian mystical understanding of emancipative knowledge. The inclusive nature of such kind of knowledge is testified by the foundational importance attributed to "God-experience" in the Christian tradition. The fire of emancipatory revolution brought out by Christ had its original sparks in His Abba experience in prayer on the loneliness of the mountaintops. The irreconcilable dialectical polarity between the oppressive social structures on the one hand and the single Fatherhood of God and the universal brotherhood of humanity on the other must have been the energising epistemic force of the emancipative words and deeds of Christ. "Why does your Master eat with the sinners and the prostitutes?" (Mt. 9:9). This accusation against Christ makes him the most powerful icon of emancipative praxis and the source of this praxis is the experience on the mountaintop.

The primacy of experience in emancipation has been gradually compromised with various doctrinal determinisms and structural fixations in the course of theological evolution. A remarkable and exceptional rethinking towards the restoration of the emancipative potentials of theology has been articulated by the Jesuit thinker Bernard Lonergan in his visualisation of a new theological methodology. The general empirical method with due recognition of the role of insight along with the eight functional specialities are quite in

tune with the neurocognitive perspectives on creativity, knowledge, liberation and emancipation. Lonergan had a strong background in science as well as philosophy. In his famous work, *Insight*,[30] he argued that a general structure is of knowing and search is present in all rational individuals. This structure is operative in simple common sensical as well most complex scientific, literary, artistic and theological operations. Lonergan highlighted the role of insight in the knowing process. He is not bothered about the known, rather with the knowing.

Lonergan's contribution is succinctly captured in the following words:

> He (Lonergan) has discovered that knowing has a recurrent structure of experiencing, pondering, judging, and deciding. He challenges readers to understand what it means when they themselves understand, and if they do this, then they not only will generally understand whatever needs to be comprehended but also will have an insight into the insight-making process itself. This understanding will promote intellectual progress in a variety of fields and also help humans to avoid false ideas ("oversights") that lead to intellectual and social decline, unenlightened policies, and dangerous courses of action.[31]

A detailed discussion of the method of Lonergan is beyond the scope of this paper. However, the productive epistemic and methodological potentials towards an integrally emancipative education at stake in the intersection between Lonergan and the current cognitive neuroscience is irrefutable. His vision of insight as a source of knowledge and discovery is a celebration of the "right hemisphere" – imagination, intuition, synthesis, visualisation, - even in the analytical and empirical sciences. The oversight or false ideas that Lonergan speaks about is consequent of the formal education, and avoiding oversight with insight is the first step towards emancipative education. Perhaps, Lonergan deserves the credit for anticipating insightfully much of the recommendations from cognitive neuroscience for emancipative education. Lonergan reminds us of Einstein who prioritised imagination over knowledge in scientific discovery.

The primacy of insight in the knowing process as elaborated by Lonergan in his *Insight* are so close to the very etymological meaning of education. Etymologically originating from the Latin word *educare*, it refers to nourishing

30 Bernard Lonergan, *Insight,* Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, eds. Frederick Crowe S. J. & Robert Doran S. J. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1992).

31 Editorial, eNotes, https://www.enotes.com/topics/insight#:~:text=With%20his%20grasp%20of%20modern,commonsense%20decisions%20to%20the%20most, accessed 14 October 2022.

and bringing up. Another root, *educere*, means drawing out. Education refers to the movement from within to without. This is very consistent with the holistic understanding of education as enlightenment driven by insight.[32]

6. Conclusion

This essay has been looking at some of the recent developments in neuroscience in general, and cognitive neuroscience in particular, to see how emancipative education can benefit from it. Accordingly, the rigorous researches in neuroscience with regard to knowledge, imagination, empathy, sociality, mirror neurons, antisocial behaviours, etc., are found to be carrying epistemic and conceptual resources for widening the dictums and contours of traditional formal education along the line of the social and liberative dimensions of education as visualised in emancipative education. The major suggestion from this essay is that the ambitious vision of emancipation through education must be founded on an integral anthropology informed by cognitive sciences.

32 https://www.slideshare.net/rdhaker2011/educationmeaning#:~:text=Education%20Meaning%20of%20Education%2D%20The,lead%20froth%2C%20to%20draw%20out, accessed 14 October 2022.

Information-Knowledge-Wisdom
The Use of Media in Education with Special Reference to Covid-19

Francis Arackal Thummy

Abstract: Information-Formation-Transformation can be the core guiding principle in education. A teacher obviously imparts new information to the students. Today, the world is full of information. But information must be converted into knowledge and knowledge should result in wisdom, to distinguish right from wrong. In so far as the students have joined an educational institution, they are under formation; parents entrust their children in the hands of teachers to form them. They have to be molded for their own and for the betterment of society. Formation involves inculcating values. This, of course, is a very delicate job, which must be done gently and with care. The purpose of education should be to form wise individuals and not necessarily oriented to securing a job. The modality of imparting information, formation, and transformation took a different turn with the onset of the virus pandemic. If the use of media in education was optional and limited in the pre-Covid times, the same became a necessity during the pandemic period. This contribution would like to explain in some detail how this challenge was met. One of the positive outcomes of the pandemic is the world's newfound appreciation of teachers. Teachers are finally recognized as being more than sources of information and knowledge to empty vessels and are looked on as being models of strong character, patient and loving caregivers, and treasures

of valuable life experiences. They are appreciated for their adaptability, especially to entirely new media communication technology, and resilience.

Keywords: Asynchronous, Education, Media, Online, Synchronous, Technology, Covid-19.

Introduction

Information denotes the organised data about someone or something obtained from various sources such as newspaper, internet, radio, television, discussions, etc. We are living in an age of information explosion or 'information overload' as some experts would like to characterize it. For instance, if one were to Google the word 'information' (using internet of course) one would get About 25,27,00,00,000 results in 0.50 seconds. Such a vast quantity of information can be mentally debilitating, to say the least. Hence information must be converted to useful knowledge. Knowledge refers to the awareness or understanding on the subject acquired from education or experience of a person. Knowledge should lead one to wisdom. Wisdom is the ability to discern inner qualities and relationships; an ability to distinguish right from wrong. Just a simple example would illustrate what we said above: information (100 miles); knowledge (100 miles is quite a far distance); wisdom (it is very difficult to walk 100 miles by any person, but vehicle transport is fine). Generally, it was thought that education imparted information and knowledge–the aspect of wisdom was somehow overlooked. But it wouldn't be far off to state that education is incomplete if it hasn't led to wisdom.

Media have always been used to impart education: beginning with the blackboard (white boards appeared much later), going on to the OHP (overhead projector) and nowadays the LCD projector combined with a laptop or a PC. Why use media in Education? For gaining attention. Attention spans have been decreasing over a period of time. For a quicker grasp of what is being taught, with the use of PPT slides for instance, a lesson can be taught in one hour what it would have taken hours. Related to this is the whole gamut of the Philosophy of visuals. The scope of this paper doesn't warrant a detailed treatment. For the moment it is enough to recognize that we are living in a visual culture–seeing is believing–brought about by constant visual communication. Our physical vision is focused on some screens–of mobile phones, wrist tops, palm tops, laptops, personal computers, and televisions–almost throughout the day.

In the context of Covid-19 education moved beyond the limited use of media. Moving has been a great analogy for the pandemic situation. Education moved from brick-and-mortar classrooms to an online modality or to what some call remote, distance, or virtual education. Like any move, it was stressful and at the same time an amazing adventure. It opened up another way of imparting education; schooling began to take a new form and we guess much of it would remain long after the pandemic has vanished. For many, moving online became the best solution to sustaining education, despite being unknown. All these and more will be treated in detail in the following pages.

Prior to discussing the nitty-gritty of using media in education, let us try to understand visual communication which media facilitates. When we speak about media use in education, in fact, it's all about visual communication in education.

1. What is Visual Communication?

Visual communication is the use of pictures and graphics to represent information for the purpose of communication. Visual communication is mainly used to add more impact to the information communicated. Teachers use visual communications to help the students to concentrate and grasp the lessons, thus making the communication more relatable.[1]

1.1. Importance of Visual Communication

Visual communication is significant in a society which is influenced and sometimes overwhelmed by a visual culture. This is true especially of the younger generation in our society. They understand visual communication faster, and it is a very effective means of communication; they are very much 'screen-tuned,' so to say. Written or spoken communications requires some mental effort to comprehend the information they provide, and sometimes the audience may find it hard to understand what is being communicated by them. But with visual communication, the information is mostly straightforward and understandable.[2]

There are various forms of visual communication. They include videos, television, slide presentations, paper handouts–flyers, brochures, and posters.

1.2. The Study of Signs and Symbols

Within visual communication, semiotics play a great role. The study of signs and symbols is referred to as semiotics. Semiotics is used to depict the way graphical data represent a message. Semiotics also provides a connection between an image and its context. It is a method used to interpret and understand the media content and analyze aspects of popular cultures.[3]

1 Caroline Ntara, "What is Visual Communication?," https://study.com/learn/lesson/what-is-visual-comm unication.html, accessed 15 September 2022.

2 Caroline Ntara, "What is Visual Communication?"

3 Francis Arackal, *Media and Society* (Bangalore: ATC Publications, 2018), 43-58.

2. Education in the Time of Covid

Covid-19 can be seen as a watershed moment in contemporary history: demarcating contemporary times as pre-Covid, Covid times and post-Covid. One can be quite sure that history from 2019 will be written in these terms. In the pre-Covid times, depending upon the technological advancement of a particular country and particular places in that country media tools have been employed in the realm of education. Smart classrooms have been set up to make the imparting of knowledge concerning various subjects more attractive to the students. It won't be incorrect to say that both the teaching and student community overwhelmingly welcomed such steps in the field of education. The main media tools consisted of the use of film slides using projectors, overhead projectors with transparent sheets, power point slides using LCD projectors, videos with the help of Laptops, Personal Computers, and education television programmes produced by both government and private channels. An overwhelming section–both teachers and students–didn't know and think beyond the face-to-face classroom centered education. It was seen as something normal.

But then, a new normal happened, it put teaching and teachers in crisis. Teachers were caught off guard by the sudden erasure of the classroom. School closures in response to the covid-19 coronavirus pandemic resulted in an immediate and universal pivot to online teaching. Millions of teachers in India and all over the world were suddenly asked to teach in an entirely new setting with little preparation and no advance notice. Both teachers and students were forced to move. After you move, nothing is the same again. Moving is a little like death, except you get to plan. To deal with death, you have to traverse stage of grief: 1) Denial and isolation, 2) Anger, 3) Bargaining, 4) Depression, and 5) Acceptance. But even after we reach acceptance, we still have to make perhaps the most important choice. We can be resigned or we can be empowered. We can try and return to the old ways, or we can seize the challenges.[4]

The new normal gave rise to plenty of challenges in the "classroom" – glitchy internet; good internet but some children lacking a device to access it; students participating from hallways outside their apartments; teachers leading classes with their own children in their laps. Of course, at the end of the day there were/are some silver linings: a few things will work better online; some students will thrive more there. Teaching online will make some teachers better at their craft. An average teacher's opinion about the pandemic teaching situation was this: "This is scary, and I miss the world as

4 Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning to Online Teaching* (New York: Teachers College Press, 2021), xvi.

it used to be – me, my classroom, my students. But this is reality. The kids need me to be good at this [online teaching], so I've got to give it my best."[5]

While online teaching has some advantages, most teachers preferred to get back to the classrooms as early as possible. For, the interpersonal interactions that have been built up in the classrooms meant so much. It's the general belief that classrooms are uniquely suited to build a culture around students that brings out the best. Classrooms can be a 'bright mirror': a place that wraps students in a culture that draws out the best from within them, but also changes them for the better. The ideal learning environment is a classroom where your peers look at you as you share a nascent idea. Soon it's not really your idea anymore, but the group's collective thinking. Together, you come to a deeper shared understanding.[6] Humans are finely evolved machines for observing and responding to the other human beings around them, having survived as a species by forming social groups. When we are together socially, we can draw on all of the tools that are wired in our brains that make us respond to positive culture. Surely then, an online setting can't provide all the things a classroom can. Besides, on net, the experience of learning online will likely to be less productive for most students than classrooms are.[7] Yes, it won't be farfetched to say that Covid pandemic gave rise to a sort of second, educational pandemic.

Mention must be made here of Doug Lemov who spent weeks studying videos of online teaching to provide educators in the midst of this transition with a clear guide to engaging and educating their students online. His book *Teaching, Technology and the New Normal* suggests the following:

- Learn strategies for engaging students more fully online.
- Find new techniques to assess student progress from afar.
- Discover tools for building online classroom culture, combating online distractions, and more.
- Watch videos of teachers building rigor and relationships during online instruction.

Although the transition to online education is happening more abruptly than anyone anticipated, media technology-supported teaching may be here to stay.

5 Doug Lemov, *Teaching in the Online Classroom* (Hoboken, NJ: Jossey-Bass A Wiley Imprint, 2020), 6.

6 Doug Lemov, *Teaching in the Online Classroom*, 6-7.

7 Doug Lemov, *Teaching in the Online Classroom*, 7.

3. Synchronous and Asynchronous Learning

It's since the pandemic that these terms have come into circulation in the field of education. Before the pandemic, learning was thought in terms of space–the classroom. In a study done by RAND Corporation[8] it was found that many teachers and students mistakenly believed that 'real' learning only happened in the classroom; meaning, they mentally connected learning to a physical *space*, rather than to the way *time* is organized. Since, the pandemic learning is being thought (or forced to think) in terms of *time*.[9] Of course, it took many months into the pandemic for teachers and students to realize that synchronous and asynchronous have nothing to do with school and home (spaces), but rather with time.

In general, learning takes two forms: asynchronous and synchronous. The word synchronous has the root Cronus, who is the Greek god of time. To be synchronous is to be *in* or *on* time, and to be asynchronous is to be *out* of time or *not in* time.[10] According to Solomon and Verrilli, asynchronous learning takes place when the work of learning occurs at different times and in different places, say, when your students complete an assignment, you have posted online and email it back to you, or when you videotape a lecture for your students to watch on their own time. Synchronous learning is what typically happens in a traditional classroom. The teacher stands in front of the class and delivers instruction. However, it's important to note that synchronous learning can also be conducted remotely through Zoom, Google Meet, Microsoft Teams or any other platform.[11] To make the concepts clearer, we can say, that those lessons when live on TV are synchronous whereas asynchronous lessons are those found on Netflix or YouTube, when they are not live of course. Asynchronous lessons enable re-filming or editing so that they can produce a higher-quality presentation.

Students have a bit more control in an asynchronous setting: they can watch lessons at their own pace, pausing when they need more time to complete an assignment, or rolling back to hear an explanation a second time.

8 The Research and Development Corporation (RAND) is a US global policy think tank created in 1948.

9 Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning to Online Teaching* (New York: Teachers College Press, 2021), 62, 63.

10 Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning*, 62.

11 Hannah Solomon and Beth Verrilli, "Synchronous and Asynchronous Learning" in *Teaching in the Online Classroom: Surviving and Thriving in the New Normal,* ed., Doug Lemov (Hoboken, NJ: Jossey-Bass A Wiley Brand, 2020), 15; Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher: Using Technology to Teach in Person and Online* (Hoboken, NJ: Jossey-Bass A Wiley Brand, 2021), 1-2, 5. Due to the limited scope of this paper we cannot go into the pros and cons of using these platforms.

Asynchronous lessons allow teachers to play with time. Lessons can have an 'expiry date' or be ever 'fresh'. The former has deadlines to be met–within a few hours or within several days. The latter kinds of lessons live forever and students can utilize them whenever they need to. As a rule, fresh videos should be short and pithy, and used primarily for reference, homework, or as introductions to new content.[12]

A few downsides to asynchronous learning are worth noting: i) even the strongest asynchronous lesson can feel like teaching into a void; ii) students may lose a sense of connectedness to teachers and peers and feel little accountability during asynchronous learning; iii) an asynchronous lesson may have asymmetric outcomes: the strong students continue to flourish, and the struggling students continue to struggle.[13]

Some of the drawbacks of asynchronous learning can be addressed through synchronous learning. When done well, a synchronous lesson can truly replicate the moods of a face-to-face classroom. Students can see their teachers and peers, live, and interact with (engage) them in real time.[14] Of course, synchronous lessons have their limitations too: i) for some teachers their home responsibilities and work responsibilities might collide; ii) getting all the students to the lesson and logged in at the same time could be a problem; iii) as with asynchronous learning, screen fatigue and drifting attention spans is a great drawback.[15]

Solomon and Verrilli are of the view:

> Though synchronous learning can, on some level, feel most like a classroom, it's not exactly. In fact, many classroom challenges are often magnified through it. How do we assess understanding, or deliver feedback, when we cannot crouch by a student's desk or read over her shoulder? How do teachers effectively monitor student engagement or continue to develop trusting relationships when we – and they – are tiny squares on the screen?[16]

12 Solomon and Verrilli, "Synchronous and Asynchronous Learning," 17; Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning,* 66; Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher,* 47-79.

13 Solomon and Verrilli, "Synchronous and Asynchronous Learning," 18-19; Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning,* 66; Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher,* 47-79.

14 Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning,* 67; Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher,* 5-47.

15 Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning,* 68-69; Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher,* 5-47.

16 Doug Lemov, *Teaching in the Online Classroom,* 26.

Asynchronous learning isn't bad or good, just as synchronous learning is neither bad nor good rather "Good learning takes place in a balance of carefully designed synchronous and asynchronous moments."[17] The right balance is vital to successful online learning.

4. Online Teaching Modes — Fully Online, Remote, Hybrid, and Hyflex

Online teaching did exist in pre-Covid times. For instance, the North American lexicon, a survey of 398 school administrators and 1,500 students conducted by Best Colleges found that online programmes continued to be in high demand. In actuality, for more than a decade now, we have known that when online faculty follow good teaching practices, their students can learn a little more than in a comparable face-to-face course. However, Covid-19 made online learning the only option available. The virus made face-to-face classroom teaching dangerous and forced institutions to adopt alternative course delivery methods, all of which rely on web-based learning to a greater or lesser extent.

4.1. Fully Online

Fully online designates courses in which students access all the learning materials and activities through the internet. Because the distinguishing advantage of online learning is the ability of anyone, anywhere to take the course, it is designed to be primarily asynchronous yet may include scheduled real-time chats or web conferences.[18]

4.2. Remote

Remote has more than one meaning in the world of education. Some institutions, define it simply as learning that takes place outside of the physical classroom, made possible by using synchronous or asynchronous technology to connect instructors with their students. A few places consider 'remote' as a temporary mode of instruction on the faculty's way to improving their courses from face-to-face to fully online. For instance, in a remote course, faculty usually have a synchronous component during a designated time which usually corresponds to the time the course would be offered face-to-face.[19]

17 Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning,* 63.

18 Linda B. Nilson and Ludwika A. Goodson, *Online Teaching at Its Best* (Hoboken, NJ: Jossey-Bass A Wiley Brand, 2021), 9.

19 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best*, 10.

4.3. Hybrid

Hybrid, also called blended, designates courses that combine face-to-face classroom meetings with asynchronous online learning. They take advantage of the same technologies and active-learning strategies used in both face-to-face and online spaces. The number of classrooms versus online sessions varies. On some campuses, a course with more than 50 percent of the sessions online will be called an online course rather than hybrid or blended.[20]

4.4. Hyflex

Stands for a hybrid-flexible (hyflex) mode, sometimes called blend-flex. Hyflex has a flexible participation pattern that allows students to take courses by attending on-campus classes, participating online, doing both, or viewing the video of the class later. Course content, structure, and activities must work equally well face-to-face and online. Typically, in a hyflex course, the same faculty member teaches both in person and online at the same time.[21]

Online learning has attracted a huge body of knowledge about what works and what doesn't in increasing student achievement. It is known that e-learning improves when pedagogy drives the technology and when faculty implement best practices.[22]

5. Effectiveness of Various Modes of Teaching

So then we can speak about the effectiveness of some of these modes of teaching: there is evidence to suggest that well-designed hybrid courses can match or slightly exceed both face-to-face and online courses in fostering both student learning and satisfaction. Synchronous hybrid classes may be more engaging than fully face-to-face or fully online delivery of lessons. For performance learning such as lab, clinical, and medical procedures, research tells us that virtual and hybrid learning can produce equal or better learning outcomes. This may be because that the instructors of online and hybrid courses take greater advantage of the wealth of online instructional resources than do those teaching face-to-face courses. These resources encompass rich multimedia learning objects and simulations. Also, because applying some of the best teaching practices enhances student satisfaction. These best practices include lecturing less, making regular use of breakout rooms for short group discussions, and taking measures to ensure that students prepare for meeting. There is also evidence that students feel that they learn better and are more

20 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best*, 10.

21 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best*, 10.

22 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best*, 11.

satisfied when they select the learning mode. Linda and Ludwika come to these conclusions after perusing so many studies done by scholars.[23]

Drawing upon the studies done by Means, Bakia & Murphy R. and Mayer R. E.[24] Linda and Ludwika go on to state that when online learning surpasses classroom learning, it is not the technology itself but the course design, time on task, and student engagement with the content that account for the better outcomes. These findings hold even for courses with rich media, which can interfere with learning if overdone, misaligned, or poorly designed.

In Chapter 4 – "Applying Cognitive Science to Online Teaching and Learning Strategies" – Linda and Ludwika in their work *Online Teaching at Its Best* lay out twenty-five principles of learning from cognitive science. Later in the same chapter they explain in detail how these principles can inform online course design and teaching. It is indeed a great treasure for anyone interested in developing online courses.[25]

In *Linking Neuroscience of Learning to Online Teaching* Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa says that we live in unprecedented times that have pushed schools to make many decisions that have been postponed for years. For the first time since the inception of public education, teachers have been invited to redesign the learning landscape by integrating an intelligent selection of digital educational resources and changing pedagogical approaches based on information from the learning sciences.[26]

6. Teaching Effectively with Technology

6.1. Interactions with Technology

From wired campuses to smart classrooms to massive open online courses (MOOCs), digital technology is now firmly embedded in higher education. Drawing on the latest findings from neuroscience and cognitive psychology, Michelle Miller explores how attention, memory, and higher thought processes such as critical thinking and analytical reasoning can be enhanced through technology-aided approaches.[27]

Hence the first requirement is student's and faculty's interactions with technology. For this Linda and Ludwika give an apt imagery:[28] As with any

23 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best*, 11-12.

24 Means B, Bakia M, and Murphy R., *Learning Online: What Research Tells Us About Whether, When and How* (New York: Routledge, 2014); Mayer R. E., *Multimedia Learning* (2nd ed.), (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press).

25 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best,* 91-107.

26 Tracey Tokuhama-Espinosa, *Bringing the Neuroscience of Learning,* 1-6.

27 Michelle Miller, *Minds Online: Teaching Effectively with Technology* (Harvard: Harvard University Press, 2014), 148-165.

28 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best,* 169.

other access, being able to open a door allows passage into a room. Students and faculty who do not know how to open the door will have trouble. For this reason, as far as students are concerned, a number of colleges and universities provide the opportunity to self-assess their readiness for online learning. Requirements include daily access to a computer, connection to the internet, and technology skills such as keyboarding, use of browsers, e-mail, file management, and downloading and running of software that may be needed in a course. Inexperience with such technologies may be frustrating and inconvenient, but an orientation can help students quickly pick up enough skills to make through a course. In the post-Covid scenario it would seem that this has to be made mandatory for new admissions to courses.

Five areas or tools can play a particularly important role in fostering student interactions:[29]

i. Announcement space: Brief instructor messages to students such as reminders, additional resources, class schedule changes.
ii. Question and Answer space: Like a virtual office where students can ask for clarifications or assistance.
iii. Content discussion space: Areas with topics and questions for students to discuss.
iv. Social space: An area for informal student-student interactions that a teacher might entitle as Student Lounge, Cyber café, Coffee Shop, etc.
v. Team space: Areas for small-group discussions.

6.2. Types of Digital Educational Resources

Digital educational resources can be divided into a) websites, b) apps, c) games, d) podcasts, e) software, f) videos, g) television programmes, and h) radio programmes. The type of resource is of less importance than their uses, however. That is, one would not choose a game just because it is a game, but rather because it helps achieve the objective better than other software, apps, or old-fashioned pen-and-paper worksheets. From the buffet of digital technology one has to choose wisely. Since the Covid-19 crisis when everyone started working and schooling from home, teachers were overwhelmed by the numerous possibilities of hardware, software, plug-ins, and apps. Perhaps it's not wise to try out everything as with the all-you-can-eat buffet.

29 Sorensen C. K., and Baylen D. M., "Learning Online: Adapting the Seven Principles of Good Practice to a Web-based Instructional Environment," in *The Perfect Online Course: Best Practices for Designing and Teaching,* eds., A. Orellana, T. L. Hudgins, and M. Simonson (Charlotte, NC: Information Age Publishing, 2009), 73.

6.3. Some Tips for Media Technology Use

- Plan to use the technology with which the teacher is already familiar. For example, if the instructors already have PowerPoint slides for his/her course, then plan to adapt them for the course platforms you will be using.
- Incorporate a technology only if you as an instructor thoroughly know how to use it and explain it to students.
- Avoid technology with a steep learning curve and high technical requirements.
- Avoid unreliable or unneeded technology.
- Identify the technology you expect your students to use.
- Give students the option of choosing a technology type, medium, or format for assignments.
- Prepare course materials in formats that are user-friendly for all students.
- If you must use web conferencing tools that you have not previously used, spend an hour or two simply practicing the mechanics.[30]

Michelle Miller speaks specifically about incorporating multimedia in teaching. She presents innovative ideas for how to use multimedia effectively: multimedia theory provides a powerful, empirically supported framework for getting the most out of varied media such as text, narration, and graphics. According to her simulations are one exciting option for using multimedia, allowing students to experience some aspects of real-world application in a safe, inexpensive, and infinitely repeatable format. There is some empirical evidence–primarily from physics education–that simulated labs can not only meet, but exceed the benefits associated with traditional in-class physical labs.[31]

Emma Pass, a hybrid teacher herself, in her work, *The Hybrid Teacher*[32] provides practical guide for teachers who want to prepare for current and future remote instruction or leverage the best practices of remote instruction and EdTech tools to bring back to their brick-and-mortar classrooms. She shows how best to leverage technology in traditional brick-and-mortar and remote classrooms, with case studies of the hybrid school model. She gives tips to all stake holders–teachers, students, and parents–to ensure that they have the skills to succeed with technology. In the US alone she has shared tips and ideas

30 The following work is an excellent resource regarding the use of Zoom: Aaron Johnson, *Online Teaching with Zoom: A Guide for Teaching and Learning with Videoconferencing Platforms* (Orlando, Florida: Self-published, 2020).

31 Michelle Miller, *Minds Online*, 163-164.

32 Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher: Using Technology to Teach in Person and Online* (Hoboken, NJ: Jossey-Bass A Wiley Brand, 2021).

with more than 3,000 teachers across the country. She has travelled around the world, speaking to teachers about the power and potential of technology to engage and differentiate for students. *The Hybrid Teacher* speaks of the most effective educational technologies available today in multiple subject areas including English language, arts, science, math, social studies, visual arts, dance, drama, music, and general education.

7. Faculty Challenges in Transitioning to Online Teaching[33]

Faculty encounter new demands and challenges when they transition to online teaching. Many approach this transition with deep skepticism about the quality of online learning and their own skills especially with regard to fostering student engagement, and creating a sense of community. They are also apprehensive about the shortage of opportunities for them to acquire online teaching expertise and their loss of face-to-face interaction with students. Here we examine some of the concerns of the faculty:

i) Lack of Institutional Support and Rewards

The absence of strong leadership, institutional commitment and support, encouragement, and rewards (recognition, remuneration, promotion, etc.) discourages faculty from teaching online. Many instructors also express concerns about the lack of clear policies and standards for online courses at their institutions. All too common is the administrative failure to involve faculty in course decision making, appropriately limit online admissions, and give ample time for course design and development.

ii) Unreliable Technology

Faculty report obsolete and unreliable technology and rapidly changing software or delivery systems as major disincentive to teaching online. Struggling with technology distracts faculty from teaching and students from learning.

iii) Absent or Poor Technical Support

Faculty lose motivation to teach online when the campus lacks sufficient technical support for them and their students, and they fear having to handle technical glitches on their own. In any Learning Management System (LMS), faculty are likely to confront plenty of unfamiliar course areas, terminology, tools, links, checkboxes, setting options, and multiple methods and places for uploading content.

33 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best,* 215-217.

iv) Absent or Inadequate Training

Faculty express concerns about the lack or inadequacy of training on their campuses to prepare them for online course design and teaching. Lack of training breeds doubts about the values of online learning and fear of the unknown, especially among instructors who also lack pedagogical training. Proactive education and the practical strategies for high quality online courses can preempt many faculty concerns. This is important because, until faculty experience online teaching, they have trouble conceptualizing it. They cannot simply structure content for asynchronous online learning the same way as for face-to-face classes. Faculty must reconceptualize not only the classroom but also classroom dynamics. They are accustomed to communicating with students face-to-face and expect a certain type of student participation and social dynamic between them and a class. But in online classes, technology mediates all communication, participation, and social relationships. Without training and at least some successful experiences with online technology, the transition to online teaching can be a slow, bumpy ride.

v) Concerns about Quality

While experienced online faculty report that their online students take more responsibility for learning than their classroom students do, those without this experience question the quality of online courses and tend to oppose or resist online teaching. Their concerns about quality take various forms: a) some faculty fear losing touch with their students; b) some think of the online context as impersonal in part because it removes the visual cues that help them respond best to students; c) some faculty have more concerns about online accessibility of students with disabilities; d) others fear that online courses make cheating and plagiarizing too easy and likely; and e) some faculty worry that the requirements of the online format may reflect badly on their personal standards of teaching. These concerns undermine the motivation to teach online.

Linda and Ludwika offer very useful tips for moving your classes online: "Great teachers know they need to acquire several new skill sets. Teaching, managing, personalizing, communicating, and evaluating are slightly different online. A teacher who is great face-to-face may not naturally be great online, but learning the necessary skill sets will improve the chances of success."[34]

8. Final Observations

Having spoken in some detail regarding media technology that can be used in education some final observations regarding the same must be made: We

34 Linda and Ludwika, *Online Teaching at Its Best,* 13, 215-217.

begin with a quote whose author is unknown: "A great teacher can teach calculus with a paperclip and literature in an empty field. Technology is just another tool, not a destination." Technology is merely a tool to help both teachers (teaching) and students (learning). Our firm belief is that technology will never replace good teachers or solid pedagogy. All stakeholders in education need "to understand how to use and leverage technology to save time, engage students, and meet individual learning needs without letting ourselves become complacent or using the technology as a crutch or replacement for teaching."[35] Teachers can't teach effectively if they don't understand their tools, students can't learn effectively if they can't access their work, and parents can't support their student if they don't understand the systems. Take students, the digital natives, for instance: some aspects of educational technology may be new to them. Generally, the assumption about these students is that because they can create a TikTok video, edit photos, or even write code they have comprehensive technical knowledge. The pandemic situation has made all the stakeholders more than aware as to where lies the technological pitfalls.

Conclusion

This topic was allotted to me at a research seminar held in the pre-covid times. I accepted the topic because I have been using some form of media in education for many years prior to the pandemic. But with Covid-19, this topic became all the more relevant and I have tried my best to demonstrate that in the pages above. As the coronavirus makes those changes inevitable in the realm of education, we hear people begin to chant that "nothing will be the same again." And that's okay. Change is good, so long as it's planned. Like a good move. All the stakeholders need to acquire the right attitude about change. Problems are opportunities and flexibility are a valuable personality trait. Resilience, above all, is the starting point for possible change. In any case contemporary multimedia technology makes it easier than ever to bring in graphics, video, animations, and audio that enhance online learning experiences. Imagining education without technology or EdTech tools now seems near impossible. I would like to be on the same page as Emma Pass who predicts that the future of education is hybrid. "When the Covid-19 dust settles and we reflect on what we've learned, I hope we realize the power of technology in education and the potential for hybrid and blended learning."[36]

35 Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher,* 229.

36 Emma Pass, *The Hybrid Teacher,* 257-258.

Concluding Statement of the ACPI Research Seminar

Morning Star College, Barrackpore, Kolkata

October 14 – 16, 2022

We, the members of the ACPI held our annual Research Seminar at Morning Star College, Kolkata, for the purpose of a common reflection on the theme, **"Emancipative Education: Policies and Practices."** Traditional forms of education were assessed in terms of their critical, creative, inclusive, relevant and emancipatory contributions.

Key Insights which Emerged from the Deliberations

1. The purpose of education is primarily to enable personal and social emancipation. Students need to be enabled to learn, unlearn and relearn, thus ensuring their ongoing personal transformation, the development of character and integrity and a fundamental openness to a value-based educational journey.
2. Educationists need to inculcate learning which serves to overcome stereotypical prejudices based on religion, gender, caste, class, language, region and ethnicity. Students need to be inspired to cultivate a sense of universal fraternity, based on an empathetic spirit.
3. Today we have more literacy than education. Literacy includes skills of reading and writing, whereas education is a much wider project, resulting in the integral development of the person and society.
4. For the more privileged, learning has gone beyond the classroom to include the virtual world. This necessitates even more accompaniment and guidance of teachers, as the digital world poses a variety of challenges hitherto unknown.

In the light of these deliberations and insights, we the members of the ACPI, **sincerely commit ourselves:**

1. To make education a liberating, democratizing and humanizing force, enhancing conditions of dignity, mutual regard, self-actualization, equity and social wellbeing.
2. To rediscover education as a vocation, and not a mere profession, or worse, a commercial enterprise, falling prey to the neo-liberal agenda of capitalist market-forces.
3. To evolve educational processes whereby all stakeholders become genuinely human and humane, imbued with a sense of civic responsibility.
4. To design educational processes that make use of the brain's neuroplasticity, so as to facilitate understanding, creativity, critical thinking and the ability to generate alternative and wholesome social narratives.
5. To enlighten learners to overcome traditional and inherited bondages and to transgress unwholesome and limiting boundaries. Such transgression will hopefully lead to transformation and emancipation. For this to happen, teachers and students alike need to be critical and creative producers of knowledge, not just passive receptors of educational systems, practices and content.
6. To realize that education is a hermeneutical task opening up to various horizons of meaning and truth, including indigenous and subaltern wisdom.
7. To understand and develop educational and research processes as social projects, in the service of the eradication of various forms of social inequity.
8. To aim at a borderless society and promote the common good, going beyond all that divides and compartmentalizes human society.
9. To ensure that educational processes help to overcome divisive, fundamentalist and extremist forms of thinking.
10. To advance spiritual education which transcends the boundaries of institutionalized religion in order to enable believers to realize that to be religious is to be inter-religious. To enable learners to perceive unity in diversity, divinity in humanity and intrinsic value in nature.

Our reflections on this theme revealed our present limitations and the need for continued efforts to make educational processes holistic and progressive, accessible to the least and the lost in our society. We need to network with those who are genuinely interested in the welfare of our country and desire to work for every section of society, to listen to the voice of the voiceless, to celebrate diversity through mutual respect, based on a wholesome understanding of personhood and society.

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Index